

An objective look at meditation
methods and enlightenment

Spirituality
Through a
Highly
Sensitive
Lens

Elaine N. Aron

Author of the international bestseller
The Highly Sensitive Person

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DEDICATION

To the long tradition of teachers—teachers of every kind—
who have sought to raise their students to their level and beyond.

To my incredibly loving husband, Art—for me, the perfect partner.

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INTRODUCTION

Simply put, this book aims to show you that you—your brain, your mind—can undergo a profound permanent change, one that you probably have no idea about. Please trust me on this: There is a way you could live with a sense of peace and well-being almost all the time, 24/7/365. Now maybe stop a moment and imagine what that might mean for you.

(Or maybe you can't do this imagining because you are highly skeptical, or you are an atheist or agnostic and picked up this book in spite of mixed feelings about *spirituality* being in the title. It's okay. What I'm asking you to imagine is in no way supernatural. And I'm not overly fond of the term spirituality either. We'll have a heart-to-heart about it early in [Chapter 1](#).)

To be clear, it is not that, once in this state, you become a saint. The change is usually gradual and to some degree goes on throughout your life, progressing to even more advanced states. Yet a big, clear permanent shift usually does occur at the start. Once it has, instead of being drawn into all the chaos, it is as though you have suddenly begun to calmly witness it. There is a peculiar sense of bliss, not as an emotion but as something more subtle. A freedom. This initial shift does not mean that you will never be unhappy or upset again, or that you will lose all desire to improve the world, but all of that goes on within a silent sense of equanimity.

This change in the brain's operation is happening to more and more people, sometimes suddenly, without expecting or understanding it, but more usually after some years of meditation practice. But it can be done. You may have started meditating but stopped. Perhaps it was because it was too difficult, or didn't seem to be working. This is almost surely because you lacked objective information about meditation. This book is especially for you.

Why a Highly Sensitive Lens?

What do I mean by seeing "spirituality"—i.e., this change in human potential—through my highly sensitive lens? As a highly sensitive person, I tend to see the "big picture" sooner than those without the trait. This is not meant as a declaration of superiority. There are advantages to not having the trait too. But research on we who are "HSPs" indicates that this is an innate trait, a survival strategy found in about 30 percent of people causing us to process things more deeply.¹ (I will explain better in [Chapter 1](#).) Given that tendency, perhaps it was inevitable, after meditating for over fifty years, that just as I saw the trait of high sensitivity that others had missed or misunderstood, I would see another new element in human culture emerging that most people do not really know about.

True, there is an enormous amount of partial information out there about what I cover in this book, mainly meditation and this shift, also sometimes called *enlightenment* or *awakening*. Yet it seems that most people have ignored this information. Perhaps it is because, if they did delve into it, they found only piecemeal information. Teachers and authors presented only their own view or the view of the "school" they followed. Who has the time and knowledge to sort it all out? And I am sure some have seen people they valued "swept away" by some spiritual teacher. They do not want that to happen to them.

For whatever reason, the majority of people still do not have this, dare I say, life-changing information, and a likely cause seems to be that no book has covered it all, objectively, so that people can

choose whether to become involved or which practice suits them, without risk of being influenced by a single persuasive voice. Hence, once again, with my high sensitivity nagging me, I felt obliged to write a book to open up this critical topic.

Why Isn't This Like Your Other Books, Written Just for HSPs?

Let me stop a moment and address the many HSPs who have read one or more of my other books. You might wonder, why isn't this book's title, *Spirituality and the Highly Sensitive Person*, in line with all the other books (e.g., *The Highly Sensitive Parent*, *The Highly Sensitive Person in Love*, *The Highly Sensitive Workbook*)? It is true that most HSPs, like most people, do not know enough about the details behind this possibility for radical change. You may have more of a sense than others of something valuable here, more longing for it. You may even be involved in what you consider to be a spiritual practice. However, there is so much more to know about the various potential forms and paths toward this enormous change. But as I researched this subject, I realized everyone needs this information, not just HSPs. So, this time you will have to share me! Rest assured, this book is almost exactly what I would have written for you anyway, and to deal with the "almost" exactly, there are sections in each chapter where I do address you specifically, adding what I think you particularly need to know.

Still, I think this book is especially important for HSPs. You are a minority of people, around 25 percent, living in a world designed for the majority. No matter how well-adjusted you are, as an HSP you suffer from the stress of the overstimulation inherent in that larger world, and being easily overstimulated is the only drawback to your trait. Being a member of a minority also means you must deal with the expectations of the majority that you live and think like them. All of this stress impacts your health and quality of life. Clearly, what I am talking about—a change in the brain that means you have a

deep calm underlying everything else—is especially important for HSPs. You need this book, but so do many, many others.

We Are in the Midst of a Supernova

This radically new possibility for a permanent change in the brain is all thanks to the Eastern teachers of meditation who arrived in the West, mainly in the sixties. To them, the purpose of meditation was awakening or enlightenment, although they may not have always expected that to happen to Westerners. Many Westerners learned meditation from them, again not usually expecting to awaken. Many stopped eventually. But a few stayed with it and really have awakened. In fact, there are now enough that we can study them—interview them, look at their brain activity. It is hard to put into words what a huge opportunity this is for all of us. My hunch is that any of us can change in this way if we commit ourselves to putting in the time. And the time spent can be pleasurable, not necessarily hard work. But we have to have the right information about what to commit to.

I think of this change as a sort of supernova in human consciousness. Just as two binary stars can collide to make a supernova, the two halves of our world, Eastern and Western, collided in the sixties. And just as it takes time for the light from a supernova to reach us, it has taken time for this collision to become visible. But we can see it now.

The only problem is that a supernova can lead to considerable chaos. Everyone having the experience of awakening seems to feel the need to write or speak about it, usually with the goal of teaching others how to get there, following the path that worked for them (and there seem to be many). Hence, there is a vast amount of information available today. It is coming now not only from different Eastern traditions but also from new Western approaches to awakening or enlightenment.

Up to now, there has been nothing done to sort out all of this information in an objective way, covering all sides. Hence, some

people have rejected the whole idea as unscientific nonsense, or just taken up whatever practice or philosophy they've heard about, not realizing all the choices. Further, they do not realize that what they have been told is the right path is not always the right path *for them*. It really needs to be sorted out, so I decided I would try.

Who Am I to Write This Book?

I am best known for my twenty-five years of researching, writing, and teaching about the 20–30 percent of people who are HSPs. I wrote six books on the subject, and most of them have now been translated into over thirty-seven languages. I started writing this book five years ago and thought it would be a quick and easy job. I knew this stuff, I thought. However, as the information expanded due to the supernova, my high sensitivity, which would have made me thorough anyway, struggled to keep abreast. Last year another metaphor came up, one more personal. This book is like an adolescent dragon that I am trying to tie down as it fights me, tooth and flame, while just growing bigger and bigger. I wanted to keep the book reasonably simple. My dragon was not on board with that. But I think I have mostly contained her, provided that you appreciate her point, which is the depth and breadth of this subject.

What's in This Book/Supernova/Dragon?

[Chapter 1](#) starts with some of the evidence for what I have said here, that there is a permanent state of equanimity and effectiveness that one might achieve through the Eastern practices that arrived in the sixties, plus their Western offshoots, and that this state is becoming increasingly available. And, as in every chapter, I address how this explosion of knowledge affects the highly sensitive person—and the highly sensitive part in all of us.

[Chapter 2](#) faces the question of what is so great about this permanent higher state if *some* of these supposedly enlightened

Eastern spiritual teachers have broken their own ethical teachings and misused or abused their followers, acting no better than some leaders in the West's Abrahamic religions. The answer is found in the work of psychologist Ken Wilber, who demonstrates that *waking up* can occur without *cleaning up*—working on personal difficulties that can cloud our judgment. To avoid such one-sided development, this book is unusual again, as it emphasizes both.

[Chapter 3](#) discusses paths—life paths or spiritual paths—and what you have done and might choose to do on yours in the future. [Chapter 4](#) helps you see the effects of your childhood on your path, allowing you to develop an inventory of ways you might want to clean up, before turning to the discussion of the task of waking up, beginning with [Chapter 5](#). There you will learn about the different kinds of meditation you might choose from, if you choose to meditate at all. I am trying not to push anything! I will also discuss the relationship with spiritual teachers, should that come up for you in the process of learning to meditate.

[Chapter 6](#) delves more deeply into all types of meditation and their traditions, including scientific research on its effects on one's daily life and on the brain, in and out of meditation. The huge differences between the various main types becomes apparent—again, your choice matters.

[Chapter 7](#) focuses on the research on and accounts of what has been called enlightenment or awakening, plus the archetypal meaning we project onto the idea, which must be seen through for us to have a healthy relationship with it as a possible part of our lives. And [Chapter 8](#) continues with the subject of awakening, including traditional stages in its acquisition and the latest in creative Western “booster rockets” for getting us to our goal faster. Finally, we turn to the all-important question of how these possible changes in human consciousness will affect a world in crisis.

Throughout this book, my aim is to be as objective as possible, pointing out the problems and the unknowns as well as the amazing events unfolding in our psychological universe when you stop and look. No one's writing can be perfectly objective, but I have tried to separate out and put in italics material about my own path, the

subjective part of this book. The italics allow you to see the personal material coming and ignore it if you prefer.

Perhaps you sense by now that my goal is to help you feel safe in this book, that you will get the whole picture, not just one perspective being pushed at you without your knowledge. I hope to show you all the pertinent information, so that you can see what is there and can decide for yourself what you want to do with this knowledge. It's all meant to be a sanctuary for you, during an explosive change in the history of humankind.

CHAPTER 1

THERES A SUPERNOVA SNEAKING UP ON YOU, AND THAT MATTERS

As I said in the Introduction, in its simplest terms this book is about gradually changing your brain until it is able to maintain a background state permanently, 24/7, that makes life much, much easier and more meaningful. Most people agree that massive shifts are happening in our species, but not many are talking yet about this one.

While in the West interest in religion seems to be declining (although plateauing a bit since 2020, that is not expected to last¹), on a smaller scale the interest in deep spiritual experiences (meditation, psychedelics, awakening, etc.) seems to have exploded, even if only in relative terms, like a star going supernova in a distant galaxy. For example, the use of meditation increased almost fourfold in twenty years, from 4.1 percent in 2002 to 18.3 in 2022.² But the underlying shift leading to this explosion is often missed. It began when meditation experts from the East came West and began teaching, especially during the sixties. They knew ways to change the brain permanently, ways from thousand-year-old traditions. They started instructing those Westerners who showed interest. Some learned meditation practices from these teachers but stopped due to

various misadventures and disappointments owing to a lack of quality information. I think this book will especially help them too. Others stayed with it, and today, a few have made it to that state of permanent peace and have started talking about it.

Thus, it began—this opening to a deep sense of well-being, present all the time, that a few mystics in the West had known about but most of us did not. The shift has definitely begun, the one I liken to a supernova in that it was dim at first but is now seeming more like an explosion. But what do you really know about it? Probably very little. Those of you who are highly sensitive—I will be addressing you later in this chapter—might know a little more. But as I said in the Introduction, this book is needed by HSPs especially, though not exclusively. Everyone needs better information about this change.

For Those Who Are Ambivalent About Spirituality

I probably should not worry about those few of you who are made uncomfortable by the word *spirituality*. In the United States alone, roughly eighty percent believe “there is something spiritual beyond the natural world, even if we cannot see it.”³ But some of my best friends would not agree with that statement, being ardent materialists, and I know many of them would gain from this book. So I have to interrupt here to say that I wrote it for people all along the spectrum of atheist/agnostic/materialist to the devoutly religious. After all, this book is largely about meditation and awakening, and many feel these have nothing to do with spirituality. Most people do not meditate for what you might call a spiritual purpose. In a study of *permanently awakened* people, half of them did not see it as a spiritual experience, mainly because it seemed so normal.⁴

Why then did I use the potentially problematic word *spirituality* in the title? This book is definitely not spiritual in the sense of opposed to fact. It is based on research as much as possible, and you will not

be asked to swallow anything supernatural. But spirituality, in some form, has always been part of the human experience, and it still is in most cultures.⁵ Indeed, in the United States, as of 2023, while the number of people who saw themselves as religious had steadily declined, those who saw themselves as “spiritual and not religious” increased to 22 percent, and only 21 percent saw themselves as neither spiritual nor religious.⁶ (As I said, in the United States as of 2025, the decline in identifying as religious had plateaued, but it seems unlikely that it will reverse itself.)

However, if you fall within that 21 percent, maybe you can lean into the more modern definitions of spirituality:⁸ the capacity (or tendency) to find (or construct) a meaningful life; or that which connects you to the “essence of life”—e.g., nature, the ultimate truth, your own wisest inner voice. It can include anything transcendent, anything that feels much bigger than you or that is out of the ordinary—strange, awesome.

My point is, please, please relax about the *s* word. Choose a meaning that fits you or just leave it alone. I’m often going to use *spiritual* from now on, not having found a good replacement, but please think “whatever” if you like. My working title for this book was actually *Spirituality or Whatever*. The word is not crucial to my message at all.

What Matters Here Is What Your Brain Can Do for You

Think of developing a safety net of deep equanimity, so that no matter how bad things get, you cannot drop down past a certain level. (I think this would be especially relevant to highly sensitive people, about whom I will discuss more soon.) Or think of the ability to rise above all of the craziness here on earth—climate change, war, violence between groups, not to mention your own problems. Not to ignore said craziness, but to do better with it. Think of *that* kind of freedom. Research on one of the methods of reaching this state

finds that it increases the connectivity among the key brain parts, making the brain—your brain, if you choose—like those who effortlessly accomplish their goals—Olympic athletes when they are in the zone or the highest-level managers.⁹ Plus, you can maintain a state of restful alertness when you anticipate activity rather than getting aroused ahead of time, also making you more effective in action.¹⁰

It is essential to grasp that this change is not a change in attitude or a new set of ideas or beliefs, or even simple neuroplasticity. New thoughts and repeated activities, spiritual or not, will change the brain in limited ways. Sometimes these can be very helpful, serving as a sort of scaffolding of knowledge for building this brain change. But the change I'm talking about is something permanent, something widely visible using neuroscience techniques, to be discussed in later chapters.

I want to be clear: This change in the brain is a change in your background state. The world's problems and even some of your personal problems will still be there, in the foreground. In the foreground you can wish things were different and work for change, whether in society or, in yourself, through psychotherapy if you need it, or minding your health. You will still need and want to act. But you will be far more effective. There will still be suffering, and you will still lose people and things precious to you. And yet, at some level you'll find it to be in some larger sense okay.

What About You?

As I said in the Introduction, after you have read what I have to say on a given subject, now and then I invite you to explore the subject for yourself and perhaps learn something new, coming from within you. Since you could say the goal of this book is learning about creating a deep permanent inner peace, this is a good time for you to evaluate where you are in that project. Have you ever been in deep distress about something? The loss of someone? Some really

bad news, maybe about your finances or health? Were you deeply upset, thrown into emotional chaos? But was there also some calm inside at all, at a deep level? What do you do at such times to calm yourself so that you can act effectively when needed? Do you turn to certain other people? To your beliefs about the nature of existence, including suffering? To nature, certain music, prayer, meditation, yoga, or anything else that settles your brain? If you have ways to touch in on or even maintain inner peace, congratulations.

Or are you pretty much at the mercy of whatever comes? There's no shame in that. Knowing where you are starting is key. I hope this book will show you ways to move from here.

What About Me?

My own memories are in italics. Why read them? Besides satisfying your curiosity, reading about at least one other person's life experiences in depth can help you appreciate the complexities of every life. But I want you to feel the sacredness of your own life, so if you tend to compare yourself to others, it may be best to skip these sections in italics so as not to fall into comparing yourself to me just because I am handy. Still, this first set is special.

You will read later, in italics in [Chapter 7](#), about the permanent shift in consciousness that I described earlier, which occurred for me in 2016, probably the main reason I wrote this book. You already have some sense of what this shift is like from what you have just read. It is a permanent sense of unboundedness, without any content, a kind of "fullness of emptiness," and it is there along with everything else, as background. The experience is tricky to describe, so I wanted to write about it in the context of the chapter in which I discuss these permanent changes at length. In particular, I wanted to be clear, and I will be now, that it took time to develop this permanent state. I was meditating consistently twice a day for forty-five years, and attending some long retreats too. But meditating

every day was easy for me because I was using the method that worked best for me.

So why am I telling you now about this permanent state I came into instead of waiting for [Chapter 7](#)? Because after turning this book in to the publisher with only minor revisions remaining, I was diagnosed with breast cancer. I think I am like most women in that those two words strike terror. The moment I heard the diagnosis, I could feel wild thoughts ignite, flaring up like fires ready to devour me. Yet there was also that same huge calm inside. It absorbed the news, surrounded it. As hours and days passed, I can't describe the comfort, even joy—yes, joy—that I felt because I had this state in which to contain all parts of this distressing event.

I had gotten used to the change that happened in 2016, the solid equanimity. Maybe even took it for granted. Until the arrival of breast cancer. Now this equanimity feels more like a miracle. I am not going to say more about the health part—the steps in my treatment, some tiring, some painful, all necessary. But the equanimity was always there, even while a very instinctual part of me sometimes reacted with a racing pulse. There is nothing unique here. We all have had or will have a nasty health issue. All seems to be fine with my health right now. I am writing this to say that the diagnosis and treatment seemed small in relation to this inner hugeness, or maybe even a sort of gift of good timing, given the book. It has given me a chance to see the blessing of experiencing something terrifying while also being safe within this huge kindness. And then being able to tell you about it. It makes it even clearer to me that this book is about real, serious change.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

I hope this has been helpful to reflect upon your resources at this absolute level of life. We are usually aware of our resources in the relative world—our health, our social support, our environment, and all the rest. But our culture does not encourage us to consider the transcendent side of life. Consider what you can do to foster this

aspect of life as you read this book, as it is probably the best way to foster that much-vaunted quality, resilience.

For the Highly Sensitive Person

As I said in the Introduction, while this is not a book specifically for highly sensitive persons (HSPs), I address them in every chapter because they have been relevant in every chapter. In this chapter, I believe HSPs have been a major force in igniting the supernova. But first, you may need a review of what I mean by high sensitivity.

What Is High Sensitivity?

Depth of processing is a highly sensitive person's superpower. D for Depth is the first letter of DOES, the way I describe the trait. O is for easily Overstimulated, the only downside of the trait, but the necessary result of all that processing. E is for stronger emotional responsiveness, which often drives the deeper processing, and S is for Sensitive to Subtle Stimuli. While many of you are reading this because you have read my other books, you may be highly sensitive and not even know it. You can take the test for it at my website, hsperson.com. Remember, men tend to score a bit lower, thanks to Western culture's view of manhood. In Eastern cultures, sensitivity in men is admired.^{[11](#)}

While only about 20 to 30 percent of people are *highly* sensitive, another 40 percent are moderately sensitive.^{[12](#)} And everyone has to be sensitive to their environment to some degree. So, when I refer to sensitivity in this book, I am partly addressing a certain group of my readers, but also addressing the sensitive part in every reader.

The HSP's innate survival strategy is to pause to observe and process deeply before acting. Something like this trait, this same strategy, is found in a minority of individuals in over one hundred other species.^{[13](#)} And even if you do not consider yourself *highly*

sensitive, you will notice that survival strategy when you want to pause before plunging into something—maybe something like meditation or working with a spiritual teacher. You sense reasons to be cautious. In short, the information in this book should be as helpful to anyone wanting to pause before taking steps in an important area of life. So when you see HSP in this book, think highly sensitive person *or* part. That is, include yourself if you like. And gain from the highly sensitive lens I am loaning you as an HSP and observer of this supernova since it began in the sixties, when I was in my twenties.

The Role of High Sensitivity in the Birth of Religion

There is legitimate scientific discussion about why HSPs in particular might have been part of this supernova, given their possible similar role in cultural revolutions in the past. Two experts on the origin of religion, Margaret Rappaport and Christopher Corbally, cite the research on the trait of high sensitivity as support for their theory that the evolution of this trait in humans was a building block in the evolution of religion.¹⁴ In their article “Evolution of Religious Capacity in Genus Homo,” published in *Zygon* (a peer-reviewed journal of science and religion), they also reason that high sensitivity must have been, and still is, more often present in those who fill religious functions. This is theory, not data, but the reasoning from the evidence satisfied the peer reviewers of the journal.

It makes sense. High sensitivity manifests most as a tendency to notice details and reflect more on one’s experiences. But this sensitivity to one’s world inevitably produces a *differential susceptibility*. That is, highly sensitive people with good-enough early environments tend to actually be a bit more competent and healthier in various ways than others, but those with poor early environments are more prone than others to depression and anxiety. We will discuss the effect of this on your life path more in later

chapters. But we can rightly say that HSPs are differentially susceptible to the entire world—more deeply affected by both the good events and people and the sad, ignorant things. Surely we HSPs in particular have always needed, for example, to celebrate the good, in music and ritual, and to try to figure out where evil comes from and what happens after death. We have always craved to talk about all this, to explore it, while the majority of people give it less thought. Or they never did, until, according to these scholars, the rains failed to come or death came unexpectedly. Then the majority finally wanted to know what we HSPs, that eccentric minority, thought and did about it, and hence, perhaps, the rise of religion. Maybe as a minority of HSPs awaken, the majority will start to notice and want to know about this too.

Out of the East, Boom!

As I have said, and emphasized by putting *Supernova* in the title of this chapter, the ability to change the brain in powerful, permanent ways has been a specialty of the Eastern traditions. It is a human potential, so it has been seen many times in the West too. It is just rarer and not part of our collective consciousness. Think of Julia of Norwich, a Christian mystic in England in the fourteenth century, revered for her deep spirituality. She witnessed intense civil and religious violence and several episodes of the Black Death, which killed many of her friends and family. Yet speaking from her place of inner peace, she repeated these words to those around her: “All shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be well.¹⁵” According to those who knew her, this was far from witless optimism. It was the kind of permanent inner security that affected those around her in the best way.

I bring up a Western experience—there are many—of this same permanent inner peace because I am confident this is a capacity in all humans, as I will discuss shortly. But what is the evidence for a supernova now, this collision of East and West?

Consider the exponential increase in the number of courses, books (including at least one novel),¹⁶ internet discussions, conferences, retreat centers, practices, and so forth about yoga, meditation, mindfulness, nonduality, awakening, self-realization, and enlightenment. Go ahead, do a web search for *meditation* or *spiritual awakening* or *spiritual enlightenment*. There will be dozens of pages. Millions of search results.

More evidence of this growth: As I said earlier, about 4 percent of people in the United States meditated as of 2002, an average of three days per week. Twenty years later, in 2022, that percentage was 18.3 percent. All right, maybe meditating is not always a spiritual experience. But spiritual experiences, whatever that means, are also up. In the United States in 1962, a Gallup poll found 20 percent of those taking the survey completely agreed—5 on a scale of 1–5—that they had “had a profound religious experience or awakening that changed the direction of my life.” In 2002, the percentage had *doubled* to over 40 percent.¹⁷ Psychedelics were certainly around in the sixties, but now there is suddenly a widespread interest in them too, as a source of healing through having a spiritual experience.¹⁸ Research on near-death experiences has also been a hot topic since 1975.¹⁹

The capstone, of course, is that there seems to be an ever-increasing number of people who report they are *awakened* or *enlightened*. The exact figure is impossible to obtain because it depends on there being an objective, agreed-upon measure of the state. But ever-increasing is certain. For example, most of the books on the subject have been written by those who consider themselves to have arrived at that state. If you search for book titles having either word in them, you will find there are over fifty thousand. Of course, not all are about higher states of consciousness, but most are. I’m confident there would have been half that number ten years ago.

It seems that a significant number of people began practicing the methods taught by the Eastern teachers since the sixties. Some people stopped, but others kept at it for years. Maybe many of them

were HSPs. For decades the changes have not been very visible. But suddenly researchers are finding when they study the brains of some of these people that over the years they have changed in remarkable, substantial ways, neurologically or spiritually—however you want to view it. The research on this is very clear, as you will see.

When the weather is being weird or the smoke from wildfires is overwhelming, I have been known to use dark humor to remind people that climate change is “coming to a theater near you.” This spiritual change is also coming, and hopefully it will mostly be positive. It is all around us, whether people talk about it or not. David Yaden and Andrew Newberg spent five years researching a new scholarly volume on spiritual experiences.²⁰ In the very first words of the book, the opening of their acknowledgments, they admit that it has been almost impossible to keep up with the new information on their subject. They also note that this intense interest is leading to increasingly extreme statements, going well beyond the data, which are being made by both enthusiasts and skeptics.

The Real Need to Sort It All Out

The problem with a supernova is that it is explosive and chaotic. But happily, often the elements necessary for life in the universe are the products of this chaos. Similarly, as a result of this collision of East and West, we now have a vast array of ideas and teachings being adapted to Western minds, and some of the methods they teach clearly do change the brain and behavior dramatically. But often the ideas are contradictory and even in conscious conflict. I have seen entire online “summits” offered, ostensibly fully covering the topic of the expansion of consciousness, with some of the leading thinkers left out in what seems to be a deliberate bias. And I doubt that many meditation teachers can accurately describe even two or three meditation methods, so that you can choose the right one for you. Generally, they teach only the one they know and, if asked about others, give incomplete or incorrect answers. As I have said, this is

the chief reason for this book. People need objective information about all of the Eastern teachings, not biased or partial information.

The problem I often see is that many more people are stumbling into this realm uninformed, staying with the first convincing approach they find, for example, or settling on a practice because of one powerful experience or a charismatic teacher. Others may be turned off by their first encounter, as often happens, without knowing enough beforehand, and become negative about the whole topic. Again, the purpose of this book is to give you a chance to see all the choices being offered to you by this shift, including the choice to back off.

Like my books on high sensitivity, as I said in the Introduction, this book has been forced out of me by the facts I have found that I feel need to be told. Think of me as a naturalist, pointing out the details of what you are seeing, having this special lens for noticing the subtleties as well as getting the big picture. I have tried to review and summarize everything that seemed relevant, although I am sure I have missed a lot. As Yaden and Newberg found, the subject just keeps growing at a crazy rate. But clearly something important is happening. Let's begin with some history.

The Coming of the Teachers

How did the East come West? It mostly happened after World War II. Let's begin with Buddhism. Buddha lived in ancient India, but Buddhism spread quickly throughout Asia. Even though China suppressed its Buddhist, Taoist, and Confucian teachings and teachers in 1949, when the government declared the country to be officially atheist—ironically, none of those *religions* involve God—Buddhism still thrived in Japan, Tibet, and Southeast Asia. Japan was opened up (to say the least) after World War II, and Americans there encountered Zen Buddhism, while Japanese Zen teachers could begin to come to the United States, talking about *satori*, or awakening. Japan has other forms of Buddhism besides Zen. Most of these are more popular than Zen in Japan itself, but Zen caught the

interest of young people in the West, and thus dominates our supernova.

Southeast Asia, including Vietnam, certainly received an opening up by the West a bit later, by another war. Thich Nhat Hanh, a Vietnamese Buddhist teacher in the Zen tradition, was banned from Vietnam for his antiwar views, so he came to the West. There, he met Martin Luther King Jr., who increased the monk's visibility by nominating him for a Nobel Peace Prize. And after China took over Tibet, Tibetan Buddhist teachers eventually arrived in the West in large numbers.

As for India, as of 1947 it was no longer under British rule and began developing its various strengths, one of which was spirituality in the Vedanta tradition (along with many, many less prominent traditions). In Sanskrit, Vedanta means "end of the Vedas," referring to the last part of the Vedas written down. (The Vedas go back in oral form for perhaps thousands of years.) You will see the term Vedanta often in this book. The term also refers to Vedanta being the culmination of Vedic thought. These Vedic scriptures are the most central to modern Indian spirituality. After 1947, there was a new interest among some of India's spiritual leaders in giving householders and Westerners instruction in meditation that previously had been mostly reserved only for those who came to teachers seeking enlightenment.

There's that word, enlightenment, again. The Eastern teachers came, or Westerners came back from the East, with a strong interest in this state as the natural goal for humans—that permanent change about which I have already spoken: not as an idea, attitude, or change in personality, but experienced as a background to everything. Again, it produces a deep equanimity, a sense of fundamental well-being,²¹ and often a life-changing compassion for, or sense of unity with, others. When any of this kind of awakening talk from the East came up, the long spiritual hunger in the West must have sensed real nourishment close at hand.

Some spiritual teachers came from the East before World War II, of course—see Philip Goldberg's²² *American Veda* for a fascinating

history of some of those early teachers. There was Swami Vivekananda, whose Vedanta societies, founded as early as 1894, are still popular. Paramahansa Yogananda, the author of *Autobiography of a Yogi*, read by millions, filled large auditoriums in all the major cities. When he died in Los Angeles in 1952, he left behind the Self-Realization Fellowship, still popular, with centers all over the world. These two and others definitely helped open the door.

The Sixties—The Door Will Never Close Again

The door was suddenly flung open in 1960, when Maharishi Mahesh Yogi came West after a decade of teaching Transcendental Meditation (also called TM) to householders in India—something that was not commonly done. He then moved on from India to the rest of Asia, followed by stays in Hawaii, California, and New York in 1959 and the U.K. and Europe in 1960. By the end of 1960, he had done enough teaching and established enough centers to hold a World Congress on meditation in March 1961. Five thousand people filled the Royal Albert Hall to hear him speak.

After that success, he began to train teachers, hoping to create twenty-five thousand. (As of 2008, there were forty thousand teachers trained worldwide, although most are now probably inactive.^{[23](#)}) In the United States and Canada, especially in cities with universities, students lined up for blocks to learn TM. This surge was helped by the Beatles learning TM in 1968 and, as a result, renouncing psychedelics. In 1974, the BBC interviewed Maharishi, and he again filled the Royal Albert Hall for a lecture. When Merv Griffin, a popular U.S. TV talk show host, interviewed Maharishi in 1975, three hundred thousand people learned TM that year.^{[24](#)} The newspaper *The Hindu* reported in 2011 that “nearly 10 million practitioners in 50 countries” had learned the technique.^{[25](#)} Something enormous had happened.

The same sort of history could be told for what we in the West call “mindfulness meditation.” This is the only time I will use quote marks around mindfulness, but just remember that mindfulness has many meanings in the tradition from which this popular form of meditation comes, as well as additional meanings being applied in the West. It has proven to be a very busy, useful word!

While mindfulness meditation has always been an element in the spiritual practices of many forms of Buddhism, when Thich Nhat Hahn came to the United States, he quickly became the *father of mindfulness meditation*—although as a Buddhist, he teaches being mindful in all areas of life, not just in meditation. His teaching is now called the Plum Village Tradition. As of 2017, it comprised 589 monastics in nine monasteries and 1271 communities of practice worldwide, so it is a major part of Western Buddhism.

But it was Jon Kabat-Zinn who brought the practice to schools, hospitals, and executive board rooms. After studying with Thich Nhat Hanh, he stripped mindfulness meditation of all of its Buddhist connections and taught it as a scientifically validated method for improving health. How many people have learned mindfulness meditation? It is difficult to know because its teaching has not been centralized the way that TM has been, but certainly hundreds of millions worldwide.

What about Zen Buddhism and Tibetan Buddhism? The explosion of interest in Japanese Zen may have begun with D. T. Suzuki (1870–1966), with his background in both Eastern and Western philosophy. He taught at Columbia University from 1952 to 1957, and many were influenced by his extensive writing on Zen—for example, Eric Fromm, Karen Horney, John Cage, and Carl Jung. Members of the Beat Generation— Jack Kerouac (*The Dharma Bums*), Allen Ginsberg, and Alan Watts—took him up. Beat flowed right into hippie. In the 1960s, teachers of Zen, coming from different schools and lineages, opened centers in San Francisco and Los Angeles, attracting huge numbers. Now there are hundreds of Zen centers around the Western world. Tibetan Buddhism, which I will get to, came a little later to the supernova, but it has been just as impactful.

The Two Stars Collide

Supernovas can be the result of a dying star collapsing, but supernovas can also be caused by binary stars colliding. In the case of spiritual experiences, our planet has been divided in two. In the West, there have been the Abrahamic traditions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam), mostly theological and intellectual, being based on the elaboration of thoughts and feelings resulting from the experiences of only a few precious people (Jesus, Mohammad, the Jewish prophets, the Christian saints, and whomever you would like to add).

In the East, spiritual experiences that are available to anyone seeking them have been the core of their spirituality, a specialty, for thousands of years, probably beginning with shamans in the Himalayas and Mongolian steppes. Alongside daily devotional practices, there has been intense focus on methods for achieving permanent higher states of consciousness, for example *moksha* (one term from India's Vedanta tradition) or *nirvana* (Buddhism). In most Eastern countries, everyone knows where to go if they have spiritual ability that they want help developing (although that may be trickier in China, Vietnam, and North Korea right now). There is always a neighborhood guru, Buddhist teacher, Taoist master, or local monastery, and if the locals seem insufficient, one can go to the forests or the mountains for more choices. But those kinds of opportunities have been slim in the West, for a variety of reasons, the discussion of which is beyond the scope of this book.

The Great Hunger

I do not think this supernova is simply a matter of East meets West, however, but the meeting of a human hunger that happened to be growing in the West at the time when the means to fill it happened to be coming from the East. I will introduce you soon to Ken Wilber, who argues what I think we all know is true: We are all born with certain basic abilities such as talking, thinking rationally (forming a

hypothesis and testing it out), and basic physical feats such as standing, walking, and running. There are additional abilities that all may have a little of, but in which some excel, such as mathematics, music, or athletics. There is a strong urge in us to develop all our abilities, whatever these are. When we cannot, you might say that they start to ache. At least to itch. We hunger for action.

How far we take an ability beyond the basics depends to some degree on innate capacity or some early interest, but we also need the right circumstances. I sometimes wonder how many Einsteins or Beethovens are languishing undeveloped in slums or refugee camps—the wrong circumstances for developing their abilities. But what a waste! Imagine how they must hunger for a chance to develop their capacity, to test how far they can go, especially if they know that others in different circumstances are able to show off their talent.

Suppose spirituality, however you define it, is also an ability to be developed in all of us, although perhaps stronger in some. We do not often think of spirituality as an innate capacity found in all humans, but the well-known philosopher and psychologist Ken Wilber includes it in his list of developmental attainments, one of the usual abilities to be developed, such as locomotion and speech. Growth in this developmental attainment is gauged, according to Wilber, by how much and what kind of interior thoughts you have about what transcends obvious outer experience. For example, thoughts about God “transcend” thoughts found in other, “outer” areas of development, such as learning about fish species or a foreign language. It’s not that thoughts of God are better, but they transcend the visible, measurable world in that they look at the nonmaterial, unmeasurable aspect of life. The unseen. And Wilber presents ample evidence for this innate ability.²⁶ Before Wilber, the psychiatrist Carl Jung also saw spirituality as innate, calling it the “religious function of the psyche.” It arises from our apparently uniquely human predilection to reflect in general, to be conscious of ourselves, to seek meaning in our lives—remember that is one definition of spirituality—and to symbolize our spiritual ideas in various ways, sometimes quite elaborately.²⁷ Again, while we see

that interest in religion is declining in the United States at least, interest in spirituality is rising. Perhaps this drive is not so easily suppressed. (I hope by now that everyone is comfortable with this term, spirituality.)

Still, opportunities vary. Even if you have an almost unquenchable desire to play music, you must have an opportunity to learn to play an instrument. If you grew up in North America or Europe, your religious experiences came from going to your place of worship and usually passively listening to words and music and watching rituals that hopefully moved you. This pattern, called the three Bs, Belief, Belonging, and Behavior (the encouragement of better behavior),²⁸ has been the basis of Western spirituality. Belief is not trivial—in the United States, 92 percent believe in one or more of these: that people have a soul or spirit, that there is something beyond the material world, in God or some universal spirit, or in an afterlife of some sort. No doubt this belief comes in part from actual, probably mostly momentary profound experiences, the number of which I said above had doubled between 1962 and 2002. Perhaps these increased unplanned experiences have only added to the hunger for what was not available regularly—that E needing to be added to the three Bs. E for deep, daily, brain-changing *experience*, as was arriving with teachers from the East.

I do not mean to be critical of churches, mosques, and synagogues. They are extremely important to those who frequent them, meeting those three Bs, especially the central human need of belonging, and they also do immense social good. But they usually have not offered training that would help you develop your spiritual ability very far. You could join a monastery or convent, of course, but even most of those are no longer places for developing higher levels of spiritual ability. Otherwise, being born with a spiritual capacity, even a strong one, you were stuck without ways to grow in this area. You were left hungry, like people living in food wastelands, where healthy food is not available in stores near you.

With global changes in communication, however, inevitably the interest and desire (aka hunger) in the West for actual spiritual

experiences, for opportunities to develop one's spiritual capacity, began to make contact with a multitude of Eastern methods. The result has been our spiritual kaboom.

The Actual Explosion, and Who's Watching from Their Parking Lot?

In 2017, my husband and I drove to Salem, Oregon, to watch a total eclipse of the sun. We imagined sitting on some scenic ridge but ended up in comfortable chairs set out in the parking lot of our hotel. As the earth gradually covered the sun, the sudden darkness unexpectedly moved me and many others there to tears. (Probably we tearful ones were highly sensitive.) It was so worth the trip.

Unlike the solar eclipse we watched, supernovas are rarely visible to the naked eye. Similarly, most people cannot yet see the metaphoric explosion being caused by these binary forces of consciousness on our own planet. But suppose there are beings on other planets in our galaxy who have the sensory equipment to observe the frequencies given off by huge shifts in consciousness in millions of brains? I like to imagine them sitting around in chairs in a parking lot, watching our planet go the consciousness equivalent of supernova. I am sure their naturalists would love to describe how this happened. I will try to do the same within my cosmic metaphor.

Actually, it was probably right around 2017, when we watched our first solar eclipse, that some persistent meditators in the West made it across the finish line, were awakened, and got on the internet to talk about how they did it, or they wrote a book. So many books since then!

The real supernova, however, has to be when the East and West blended, with the West adding its own character. The combustible mixture was apparent when Eckhart Tolle's *The Power of Now* appeared in 1997 and *The Secret*, in 2006. Both are very Western in flavor, and Oprah then made them both—along with many other spiritual teachers—even more famous on her *Super Soul Sunday*.

She herself learned TM. But some people were saying about all the various forms of meditation, “Twenty years of meditating and people are still not enlightened?!” And about Tibetan Buddhist methods, “Three-year retreats? A hundred prostrations a day?” People were thinking there had to be a better—meaning faster—way. And perhaps most striking, suddenly not only were many more people saying they were awakened or enlightened, but many of those now wanted to teach about what they had found and, more important, how they had found it, faster.

Here is the finally visible supernova: Hundreds of spiritual teachers, mostly Westerners, are teaching what they consider to be the fastest paths to awakening to anyone wanting one, and there seem to be thousands who do. For example, the *nonduality movement* emerged from India’s Advaita Vedanta, a particular branch of Vedanta. You will learn more about it in [Chapter 8](#). It definitely has its pros and cons. Nonduality is another way of describing enlightenment, as the state in which one fully experiences that all that we see in this *relative* world is fundamentally consciousness itself—not two or more things but just one. Nondual. A teacher explains it to you and you get it. You wake up. Sometimes.

Want a short cut that is a bit more conservative? Take a six-week course, sample various methods, find the one you like best, practice it a little, hear some specially designed lectures on positive mental health, and boom, you are one of the majority, so it is claimed, who go from being a seeker to a finder, just that fast.²⁹ When the COVID-19 lockdowns forced people to meet by video, teachers could spread teachings even faster. They now continue: You can learn the latest methods or be on a retreat from your own home. (A friend took a weekend course from a well-known teacher who, in 2022, was happy when one hundred enrolled. In 2023 there were nine hundred students in his online course.)

As I said before, psychedelics were also there in the sixties. That fire was lit, then sputtered. But there was that ember that remained, burning underground. Now psychedelics are being widely reconsidered under the umbrella of treatments for PTSD, depression,

anxiety, and almost everything else,³⁰ and their use has definitely gone supernova.

Next, add the discovery in quantum field theory of electron entanglement—when two particles become linked in a way that their behavior matches in the moment, no matter how far apart they are in space. This “spooky action at a distance,” as Einstein called it,³¹ is now the perfectly logical explanation for so much that could not be explained before, such as consciousness and matter perhaps being one unified field.³² Quantum entanglement is now legitimized, made visible, material, by its being applied to create quantum computing. And there it is, the oldest traditions of the East colliding with a wave of secular, technological, go-get-’em-ness in the West to produce a supernova.

This Book Is Intended to Be a Sanctuary

Back to that parking lot. Take a seat and relax as I change metaphors. I want this book to be a sanctuary, where you can watch what is going on and delve deeply into it, slowly figuring out what it means for you without pressure to adopt any viewpoint. This is not a place where you will be swept away, as you might be by the first video, website, or book you chance upon that has a particular bias toward one meditation, spiritual practice, or awakening technique. I am hoping to offer you the equivalent of those comfortable chairs we enjoyed in Salem, where you can observe the whole kaboom and see how it moves you personally, whether to tears of awe, to renewed scientific interest, or simply to satisfied curiosity.

Again, to that end, I will try to be as objective as possible, although I acknowledge that some bias will be present. For example, being an introvert, I do not emphasize the role of community (e.g., the Buddhist *sangha* and Vedanta *satsang*), and being highly sensitive and a cautious inner sensation seeker, I discuss psychedelics only a little. I have tried LSD only once. I had a typical experience. But I find it a difficult subject to sort out in the current enthusiasm, which sometimes has the hint of the proponent's addiction speaking. You can find plenty on the subject elsewhere.

Otherwise, this book is not pushing or withholding any particular philosophy or practice. I encourage you to keep a journal, to reflect on your experiences as you read, to find your personal place in it all, again, starting from a safe distance. Or if you have already been affected by the supernova, this can be a sanctuary where you sort out what you have read or heard. I know it can be difficult to find a place to do that. Reflecting with friends about one's spiritual views can be more uncomfortable than discussing your sexual views. People have such intense feelings about religion, in particular. But how do you mature in your thinking in a total vacuum? This is a large sanctuary. In fact, on one side there is no boundary, so there is plenty of room for you to explore.

Trouble is, you may retort, offering a sanctuary ignores the terrible problems outside of it that demand attention. You may be thinking, *There's no time left for people to work on their own inner life or spirituality. We have huge crises to face, and spirituality has not contributed anything special to solving them. So do we really need it?* You are right, at least, in that spirituality is not a necessity for social awareness—atheists are some of our most compassionate, dedicated activists. And I am grateful for everyone, spiritual or not, working on these problems. But maybe we can set aside the outer problems until the last chapter, after you have developed a larger perspective.

My Sanctuary, My Rules

Now that you know this book is partly about a permanent, positive change in the brain, sometimes called awakening or enlightenment, it is time for you to know my two rules for keeping this a sanctuary. After all, you may be thinking, understandably, *This book is all leading up to discussing some advanced state of consciousness that will never happen to me. Reading this will only make me feel inferior.* So, the first rule is *no comparing yourself to others, including me.* I have a fine tangle of flaws. So, no ranking yourself or others as better or worse than you. We are all created equal and different. We are all sacred in this sanctuary. What do I mean by sacred? Come on. You know. You can feel it when you walk into a sacred space, such as a cathedral. You may not usually feel that *you* are sacred, but I would like you to try for that while reading this book.

As for this permanent positive change, I will show you that it might very well happen to you soon even if it might not have been so easy a few decades or years ago. But I will also show you that it is both over- and underrated, and definitely still misunderstood. The problem is that the very terminology creates a feeling that there are the *haves*, those who are awakened or enlightened, and the *have-nots*, those who are not yet enlightened, saintly, or anything else. We are not going to buy into those divisions or contribute to a

ranking of humans or the creation of classes. I have seen enough of that in my work with highly sensitive people. People want to decide if highly sensitive people are weaker than others or stronger, having superpowers. Neither. Are they kinder than others? Or more self-absorbed? Happier or more miserable? I refuse to engage in the ranking of traits or brains. Ranking is a natural survival instinct, as I discuss in [Chapter 5](#), but it can also be a major source of anxiety and depression. All social animals compare and decide who is better and then, usually rightfully, put them in charge. Of course it happens with spiritual teachers as well. It is an instinct, but we can control it, just as we do other instincts. So again, my first rule: Try not to compare yourself to others.

The second rule is that you be honest with yourself. Much of this book involves self-examination, as I am about to explain. Try to be honest about what is true of you and maybe what you would like to change, even as you do not judge yourself. You can love yourself and correct aspects at the same time. Both can be done. We do it all the time with some of the ones we love the most—our children, our pets, and our partners.

What About God?

This supernova has thrown views of God every which way. To some in the West, Buddhism is the perfect path, as Buddha felt he transcended even God to reach nirvana, so in modern Western Buddhism, at least, you are not expected to believe in God (although some Buddhists in the East have their deities). Nondualists in the Advaita Vedanta tradition would say there is no God separate from you, and no you except pure consciousness, so no worship is possible. Yet in India, even among those who hold to Advaita Vedanta, devotion to God is an essential part of their path in a nondual sort of way. They accept the paradox as part of the spiritual life.

I know that for some of you in the West, God is the most important part of your life. But for some of your fellow readers, God

is not part of their spirituality at all. It seems that there's room in this explosion for everyone. It's not a private club for theists.

Indeed, I hope some readers with serious doubts about everything related to God are reading this book. I want you to feel at home. Maybe you feel God obviously does not listen, given the world's problems, so why pray or even believe? And given the size of the universe, not to mention possible infinite numbers of multiverses, why should we matter? Maybe it seems irrational to believe in God, that it is more like superstition. God is not necessary to explain creation or moral behavior. Maybe you think belief in God has been the cause of endless conflicts, wars, and persecutions, so really, what is God good for?

Dear reader, that is for you to decide, and maybe you want to allow it to be fluid, given Wilber's idea that there are stages of spiritual development. Beyond this sanctuary it is wise to figure out the truth as best we can. But here, maybe give it a rest. Maybe we can think of perspectives on God as lying on a dimension that we all slide along, from days or years at the No-God-for-Me end (along with most Buddhists) to the other end, where faith in God is beyond doubt.

What we mean by God can also change. I am asking you to be inclusive about that too. At times it might be a personal God, at other times something completely abstract, without attributes, akin to or the same as Brahman, the ground of Being, or pure consciousness in Vedanta. Or maybe have it both ways. The medieval Christian mystic Meister Eckhart (1260–1328) spoke of God as one member of the Christian trinity—Father (God), Son (Jesus), and Holy Spirit. In that sense, God is more like a person or personable. Then Eckhart also described the Godhead, the aspect of God that is so complete it is beyond any particular qualities you can name but is the source of everything. Eckhart saw creation as constantly bubbling out of the Godhead,^{[33](#)} much like today's concept of the quantum field. According to the Heisenberg Uncertainty Principle, a quantum field cannot sit still. Instead, it froths and boils, a bubbling soup of particles and antiparticles, constantly created and

destroyed.³⁴ It is the basis of everything, with virtual particles constantly manifesting according to the field's energy state. If one calls this God or the Godhead, you have a purely scientific view of the Great Whatever. That is, the supernova has expanded your ways to experience God, or to not to.

What About You?

Now seems to be a good time for you to reflect on and maybe write about where you are on the subject of God, or of spiritual experiences generally—any experiences that have opened you to a vastness, an absolute reality that was more than this concrete, material existence, a truth that is not obtained by observing this relative world. I have found that almost everyone has had such an experience, although they may have talked about it so rarely that they sometimes have to search their memory to remember it.

What About Me?

I suffered off and on from extreme depression for decades. One night, when I was about fifty, I was extremely depressed and unable to sleep. I just wanted to die. I was seriously planning how to end my life in the morning. When I finally sort of slept, a young man sat beside me in a rocking chair to comfort me and prevent my plan. I suppose it was a dream, but this figure was there all night, not coming and going or even changing. Just sitting, rocking. It seemed like I was awake in the dark with him, in deep and sacred silence. In the morning, after that night with him, I felt I could go on. I named him my Seminary Student.

Another night when I was lying in bed feeling very depressed, but not quite as much so as when the Seminary Student joined me, I thought how much I wished that I had concrete evidence of God that I could trust for the rest of my life. At that time, God meant to me someone or something that cared about me and guided my life.

(I don't know why the Seminary Student experience did not suffice, but I am by nature very skeptical about these things.) Immediately after having this wish for a sign, I saw in my mind a small automobile accident, a fender bender, with me standing at the back of my car beside the driver of the car that had hit me, looking at the damage. That bit of imagery seemed like a dumb, random thought that I certainly hoped would not manifest. But the next day—you guessed it—I'm on an on-ramp into a congested freeway and the car in front of me stops suddenly. The driver of the car behind me did not see me stop and hit me. We pull over and get out to exchange info, but I am smiling, almost laughing. This was my sign, my peculiar sign.

Even though I had already been meditating for twenty-plus years when this happened, seeing the spirituality all around me in my life required considerable time. I could not really call these experiences coincidences, but at the time I had no place to put them cognitively. Having such a place would have required a deep confidence that someone or something cared, and that would take years more for me to develop.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

If you have given this subject of God serious thought, I suspect—maybe I hope—you have found you have unique views, perhaps varying with stages in your life. Flexible views that allow for change with experience. May you be happy with where you are now and where you might be headed.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

As we end this chapter, where are we? If I may wax poetic, you are in a sanctuary (or a parking lot, if you would prefer), watching a supernova of human consciousness that is not quite fully visible yet to the naked eye—that is, not yet at the center of our culture's

attention. But you have a sense of it now, exploding all around you. Our goal is to clarify what is now unfolding, and perhaps to find a way for you to have a change in your brain like those described in the Eastern traditions, something that can become permanent and sheltering. To meet that goal, or goals, we will go step-by-step, chapter-by-chapter, with all the information and encouragement you need. Just to be clear about what step we have finished and what the next one is, I will always end chapters with *Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going*.

A final personal story about this sanctuary. Perhaps a decade ago, I had fantasies of setting up in the parking lots of malls some small, prefabricated chapels, decorated with symbols of all the religions, but each with a theme. Ah, parking lots again! These would be places where people could go to rest, in the spirit of Thomas Merton hoping that there will always be quiet, dark churches where people can go. Even if they do not know how to pray, “at least they can be still and breathe easily.”³⁵ But I am a writer, not a builder, so it turns out I am envisioning myself building a sanctuary with words.

Or maybe something more modest, like a comfortable chair. The other day, a friend pointed to a chair in his home office where he reads poetry or books on spirituality and where he meditates. Or maybe dozes off. But he said that whenever he sits in that chair, he has a taste of something profound that is beneath all of what he does there. Whenever and wherever you are reading this book, I hope it will be for you like his chair.

However, I suspect some of you HSPs have not yet sat down in that chair. I know from experience that you are slow to decide—to sign up, for example, for a weekend with other HSPs. You will wait until the last minute or put it off until next time. You want to think about it. In this case, maybe you have been thinking, *Why should I proceed any further in a book about some kind of special spiritual talent given all these revelations about spiritual teachers behaving so badly*³⁶? *What use is spiritual development if it can go so awry?* This is such an important question that it deserves an entire chapter, one

that opens out onto a rich understanding of we humans and our potential.

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CHAPTER 2

WAKING UP AND CLEANING UP

Now you may be stumped. You would like to find this deep equanimity that some spiritual teachers or teachings impart, yet you know there have been serious misbehaviors among a few teachers in all the Eastern traditions—regular Buddhism, Zen, Tibetan Buddhism, and all the other varieties, plus seemingly all the Indian or Vedanta traditions. It is even talked about in old texts. In the Indian scripture *Kula-Arnava*, written around 1000 CE, many lines are devoted to warning the student, for example, that gurus are as numerous as lamps in every house. “But, O Goddess, difficult to find is a guru who lights up everything like a sun....Gurus who rob their disciples of their wealth are numerous. But, O Goddess, difficult to find is a guru who removes the disciples’ suffering.”³⁸

Meanwhile, the Western religions have been struggling with the revelations regarding the sexual and emotional abuse perpetrated by some Catholic priests, Christian evangelists, Muslim imams and teachers of the Koran in religious schools,² some Jewish rabbis,³ and all the rest. All of these perpetrators were supposed to be *spiritual* people. What are we to make of it? I think we are learning the answers.

In this chapter, the question will lead us to some profound insights about human development.

What the West Is Learning to Do Best— Figuring Out People

Let's go back to the planet having two hemispheres, much like the human brain. Remember, it is only a metaphor. But I think it helps to see the left hemisphere being like the West, skilled at rational problem solving. The right hemisphere is like the East, skilled at feeling and intuition, the necessities for spirituality.⁴ Each has been contributing in its own way to the changes, to the supernova, we now see.

Since World War II especially, the West has focused more on understanding human psychology and the diversity of human behavior. Children were no longer seen as small, uncivilized adults, but having observable stages of development, just like any other animal. But with their long childhoods, it was found that there were more opportunities for widely different results due to variations in the quality of parenting and general environment. Deviations from normal in adults began to be considered problems that could be understood, often as the results of childhood abuse or neglect, especially wounds resulting from an insecure attachment to a caregiver in the first years of life. Treating these disorders stemming from childhood led to the various psychotherapies.

When Eastern methods for achieving enlightenment met Western psychology, many heard the claims and thought this knowledge would certainly also solve most personal and behavioral problems. But it simply did not work out that way.

Ken Wilber, a Supernova Thinker

Just as when a star goes supernova it spreads elements—iron, carbon, oxygen, etc.—not previously present in that region, the supernova created by the collision of East and West created a synergy in many areas, a combined effect greater than the sum of its parts in their prior existence. A major example is the work of Ken

Wilber, who in the sixties was a pre-med student at Duke University, studying to treat disorders scientifically. He was soon swept into studying Eastern philosophy instead, trying to understand it in the light of his own Western, scientific education. In a few years he had quit all university education and began studying this interface—what I am calling the supernova—on his own.

Wilber's first book, *The Spectrum of Consciousness*—what he saw as a synthesis of Eastern and Western views—was rejected by twenty publishers before it was published in 1977. He was simply way ahead of mainstream publishing. (Hmm. *The Highly Sensitive Person* was also rejected by mainstream publishers.) But the supernova has carried him on to being one of the most widely read and translated philosophers of human psychology and evolution. I brought him up in the last chapter because he argues persuasively that humans have an innate spiritual ability that seeks development. I wish there was room in these pages to describe more of his theories about human development, but there are many summaries by him and distillations of his work by others for you to read if you are interested.⁵ What matters here is that he took on this question of how an enlightened spiritual teacher might behave terribly, and why awakening does not solve all or even most psychological disorders, and his answer is simple and momentous.

Waking Up, Growing Up, and Cleaning Up

Wilber saw in the stages of childhood development a template for understanding all human development. As I said, Wilber and many others had noted that children develop in standard ways as they learn to speak, to reason about their world, interact effectively with others, and go through the physical stages of learning to stand, walk, and run. But these and other innate capacities can be further developed according to a person's desire and perhaps innate predilections, as well as opportunities provided by one's culture.

Wilber was particularly interested in three developmental areas not always discussed by developmental psychologists: *waking up*,

stages or levels of spiritual experience; *growing up*, a type of moral development regarding how you see your role and that of others in the world (e.g., egocentric or all about me, group centric, world centric, etc.); and *cleaning up*, or levels of managing the complexes (aka emotional schemas) that inevitably arise due to childhood difficulties. These complexes can cloud our thinking unless we clean them up—usually in therapy or through the self-help methods we have developed in the West for this purpose.

Wilber saw that looking at any line of development, not only these but all developmental tasks, one could be high on one task and low on another. One could have great intellectual skills but undeveloped athletic skills. More to the point, you could be enlightened, high in the waking-up type of development, yet be low in growing up, the expansion of one's moral development beyond your own needs or your group's. For example, few Japanese Buddhists during World War II, probably most of them quite evolved spiritually, had a problem with their nation's brutal military offensives. Their moral development was still stuck at the level of focusing on the good of one's particular group, namely their nation.

This was a revolutionary idea regarding spiritual growth. Waking up—that is, reaching that permanent equanimity and effectiveness I have been talking about—has been a specialty in the East, according to Wilber. Those with a talent or interest in this line of development had ample opportunities to grow. The results were stunning. In contrast, knowledge about cleaning up—that is, working through one's personal emotional issues—is relatively new for all humans, but far more advanced in the West. Then there is growing up, one's social/moral development. Highlighting these different lines of development meant that one could advance on all of them, or be advanced on one but operating at a low level on another. The idea was going to change the world.

According to Wilber, what growing-up level you are at depends greatly on one's culture. If hanging criminals is normal and expected in your culture, you are not likely to develop in yourself a sanctity for all life. High levels of what he sees as moral development have been rare anywhere until the last one hundred to three hundred years,

and that occurred mostly in the West. He gives the abolition of slavery as an example. Humans have always had slaves, until some of us *grew up* in this way and thought about fairness more carefully.

Sometimes Wilber described the stages of growing up with five or more levels. But to keep it simple, he often used Carol Gilligan's stages of moral development.⁶ At the lowest level, an individual is focused only on themselves. The next level is when one is focused on the well-being of one's group, favoring it over all others. This is what we mostly see in the world today. It's a strong instinct that all social animals have—to protect their pack, herd, extended family, tribe, nation, race, or whatever. Buddha may have had compassion for all beings, but for the most part, throughout the East as much as in the West, even among Buddhists, fighting to maintain the dominance of your lineage, caste, monastery, gender, and so forth was rampant.

However, in the last hundred years we have seen the development of the third of Gilligan's stages, one not seen before in the East or West. Wilber calls it worldcentric: a focus on the well-being of the entire human species, all people. It is a new development in moral reasoning. Again, Wilber claims that it resulted in the abolition of slavery, which humans had practiced since around 6800 BCE, including in Greece and the American colonies. But then, during what is called the Age of Enlightenment (1685–1815), we finally thought more about how all humans should be treated. This new thinking led to the abolition of not only slavery, but the recognition of the equal rights of women, the abolishing of the caste system in India, and the United Nations' Bill of Human Rights—all new ideas. Yes, there is still warfare and mistreatment of groups seen as inferior, but more oppose it than in the past. A fourth, higher stage still, is to be focused on the well-being of all living things or of the entire universe.

Just as cleaning up was not really part of the Eastern traditions, this worldcentric level of development had not appeared in the growing up line of development when Eastern spiritual traditions began, so it is not built into them. Even if you are enlightened,

according to Wilber you cannot see the world from the perspective of a level you and your society have not yet attained. Spiritual masters and sages in the East did not see women as equals. There were certainly exceptional women who earned male respect, but to treat all woman as equal to men? It could not be imagined.

So, alas, waking up is separate from growing up. True, waking up can broaden your perspective and increase your compassion, but only up to certain cultural limits you cannot even see. I will not be saying much more about growing up. The rest of this book focuses on waking up and cleaning up, how they can be combined so that if you wish to develop in one way, whether waking up or cleaning up, you can also develop in the other way. This allows us to avoid the lopsided development that Wilber needed to explain. Now, let's revisit that urgent question, why a few spiritual teachers have messed up so badly.

Knowledge Is Power Regarding Flawed Spiritual Teachers

Thanks to Wilber, I think we can finally understand how seemingly great, charismatic, even enlightened spiritual teachers can fail morally. These individuals were or are high on the spiritual line of development, but low on the other two—low on growing up because of their culture's level of moral development or low on cleaning up due to their not being aware of their personal issues. It seems that spiritual teachers, even the most enlightened, can be oblivious to huge latent complexes about, most obviously sex, money, or power. Their widely recognized spiritual attainment gives them vast influence, not to mention the freedom to express culture-based prejudices they hardly see, such as sexism and racism.

It is difficult to know the personal histories of many spiritual teachers, because in the East they often traditionally turn their back on their families, and no doubt family issues and memories, when they become monks or priests. So, to test my hunch that not

cleaning up one's childhood adversity is the greatest problem, at least in our culture, I looked at the childhood of one of the worst spiritual teachers I could think of, Jim Jones, whose childhood we do know about. Jones was a much-admired charismatic religious leader in the San Francisco area, with over 5000 members in his Peoples Temple. But when there were reports of abuse within his community, he took his followers to Guyana to escape the criticism. When a Bay Area delegation came to investigate more reports of abuse, they were eventually killed, and then Jones ordered his followers to down a flavored drink laced with cyanide, killing 909 people, including 304 children. (I'm sorry to bring those images to mind, but I do so to bring home the seriousness of cleaning up.)

Jones grew up in terrible poverty, raised by a mother who did not want him and a father too sick to work. He was left alone to wander the streets, sometimes naked and probably usually hungry. Extended family members and neighbors did try to help, but he was not an appealing child; he was full of hate and profanity. The wife of the local Nazarene pastor became involved, taking him to church three times a week and teaching him to study the Bible daily and follow the strict Nazarene code of conduct. Clearly this was important to him, as he eventually became a minister, then created his own church, suited to his interest in civil rights and socialism. I do not know where Jim Jones was in the process of waking up, but he certainly had something that attracted even very well-educated, otherwise intelligent people to his church, and for a time, earned the admiration of many usually discerning people (e.g., the California governor and lieutenant governor at the time, the local assemblyman, activist Harvey Milk, Vice President Walter Mondale, and Rosalyn Carter, to name only a few).

Maybe it is not very comforting to know that people who have developed spiritually to a high degree can still be so wrong in their behavior, but at least we have an answer to the question of why we see a few very spiritual people make a mess of things. It is rarely necessary to look far to find the answer if one can obtain the information. It is usually, just as I expected to find in the case of Jim Jones, right in their childhood. Or it might be in their culture, or in

their being unprepared to handle the power over others that comes with being perceived as awakened or in some special way personally representing God.

In short, we do not have to be confused, upset, and powerless about some spiritual teachers being flawed. We can value someone's teachings tremendously yet be watchful for behaviors that do not work for us. Those who train spiritual teachers can carefully observe an aspirant's level of psychological clarity, not just their spiritual readiness. Above all, anyone at any level of development on the ladder of waking up can and should work on growing up and cleaning up as well. Indeed, a strong ego, one without unconscious issues undermining conscious good intentions, is essential for handling the higher levels of spiritual experience, including what is sometimes experienced as a loss of the ego. This is why this book is almost unique—except for Wilber's writing—in putting waking up and cleaning up on an equal footing. (Although, modern Buddhism, as it absorbs Western psychology, is placing greater emphasis on cleaning up for its own sake, not just for awakening. See, for example, *A Monk's Guide to Finding Joy* by the eminent Tibetan Buddhist Khenpo Jigme Phuntsok Rinpoche.)

Does a permanent positive change in the brain seem less valuable if someone—maybe you—could achieve that and still be so flawed? For me it is both yes and no. What these higher states actually can do for a person is quite impressive. But cleaning up and growing up are also impressive accomplishments that you can be proud of. Without all three, perhaps one is not truly enlightened or awakened in the sense we would like that state to mean.

Cleaning Up and HSPs

Again, cleaning up is still a relatively new possibility. There was no science-based understanding of the causes of dysfunctional behavior, much less anything like psychotherapy, until about a hundred years ago. We humans, being new at this, must stay alert as we work on cleaning up. One may need help developing in this area, just as one

needs a coach to become an outstanding athlete. Skillful psychotherapy (or sometimes other methods, such as hypnosis or dream analysis, or simply self-analysis and education) can now uncover and integrate what has been repressed, once we realize the need.

I think that HSPs are particularly suited to cleaning-up work. One reason is that they may need it more. HSPs are characterized by differential susceptibility—they are more susceptible to good childhood environments and also to poor ones. For HSPs, a painful childhood more often leads to depression and anxiety.⁷ Thus, given the same problems, they may well need more psychotherapy than the average person. Because they absorb helpful as well as harmful experiences, they also gain more from psychological interventions.⁸

In addition, although psychotherapy can sometimes bring up painful issues, HSPs typically enjoy it. They love to process their experiences deeply and have the kind of intimate, personally meaningful conversations rarely found elsewhere. Especially if their childhood was a problem, they are truly appreciative of the kind attention a therapist may offer.

This appreciation of psychotherapy can be in stark contrast to the attitudes of a less-sensitive culture, which can often seem to discourage psychotherapy, as if it is for the weak. If it does seem warranted, the sense is that it should be as brief (and therefore inexpensive) as possible. This attitude needs to change, since most people, HSPs or not, could use much more cleaning up than they have done. Cleaning up can be done outside of psychotherapy, of course, but psychotherapy is usually the best place for consistent, focused work. And having been a depth psychotherapist, I know that lasting change takes time, sometimes years, especially when the problems go back to early childhood.

But I sense sometimes that just because HSPs not only benefit and gain more than others from psychotherapy, and also enjoy it, they can feel defensive about continuing in it, given the dominant attitudes. They will sometimes have to swim upstream against the prevailing current that seems to say, *Everyone had a bad childhood*

—get over it! Or What, you are still in psychotherapy? Perhaps HSPs can think of themselves as role modeling the cleaning up that everyone could use. Indeed, many more people might enjoy it if they could get over seeing it as a waste of time or money, or themselves as weak for needing it.

Appreciate the Progress

This field of helping each other clean up continues to grow, as new disorders are identified. It is difficult to clean up what you cannot name. For example, post-traumatic stress disorder or PTSD was not named until the 1970s; moral trauma, only recently. (Moral trauma is the result of having to kill or allow someone to die when it violates your values. It is not yet formally classified as a type of trauma disorder, but I am sure it will be.⁹) With new diagnoses come new treatments, or simply new insights for an individual to use to understand themselves and from there find new ways of thinking and behaving. That is, individually and also as a society we can develop increasing awareness of largely unnamed or totally unconscious complexes.

We are used to all of this cleaning up—the self-help books, the mental health clinics, the careers in counseling, the online therapy. It is part of our culture. But as I said, it was not known just one hundred years ago. I think the progress we are making in ways to clean up is truly important for our collective future. By being eager to clean up our personalities, even if we are not suffering from a disorder, we can all take part in reducing our likelihood of falling into the kinds of behaviors that make our world such a troubled place. Whatever the past, we are all capable today of waking up, growing up, and cleaning up, in any order, and even better, progressing with all three at once. These are natural capacities, but we advance developmentally only when we can name them and make use of theories and methods available in our culture, as we all grow together. Again, going forward I will emphasize Wilber's waking up and cleaning up.

Keep in mind that you can progress along all lines of development, like developing athletic ability and musical ability at the same time. But while there is an infinite amount of material out there on both cleaning up and waking up, there is not much that puts the two together in the way they deserve, with a full grasp of both. One notable exception is John Welwood¹⁰'s *Toward a Psychology of Awakening: Buddhism, Psychotherapy, and the Path of Personal and Spiritual Transformation*. Welwood is famous for first using the term *spiritual bypassing* to describe how often people dive into waking up to avoid cleaning up. Welwood suspects that waking up in the East may not have ever required as much cleaning up as it does here, because Eastern students would have had a healthy foundation of community, religious customs, and shared moral values that we in the West mostly lack.

Another reason why this book considers *both* cleaning up and waking up is that there already seem to be too many Westerners who have woken up without cleaning up. And we know there are also way too many people cleaning up to become better individuals without knowing they could also wake up and be happier and more at peace in an entirely different way. How many mental health professionals tell you about that possibility?

This book puts you in the cozy heated cab of a snowplow, so to speak, fitted with a blade to *clean up* your route, to clear the drifting snow of your past difficulties. And the engine of the plow is the steady developmental push for some degree of *waking up*, usually facilitated by some type of spiritual practice. Blade and engine move you forward simultaneously—and in Wilber's view, also help to move our species beyond its current problems.

This book is not a full-on manual for cleaning up. (Actually, I wrote what I think is a pretty good one, *The Undervalued Self*, but there are many other valuable sources out there as well.) This book aims to help you do an inventory of what needs to be cleaned up, so that you at least know what you are carrying with you. And it needs to be a careful inventory, because the farther you go toward waking

up, the trickier it can be to see what remains unprocessed and probably has been skillfully avoided up until now.

Starting the Cleaning Up by Going Back to the Ancestors

The shamans talk about three worlds: This World, the Upper World of spirit, and the Lower World of archetypes, dreams, collective unconscious, and also the ancestors. The Upper and Lower Worlds help us prosper and aid others in This World. For waking up, we enter the Upper World, but for cleaning up we also may need help from the Lower World, and it is wise to start with the ancestors.

My specialty as a clinical psychologist was depth psychotherapy, and the finest spokesperson for that was Carl Jung. It was his view that the goal of all psychological work was individuation, a kind of underworld enlightenment and the ultimate cleaning up. It refers to how one becomes an in-dividual or un-dividable person—separate and whole—by integrating one’s conscious and unconscious parts. That is, you go down into that lower world and bring up the treasures there.

But there is more to individuation, in that according to Jung, it is almost the opposite of individualism.^{[11](#)} Individuation requires that you forsake your independence, your precious individualism, which may be the result of carefully separating yourself from parts of your past you wish to deny. Individuation means consciously working on the problem or the question you inherited from your ancestors. Maybe they inherited it from their ancestors but could not finish it. You, in your life, try.

You do not get to choose the problem, but it is your choice to move forward or not with the particular problem or problems that you have received. This might be an unachieved goal (maybe women in your family were denied higher education) or some unresolved grief, guilt, or shame (maybe about a personal loss, or else about some cruel behavior done due to social pressure—what I

described earlier as moral trauma). It can sit in the middle of your path, whether you see it clearly or do not quite yet. Your job is to move it at least a little more out of the way, by acting to resolve it or even just making it more conscious. Otherwise, according to Jung (and my own experience as a therapist), the next generation of your family is left with the issue and will have to move it forward themselves—or again refuse it.

Here is the chance for your first descent into the lower world, focused on your ancestors. Many traditions say they are still with us, guiding us. See what, if anything, they have left undone for you to clean up.

What About You?

As you reflect and write about your ancestors, it may be best to focus on only one of them at first, the one whose story has stuck with you or seems to still influence you. Has this person left you with your individuation task, that crucial problem that your ancestors and your parents could not answer and have left for you?

Do not forget that you are conditioned by your ancestors' DNA as well. The genes of a famous explorer in your family may be making you what psychologists call a high sensation seeker, someone who finds it difficult to settle down. Or perhaps you have inherited an artistic streak that you have tried to ignore but it keeps resurfacing, perhaps as a tendency to see beauty others miss.

Reflect especially on whether there were events—possibly major traumas—that your ancestors experienced that still reverberate down through to your own life. Did these increase your ancestors' spirituality, their need for a solid belief perhaps, or did it eliminate their faith in anything or their time and energy for spiritual matters?

Perhaps you do not have anything dramatic in your history, but please think before dismissing the question. Often, we humans dissociate or conveniently forget some of the biggest traumas. History books almost always leave out the Spanish Flu pandemic of 1918–19, which infected a third of the world's population and killed

20 to 50 million people (some think 100 million), my grandmother included. This occurred at the end of World War I, and in the United States, more soldiers died of this virus than in battle.

Sometimes our own behavior is an expression of a rebellion against something precious to our ancestors—the child of a royal house may become an ardent communist. My husband's great-grandfather was an Orthodox rabbi, and his grandfather was a total rebel, refusing to give his son (my husband's father, my father-in-law) a bar mitzvah when the time came. Given all that, my husband's father was pretty wishy-washy on religion and spirituality, not giving it much thought. Hence, the problem came down to yet another generation, where I think it is being resolved. My husband can see both forces inside himself, rebel and Orthodox, without feeling conflicted.

What About Me?

Sixteen-year-old Henry Ashcraft sat on his horse, rope at the ready, just within earshot of the preacher, or at least this is how I imagine it. He knew from considerable practice which tent peg would bring all that heavy canvas down on the camp meeting. It was always a great joke to him and his pals. Soon this crowd of dusty, weary homesteaders attending the only family entertainment west of the Mississippi would be thrashing under the big top like kittens in a burlap bag headed for the river. So much for salvation.

Except, dang. The preacher was speaking with adamance, and Henry, who had been stripped while young of his sense of life's purpose, was being yanked forward toward one. He never threw that lasso. He had been roped himself. B. C. Johnson, a pastor who was observing, said young Henry was "slain in the spirit," really hit hard by God that night. I guess he forgot all about his horse and lasso. It seems that he collapsed and crawled down the aisle to the altar.

Henry was my great-grandfather, the father of my mother's mother. As just a boy, he had fought in the U.S. Civil War. The Union was losing when he enlisted. You had to be eighteen, but in order

not to lie about it, he wrote 18 on a slip of paper, put it in his shoe, and declared he was "over 18." He saw heavy fighting and terrible conditions. Eventually, he was part of the infamously cruel campaign of General Sherman "from Atlanta to the sea," that is, to Savannah, Georgia. The army's sole purpose was to terrify the civilians enough to frighten them into surrender. We cannot imagine all that he saw and did. After the war, Henry joined other hooligans wandering the Midwest, all ex-soldiers who were no doubt suffering PTSD or at least sorely disillusioned with the human race.

Why did Henry pause to listen to the preacher that evening? It may have been his guilt about things he had done in the war, but it may have been something deeper in him, in my family. His cousin Franklin was also converted, and the two cousins wanted to be evangelists. This was something serious in them. First you had to repent and be forgiven for your past deeds, but then you had to experience holiness by surrendering your life to the holy spirit. And that's exactly what Henry did: He spent much of the rest of his life spreading the Word all over the West, from Illinois to Texas, Oregon, and California.

At seventeen he met Minnie Evans. They married and had a baby named Mabel. When the baby was still under six months, there was a push to go west to Oregon Territory and evangelize. Their family went. Mabel sickened on the trip and died, and Minnie went home. For a time, Henry soldiered on, traveling by foot, wagon, or occasionally train, suffering from hunger, temperature extremes, and, given his letters, from a seemingly endless string of colds. He camped with his fellow preachers or took shelter in the pioneer homes of people struggling to survive with next to nothing on raw land. When I reflect on it, he really was still the soldier enduring hardship for the greater cause. What they all had in common was that their feet were firmly on a new path, having been not just born again but "sanctified by the Holy Spirit" and wanted to spread the word about it, glowing with charisma from what had to be tastes of waking-up experiences.

What was this path? The Free Methodists—Franklin, Henry, and Minnie's church—and the Nazarenes, the church of my father's father

and my father, were two of the Holiness churches that gained popularity in the Midwest in the 1800s. These were decidedly evangelical, a term with other meanings now. But what interests me is their belief, which they took from the Methodist Church's founder, John Wesley, that after being saved from sin (born again), one could be further sanctified, made perfectly holy in your love of others and lack of personal ego, a kind of Christian enlightenment. As a child, I met some sweet women among those early Free Methodists—I do not recall the men so well—who had an inner glow and intense light in their eyes, something more than just sparkle or obsession. It was similar to the look of some Indian gurus I have met, or saintly nuns and monks.

The ancestral shadow that must be brought to light, however, is the PTSD my young ancestor was suffering from after being part of Sherman's March to the Sea. Every war has produced PTSD—in the Civil War, the overactive autonomic nervous system, the pounding heart, was called soldier's heart and the other symptoms acute mania.¹² Some people awaken, genuinely and lastingly, during or after trauma or tragedy.¹³ If that was the case with Henry, then perhaps, as many awakened people do, Henry set out to bring others to his state of consciousness with no thought of his own needs. Or maybe he was not awakened, but simply went on being a soldier, not knowing anything else to do.

What is the issue passed down to me from Henry? First, clearly, this spiritual passion. But behind it, possibly unbearable guilt around the war, compounded by unbearable grief about the child he lost while in the West. His next child, my grandmother, later experienced unbearable grief, which in turn deeply affected my mother, who never dealt with it, and hence it was passed down to me as part of my individuation issue.

Interestingly, I am having to add a huge grief in my ancestry that I had completely forgotten the first time I wrote this. My grandmother's grief, which I will get to, was about the loss of her young husband, my grandfather, Francis Harden. What I had forgotten was that his mother was part Native American. No one has

been able to learn which tribe. I have seen only one picture of her, standing in a dugout home in South Dakota, on the land she and Francis's father were trying to farm. In the picture, she is young and seems grossly obese, but in fact she was dying of what they then called Bright's disease (kidney disease or nephritis). It was probably a marriage of convenience for my great-grandfather, Francis's father, since he immediately remarried after her death—you could not work a homestead without a partner, and Native Americans may have been easy to force into marriage. Her son, Francis, just four years old, was not liked by his new stepmother. His family attended a Free Methodist tent meeting, and somehow that resulted in his being sent off to the Free Methodist school in Wessington Springs. But soon he ran off to become a cowboy. What grief he must have felt for the loss of his mother and then of his home.

My ancestors, especially Great-Grandfather Henry and the husband of his daughter, Nelle, my grandfather Francis, focused on their spiritual goals without cleaning up their grief and trauma. As you will see, their wives, my great-grandmother, grandmother, and my own mother, also carried heavy loads of unresolved grief. But something in me has not allowed it to remain. I don't think I was someone who could awaken until my individuation task was at least moved forward a bit. Hence, I hope I have not passed on to my child and our grandchildren the issue of unresolved grief that I received. I cannot spare any of them the moral trauma and grief from our collective memories of outrageous cruelty to others, in our nation and the world, or the guilt of not having done enough to stop what was happening, or to help the victims, although they face these collective moral failures more than most young people. But having worked fairly successfully these last years to clean up my personal obstacles (in my case, in depth psychotherapy, but more on that later), I hope I can do something through this book to lessen the collective burden of our past, allowing us to better avoid making the same mistakes in the future.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

You may have found that you always have been so keenly aware of your ancestors' views about morality, spirituality, or some other issue, that you have felt duty-bound to carry their views forward. Or perhaps you never thought about it, even though you knew there were some people in your family back then who had peculiar ideas or practices, things that seem to have nothing to do with you. But even the way in which those things were lost is part of your history.

So, reflect on what you wrote. Again, mainly you are watching for individuation issues, any burdens that you are carrying that were passed down from the past and slowing you down now.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

Hopefully, you are feeling clearer about the misbehavior of spiritual leaders by learning about waking up versus cleaning up as different lines of development. More importantly, you have begun to explore these two for yourself. Where do we go next?

Some people have quite spontaneously woken up—that is, switched into the powerful background state we are talking about. But for most people it takes time, with changes in the brain happening every day in small increments. If you are going to invest that time, you want to be on the path that is right for you, so that you can look back after a few years and see you have changed substantially, becoming calmer, harder to upset, and far more effective in whatever you do. In the next chapter, I will present various paths for waking up so you can find one that resonates with you.

CHAPTER 3

PATHS AND PRACTICES

This chapter looks at how spiritual paths and practices have expanded since the Eastern teachers arrived in the West, adding to your choices of ways to live your life and see your path. Why the word *path*? Life path, spiritual path—we use *path* so much in this way that it has almost ceased to be a metaphor. Life, like a path, has ups and downs, detours, roadblocks, and so forth. The metaphor works for me.

But paths are more than maps of passive journeys. They involve choices, or at least noticeable changes in direction. So let's begin with a What About You in which you look at your life path thus far. Just the big turning points. What your big choices have been, what simply happened to you, and maybe what was more a combination, especially when something from the Lower World, your unconscious and ancestral influences, forced you to change direction. How much have you cleaned up, so that those sorts of forced choices happen less? How much is there to celebrate about your path?

The beginning of a life often looks more like a moving sidewalk. You were born. No choice there. And you started to move along, to grow from a child's body into an adult's. Biology sees to that. Your society, through your family, saw that you received an education (you are reading this), so that you would be useful in some way,

able to support yourself and contribute to the larger good. Depending how far along you are, biology and culture has supported your interest in finding a mate and having children, working at a job, and then retiring and maybe helping raise grandchildren. That's the moving sidewalk, and of course we all add our unique touches to the trip, but maybe you made some larger choices. Watch for these while doing this exercise. Maybe you decided not to have children or never to retire. Maybe you took up sailing and sailed around the world, or you raised parakeets and even made a living at it.

Time is what a path and a moving sidewalk have in common. Time has been taking you forward toward the end point. In an airport you might choose to just step off and stand still, but life does not allow standing still. This next journaling prompt is partly for you to watch for those places where your life path stopped being just a moving sidewalk. Maybe places where you ran into real obstacles and turning points that forced you to take a new direction. I want you to sharpen your awareness of these times, because it's easy to forget we can choose, given that we do not at first. When did you first make a choice? Are you proud of at least some of your choices? How did your circumstances force change? How much did you seem at the time to be making conscious decisions that you look back on now and see were forced by your unconscious—things from your past? Or by social pressure? Of course one can see everything you've done as determined by something, but that's a topic for another book—by a philosopher, not a psychologist!

What About You?

Try looking back and creating a sketch of your path in words, written down or just in your mind. Maybe think of it as a story about someone else, someone you know well. This will help you be more objective. Or think of your path as a long road map and look back on the events in your life as spots along the way where you turned and went in a new direction. *First I was here, then I had to go here, then here. Then I arrived here, where I am now.*

The length of your sketch will probably depend on your age (mine is long), but write or reflect only as much as you like. Use dates if that helps. Include your demographic variables, such as age, place of birth, education, marital status. Mention any spiritual practices you started and how long you stayed with them. But mainly look for the big moments, the big turns. Maps do not show every town or feature—just what’s important. Maybe a graduation, a surprise job offer, an accident of some sort, a death of someone close to you, or a major decision. Or a combination, a decision forced by your past history. Above all, look for a pattern, the flavor or the signature of your path so far.

What About Me?

The details of my path are found in italics throughout this book, wherever they seemed appropriate, so you will not find all of the details here. Here I will stick to what I am asking you to do, to provide a sketch of the whole trip and a pattern I found. Some of what you will read here and in later chapters are about difficulties that needed to be cleaned up, things that might seem hard or sad. So, before you get to those parts, I am glad you can see here that it ended well.

I was born in 1944, in Los Angeles, California. Both parents were mostly of white European descent, middle class, and Protestant in values. I was born highly sensitive and became an introvert as I grew up. My physical appearance was normal, although I never thought so and now rarely think about it. I had a brother nine years older, with whom I got along well, and a sister six years older, who made me very unhappy at times. My parents had serious personal and marital problems and were divorced when I was thirteen.

Having done years of cleaning up, I can describe the overarching pattern and how it has turned out. As the result of a difficult beginning (next chapter), it seemed I was always longing for a kind person to love me. Surely some of this came to me through the losses my parents and grandparents experienced—as I said, often

the next generation repeats the effects of an unresolved trauma. Anyway, from the time I started school I always loved some boy from afar, as well as my teachers, who were usually kind and fond of me. When I was thirteen, a boy, Don, loved me back. It was the first time. I married him in 1963, at nineteen, but this marriage only lasted four years. Don was a kind-enough person, but in the end, we were very unsuited to each other. Among other things, he was racist and disdainful of anything spiritual.

In my first year of college—Occidental in Los Angeles—just before my first marriage, I became very depressed and had a counselor briefly who was, yes, very kind, as they usually are. I was so attached to him that I followed him at a distance when he walked around campus. The summer between my freshman and sophomore year he wrote me to tell me, very gently and sweetly, that he had taken a job working with delinquent girls for the next year. I quit Occidental, to the dismay of the deans (I had a full scholarship and the highest GPA in the freshman class), and married Don in October, to help him avoid the draft (didn't work). I think this is the first time I stepped off the moving sidewalk, making a decision for myself. A bad one, because I was not actually free to choose. I was being driven by unconscious forces.

My last two years of college were at Berkeley, while still married. This was Berkeley in the sixties, which I, as an HSP, responded to deeply, I think as a spiritual experience. Again, I saw a campus counselor to deal with my confusing emotions, mostly depression. But the big change was that I also latched onto another man—no, three—whom I met in different encounter groups, while still married. (Few marriages survived Berkeley in the sixties!) One of the three was my current husband, Art. We were attracted instantly, at the same time, so I never spent time yearning for him from afar. Although he was kind, he was also passionate and intellectually interesting, a philosophy and social psychology graduate student. This felt more like ordinary mutual love. The weird, driven search for perfect love was put off for a while, no longer the main force. But this was another big turn; I left my poor husband Don and moved

with Art to Canada because of the draft. Now I was making real choices, not just driven by a hunger left over from childhood.

Four years after meeting, we decided to have a child. We were both in graduate school in Toronto, then moved to Cortes Island, in British Columbia, interspersed with a year in Paris. Our son, Elijah, was born while we lived on Cortes. (I do not mention him more often in this account because this is about my path, not his. Plus, unlike your account of your path, where you might discuss your children a great deal, this account is in a book, so I wish to respect his privacy.) During the year in Paris, we started meditating (Transcendental Meditation). Back on the island, we spent time each morning trying to figure out how best to "change the world." Where to apply our energy. But we did not fully realize that we were now on a path mostly in the Upper World. We decided to leave BC to become TM teachers, and then faculty members at Maharishi International University, sometimes in Europe with Maharishi and more and more in Iowa, at the main campus. Helping to start a university committed to changing consciousness seemed like the best way to create change. A choice.

After ten years with the TM organization, we moved back to my home state of California, to Santa Cruz. Suddenly the Lower World, put off for so long, yawned open. After some very insistent, explicit dreams, I started psychotherapy, and of course developed an obsession with my kind therapist, an intense transference, a phenomenon in psychotherapy that I will describe later. I also quickly fell into a deep depression requiring antidepressants, and started menopause early, further affecting my emotional equilibrium. There were good times, too, of course, especially annual walking trips in Europe. But then my only child also left for college, triggering fresh loss, but increased by that old pattern of grief and desperate attachment coming from my ancestors. My husband held steady through all of this, working at the University of California, Santa Cruz. But mostly it was a dark period. The path was passing through a thick wood.

The first therapist was very kind, but she did not know how to handle my intense feelings. She did, however, notice my sensitivity,

and in commenting on it started me in my research and writing on the subject. This focus on the trait of high sensitivity became, or demanded that it become, my life's work.

Another demand, however, definitely from the Lower World, was that I go back to graduate school to earn my Ph.D. in depth psychology (a Jungian program) and gain my clinical psychology license. I had been writing novels before that. One was published and fairly successful, and I deeply felt the loss of that path due to the insistent demand that I work in the Lower World of the unconscious as a Jungian therapist.

At this time, Art took an academic position on Long Island, New York. I grieved for my home state, California, and we became bicoastal for about ten years, each of us flying back and forth to live and work in California as much as possible, having a place in New York City when we were there for Art's teaching.

Back in California, around 1996, I found my next therapist, a highly skilled Jungian analyst. (I was careful this time and met with eight before finding this one.) A wise HSP and fellow Jungian pointed out to me this hidden gem among the local analysts, describing him simply as "very kind." He did not need to say more. I worked with this analyst for twenty years, usually three times a week. That long? Yes, HSPs can need longer than others, and in my case it was really necessary, especially given that I was a therapist myself. It was intense, but very fruitful. Of course I continued meditating through it all, but the Upper and Lower Worlds seemed completely separated, while in This World my work as a therapist and with HSPs buffered and benefited from all that cleaning up and progress toward waking up.

When my Jungian analyst told me in 2014 that he would retire in a few years—he knew I would need considerable warning—I lived with the dread of that last session. Part of my solution was to leave the day after and begin six months of travel. During this travel we began doing our at-home (or wherever) meditation retreats one week per month. By the end of the six months, I was aware of a major positive change, which I mentioned in the italics in the first chapter and will describe in [Chapter 7](#).

I practiced depth psychotherapy (you might call it working from the Lower World to affect this one) for about twenty-five years. At the same time, I was writing six books for HSPs and one on self-healing psychological problems (The Undervalued Self), helping to make several films about HSPs, plus doing research and teaching about HSPs. When I turned seventy, I stopped being a therapist and cut down on HSP work to write this book, a wonderful return to being creative again, about a subject dear to my heart.

Looking back, I see the pattern of searching in all three worlds for a kind, loving presence in my life who would love me no matter what. This comes from generations of grief that made parents either too preoccupied to love their children or too defended against ever loving anyone again. When I finally found someone who could not just love me but handle my desperate longing for love that was rooted in my childhood, the Lower World stopped harassing me and the searching in This World ended. I was confident about my analyst's caring and able to face that he was a mortal being subject to time and his own needs for retirement. When I was forced to part with my analyst, I was free to turn again to the Upper World. The cleaning up was done (to the degree it ever is) and the waking up was free to happen.

It is difficult to describe how good my path is now. In a sense, the three worlds now feel like one, filled with the kindness I had sought. My son has been very successful in his career, has married a wonderful woman, and I now have two sweet grandchildren. And I have that deep equanimity, even if the old wounds sometimes return, as during the first hours after separating from my son and his family at the end of a visit with them. No, the shift never brings perfect happiness.

As many do who have come this far, I want to share all that I can. However, I have unusual limits. Although I have no anxiety about public speaking, I can only do it for at the most about two hours a day, maybe once or twice a week, whatever the size group. Once I step back and am alone, I notice I am sick with a weird exhaustion throughout my body and mind. It is almost cellular and has always been true, so it is not age-related. I am simply admitting

it finally, which is a big step. It's hard because I truly enjoy speaking. But perhaps it keeps me on my path of writing and will definitely prevent me from becoming some spiritual guru!

As for aging itself, it is a challenge, especially interacting with the medical establishment, which is so based, for better and for worse, in scientific fact, devoid of the Upper World. But I can bring the Upper World to it—I can love the people within medicine who help me, and I can feel that the unnamable is with me, or that we are one, whether I am remembering that or am distracted and momentarily forgetting it. I can fully experience this unnamable absolute side to life and also all the rest of life, the relative, everything I have done and do now. But I view aging as growing further into that oneness with the absolute side, gradually letting go of the relative, so that it is okay that Elaine Aron, body and personality, is a passing phenomenon. But not passed yet! Indeed, I feel younger than ever in many ways.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

Every path will be different, but as I said, watch for the flavor, the uniqueness, as well as the recurring themes, because they will be important as you consider the path ahead.

The Path Ahead

This book is intended as a sanctuary—a sanctuary from misinformation and confusion. But it cannot be a sanctuary from the facts, especially this one: *Dear gentle reader, we all die.* Some people believe in reincarnation, but let's set that aside, as it does not change the fact that this particular life of yours will end. The moving sidewalk always stops at the last gate in the terminal.

Of course, we cannot be thinking about death all the time, so we assume we will live a normal lifespan. The HSP (remember, that means the highly sensitive part of you or you as an highly sensitive

person) has thought deeply about death because of that survival strategy of processing everything deeply. But the years keep passing and the HS part knows we would be fools not to make the best use of the time that we have. That means establishing priorities. Making choices. But you have to know about the choices, or you might just pass right by some of them. This supernova has expanded your choices, and this chapter is a map for figuring out where there are crossroads in this new landscape that are at least worth exploring.

To me, the biggest impact of the Eastern teachers coming West is the possibility of the goal I enticed you with in the book's first chapter: a brain changed so much that it is in a state of permanent, almost perfect equanimity, not wasting energy on unnecessary worry and thus highly effective. How to get to that goal involves choices, of course, and then commitment to your choices. So, before we get more practical, let's just savor the sweetness in this possibility.

The Beatles and the Long Winding Road to the Door

I imagine that after World War II, a walking sidewalk or conveyor belt taking people from wartime fear and deprivation to a normal life of having a partner, children, and a good civilian job looked pretty appealing. But naturally, the next generation, their children, longed for something beyond material security. Hence, it was in perfect synchrony that the Eastern teachers arrived just as a generation of young people were stepping off the conveyor belt. They wanted something new—in music, fashion, and psychological experiences. The Beatles expressed that for them. No more "Mr. Nowhere Man" who doesn't know where he's going.

Then there was the meeting, the collision if you will—one of many, but this one included the Beatles (along with the Doors, Donovan, the Beach Boys, and several others back there in ancient musical times!) with the classic Eastern-teacher-come-West—Maharishi Mahesh Yogi. Suddenly the Beatles had an answer for Mr.

Nowhere Man. After the Beatles learned TM and spent some of their most productive time in India with Maharishi, they were suddenly telling the world about a path completely unlike any conveyor belt, and their songs about the path were immensely popular. “The Long and Winding Road” was the group’s twentieth, and last number one hit in the United States. The intensity of the longing to be taken to the door was so palpable, being felt by millions of Beatle fans. (Maybe take a moment to stop and listen to the song.)

“My Sweet Lord” was the first number one hit by a solo Beatle, George Harrison, the biggest-selling single of 1971, and the Grammy award winner that year. It was about the desire for spiritual *experience*, not just ideas. These songs, like Ken Wilber, were products of the supernova, and they worked their way deep into Western consciousness and spirituality. (By the way, all four Beatles continued TM, and as far as I know, Paul and Ringo still practice it.) Well, enough Beatles nostalgia. The point is that the teachers from the East, along with those Westerners who visited there and returned, such as Richard Alpert, who came back from India as Ram Dass and wrote the bestselling book *Be Here Now*, all introduced to the West explicitly spiritual paths that fully described the spiritual goal of awakening, enlightenment, or, in Ken Wilber’s terms, waking up. At the time, this was all on the fringe, a youth culture, hippie thing. But the youth grew up and some of them developed that permanent change in the brain, and there begins the real supernova.

From the East: The Ultimate Goal of Every Path

As I said in [Chapter 1](#), the goal of all Eastern teachings is enlightenment, waking up, that permanent change in the brain I keep talking about. In [Chapters 7](#) and [8](#), we will go thoroughly into both the research on it and descriptions of how it actually looks in Western culture, but for now, think of it as a door. Paths can go anywhere, but a door signifies a transition, an opening to an entirely new world.

Waking up does not have to be your only goal in life, of course. But if you can grasp that you (and all humans to some degree) have a capacity to make progress toward waking up, you could add that to your life goals. Certainly, the more you make it a priority, the more progress you will make, as with any capacity you choose to emphasize. One purpose of this book, and this chapter in particular, is to give you the chance to consider fully what adding such a goal would mean and how much you might want to invest in it so that you reach it sooner.

The teachers in the East analyzed human life deeply. They saw that the simplest human path is one that makes you happy and avoids pain. What makes you happy—or gives your life meaning, another goal we mentioned—depends on what you value. But looking farther ahead in life than you may want to, the teachers (probably HSPs or in touch with the deep-processing HS part of themselves) saw that you can get used to anything, even a great pleasure or achievement. We habituate to every stimulus. Think of fame. Or becoming really successful at something. Or something as simple as coffee. After a while, you get used to any of these. You may need them to feel good, but the original thrill passes. Falling in love is fantastic. Living with someone you love for ten or twenty years feels different.

You might respond, *Okay, if I get used to something, I can find a fresh source of pleasure or happiness.* But that still admits that nothing is permanent, which is disturbing in itself, and even a relatively perfect life eventually leads to aging and death. From the viewpoint of the Eastern teachers, while there is nothing wrong with pleasure, to be happy long-term requires that life be more than a series of pleasures or goals achieved.

I love Jeffery Martin's story of his search for happiness because it sounds almost like one you would hear an Eastern teacher tell his students: "There was a young man who had everything, but he was still not happy. He thought there must be something more, so he went in search of ¹ ..." Martin was a highly successful Silicon Valley figure who, having reached all his life goals, realized he still was not

happy. He decided to make happiness itself his next project, by using all the advanced research tools he could muster (studying neuroscience at Harvard just for this purpose and earning a Ph.D. elsewhere in research methods) to locate and understand the happiest people. He found they were the ones farthest along on traditional spiritual paths—awakened, enlightened, or whatever they called it.

In short, while you can try to enjoy every moment, it all will depend on your state of mind, your ability to savor or at least gracefully tolerate even the boring, ugly, or painful moments. Your *state* of mind. As for that other possible use of your time, helping people, I am sure you have noticed that the more you can give others your calm attention, the more you can help them—whether that is helping them avoid danger, listening to their troubles, or reflecting with them on a decision. So when it comes to how to use your time while alive, the Eastern teachers arrived at one answer: a permanently calm state of mind, one able to enjoy every moment and be maximally helpful to others.

The Vedic tradition of India focuses more on developing an internal, unchanging state of something akin to *eternal bliss*. This state is beyond the relative world of the senses, so it is not your ordinary bliss. It is in the background, creating permanent equanimity. Buddha's version of this state has a slightly different flavor. He focused more on the problem of impermanence—that pleasure always ends, as does life itself. The only solution in his opinion was to go beyond the relative, impermanent world, even beyond a state of eternal bliss (which he thought one might become attached to as another relative pleasure), and realize the emptiness of it all. This realization leads to an equanimity beyond pleasure or pain, a happiness beyond happiness.

If you skip the philosophical details, the bottom line is that we live in this relative world, with all of its infinite variety in space and time, and it is very satisfying sometimes—we would not want to miss it even if we could. But ultimately, we get used to every part of it, and it is impermanent, and so not fully satisfying. Then there is the experience of the absolute, pure being—call it a fullness of fullness

or fullness of emptiness. We can know about it, although many do not. Others have heard about it, that *mystical nonsense*, but figure it is all just talk. That's true. When it is just an idea, or someone else's experience, it is not very useful—unless the talk includes a way to experience this other half of life, living it 24/7.

So, the actual bottom line is that we can live in two worlds, the relative, measurable world and the nonrelative, infinite world. Most people only know the relative world, but that means they miss the equanimity of the nonrelative, along with the brain changes that make life in the relative so much easier. All agree that the development of this *knowing* of the nonrelative world, this state of permanent equanimity, usually takes some time. But even a little progress on this path can be satisfying, maybe even more than most temporary pleasures and certainly more satisfying than being lost in suffering.

Other Views of the Idea of Path and Goal

Some of you may have already heard spiritual types criticize thinking of awakening as a goal. That kind of talk only perpetuates one's sense of distance from something that really is already here. In one way this is very valid criticism. *Path* is only a metaphor and can get in the way of seeing that in a sense you are already at the goal—you and everything around you are aspects of one whole. But for that perspective of unity to be true for you, you must live that state of consciousness, a real state generated by your brain. As an idea, again, it is not very helpful. If someone is on the top of a mountain and you want the same view, you might think about stopping your climb if they shout down to you, "Don't bother, it isn't worth it." But it would sound like nonsense if they shouted, "Don't bother, you're already at the top." You *know* better.

One Path, Four Paths, Infinite Paths

There are two Eastern traditions that you will hear about often in this book. One is Vedanta, the *end of the Vedas*, the most recent thinking in Vedic philosophy (still very old), with origins well before 200 BCE), based in India. There are of course several varieties of Vedanta, but we will not worry much about that. The other tradition is Buddhism, which began in India and came out of Vedanta, but spread further than Vedanta and evolved in different locations into very different types of Buddhism. Of course, from the beginning they had slightly different views about enlightenment and the paths to it or there would not be two traditions. For us, it means we have choices, once we thoroughly understand the choices.

We will begin with Buddhism, only because Buddha taught one path with eight aspects to it. Then we will turn to Vedanta, which, besides having one path with eight aspects, also talks about four what we can call sub-paths, or routes to the same goal, although all paths involve some form of meditation, to be discussed more in [Chapters 5](#) and [6](#). But you can catch the flavor of Vedanta's four paths in this chapter.

Buddha's Eight-Fold Path

First, this is not just history. Many modern Buddhists are following this Eight-Fold Path. This may well be your choice too. There is some order to the eight, but mostly you work on all of them at once, something like a twelve-step program, if you are familiar with that. In fact, twelve-step programs work on body, mind, and spirit, and the spiritual part of the program is said to lead to a spiritual awakening, by decreasing one's self-centeredness—an idea that is going to become quite familiar to you in these pages.

As you will learn, or may already know, spiritual awakening or nirvana was Buddha's only goal, and when he reached it, he dedicated himself to sharing what he learned. When he began to teach, supposedly his first words were about the Four Noble Truths, which I will discuss more in [Chapter 5](#). The fourth Truth was that you should aim to reach nirvana using the Eight-Fold Path.

What are Buddha's eight folds? Today the eight are often discussed under three categories. The first includes the two folds that cover the subject of wisdom: *right view*, or the intellectual side of wisdom, learning what Buddha taught, and *right resolve*, the compassion side, meaning resolving to have thoughts of selfless renunciation and detachment—that loss of self-centeredness I mentioned as part of twelve-step programs too. According to Buddhism, you are not truly wise until you have your mind and your heart both in the right place. So you can see these two as the place to begin, but also to return to again and again.

The second category, the next three folds, fall under ethical behavior: *right speech*, *right action*, and *right livelihood*, which we will return to in a moment.

The last three are *right effort*, *right mindfulness*, and *right samadhi*. These come closer to what we think of as meditation. Right effort refers to energetically getting rid of unwholesome and evil thoughts and producing good, wholesome ones. Right mindfulness means being diligently aware of everything going on, all the time: what is happening in the body and in the mind—all sensations, feelings, thoughts, and ideas. When right mindfulness is practiced in meditation, this part of the Eight-Fold Path is the source of mindfulness meditation, which you have probably heard of—mindfulness of breathing. Buddha termed this specific practice of being aware of the inward and outward breath *anapanasati*. *Samadhi* means, roughly, *right concentration*. We will finish our discussion of Buddha's view of meditation in the chapter on meditation.

The exact meaning of some of these eight folds have changed with modern Buddhism. Originally, right view or understanding was about understanding karma and rebirth, and right resolve included nonviolence, but also setting out to become a monk so that you can avoid having to do any violence. Of course, the Eight-Fold Path has changed in its details. But I hope you can see now that it is a commitment to something meant to be completely life-changing and leading to nirvana, that final goal, something beyond the relative world.

Vedanta's Eight Limbs of One Path, But Also Four Paths

As in Buddhism, the Vedanta tradition has a general path, specified by the Eight Limbs of yoga. Yoga here means union with the absolute, Brahman, or pure being. (Just to be clear, in Sanskrit, *Brahman* refers to the absolute, both manifest and unmanifest; *Brahma* to the creator God; and *brahmin* to the highest class or caste. They are easily confused because they sound almost the same, the Sanskrit root *brah* meaning “firm, strong or most remote and expanded.”)

If Eight Limbs and Eight Folds sound similar, so will their content. It is no surprise, because Buddhism came out of Vedanta, and they continued to greatly influence each other. The first of the Eight Limbs is a list of things you should not do: do not harm others, lie, steal, lose self-control, or hoard. The second limb is a list of what you should do: be clean, contented, disciplined in your spiritual practice, study scriptures, and surrender (let go of your ego's insistence on having its way). The other six are about how to breathe in a way that supports your practice (called *pranayama*), how to stretch your body in preparation for sitting a long time (various *asanas* or poses)—which became yoga in the West—and four aspects of meditation.

Not part of the Eight Limbs of yoga is Vedanta's description of what you might think of as four routes to the same final goal, described as four because it was understood that people differ. Individual differences in the West are now treated as even more significant than in the East, thanks to the study of personality and temperament as part of scientific psychology. So now, as part of the collision of the two cultures—East meets West—the Spiritual Paths Foundation² helps you explore twelve possible spiritual paths based on “twelve families of archetypal styles.” However, here I will stay with Vedanta's four: service to others, devotion, self-inquiry, and meditation, along with the addition of one more that seems obvious, a path via nature. These are not tidy categories, however. Meditation

is usually practiced on the other paths, and most Vedanta teachers recommend you blend one or more of the four paths, or even use them all.³ Indeed, because everyone is unique, every path is unique. But let's look at the categories for the sake of seeing how they might look for you, in the West.

Mind the First Step

Before we look at specific paths, however, I want to emphasize that the Eight Folds and the Eight Limbs begin with vows to maintain ethical behavior. You rarely are reminded of this when investigating teachers and practices in the West. I suppose the fear is that it might turn people away, given that beginners in the West can be skeptical or lack dedication as it is, without the imposition of moral imperatives. But I think you need to know that, traditionally, no student in the East embarks on a spiritual path without first vowing to behave correctly. Failing to keep these vows, although it clearly happens, is thought to render every other effort useless. Correct behavior is built into the path, and without it you are not on it.

You can see that the ethical aspects of these lists are similar to those of any spiritual tradition or religion, such as the Ten Commandments. If you look deeper, the purpose of the ethical emphasis is not just about being a good person. It can reduce the importance of the personal ego or self when you focus on what someone else needs. If you do this enough, it changes your actual behavior, and hence your idea of yourself, how important you are in relation to those you are helping. The reduction of the ego's role in your life is a major emphasis in all spiritual traditions. This is not a surprise, given the substantial research that altruism increases well-being.⁴ If you think about the stress in your life, much of it comes from your ego worrying about its status in the eyes of others, worrying about being loved, and worrying about bodily health, because the body carries around the ego. These ethical guidelines reduce that stress. (Life is usually less stressful, after all, if you do

not commit adultery or dishonor your parents!) But when you seriously live by these guidelines, you are also automatically making your personal desires less important. By putting others first, your ego automatically shrinks. A reduced ego is associated with enlightenment. Is it cause or effect? A big question we will return to.

By the way, celibacy is not usually one of the vows explicitly. It is encouraged in the East and included under the vows involving right intention, being disciplined in your practice, controlling your senses, and surrendering your ego's desires. Buddha saw celibacy as important for his monks and nuns for them to stay focused, but many married people also became enlightened with his teachings, and in some Zen and Tibetan traditions, priests or monks (dedicated teachers) do marry. In the Vedanta tradition celibacy is associated with the student stage of life, intended to keep young men focused on learning. The time for reproduction as a householder, if that is one's path, comes later. Having said all that, there is no tradition in which you are allowed to exploit anyone sexually.

Clarifications about Vedanta's Four Paths

I will go into these four paths (plus my fifth) because, regardless of whether you choose to pursue any of them, I think it is interesting to see how they can be pursued in today's world if one chooses to. You may even find you are already on one of these paths. Keep in mind that they are often blended. You could practice all of them a little bit, but still have a specialty. And meditation or prayer is almost always part of the blend, because what matters is whether you are able to make the activities actually connect you to something larger, to the absolute or to God. This is crucial. At the same time, to be clear, none of the paths require excluding practical matters. In fact, the path of service, in particular, is intensely practical. And when people do reach their spiritual goal, they often continue the same activities.

The Path of Loving Service to Others, Good Works in God's Name, or Karma Yoga

What seems to be key to the path of service when it leads toward a spiritual goal is what is called selfless giving—a usually conscious spiritual choice to empty or forget oneself. During interactions with those you are helping, you might see God in the other or see that you and the other are one. In the New Testament it is what is meant by “Whatever you do unto the least of your brothers and sisters, you do unto me” (Matthew 25:35). In the East, a teacher might require so much mindfulness in a student while performing service that the self or ego is completely forgotten. No doubt that is the best state of mind for doing any good work. But for a Westerner not used to giving up all ego consciousness, it might be simply an intense emotional response to the needs of others that overcomes self-conscious thoughts such as *Am I doing this right?* or *What should I do for this person?* The point is, as the ego dissolves, the response becomes almost automatic and, again, the ego gone is the real purpose here, not just helping others.

I highly recommend further exploring the lives of two men who exemplify this path today. You can meet them both on *Buddha at the Gas Pump* (www.batgap.com). This remarkable website is the creation of Rick Archer, who has now interviewed over 750 ordinary spiritually awakening people. (He is cautious about the finality of the words *awakened* or *enlightened*.) The website's name alludes to just how common awakening has become—you may be pumping gas beside someone who is enlightened. By the way, most of the interviews on *Buddha at the Gas Pump* have transcripts, should you find reading them suits you better.

The first person I urge you to meet through this website in the context of service as a path is Adam Bucko, a young Polish seeker who spent time in India working with the homeless, and then did the same on the streets of New York, with kids, most of whom were fleeing sexual abuse or fell into sex work as a way to feed themselves. He combined the work with an even more diligent

meditation practice until he found they merged. He began to notice that he was using fewer skills and more of a sense of presence—not his, but God’s—in his interactions with those he was trying to help. “It is a practice of surrender, to let God work through me,” he says. He describes fully entering into a youth’s pain, then riding “a wave” of grace, knowing what to say without having to think about it. He now can feel that grace or presence whenever he wishes—it is only a matter of remembering. (This easy remembering is how many awakened people describe their state—they are not constantly thinking about grace, presence, or pure consciousness, but it is always close at hand.)

The second example of the path of service on the website is Nipun Mehta, founder of ServiceSpace, among other things. He describes ServiceSpace as being at the intersection of technology, volunteerism, and the gift economy. Although thirty-day silent meditation retreats are part of his practice, he is very out in the world the rest of the time, saying on his website, “My life is an attempt to bring smiles in the world and silence in my heart. [Relative and absolute.] I want to live simply, love purely, and give fearlessly.⁵”

Mehta says his compassionate action is not planned, but happens spontaneously, moving from within, and then becoming increasingly automatic, “guided by grace.” Like Bucko, he says that if you surrender to the flow, things will go better than if you let your ego guide you. How do you get started? He suggests small actions, perhaps opening a door for someone, and you automatically switch from *I* or ego to *we*, you and the other. This expansion has maybe only a tiny ripple effect in the world, but it has a significant effect on you. If you do enough of these small acts, which we can choose to do many times throughout the day, it begins to “dismantle the inner architecture, the egoic structure,” and you “fall into something much deeper,” that sense of being guided.

The Path of Devotion or *Bhakti* Yoga

Devotion is called a path of the heart, especially love of God. It can be expressed by devotional acts to God or to symbols of God or to the Godhead or Brahman, or else to those thought to be much closer to the goal than the devotee, such as saints. In the East devotion is also directed toward revered teachers.

Praying regularly and practicing rituals are often part of a devotional path. Think of the Muslim act of submission to Allah through praying five times a day, or the Jewish celebration of Shabbat, or any consistent time spent in a place of worship. You may want to find a church, temple, or mosque with services that truly focus on devotion. If you are Christian, look into Taizé services.

If you want to experiment on your own, you might want to try some of the eighteen devotional practices from various traditions that Andrew Harvey describes in *The Direct Path*. Or consider pilgrimage, a devotional path literally. Of course every Muslim is required, if it is possible, to make the pilgrimage or *hajj* to Mecca once in their life. One of the most famous pilgrimage routes is to Santiago de Compostela in the far northwest corner of Spain, where the Christian apostle James (Santiago or Saint James) is believed to be buried. About 350,000 a year walk at least the last 100 kilometers (375,000 in 2019), and many report deep spiritual experiences during the walk or after their arrival.⁶ If you are interested, there are websites with lists of pilgrimages all over the world. Or you could create a pilgrimage on your own, perhaps to the home of a revered ancestor. Remember, you are not aiming in this case for a tourist adventure, but a journey with meaning, dissolving your ego through physical effort and the focus of a traveler on foot.

The Path of Intellectual Inquiry or *Jnana* Yoga

Knowledge, right knowledge, is essential to any path. But in the East it can have a narrower definition: the process of self-inquiry, first emphasized in *The Upanishads*, which were written between 800 and 200 BCE. On this path you are repeatedly asked by a teacher, or you can ask yourself, *Who am I?* or *Who is thinking this thought?* or

Who is living in this body? The idea is that eventually you realize that you are not your ego identity, your body, your thoughts, or anything else except pure awareness or, in Buddha's terms, pure nothingness—the background to all your activities, the absolute wholeness that was there before you were born and there after you are gone. Of course, you can hear or read that idea a thousand times without it really meaning anything to you. Therefore, preparation through meditation or the presence of a teacher living this reality is usually essential.

Considering deeply the impermanence of the self is also part of the Eight-Fold Path and at the heart of a large portion of some Buddhist practices. A similar path of inquiry in the Zen Buddhist tradition would be to work on a koan with a teacher who sends you back to your *zafu* (pillow for zazen meditation) over and over, telling you that you still do not have it, until suddenly the proper realization comes.

In modern times, Ramana Maharishi (1879–1950) was the greatly admired Indian teacher who most promoted this path, as well as Sri Nisargadatta Maharaj (1897–1981), who recommended meditation along with self-inquiry. Both teachers have died, but their teachings are available in books and are some of the liveliest parts of the supernova of Western adaptations of the East's teachings. For example, you might read or watch on video Rupert Spira, Fred Davis, Michael Singer, or Francis Lucille talking about this path. There are hundreds of others teaching what has been called Neo-Advaita Vedanta or radical nonduality. I mentioned them before and will come back to them in the last chapter.

Indeed, the supernova has given rise to countless books and websites on all forms of spirituality—a very broad path of intellectual inquiry indeed. When exploring all this information, one must be alert as to what is taking you forward and what is distracting or leading you away. But people do report becoming enlightened through reading a book by someone who was already there—for example, reading Eckhart Tolle's *The Power of Now*—and some books are meant to do exactly that: Fred Davis's *The Book of*

Undoing and The Incredible Reality of You by LUCIALORN (awakeningworld.net).

The West has always emphasized intellectual study as a path to God, hopefully culminating in some form of God realization. If you are Jewish, you might know the intellectual path through study of the Torah, or you might pursue a more intuitive-intellectual path with a teacher of Kabbalah. In Christianity, scriptural study is used to go deeper and deeper into the meaning of God's words using *lectio divina* (Latin for divine reading), a traditional monastic practice of scriptural reading, meditation, and prayer that was formalized by Guigo the Carthusian in the twelfth century. Pope Francis left us a modern, nine-step version on the internet. The final step is always the goal of a direct experience of the presence of God.

The Path of Meditation or *Raja* Yoga

Meditation is a path in itself, but also meant to be blended with other paths, hence it is sometimes called *Raja* (meaning king or ruler) yoga. There are now so many practices called meditation that part of [Chapter 5](#) and all of 6 are entirely about the different kinds so you can better choose.

The Path of Nature and the Body

I added this fifth path, of the body and nature, partly because of the West's focus on the physical practice of yoga, and also because so many people in the West simply say that their spiritual path is spending time in nature.

Nature, however, has not always been seen as a path, in the East or the West. It is in part the result of an earlier contact of the West with the East going back to Ralph Waldo Emerson, the transcendentalist. Emerson was fascinated by Eastern spirituality and took from it the view that nature is a way to be one with the Divine, independent of institutions. His friend, Henry David Thoreau, chose

a spiritual path of living in a simple cabin in the woods. (Thoreau's *On Walden Pond* was a favorite read in the sixties.)

It seems to me that Western disillusionment with both religion and reason, plus seeing war after war, all added to this return to nature as the final place of solace. It is seen in the psychologist Carl Jung, who hand-built a tower of stone as a spiritual retreat, and in so many poets at that time, such as Yeats, Robinson Jeffers, and Rilke, who all lived in and/or built stone towers, seeming to seek the Upper World through the Lower World of nature, full of that hunger for an answer in stone to the meaning of life that later fueled the supernova.

In relation to the supernova, there is also the explosive popularity of yoga in the West. These body postures, called *asanas*, that I said earlier are only one aspect of traditional yoga's eight limbs, may seem to many as a familiar, reliable, controllable path to something better. The body is certainly part of nature and one you can see—no belief required. Further, you can feel the results of your practice quickly. It seems that we have pulled yoga postures out of the supernova and made it a path of its own.

Of course, this aspect of yoga can be practiced independent of any spiritual path, just as compassionate behavior can be practiced by atheists. But many forms of yoga do retain their spiritual roots, such as *Kriya* yoga, which focuses on breathing and specific postures to reach the common spiritual goal of enlightenment. Tantra yoga also focuses on the body, and while we associate it with enhancing sexuality, it is much more than that.

There are other richly developed methods coming from the East for the use of the body for spiritual purposes—for example, Qigong and Tai Chi, movements based on Taoist and Chinese medicine principles surrounding Qi or the spiritual energy within the body. (Qigong, five thousand years old, is much easier to practice; Tai Chi arose out of it as a martial art, but now they are used similarly.) And we should not forget all the traditional shamanic and indigenous methods of using the body as a path, such as dance, drumming, fasting, and sweat lodges. These do not come to us directly via the supernova, although the increased interest in them is surely largely

due to the supernova's emphasis on higher states of consciousness. Which brings us to psychedelics ...

Psychedelics, a Doorway?

Another path, or perhaps best described as a doorway, is the use of psychedelics, such as LSD, psilocybin, mescaline, and ayahuasca. Psychedelics might be seen as a path involving nature because, except for LSD, these come from plants and mushrooms, knowledge of which was possessed mostly by the West's indigenous cultures. And some of them lead to experiences involving new perceptions of nature. In the East, while psychedelic plants were less common, they were certainly available and must have been recognized as a source of spiritual experiences. The Vedas have an entire book dedicated to *soma*, a deified drink made from a plant. But there is great controversy as to what *soma* actually referred to, and it was probably not in use at the time of Vedanta. But however much psychedelics might have once been used in the East, it seems to have faded from favor as a path to enlightenment.

This is a hot topic, for sure. Psychedelics sit right in the middle of today's spiritual landscape—in the middle of our sanctuary too. Some of you have already used psychedelics or are interested in them. Others of you I am sure would never try any of them. And then there are the hesitant but curious.

I have absolutely no wish to judge their use. But I do wish to stay focused on my topic, because I have not seen anyone, East or West, describe regular use of psychedelics as a practice that leads to awakening, or to the calm, efficient mind 24/7 that I have urged you to develop. The use of hallucinogens was not approved by any of the Eastern teachers who arrived in the West, as far as I know. Paramahansa Yogananda, whom I mentioned in [Chapter 1](#) as one of the earliest teachers to come from the East, stated unequivocally that no great spiritual teacher advocated their use.⁷ Among traditional Buddhist teachers, not using intoxicants is one of the

standard Buddhist precepts that you may be asked to accept if you learn Buddhist meditation methods.

If you are interested in the first collision of the longing for spiritual *experience* in the West with new methods to get there, you can look up both Ram Dass and the Beatles. Both were leaders in the use of psychedelics before turning to Eastern methods for getting high. Remember my supernova analogy involves a collision in the sixties, but as with all supernovas, it took years for its light to reach us. Now one way we see it is in a resurgence of interest in psychedelics as providing potentially life-transforming spiritual experiences. Research on their clinical use has resumed, especially on the carefully planned use of hallucinogens for reducing symptoms of depression and PTSD. The research is well summarized in Michael Pollan's 2018 book *How to Change Your Mind: What the New Science of Psychedelics Teaches Us About Consciousness, Dying, Addiction, Depression, and Transcendence*.

Very few of today's spiritual teachers, especially Westerners who were students of Eastern teachers, would simply say do not use hallucinogens under any circumstances. But those speaking from personal experience continued to mostly discourage it, including Ram Dass⁸ and Alan Watts.⁹ Clearly hallucinogens can lead to interest in an Eastern spiritual path. Besides Ram Dass, an example is Rick Archer, who I mentioned earlier as the creator of the podcast *Buddha at the Gas Pump*. In a 2022 interview of himself by a guest¹⁰ he discussed his avid use of LSD and other drugs as a teenager. Asked if there was any path that he advised against, he said that one would be using psychedelics over and over and thinking you would eventually arrive at "some abiding liberated state. I'm very skeptical of that. I haven't seen it." And this was after interviewing 670 awakening persons by that time. He added that the greatest value of it is perhaps as an eye opener, as it was for him. Steve Taylor, a professor you will meet in [Chapter 7](#), who has studied enlightened people for decades, said the same: He has never seen the use of psychedelics lead to awakening, although, like Archer, he sees these experiences as potentially transformative in other ways.¹¹

If you are still interested in the pros and cons of psychedelics bubbling inside the supernova, you can follow the debate within modern Buddhism, with a new, younger generation speaking up about whether or not psychedelics can enhance meditation practice or at least bring people to it, or if it should be avoided, not being at all what Buddha had in mind.^{[12](#)}

A Few Thoughts on High Sensitivity and Paths

The HSP (person or part) seems especially likely to see the value of a spiritual path and may be most drawn to a path of selfless giving, given their deep empathy for the suffering of others. They may easily forget their own needs as they move into the egoless state that is ideal for this path. But one must be careful to protect at least one's basic physical health. (Even Jesus did not heal everyone in Galilee. If you read carefully, Jesus gave of himself totally at times, yet displayed excellent boundaries when he chose to.)

A few more comments on this subject: Paths related to nature may be very attractive to HSPs, with their keen awareness of the subtle details in natural environments. Practices involving the body can help ground HSPs. High sensation seeking is another trait the HSP can be high or low on,^{[13](#)} and if you are a high sensation seeker, this will also definitely affect your choice of paths. For you, the more interesting the sights along the pilgrimage route, the better! Finally, high-sensation-seeking HSPs in particular may be very interested in psychedelics, but all HSPs should be cautious about them, as HSPs tend to be more affected than others by medications of all types.^{[14](#)}

Spiritual Path and Practices

Spiritual paths and practices are intimately connected. I only separate them because you may well be involved in a practice, such as yoga postures or mindful breathing, that you have undertaken

independent of any particular path, and there are some things worth saying about practice in itself.

Why Have a Practice and Which One?

Back to the moving sidewalk. Time passes whether we engage consistently in a practice or not, but if we do not bother, or choose the wrong practice for us, we are missing an opportunity. Although awakenings do sometimes happen suddenly, mostly they are the product of doing the right practice consistently. As I said earlier, meditation in particular can be like a souped-up snowplow engine, moving you faster and faster toward almost any goal, from better parenting to better marathon performance to enlightenment.

The practices available today look like crisscrossing ski trails around a hot chocolate stand. There must be hundreds of practices, and that abundance may be good, because the right practice for you is the one you will keep doing. And with so many possibilities, you are less likely to accept the first practice you hear about and miss something that might be better for you.

If you identify with a religious tradition and do not want to leave it entirely, that narrows the choices some. But not entirely. It seems that most or all religions are starting to include more practices to provide direct experience—for example, Christian Centering Prayer and Christian Meditation, various Jewish meditation practices,^{[15](#)} and of course Muslims have Sufi practices available, including meditation.

Sampling Before Settling Down

If you are trying out different practices, you probably do not have, or have given up on following, the instructions of a spiritual teacher, guide, or director. That means when you consider a practice, you must hear out the reasons teachers have developed it and adherents do it. They are going to be enthusiastic about it. There may be others who trash it. Be careful both ways. After learning a little,

check in with your own wisest self. Carl Jung felt that Westerners, in particular, tend to think of their own souls as barren, needing to bring in some teaching or practice from elsewhere, especially from cultures not their own, whereas we all contain archetypal knowledge of the mysteries if we would seek to find that inside ourselves.¹⁶ His view might seem a bit extreme, yet not only your path but your experiences with a practice will be unique, so allow your inner self to find and develop your practice in the ways that suit you.

If You Have a Practice Now, Stay with It or Change?

If you already have a practice, learning about others can lead to a crisis of faith around your own. Go slow here. The grass may be greener, or just more colorful. Remember why you took up the practice you have been loyal to thus far, and whether there has been progress, even if gradual, and whether you have devoted enough time to it daily for it to work as it is supposed to. There will always be ups and downs. A practice requires consistency to see past the bumps. The speed toward your goal is not the only criterion. The depth you sense behind the teaching of the practice matters too.

On the other hand, you only have so much time in your day or your life. Consider whether you have given it your all—practiced *consistently* for years, and if it is meditation, gone on some retreats. Do you still have serious doubts about your practice? Had them for some time? Then possibly it is not actually working to take you, personally, to its purported goal. Or perhaps your ultimate goal seems different to you now. I think we can move along a path and reach a certain milepost and realize it is only an end point of one leg of the journey. Then you move on using a different vehicle. I wish I could help you more, but everyone's journey is unique and only you can find the best path for yourself. Perhaps try switching for only a trial period. And maybe only do that after finishing this book and

reflecting for a while. And if you stop what you were doing, remember you can always return to it if you choose to.

Above All, Ride the Tiger

Consider carefully how much time you can give your practice consistently—twice a day, once a day, once a week. You might want to do more but simply cannot given your circumstances. In allotting your time, seriously consider your priorities, the goals (plural) pulling you. Remember it is not about choosing one goal over another, relative versus absolute, but about budgeting time according to your priorities. Although, remember that some practices (especially meditation) can make you more efficient at reaching your other goals. Finally, give yourself credit for doing what you can do. Remember to get rest—meditation or quiet prayer, but also enough sleep and downtime. Exhaustion leads to dull experiences in your practice and then to loss of faith in it.

A regular practice should be changing your nervous system. Of course everything we do every day changes our nervous system because of what is called neuroplasticity. The goal with any practice is to take advantage of that. Ride that hungry tiger called time! Sure, time, like the tiger, will kill you someday. But meanwhile, make time itself, every passing day of it, take you where you want to go.

What About You?

Do you have a spiritual practice? If you do not, reflect honestly and compassionately about why. If you do have one, are you happy with it? If you're not sure, have you lost touch with how to do it correctly? Are you devoting enough time to it for it to work? If it feels right sometimes but not others, what circumstances facilitate it? Who supports you in it (and who does not)? Or is it time for a change? Maybe you have changed several times. If so, why?

I apologize for all the questions. I am just trying to stir your thoughts.

What About Me?

Here's how my practice began: It was early autumn in British Columbia, so naturally it had been raining all afternoon. I was six months pregnant, and we were living in a pup tent (hard to get in and out of at that stage, or spend a whole day in when it is raining). The tent was near the well and a broken-down house on the ten acres of land that Art and I had bought, without first seeing it, on Cortes Island. Night was falling, it was cold, and we were trying to build a fire with wet wood.

Why in the world?! It was the sixties, or rather 1970. Like many others of our generation, we had gone "back to the land," taking the revolution we were hoping for out of the cities, where it had become mired in drugs. So much of that era was innocently spiritual, a path involving nature. Being pregnant, which we very much planned, was all part of that. As for living this close to nature, in a tent and all that, I figured that (although not really knowing much on the subject) if indigenous peoples had lived in rough shelters with no running water or electricity, so could I.

Except we were basically city people. We had left Berkeley for Canada because of the new draft policy of enlisting first-year doctoral students, then left Toronto when Art had that doctoral degree. We had arrived in a Triumph Spitfire that had lost first gear somewhere in Manitoba, so it was not going anywhere anymore. Once we were on the island, we had to walk a mile just for groceries. (Until we bought a horse.) We were totally ignorant of how to accomplish our plan of raising our food. I planted a garden right away that was sure to fail, with the weather getting colder, in ground without topsoil, with no fence around it. The deer loved the five or six little green sprouts that sprang up.

Still, we held on to our dream, although it was fading that night like the gray light. Then we saw a yellow pickup truck stop at the top

of the driveway. A guy with long blond hair got out and stared at us. A local, pausing to gather comedy material for a dinnertime story? No. It was Barry. We had met Barry and Trisha briefly a few days before at the little island store, and we were all eager to get together soon. They were two of the growing number of hippies (about thirty) on the island and had been there the longest, living in a geodesic dome Barry had built. They knew which property we had bought, so Barry had stopped by. They had no idea we were in a pup tent.

Barry rummaged through his truck, then came down to join us. He had a relatively dry cardboard box and a can of lighter fluid. "Let me show you how this is done the old-fashioned way." He put kindling in the box, put the box on its side to keep out the rain, and doused the whole thing with lighter fluid. Fire! Then, after chatting a bit in the pouring rain, Barry of course invited us to dinner. This was before cell phones, so he could not warn Trisha. Still, in the manner of our shared communal vision of life after the revolution, she cooked up a feast. These two were angels!

Trisha was just back from Mallorca, Spain, after spending many months, with hundreds of others, at a meditation course with Maharishi Mahesh Yogi. Yes, we had heard of him. Transcendental Meditation. The Beatles. Maharishi said meditating twice a day would bring us all to enlightenment, and if enough did it, it would change the world. Two of our life goals with one practice. No belief needed. It was all documented with physiological research, she told us.

We went for a new path, practice, and goal, all in one. We learned TM in Paris the next year (long story there), and the year after we became TM teachers, then faculty members of Maharishi International University. Just to be clear, it was never about Maharishi. I was not starstruck by him. It was all about those two goals—becoming enlightened (Maharishi spelled that out very carefully) and changing the world, helping others, effortlessly. I have been doing TM very regularly ever since, because for me it is so easy and comfortable, like wrapping myself in my favorite blanket and sitting down in an easy chair. It seems to save time in the long run to be clear minded when doing whatever I am doing the rest of

the day, so I have rarely felt I just did not have time to meditate. Sometimes circumstances require meditating less, but most of the time now we meditate one hour in the morning and one in the afternoon. (Most people who learn TM meditate twenty minutes twice a day; we are doing an advanced practice so we add more time.)

We also do some yoga asanas and pranayama or breathing practices that are part of the Eight Limbs of yoga, and a rest before the afternoon meditation. We do longer meditations during at-home retreats, something we asked Maharishi's permission to do years ago because it is generally not recommended to do long meditations at home simply because a few, very few, people have strange experiences when they do that. (The TM organization runs retreats frequently.) I look forward to our retreats, usually six days every month now, and I still think I get more done by reducing my work month to only three weeks for this purpose than if I did not.

Would I meditate even more? No, I don't think I would derive any more benefit, and I enjoy the things I do when I am not meditating also, such as writing this book. But meditation is the foundation of my life. It is about a state of consciousness that enriches every aspect of life, making for greater creativity, success, love, happiness, health. But this is my experience. It does not do everything for everyone. So I will not go on and on. This is one reason why these sections are in italics!

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

Having given the issue of a practice some thought, do increase your practice or add one if you have decided you want to. Maybe start simple. Consider a regular time in your day for a brief ritual, prayer, or meditation—when you get up, before a meal, or before bed. Maybe just go outdoors or to a window each morning to greet the day. Read some scripture or poetry at a regular time, then reflect on it or carry it in your heart through the day. When there is more stress in your life you might think to drop your practice, but that

may be the best time to stay consistent, at least for a month, and see if, as TM teachers would say, you actually *do less but accomplish more*.

The Social Side of Paths and Practices

Like most highly sensitive people, I am an introvert (although at least one-third of HSPs are extraverts). The sensitive part of most people is more introverted, preferring to reflect privately on experiences or have a deep conversation with one other person. For this reason, I will not dwell long on the social side of your path except to say that it is unavoidable and potentially valuable. Indeed, all the traditions espouse the value of group life because being with others who have the same general goal, such as staying on the Eight-Fold Path, supports your own practice and life purpose. Group life still can be tricky for HSPs, given that the majority of people, even in a spiritual-practice-oriented group, may not be very sensitive. You will want to seek out some other HSPs in the group, or those with their HS part most available.

A group usually means there's a leader, and that usually means a spiritual teacher of some sort. Thus, I need to touch on the subject of *perilous paths*. The internet has hundreds of tips for recognizing an unscrupulous spiritual teacher (why they do indeed exist was the subject of [Chapter 2](#)) and I recommend you read some of this. A few highlights begin with, first of all, realizing no one is perfect, not even a *realized master*. There is always some personality left, so watch for a teacher's particular issues. You can learn a great deal even from watching videos. Is the person genuinely humble? Or do you sense something a little fake? How commercial is the atmosphere?

If or when you are around the person more, how does he or she handle money, power over staff or volunteers, criticism or correction, the natural environment? In your interactions, do you feel genuinely seen and heard, or do the person's responses seem rote or inapplicable to you? If you want to shop around, is that okay with this person? Preferably it is even encouraged.

As for the group, how do you feel among them? Notice how they behave—they are partially the products of this person's teaching. How do they treat one another and you? You need to observe at first from a bit of distance, because very soon that distance will be gone.

All spiritual traditions recommend a group life. That is not surprising. Social psychology teaches us that joining a group always means adopting some of the group's attitudes. However, the nature of spiritual teachings gives group life a particular potency, creating a slippery slope—from reasonable students agreeing on main points, to a solid group of total believers rejecting other perspectives, to, sometimes, something more like a cult. Here is the perilous path that I doubt you will find yourself on, but there are a shocking number of stories of seemingly normal, intelligent people coming to believe in outlandish ideas presented by convincing leaders, or just ignoring things that should not be going on, such as a leader using students for their own sexual or financial purposes.

Of course one wonders how it can happen, but besides normal group pressure, consider how you would feel if a truly powerful spiritual leader elevated you to the inner circle? It is one of the most delicious rewards humans can feel. You might be willing to ignore a few problems to enjoy the ethereal atmosphere. Conversely, being forever rejected from the inner circle, banished back into the mud of eternal ignorance, can feel like one of the worst punishments imaginable.

I recommend everyone learn to protect themselves from destructive group dynamics by reading Phil Zimbardo's *The Lucifer Effect: Understanding How Good People Turn Evil*. It's one of the most important spiritual books ever written, although not intended at all to be one. But it seems no coincidence that Zimbardo put Lucifer in the title, as the name symbolizes ultimate spiritual evil. You will be fascinated by the story of the Stanford Prison Experiment, but do not miss Zimbardo's ten steps for resisting this universal poison.

Now that I have scared you about perilous paths, I really do believe you can recognize a problematic spiritual teacher, if not right away then eventually. It's just that sooner is better.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

This chapter has focused on paths and practices, mostly from an Eastern perspective. The next chapter is about the effect of childhood on spiritual paths, which may involve your making wonderful discoveries as you read and reflect, but might also mean finding more to clean up. As I keep saying, cleaning up is so important for balancing a path of waking up. Addictions, recurring nightmares, abusive relationships, a miserable life at home or at work, anxiety, depression—they often have their roots in childhood, and they have to be faced for the sake of your life path, even if you can only clean them up imperfectly. Please keep in mind that the Lower World is sacred, and if we ignore its messages, it will only send stronger ones. Your childhood is also sacred, whatever it was like, because, as I said at the outset, you are sacred. So approach the next chapter with a heart full of love for the little boy or girl to whom it is devoted.

CHAPTER 4

LEARNING FROM CHILDHOOD

In this chapter we will look at how your childhood has affected your life path. We will start with what came before you and shaped your childhood: your parents' parents, that is your grandparents, and your parents' childhood. Then, before you consider your own childhood, I will give you some aspects to consider—your innate temperament, your parents' parenting style, your attachment style, and any traumas you experienced.

As I have already said, this book rarely goes into *how* to clean up, but simply helps you take an inventory that is relevant to your path. Of course, even simply taking an inventory can lead to uncomfortable places. So what happened to the idea of this book being a sanctuary? Okay, think wildlife sanctuary: We honor all life, no matter what part of nature we are seeing at the moment—in this case, your nature. It's a sanctuary in that you do not have to worry about being given a one-sided perspective, but it is not always perfectly comfortable. Thus, you might want to make use of the practice I give below, now and then or even daily. Especially if you develop the habit, you will have an established relationship with *someone* for when things are difficult, including while working with the inventory sections of this book.

Conversing with Your Holy Other About Troubles, Trauma—or Anything

With all the emphasis in the last chapter on practices, I am going to suggest one you will not receive elsewhere: talking with the Big Therapist in the Sky (joke). Remember our discussion of God in [Chapter 1](#)? Please be open-minded about trying this practice. You do not need to think you are talking directly to God. Maybe consider that you are connecting to a very personal part of yourself. What you believe in this regard really does not matter for this practice to work. If some version of God would not be your choice, you could easily do this dialogue with Buddha, Jesus, Mary, Mohammad, your favorite bodhisattva or saint, your higher power, your highest self, or the Great Whatever. I like my Holy Other. Or get to know your animal ally—there are several books on this, for example *The Practice of Ally Work* by Jeffrey Raff. In this case, you have the whole animal kingdom in which to find the individual beastie waiting for you.

If you want to involve God, you might consider looking at Neale Donald Walsch's *Conversations with God*. I like the opening, in which he suggests that God would like to talk *with us*, privately, daily, and how we might do that. The prophets dialogued with God (if they could get a word in edgewise!). Why not you? If it suits you, of course. By the way, Walsch felt strongly that we should not impose onto others the insights that come from our dialogues but keep them private. I totally agree. That said, the rest of his book is about the insights he received during his conversations! Oh well.

What you will be doing is called active imagination, something developed by Carl Jung. It is a potentially very powerful tool, to be taken quite seriously. It is not daydreaming or ordinary fantasy, but a dialogue between your conscious mind and any part of yourself (or from a larger realm) that you are not so conscious of. You might, for example, use active imagination to converse with your inner little boy or girl, as I discuss at length in *The Undervalued Self*. But here our focus is on the highest *whatever* you might want to hear from.

Start your conversation by putting your name or initial on the first line of a page, on paper or on your computer, as if writing a script. (You can also do this without writing, but your mind is more likely to wander, or else to race, so that you cannot recall later what was said.) Write what is on your mind, then on a new line write an initial to represent the other. Then wait.

You might find yourself hearing and writing down something surprising. Or not. Do not judge yourself or your conversation partner. If nothing comes or feels very clear, write anything that comes to mind after your partner's initial. Now respond on a new line, starting with your own initial. Always start on a new line with the initial of whoever is speaking. If the dialogue starts to flow, continue until you feel it is coming to an end.

Do you think you are just imagining this other's voice? Of course you are. *How else would it reach you?* Think of it as an extension of your dream life. Where do dreams come from? From your unconscious, the realm of things you do not consciously know about but ought to. The Lower World. The inventories you will be doing in this chapter and future ones will probably take you into that Lower World, as you reflect on all parts of your history, including the traumas. If this stirs up uncomfortable feelings, you may want to seek out a therapist, of course. But you also may find this practice will lead to conversations through active imagination that provide comfort or insight of a fresh kind.

More Cleaning-Up Inventory—Now Your Parents

In a previous chapter we looked at how your ancestors shaped your life path. In this one, we move on to your closer family history, your parents' lives before you were born, so that means also their parents (your grandparents). Of course we might hope you have little to report about your parents and theirs that could trouble your path, but that would be surprising if you are looking at your two parents

plus each of their parents and all of the siblings possibly involved. Remember, this is just taking an inventory so that you know better where to clean up when you are ready to.

What About You?

Given your parents' childhoods, what were their likely goals, conscious or unconscious, and what did they perhaps wish to avoid at all costs? What were their underlying fears or unprocessed griefs? Keep in mind that you are watching for portions of life that are cut off, unlived. These are often sources of depression, grief, anxiety, or repressed trauma that you may not have given voice to before. This is not at all meant to make you feel negative about your past or blame your parents, but simply to know where to smooth your path and to become freer to make the right choices by understanding better where you are coming from.

What About Me?

It was March 1919, and the Spanish flu epidemic was raging. My father, Wesley, was eight. Through his bedroom wall he could hear the doctors pounding on his mother, trying to restart her heart in a fight for her life that failed. His little sister was screaming, "Stop spanking Mama." Young Wesley knew something bad had happened when it became very quiet. He was recovering from the flu, like the other kids in his large family. His mom had nursed them all and now was dying from one of its complications.

Her name was Pearl. She was very young, and photos tell me she was beautiful. I can just imagine her quarantined in her home. My grandfather, who adored his Pearl, was away on business, so she was alone as head of the house. There would have been about a dozen, as she was the second wife and had three young children of her own as well as stepchildren nearly her own age. Suddenly she was gone.

This was a grandmother I never knew, someone who might have made a large difference in my life as well as my father's. Both she and my other grandmother, my mother's mother, Nelle, whom I knew well, left me with a legacy of grief and loss. Added to that, the man Nelle married, Francis (the man with the part-Native American mother in the previous chapter), lost his mother when he was four, and he died while Grandma Nelle was a young mother, leaving her alive but without her incredibly handsome and generous husband.

My aunt was only three years old, but she remembers her mother, my grandma Nelle, lying on Grandpa Francis's grave, clawing at the grass, trying to dig down to her husband's body. My aunt heard Nelle tell her mother, Minnie, that she would die without him.

My mother, eleven years old, was her father's darling. What did she feel, with her grief overshadowed by her mother's, the mother she seemed to be losing now also, all because of loving someone so passionately?

The back story to the death of Francis is that my great-grandmother Minnie survived by decades Henry Ashcraft, whom you met in [Chapter 1](#). He was the young man suffering from PTSD after the Civil War, who went from hooligan to preacher. Minnie raised his surviving son and daughter. The daughter, my grandmother Nelle, was only eleven when she lost her father. (That age would repeat with her daughter, my mother.)

Minnie kept the family in the Free Methodist tradition, straight and narrow. When Nelle had graduated from Greenville College, the local Free Methodist school, the family was invited to come West to a new Free Methodist school in Wessington Springs, South Dakota. The widely respected Minnie would be a preceptress (a female teacher of morals) and Nelle would teach music. Music was very important to churches and to pioneer life generally, it being almost the only easily obtained entertainment (at least of the approved sort). Every woman needed to be a musician, for her family, church, and the advancement of civilization.

In the rustic little town of Wessington Springs, Nelle stood out as a gorgeous, buxom redhead. She was engaged to someone back in Greenville, a stodgy lawyer it sounds like, but in Wessington Springs

she met the man whose loss nearly killed her. This was my grandfather, Francis Harden, whom I wrote about in the previous chapter, about ancestors. You might recall he also ended up at Wessington Springs, although he spent most of his time working as a cowboy. However, it seems that he took one look at Nelle and decided it was time to learn to read and write, if she would teach him. Teach him? She would marry him. So much for the lawyer fiancé.

Minnie was not crazy about Francis but accepted the inevitable. At least he seemed to have a knack for learning, given how quickly he advanced in the educational programs of the Free Methodist Church and beyond, but I am ahead of myself.

Nelle and Francis were quite the item, both extremely good-looking. They married almost immediately after meeting, and Minnie took over the advancement of her impoverished but obviously talented son-in-law, just as she had managed her daughter's life. They moved back to Illinois, where Nelle and Minnie were from and where my mother was born. Then they moved to McKinney, Texas, where they had been invited to start a new Free Methodist college (these were more like high school and college combinations). Francis was an important part of the faculty but also loved athletics and teaching physical education. In the class photos, he was the exceptionally handsome guy with the sculptured face of the classic Plains Indian.

When the school was closed, the victim of church politics, Minnie moved them all farther west, to Berkeley, where Francis studied economics at the University of California and was about to write his doctoral dissertation when he was "called" to be president of the new Free Methodist college in Los Angeles.

Their first child, Marian, was my mother, born in Illinois, before the move. The birth was horrible, I am sure scarring both mother and child. Marian was wrenched out by forceps and screamed for weeks—the neighbors all remembered it—because of the damage to her skull. For years Francis and Nelle feared having a second child, but a wise Berkeley woman doctor saw Nelle through another childbirth, keeping her weight down so that the next baby was not

so large. This yielded my beloved Aunt Kay. All four members of the young family were absurdly happy with one another, and no doubt the ambitious Grandma Minnie was pleased too. All had gone well.

Then the tragedy of Francis's death. He was on an outing with the college kids up to the snowy mountains above Los Angeles. The legend is that he already had the flu and got chilled helping dig cars out of the snow. He would get better, go back to work, then relapse. Finally, it turned into something worse. My aunt said it was a mastoid infection (infection in a bone in the skull). I also heard he had meningitis, which can result from that. There were no antibiotics back then, and he was in terrible pain. They used glass straws in those days, and my Aunt Kay remembered her mother Nelle saying it was so painful that he bit through those straws when gritting his teeth and the glass had to be cleaned out of his mouth. It was a quick, horrible death. My mother says she was told his last words were the words of the hymn, "Nearer My God to Thee."

Nelle just wanted to die, but my very grounded great-grandmother Minnie stayed with her day and night and held the family together. My mother must have tried also. She never cried—until two months later when her dog ate the pet chicken her father had given her. That broke the dam. A few years later, at thirteen, she fell in love with an unusual intensity. But the boy's parents thought this was inappropriate and broke up the romance. She grieved for months, as deeply as her mother had, and then told me later that after the breakup she decided never to love anyone again. This vow, arising from unresolved grief, did not bode well for her future husband and children.

I carry that trauma of Francis, Nelle, Marian, and Kay in many ways. One expression of it was denial. For example, when I would inquire about these events when I was older, my mother would say with obvious frustration, "Can't you forget the past?" My mother constantly urged me to be happy. Whatever we were doing, she had to ask, "Isn't this fun?" Which of course had the opposite effect. Ironically, at thirteen I met a boy; I was the same age my mother had been when she fell in love and her boyfriend's parents made them break up. My mother did not approve of my boyfriend and

tried to break us up. This is a good example of how denial of past pain opens us to passing on the same pain to the next generation.

As for the spiritual impact on me, it seems simple now: For most of my life I never could grasp the idea found throughout Christianity that God or Jesus loves me. It required twenty years of intensive therapy to open the door of love closed for three generations because it had been so risky to hold on to anyone.

Your Path, Your Childhood

Having discussed parents of parents and parents prior to their being parents, we have arrived at the subject of your parents as parents and of childhood. I could provide countless examples of how childhood affects one's path. For example, I have a friend who is a dedicated psychotherapist. She would like to attend meditation retreats now and then, but that would mean missing some sessions with her patients. She takes vacations because her family wants her to, but these retreats would be in addition and just for herself. Having been taught in her Catholic school and home that one should sacrifice unstintingly for others, taking time for her path seemed self-indulgent. She knew this was not true. In the long run her patients would be better off if she went on retreats, but she could not see retreats as a choice until she did some serious cleaning up of her guilt about doing anything special for herself.

Equally interesting are the ways unusual childhoods substantially affected various spiritual teachers. For example, Martin Buber was abandoned by his mother when he was three, and as an adult focused his spiritual teachings on what had been missing in his early life, the I-Thou relationship.¹ Or Andrew Harvey's life story, in his book *The Direct Path*, in which he describes his idealizing of and later being wounded by first his mother and then later a woman guru. The pain caused by the guru led to his wishing to save us all from the guru system, but surely the mother played a role in this thorough disillusionment. Thomas Merton lost his mother, then his father, joined a monastery, chose solitude—then experienced a spell

of almost uncontrollable attraction to a nurse, a caregiver he had while recovering from surgery. It is as though his unconscious need for those lost connections finally surfaced. I do not mean to disparage the insights of any of these teachers, but only want to point out that our spiritual paths and insights are inevitably flavored by our childhoods.

Childhood and HSPs

As for the HSP, childhood has an even greater effect than it does on the less sensitive person. As I mentioned in the Introduction, many research studies show that HSPs possess what has been called² *differential susceptibility* to their environment. The word choice is deliberate, *susceptible*, not *vulnerable*, because they are damaged more than others by bad environments, true, but also benefited more by good ones. This susceptibility or high sensitivity to one's environment operates especially in childhood, but the effects are there throughout life. Therefore, HSPs should especially gain from this chapter.

I like to note, too, that because of this susceptibility, it is difficult to make generalizations about HSPs. The correct generalization is that they like to observe and reflect before choosing how to act. Their goal is to make the best adaptation to the current situation based on past experience in similar situations. We see that in an amazing study finding that highly sensitive refugee children from Syria with violent, chaotic home lives, had less PTSD from being in war zones than highly sensitive children who had had better home lives up until then.³ Violence and chaos were familiar for those with prior bad home lives. They knew how to adapt. The point is, what you learn in childhood you expect later, in adulthood. It seems like the best way to be prepared, to adapt. Were you bullied? You may still tend to expect to be bullied. Or were people loving and kind? Were you generally successful at things you tried as a child? You can see how these latter expectations would lead to especially good

adulthoods. So, all in all, it is difficult to predict the behavior of HSPs, given that it reflects the adaptation to a potentially wide variety of past experiences.

Insight Nurtures Compassion

Another reason for this chapter on childhood is that paying attention to your childhood helps us understand others. Maybe that seems obvious, but maybe not. Compassion is a trait exalted in every spiritual tradition, and that begins with compassion for the little girl or boy who started out on your path, under the guidance of parents, schools, and culture, and believe me, is still within you. If you will open to him or her, you will be open to the hidden needy child in others, making you that much more caring.

Soon you will take a more complete inventory of your own childhood, focusing on what might be most related to a spiritual path. But let's begin to build your understanding with what you know about just the spiritual part of your childhood.

What About You?

In what ways was spirituality encouraged or discouraged during your childhood? Was it simply not present in your family and in yourself? Or did you have a special connection with God or with a church, temple, or mosque? Did spiritual things happen to you spontaneously, such as visions, voices, a sense of unity with nature or with an aspect of nature such as a tree or pet? An experience of unboundedness, of pure awareness? In what sense might your earliest years have hinted at a determination to follow a particular path? Or were you disillusioned by your early experiences? Even traumatized? Frightened by threats of God's judgment or hell and damnation?

What About Me?

If omens matter, I was born in Queen of the Angels Hospital, in the City of Angels (ha!), Los Angeles, on All Saints Day. Not bad for a start.

From as early as I can remember, we went to church. The first was a modest, slightly shabby Nazarene church on a dusty corner lot in Temple City (hm, another sign). If you recall, my father was raised Nazarene. I attended Bible summer camp there, making little paper figures to stick onto felt boards. I remember best Joseph and his coat of many colors, the well he was thrown into, and some camels around. My father taught Sunday school to the older children. There was no childcare, so I sat at his feet, in rapt attention, thinking he was God.

When I was about four or five, we switched to a nice, middle-class Methodist church. Perhaps we even went to both churches for a while. (I think my parents were moving toward being more mainstream to promote their social standing and businesses.) The new church was in downtown Temple City, next to the city park, and, yes, the front did look like a Grecian temple, with columns and a bit of a dome. I went there until I was thirteen, and during those years they built a modern church next door to replace it, one I never liked. I still have dreams about being in the old, 1930s' neoclassic sanctuary with the sun coming in through the cheap, mottled-green windows and the congregation singing "Holy, holy, holy....Early in the morning our song shall rise to thee."

My happiest memory there was of being cared for by Mrs. Searles in the nursery during the services. I was still not very old, because I remember her holding me in her arms. She was the kindest person I had met so far, and replaced my father as being most Godlike. (I was always a sucker for kindness.)

I had countless dreams of flying. Some think this is a sign of latent shamanism, others think it is the unconscious wish to fly away from a bad situation. Whatever it was, I loved the feeling. I would wake up still wanting to, and my sister would (mainly playfully) urge

me to try it, to jump off the roof of the garage. My last flying dream was in adulthood, while seeing my first therapist, a Catholic, who wanted me to be more grounded and stop idealizing her. In the dream I was a nun, with other nuns in a chapel, and I was flying above them, greatly enjoying myself. The Mother Superior, however, was angry and ordered me down to lie prostrate on the floor and pray.

When I was thirteen my parents finally divorced—I was their youngest, and now that I was a teenager, they felt they could break up the family. They immediately expressed their freedom by leaving church attendance behind. I guess they figured that if they were going to be immoral in the eyes of others, they may as well go all the way. However, something spiritual was certainly in my genes, especially on my mother's side, where there were those three generations of Free Methodists. My aunt once told me that I seemed only half here on earth, the rest more transcendent. Perhaps it was her sensing my high sensitivity. She never doubted my connection to my family's religious history, telling me smilingly near the end of her life that HSPs were my ministry, and working with them my mission.

Not a very spectacular beginning, although I sometimes have a sense that it was all as it was supposed to be.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

For some of you this was a chance to remember some very sweet hints of a path or even the goal. Maybe you knew what it was, instinctively. Maybe you built little altars, or just treated certain things as sacred. But if the experiences were darker, perhaps a negative relationship with an adult spiritual figure in your life, how are those experiences affecting you today? Can you work with them in a new way, perhaps with someone who has had similar experiences? Or in therapy, if you can find someone who can work well with your memories without being triggered by their own spiritual views.

Your Childhood Began with Your Parents

We are getting closer to examining the full picture of your childhood. We will do that in parts, actually. We will focus again on your parents, as romantic partners and parenting parents, since parents have so much influence, and do an inventory of that. The fact is, some parents do a much better job raising children than others. Some of this is determined by how they were parented, so you can keep your grandparents in mind too. How else would your parents learn to parent?

What About You?

Reflect and write more, if you wish, on your parents, as partners (or as single parents if you never had two parents that you knew), both before you were born and after, but leave out most of their parenting of you and relationship with you. That comes next.

If you do not know much about their lives, now is the time to ask. Children often lack interest in their parents' lives—until it is too late to inquire. It affects you, so learn more. Most parents love to share stories from their past. In most spiritual traditions, honoring your parents is not only a duty but an expression of gratitude. Perhaps wishing to deeply understand them is the best way to express that.

Start with anything left over about your grandparents and begin as early in your parents' lives as you like, recording anything that would have especially affected their relationship with each other and their parenting, and anything about their spirituality, all of which you can be sure affected you. If there was someone else very involved in your parenting, write about them too.

This could be long. Mine was. Write as much as you like.

What About Me?

Given that my mother lost her beloved father suddenly at age eleven and my father lost his dear mother when he was eight, in the Lower World they must have seemed made for each other. Both probably had decent beginnings, but for most of their childhoods they were raised by grief-distracted parents or whoever stepped in. My father's father, Albert Starr Spaulding, had a number of children and kept a strict household, much like the book and movie Cheaper by the Dozen. If you were late for dinner, you missed it. If you did not finish what was on your plate, well, you DID. But from my aunts' accounts, they all felt loved—until Father lost his beloved Pearlie. Grieving deeply, Albert sent my father, his youngest, to live with relatives. One can imagine how difficult that was for him—a double loss, losing both parents. Again through a wall, as when he listened to the doctors trying to save his mother, he heard these relatives talking about wanting to be rid of him. I believe it was about then that he contracted TB, and his father took him to Palm Springs to be healed, living there with him, as if the little boy's body had found a way to force one parent to come back and take care of him.

Later, my father went to Greenville College in Kentucky, where all good Nazarenes and Free Methodists went, and there he caught polio. Back home he came. This time his father sent him to be cured at the Los Angeles Sister Kenny hospital, the best for polio at the time. The nurses gave the handsome, pitiful young man special treatment. He loved how his entire bed could be moved on an overhead track to the warm pool that was supposed to relax bent limbs.

I think you can see a pattern. My father was learning that being helpless and dependent was comforting, even for a grown man, and no reason for shame. Illness would serve him well throughout his life. (But not improve his parenting of his children!) Indeed, when he developed dementia in his eighties he was looking forward to moving into the fancy nursing home he had already picked out.

My mother's Depression-era practicality focused on marrying a wealthy man. Her mother (my grandmother), widowed with two children, had been supporting her family by teaching music, but when no one could afford music lessons, for a time they survived by

her knitting socks in an attic with other destitute women, her work paid for by the WPA (the United States relief organization during the Great Depression).

In contrast, even during the Depression, Albert Starr Spaulding was a self-made wealthy man, mostly through shrewd marketing of real estate to newcomers to California, as Los Angeles County transitioned from farmland and cattle ranching to cities and suburbs. One of his schemes was offering free hayrides on Sundays, so the whole family could come out to picnic in open meadows he owned and choose a lot for five-dollars down, five dollars a month. If they didn't keep up the payments, the lot went back on the market and he sold it again.

The Spaulding family (my grandfather and his many children) lived all over California, going where he had business ventures. But at the time that my mother met my father, the tribe lived in an almost mansion in the best part of Pasadena. My mother expected that Wes, my father, would inherit a nice fortune. In the last days prior to the wedding, her mother, my grandma Nelle, had learned some strong reasons for my mother not to marry him. These were never revealed to me; I suspect they were sexual in nature. But the invitations had been sent and my mother held to her decision. There was something that might have changed her mind, but that fact she had not yet learned. You see, Albert had other ideas about his money. He gave each child all the education they wanted, then three thousand dollars to get a start making their own fortunes. After his death the rest of his money was to go to church charities, not to his children. Once my mother did learn this, it must have been a bitter beginning for her.

My father was tall and handsome; my mother was beautiful, with a perfect hourglass figure, as the fashion industry called it in those days. Both were musically gifted (my mother could play anything by ear and my father played several instruments, sang, and wrote songs). They moved to Laurel Canyon, near Hollywood, the haunt of movie stars, and proudly reported later the famous people they played softball with. Clearly, they hoped, as did many young people

living in Southern California, to be discovered themselves by some talent agent.

This was still during the Depression, however, and they knew about being practical and the value of education. My father went back to college, to the University of Southern California; my mother completed a two-year degree at Pasadena City College. When World War II started, my father was draft exempt due to his polio-induced weak right arm and was assigned to working for the telephone company, Pacific Bell, an essential wartime industry. Ma Bell took care of him the rest of his life, but during his off-hours he tried get-rich schemes, mostly selling insurance and real estate in the style of his father. He never made much from these while I was young, but they took up most of his free time.

My mother tried to settle into being the perfect housewife but soon was helping out during the day with the businesses. For both, getting rich was almost as important as becoming a movie star, and love seemed low on the list. I think in those days having a family was just what you did (or could not avoid if you had sex). I never sensed it was important to them.

My father was unfaithful almost from the start of the marriage, finishing later in life by wedding one of his many sexual partners, a colleague at Ma Bell. She stumbled into the role that guaranteed his fidelity: She took care of him, with good cooking and nice decor, through colon cancer, which he survived, and then through the start of Alzheimer's.

My mother, too, went to bed with at least one person early on, one of their closest friends, perhaps as revenge, hoping to get my father back. Later, when I was in my teens, she took her best friend's husband as her secret lover. This best friend also worked with her, and she and her husband were the people my mother and I spent most of our time with after my parents separated. When I was in my twenties my mother and the husband were caught in their affair, and the three settled down together as a threesome. (The brief life of the couple's only child is another sad story.) It sounds like a soap opera, yes?

Overall, my parents' lives seem tragically cut off from deep feelings of love—love for each other, for friends and children, for God (who they would have assumed in childhood clearly did not love them, given their losses), and also I think deep love for themselves, given their superficiality. But I have great sympathy for them both. And their children never lacked for food or shelter.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

I hope that taking this time to remember your parents' lives, separate from yours, was productive. Our parents' lives before ours is not something we usually think about, yet it impacts us greatly. When people become parents, they often strive to do better in certain specific ways (e.g., be more lenient, more attentive) than their own parents did, but whether they do the opposite or more of the same, their behavior is still being guided by their own childhood, tempered by their own innate temperament!

Temperament

We have considered your parents. Now we finally get to you, beginning with your temperament. Everyone is born with certain temperament traits. There are various lists of these innate traits, but here's a good one:

- Active or not so much
- Dramatic and spontaneous or calm and in control of your emotions
- Easygoing or often irritable
- Needing some novelty and excitement or preferring routine
- Reaching out to others (more extraverted) or preferring to be around a few familiar people (more introverted)
- Desiring closeness and feeling empathy for others or being more independent

- Being easily distracted or not
- Highly sensitive or not

With each, you can be at either extreme or in the middle. You can learn more about these traits elsewhere. The lists of traits may vary a little, but I like two books on temperament: Mary Sheedy Kurcinka's *Raising Your Spirited Child* and a more scholarly book by Mary Rothbart, *Becoming Who We Are*.

Your temperament is not isolated from your parents', of course. You may be similar to one or both, or not at all. And whatever their own temperaments, some parents are naturally in sync with one type of child but do poorly with another. They may have been good with their first child, with whom they learned to parent, or with children like their siblings, but with their second child or just a different type of child, they may stumble. They may simply like a certain temperament or really dislike a trait (often high sensitivity) and try to eliminate it, whether they have it themselves or not.

If your temperament traits are especially strong—for example, highly active, dramatic, distractible, or sensitive—your parents had a further problem, because people around them would have started giving them advice or telling them that any unusual behaviors they saw were the result of sloppy parenting, when it was probably innate. Most parenting books are about the average child. Other books are about correcting problems, often presumed to be the fault of parenting mistakes. But again, many of these problems and mistakes originated with temperament and a lack of knowledge about how to handle it.

When everyone is set on changing a child's natural behavior style, the child begins to feel something is quite wrong with him or her. The parents lose confidence as well, and someone has to be blamed. It has only been in the last few decades that the issue of temperament has been recognized at all in children, even though everyone who has had at least two children knows they were born different.

Temperament never goes away. There are advantages and disadvantages to every trait. You may have an outside-the-average

temperament, such as high sensitivity or high distractibility, but those will just bring bigger advantages and disadvantages. With unusual traits, most of the focus has been on disadvantages (although discussions of neurodivergence are changing this). You may have learned while young to see only the problems you caused by your intense emotions (drama queen) or high activity level (wiggle worm). Or you may have been praised for your innate adaptability or friendliness, so that it was almost scary to be any other way for even a moment.

What About You?

Take a moment to see both sides of all your traits and, above all, how temperament has affected your path. It always does. What are your temperament traits and how did your parents view them? Ask family members what you were like as a young child if you are not sure. They may immediately tell you about your tantrums (perhaps a sign of irritability you may already know about, but often a sign of exhausted overstimulation in a sensitive child) or easygoing nature. All of this is part of your path, like the ground under your feet, rocky or sandy or whatever.

What About Me?

In my family there were three children, each with different strong temperaments, so that my parents had to reorient each time. My brother was kind yet loved to argue and rage, but I was nine years younger and he was never angry with me. My sister was dramatic and extraverted and often dragged me into her scenes. I was highly sensitive, and I remember a great deal of fear of loud noises such as fireworks, and anxiety about things I had been warned about, such as drowning, falling, or being burned.

My brother and sister, being older, often wanted to do things that were fun for them, such as get as close as possible to fireworks or

go on a tour of a big factory (my father liked to take us on educational outings). I had to go along because I could not be left alone. I especially remember the huge, roaring open furnaces of the iron foundry we visited. They terrified me. So did open ski lifts, and even the hole above the bathtub where the soap dish was missing and there was an icy draft up from the basement. The basement was the home of the black widow spiders I was warned about.

Because I had to go along with the rest of the family, I don't know now how much of my anxiety was due just to my sensitivity and how much was due to my parents minimizing my reactions, leaving me without a sense of protection. No one was looking out for my boundaries. I know my son and daughter-in-law would never, ever force their younger, more sensitive child (my grandson) to do something that frightened him, even if it meant splitting up so that someone could stay with him.

On the bright side, I think my brother understood my sensitivity—not consciously, but he never did anything with me that frightened me. Rather, he sensed the deep-processing side of my trait of sensitivity, which made me mature for my age and brought us closer. He loved classical music, and I quickly did too. Often when he was washing dishes, he would set me up on a chair with a black conductor's baton (a painted piece from a coat hanger) and he would play recordings while I would conduct: Beethoven, Greig, Strauss, and all of our other favorites. I think he actually enjoyed my company, young as I was. He took me to professional baseball games, read Donald Duck comics to me as we lay together on the front lawn, and explained the maps of World War II battles that hung on the walls of his room.

My sensitivity was evident to my beloved kindergarten teacher, Mrs. Turchi, who wrote about it on my first report card: "Elaine has so many wonderful ideas and expresses herself so well. She is interested in all the things we do." After the second semester she wrote that I was "well-adjusted socially and emotionally," and that I "contribute so much to our group." Then on the third report card, she said that I work well, my "paintings are lovely," but I seem "very quiet lately." By the final report I am apparently "happy and secure"

with my friends, and have "very good work habits," but "Elaine seems sensitive and quiet at school." Was she trying to tell my parents something?

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

I hope you have a better understanding now of your temperament and can appreciate all the advantages of your particular traits. Above all, you should be able to see that your temperament paints your path as an artist might, giving it a certain necessary landscape and coloration that you cannot change. Nor should you want to. Every individual is different and contributes to the whole.

Parenting Style

Research conducted by Diana Baumrind observing parents with their preschool children led to the description of three parenting styles.⁴ One style is *authoritarian*—being very strict, not very responsive, and making strong demands. Children being raised this way tend to be withdrawn and discontented. *Permissive* parenting, just letting children do as they like, with low demands, seemed in this research to lead to preschool children with low self-control and low self-reliance. Surprisingly, permissive parenting appears to be especially unhelpful to highly sensitive children.⁵ *Authoritative* parents, who are both responsive to their children and have high expectations and strict limits, seem to have the best effect. Their children tended, in this research, to be assertive and self-reliant.

There is a fourth style, in which parents are neither responsive (warm) nor demanding (strict), what Baumrind called a *rejecting-neglecting* style. It is unlikely but possible that this was your parents: Providing for you in physical ways and maybe even saying they loved you, but in fact choosing to spend little time with you (as opposed to being unable to) and showing little real interest in you. There is much more to this parenting style, but that's enough to give

you a feeling for how much you might have to clean up after such a painful start.

Think about how you were parented, using these categories of parenting style, but hold onto that until you learn about the next two topics, *attachment* style (related to how you were parented as an infant) and *trauma*, since these probably weave together in your early life path and influence you spiritually now.

Attachment Style

I (and many others) have written a great deal about attachment style elsewhere (for example, my book *The Undervalued Self*), so I will keep this brief. Attachment is all about how we got along with our earliest caregivers, usually our mother. The list of an infant's needs is long, so it is easy to see why excellent parenting is not that simple or even common. Caregivers usually have a lot on their minds besides the baby they have with them, but infants and young children have the solution—crying, sometimes screaming. If that does not help, well, babies seem to be programmed from birth with three ways to cope, according to the type of caregiver they are dealing with. These are called attachment models.⁶ Like a theoretical model, it provides the infant brain with ways to predict what to expect from caregivers and it organizes the infant's behavior around that model, turning the behavior into an adult attachment style.

The first prediction or model is *secure*. With this model, the child has learned to expect caregivers to fairly consistently meet the child's needs. The infant simply bonds in the normal way. This is the case for about 50 percent of infants.

Insecure models come in two flavors, *anxious-ambivalent* and *avoidant*, which are also normal in the sense that they are innate responses that only kick in when parenting is flawed. Infants develop the anxious (or anxious-ambivalent) style if the caregiver is inconsistent—distracted, for example, by poverty, illness, fear, depression, conflict with family members, having many other children, or simply not liking to be constantly available. The infant

adapts by being super alert to the caregiver's state, always watchful for what can be done to keep that caregiver meeting their needs. Be nice? Be quiet? Be angry or loud? With this model active in childhood, adults tend to grow up expecting those they depend on to be inconsistent at best, or perhaps unfaithful, and that they need to do everything they can to keep a close other's attention.

The avoidant style occurs if the caregiver is truly neglectful or even abusive, or away too much or dies at a crucial time and no one really replaces that person. The infant watches for how to get their basic needs met while avoiding (being avoidant) or at least surviving the worst things the caregiver does, including disappearing. As they grow up, children with this style begin to act indifferent toward potential caring others and try to be self-sufficient. By adulthood they continue this way, barely conscious that they are still trying to get those early needs met without letting them show. (As you can imagine, misery often ensues when someone with an anxious ambivalent style partners with someone who has an avoidant style.)

In the West, where God has been an important spiritual concept, these attachment models or styles are intimately connected with spirituality. All of what follows is based on substantial research,⁷ suggesting that attachment models can predict how we view God or the universe. If you have the perspective of a secure model, you are more likely to see God as benign and to feel you have a personal relationship with God and turn to God when in need. Or if God is not important to you, you feel that the universe is a safe enough place, a place to be trusted. If your parents were religious and you were secure with them, you are more likely to be religious, changing only gradually if you change at all.

Insecure styles, on the other hand, are associated with being less religious than one's parents. Still, with an anxious style, you might well turn to God as an attachment figure who could provide all that your caregivers did not. Indeed, there is a tendency to experience sudden religious conversions or to attach to spiritual leaders, especially in times of stress. But attachment anxiety is also associated with seeing God or the universe as inconsistent or

dangerous, or your relationship with God as being very contingent on your good behavior.

With an avoidant style, you may dismiss God as never having been helpful—and as best as you can see, not helpful to anyone, really. Or you may simply prefer to avoid the subject, perhaps not realizing the depth of the source of your discomfort. Although, being insecure underneath all that, your type is also prone to sudden spiritual interests or conversions.

In short, everyone has an attachment style, and everyone's spirituality is affected by it—not totally controlled by it, but it is there in the picture.

Trauma

Psychological trauma is a term that may be a bit overused in psychology right now, as we keep expanding what we mean by trauma. Or perhaps the subject has been ignored for too long, especially trauma in childhood. As a child, like all children, you experienced the world freshly and may have been deeply shocked or wounded by events adults were used to, such as other kids cheating or being mean. This is especially true for the HS part of you. So try to remember the child version of yourself as you think about trauma.

Another term in use now is *adverse childhood experiences* (ACEs), which includes physical and psychological abuse by parents or siblings, sexual abuse, alcoholism, mental illness in the family, and witnessing abuse to others in the family. In the United States at least 61 percent of adults report having had an ACE. But the term does not include external issues such as natural disasters, poverty, or racial injustice, which can be especially overwhelming if caregivers are also overwhelmed or cannot offer help. So do not forget how these also might have affected you.

What About You?

So far you have reflected on your parents without you in the picture and on your temperament. Having read about parenting style, attachment models, and childhood trauma, it is time to finish reflecting on your childhood in the light of these three. Remember that others in your family, your friends in the neighborhood, and those you knew at school were also influences on your path, so include their impact, too, if it seems relevant.

A word about parenting style and attachment: Do not worry if you cannot decide which of the three types of parenting styles fit your experience of your parents or which of the three attachment models was true of you. People rarely experience purely one type; these are just useful broad categories. For example, most people had more than one caregiver, and even if there was only one, you and that person may have changed during those early years.

Also, regarding attachment, because you do not remember your first two years, the ones most crucial to forming your attachment style, you must extrapolate from a general feeling, or from how you got along with your caregivers later, or from what you can observe now about how they felt about infants. Crazy about them? Tolerant? Avoid them?

When researchers try to categorize a person into a type of model through interviews, they pay the most attention not to the facts but to how a person describes their childhood: coherently with the simple facts about their family and school life (secure model); long and incoherently (anxious-ambivalent model); or brief and lacking feeling (avoidant model). So watch for the style in which you think and write about your early childhood.

Please, please do not feel doomed by what you figure out. You can't change the past, but attachment models and the effects of childhood stress can be mitigated, provided one is in a supportive, secure relationship for a long enough time, including psychotherapy with someone who works well with clients who have attachment issues.

Where to begin? One point of entry might be your first memory, which can be symbolic of the entirety. And as with dreams, it's not just what happened but what you think happened.

What About Me?

The length of this entry alone suggests an anxious ambivalent attachment style! My first memory was of my mother screaming at me. I was in my crib, and I think I must have removed the contents of my full diaper and spread them around, probably feeling bored and finding this an interesting activity. I know that when she discovered me, I was terrified and never forgot it. Knowing she was capable of such rages, I think I tried to ensure that she was never angry with me again. As a result, I became her most well-behaved and therefore favorite child. (My poor sister was assigned the role of troublemaker.) My father agreed: When I asked him later what he remembered of my childhood, he said, "Not much." I asked several times, and his responses became, "Well, you never caused us any trouble." I think now that will be on my tombstone: "Here lies Elaine Aron, who never caused anyone any trouble." You can see from this and the earlier sketch of my path that for a long time I had an anxiously insecure attachment style, always longing for a better, kinder person to love me, but not believing that could ever happen.

As for my parents' parenting style, it was a mixture of authoritarian (schedules, spankings for small things) and permissive ("since she's so good, no need to watch her"). Attachment was the larger issue. My longing for ideal attachment figures was perhaps affected by the media. My sister and I were free to watch all the TV we wanted, and on Saturdays we watched about five movies back-to-back, two or three of which were love stories, mostly set in wartime. The important characters were always kind to each other, faithful, and self-sacrificing, whatever the ending, happy or tragic. I definitely wanted someone like those characters to hang on to.

Until I was six I was closer to my father than my mother. My mother was not fond of mothering, which I saw clearly when she became an uninterested grandmother. She became better at being a mother as I grew older and we could talk about things. My estrangement from my father was sudden and total. My mother told me later that she made a point of never leaving us alone with him,

although she never explained why. But one weekend she had to go visit a sick friend for an entire day. My father brought his mistress from work to our house (later his second wife). They were in the backyard, my territory, but I knew not to go out. Still, I peeked through a window and saw them sitting side by side, naked. My father was always fond of nudism and joked about it. I had showered with him but had never seen people sitting around naked like that. Later, I was with them in the kitchen and my father asked me to treat her like my mother. I was overwhelmed by emotions I doubt I could identify, but I no longer liked him at all.

When my mother came home and found out about his behavior from my sister, all hell broke loose. The fight terrified me. I remember kneeling at the piano bench in the dining room while in the kitchen they screamed and threw things, something I had never seen them do before. I knew neither of them was even slightly aware of my existence. I finally put myself to bed. In the morning I heard my sister telling my mother that I had cried all night.

I remember the fight and my sister's pronouncement in the morning, but it was not until I was an adult that I found out that the events of the night had been preceded by the events of the day. I had remembered them as separate, disconnected events. Dissociation is powerful, especially in children.

After that weekend, my parents were unofficially separated. My father lived in the attic and then in rented rooms, usually someone's converted garage. On Friday nights he took one of us out. I remember him telling me at a drive-in theater that I was his favorite. I proudly told my brother and sister, but he had told them the same thing.

My mother worked as I was growing up, from a home office created by my father. Soon after I was born, my father bought our house from a builder as part of some business trade without even showing it to my mother first. To my father, one of its charms was that it was on a busy street (and on a route used by gravel trucks, so their air brakes squealed as they stopped at the corner). My father converted half of the two-car garage into an office, where my parents had a real estate and insurance business. My mother hated

that house and hated having an office in it, but eventually took to working there almost full time. I recall sitting for many hours outside that office door, hoping for a chance to be with her. She was so close, yet so out of reach for an obedient child.

Even with all that, my upbringing did not seem unusual at the time. How does a little child compare? We were taught to be honest and not to steal, to keep our rooms neat and do our chores. We were always physically well cared for. Our mother made clothes for my sister and me that were identical to the expensive-brand dresses and skirts the other girls wore. We were not rich but never felt poor. Indeed my parents occasionally took us to very fancy places, usually for lunch—at hotels that had Biltmore in the name or at the Turf Club during racing season at Santa Anita racetrack, which we lived a few miles from. They had always hoped to be discovered and become movie stars. At least at these spots they could play the role—if you forgot we kids were there. But I loved those places. Until their separation when I was six, we took family vacations to national parks. My father loved taking us to new places. My mother created spectacular holiday decorations and birthday parties. It all looked very good on the outside, which was important to them.

Something more was visible in other families and in the movies. Something that felt more like love. Looking back, I would say I actually had uninvolved parenting, so I suppose it was neglect. For example, I loved horses and always wanted one, but my parents declared it out of the question, and never even considered arranging for me to take riding lessons. My father did take me horseback riding once, before I was six. We went with a guide, and when he and my father decided to gallop, they apparently forgot about me. My horse galloped too, of course, and I promptly fell off. But they did not notice for quite a while. When they did I was put back on the horse, according to the old maxim. It never occurred to me that he could have put me on his horse with him and have the guide lead my horse home.

I have to remember that his thoughtlessness grew out of a lovelessness, true for both of them, that grew out of their traumatic losses of those they had loved with all their hearts when they were

young. They could not afford grief like that again, especially for a child, and so there was a void left that they filled with having some fun, making money, and having sex made more thrilling by it being illicit and furtive. I know now that for the rest of my life I have struggled to avoid the siren call of not caring, or not seeming to care. It is so safe not to care. But what you keep from coming in through the front door—the conscious mind—sneaks around to the back door—the unconscious. Hence my irrational, intense attraction toward anyone kind and loving toward me.

In school, having seen love in the movies, I always loved some boy from afar. I also adored all but one of my elementary school teachers. If they had playground duty, I stayed with them, along with the two Jewish kids in the school. I did not know they were Jewish and anxious for other reasons, but I was glad I was not alone. The day after the last day of school I would come back and help my teacher for that year put things straight for the summer, giving me a little extra time with them and the praise from them that I craved.

In seventh grade, for the first time, a boy sort of liked me back. Having been forced to choose a dance partner in a ballroom dancing class, he chose me every time. It was astounding. Of course I drove him off with my adoration—probably a common story at that age. Then, in the summer before starting high school, a high school senior, Don, the friend of a friend's older brother, loved me back. I supposed it was ordinary in one sense, a teenage crush, when you think you cannot live without the other. He was not attractive by anyone's standards, but the important thing was that he liked me, and at that time, that's all that mattered.

I know now that I was also glad to be out of the teenage drama of dating, making out, petting, and falling in and out of love, but especially the sexual fears. Don and I explored sex very slowly, never going all the way, as those were the days before contraception. My mother did not approve of his age and our exclusivity and forbade me to see him, but I pleaded my case with our family doctor and the minister of the church my mother and I sometimes attended, and she relented to my seeing him once a

week. But she could not alter the attachment needs she had created. At nineteen I married Don.

I can see that most problems on my path resulted as a tight weaving of my sensitive temperament, attachment issues, my parents' (non)parenting style, and some trauma, especially my first memory and the event with my father, which had many repercussions. In a way, it seemed my parents mostly just forgot me (for example, when I fell unnoticed from the horse, or when I was supposed to be picked up at school and ended up sitting on the curb as it grew dark, until someone noticed me and called my parents). I could have been pulled into an overly dependent relationship with a spiritual teacher, except that men with Godlike authority surely reminded me of my early love for my later-hated father, and I could not rely very much on a spiritual group, given my mother and family life.

I know all of this may sound awful, but remember, my story as of now has turned out well, very well, and the difficulties I experienced then almost seem now like necessary steps on my spiritual path.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

Parenting style, attachment style, and trauma—that is a lot to inventory, on top of temperament. Please give your childhood a generous amount of your attention, so that your spiritual path is not unduly shaped by these and you know what to clean up. If looking back on your childhood was difficult at times, remember that your sincere, authentic desire to know the truth is essential on your journey. Finally, remember that your particular childhood issues and the complexes you carry as a result do not just affect your path. They *are* your path, the beginning of it, and make it unique. It is never too late to start keeping an eye on any issues you uncovered while reading this chapter.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

This chapter on childhood was intended to allow you to make a deep, even scientifically informed assessment of your childhood, to help you with the developmental task of cleaning up. The next chapter blends cleaning up with that other task, waking up. To finish the subject of cleaning up, it looks at adult issues of anxiety and depression, although these are often the result of childhood trauma. Still, both of them are common to the human condition and so have been addressed from both the Upper and Lower Worlds.

As a bridge to the subject of waking up, the next chapter also considers again the potential relationship with a spiritual teacher, this time not in terms of the teacher's characteristics, but yours—what you bring to it, the nature of your relationship to those in power, and your temperament and childhood history.

CHAPTER 5

THE EASTERN TEACHINGS ABOUT SUFFERING COME WEST— WORKING AT THE CROSSROADS OF CLEANING UP AND WAKING UP

This chapter is a bit of a bridge between the emphasis on childhood and cleaning up in the previous chapter, and the emphasis on waking up, which is to come. We will start to discuss meditation, but because learning to meditate usually involves a teacher, we must, toward the end of this chapter, return to the subject of anxiety and depression, attachment, and complexes around power, this time as they affect the student-teacher relationship. But let's begin with two stories.

The Bhagavad Gita—a Story Fit for a Supernova

This story is found in the Indian epic, the *Mahabharata*, and within it, the *Bhagavad Gita*. The *Gita* is the most important scripture in Vedanta, and functions for many in India like the Bible, the Torah, or

the Koran. It is uncertain when it was written, but scholars believe it may have been around 500 BCE. It is the chronicle of a battle for who is the rightful king. (The parallels to the King Arthur legend are uncanny.) The characters' huge extended family was divided by the dispute, which inevitably led to war. The *Bhagavad Gita* is about what happens at the moment when the two sides are finally lined up—hundreds of warriors in chariots or seated on elephants and even more on foot. All are related and all are ready to fight and die for their side. Arjuna, whose brother is the rightful king, is said to be the greatest archer in the land and has the task of shooting the first arrow, the one that will start the battle that can only end in a massacre of the people on both sides whom he holds dear.

Arjuna is in a chariot driven by his cousin Krishna. (In the story, Krishna is not a Godlike figure or avatar, but simply a highly respected older cousin.) As the tension mounts, the brave young warrior begins to despair, and Krishna deliberately adds to it by repeating the tragedy that will begin with Arjuna's first arrow. But when Arjuna wants to back out, Krishna says he must fulfill his duty. Arjuna, all but fainting now, cannot imagine how he can proceed. So, Krishna gives his famous speech, centered around three words—in Sanskrit, "*yogastah kuru karmani*"—but expanded on for seven hundred verses that were divided into eighteen chapters and now are translated into almost every language, with commentaries by almost every modern spiritual teacher. One such famous spiritual teacher, Gandhi, called it his "spiritual dictionary."¹

In those three key words you can recognize the word yoga in *yogastah*, here meaning being firmly established in the union—*yoga*—of the individual with the absolute, the unchanging, Brahman. And you'll recognize karma in *karmani*, the plural of karma. In between those two words there is *kuru*, meaning do or perform. So, the best translation of these three words is, "Established in Being, perform actions," which may be the shortest possible answer to the great existential question of how to live in this difficult, often frightening world, with all of its inner and outer conflicts. Connect with Being,

Brahman. Use the absolute to deal with the relative world, including conflicts with relatives!

Much of this chapter and even more of the next is about meditation, the *yogastah* part, how to develop stable emotional calmness. But let's not forget *karmani*. Action. Krishna is *not* saying that Established in Being means retiring from activity to become a monk or seeing the relative world as some sort of illusion. The idea is that with a nervous system that is deeply calm, with that as a background state, one sees the situation more objectively and engages more effectively (possibly even fleeing if that is objectively needed). Happily, Krishna also says "even a little of this *dharma* delivers from great fear," *dharma* referring to the practice of meditation. So even a little meditation can help.

Buddha—How One Determined Person Changed Our World

I said I would tell you two stories. This second is also about a prince. This one is Siddhartha Gautama, born in what is now Nepal in perhaps 564 BCE. As a youth he lived a life of privilege and comfort, so that, as legend has it, he had not seen much of the sordid side of life, until all in one day, he came upon an old man, a sick man, and a beggar. He had a lovely wife and a four-day-old son at home, yet he was apparently so horrified by what he saw that day that he immediately stripped off his fancy clothes, shaved his head, donned the robes of a mendicant monk, and set out for the forests, forgetting his family and his easy life up to then. His only goal was to find a teaching that would help him escape repeated reincarnation into this hell of birth, aging, and dying. (Reincarnation was assumed in his culture, an idea dating back to perhaps 800 BCE.)

Actually, this seeking was so common that there was a term for it: *going forth*. People were desperate for something more meaningful than their old religion of ritual sacrifices to the gods by the priests, which seemed to accomplish nothing.² So, in the forest

Siddhartha met many other seekers and tried numerous teachers. He learned to meditate deeply and engaged in the strictest possible ascetic practices, starving himself and sleeping outdoors in any weather, because it was believed that the enlightenment he was seeking, the awakening to that which is beyond endless rebirth and suffering, might only come when one was near death. But when he was at that point of almost dying, a woman gave him a little rice. He revived and decided to give up the extremes and focus entirely on meditation. Eventually he sat down under the famous bodhi tree or “tree of awakening” (actually a type of fig tree), proclaiming that he would not get up until he experienced this awakening.

The awakening did finally happen, supposedly after seven weeks of sitting without moving. When he got up, he knew he needed to tell others what he had discovered, which was different in important ways from any teachings he had heard up until then. But who would want to hear his drastic message? He wanted to try it on the five friends with whom he had spent most of his time—until the day they saw him eating food and, not wanting to give in to their hunger, ran from him! He thought they would run off again when they saw him. But this time, Siddhartha was reportedly glowing in such a way that his friends knew he was a buddha, an awakened one. *The Buddha*.

As I said in [Chapter 3](#), his first talk may have been about the Four Noble Truths, the last of these being the Eight-Fold Path we discussed. The first three truths were apparently well known by those who had *gone forth*, the first truth especially: If you look at the whole of it, life is *dukkha*, not ultimately satisfying. Whether or not you believe in rebirth, life always leads to death, usually involving old age and illness. The pleasures that do occur never last. Relationships and accomplishments are always impermanent.

The second truth is that the cause of our suffering is the desire emanating from our egos—not just for pleasures but simply for life. We cling; we are attached to others and simply to living. These lead to hindrances and defilements (the *kleshas*, described in Vedanta too): attachment, aversion (leading to hatred and fear), ignorance, the will to live or fear of death, and egoism. All of this clinging and

disliking are habits we brought with us from birth, but Buddha saw a way to break these habits: the third truth.

This third truth is the realization of what he saw as the ultimate truth, which is nirvana. What I have been calling waking up. Awakening. Enlightenment. The experience of equanimity established in the nervous system 24/7. He knew it was difficult to grasp nirvana without experiencing it, but he was confident that it was the only real solution to suffering.

Nirvana literally means *blowing out* or *quenching*, and refers to the extinguishing of all the fires (those *kleshas* I listed) that lead to reincarnation or, in terms of modern Buddhism, the fires that create mental suffering or just disturb our mental equilibrium. It is not that in nirvana you have no needs or preferences at all, but you cannot be caught in them. When all of these are blown out or quenched, even the ego's fear of death, we reach nirvana. The result, according to Buddha and then to those of his followers who also reached this realization, was reportedly an unspeakable freedom and happiness. Remember, Buddha spent years getting there (and expected we would need years to get there, too, at least seven).³ For more on nirvana, see Karen Armstrong's *Buddha* and Walpola Rahula Thero's *What the Buddha Taught*. These descriptions may not be perfect, but they are in language we can understand.

Both Buddha and whoever wrote the *Gita* saw meditation as the best way to end suffering. Many in the West are starting to agree. One of my favorite books on coping with anxiety is Paul Foxman's *Dancing with Fear*, and in his last chapter, "Spirituality and Anxiety," he says that "effective anxiety treatment must include a spiritual dimension."⁴ Then he states flat out that for those with anxiety, "Meditation is the most essential spiritual practice."⁵ So let's get to that.

Types of Meditation

When someone like Foxman recommends meditation, or someone says that they meditate, or that they are going to teach you to meditate, it sounds as though meditation is just one thing. But they may as well say, “I recommend pills.” That is, there are many kinds of meditation, just as there are many kinds of pills. And each form of meditation has its purpose. There are various ways of creating a list of the kinds.⁶ I have focused here on the kinds of meditation you are most likely to encounter. Even if you already have a favorite way to meditate, let’s look at the three general types, then focus on the last category, silent, eyes-closed meditation, so that you know where to place your practice in the big scheme of things.

Relaxation

Some meditations are designed to help you relax or go to sleep. Someone speaks in a soft voice (in person or an audio recording), instructing you how to relax. For example: “Take five deep breaths, in through your nose and out through your mouth, then bring your attention to your center, around your navel, feel the warmth there ...” It is best if you can learn to do the method without listening to instructions, so that your brain can be less busy. This form of meditation always involves listening to words, so your mind must process these words.

Guided Meditations

Another “busy” form of meditation happens in guided meditation. After relaxation instruction, you are guided in how to think about yourself or someone else—for example, to think about your inner child and then imagine embracing this child. Or “You are at the edge of a deep forest, there is a path into it, someone is waiting in the forest to guide you through this dark place.” Pause. “Who do you see?” Guided meditation can also be used like hypnosis, to help you

break a habit. It can be lovely. But your brain is still quite busy. You can go deeper.

Meditation as a Kind of Prayer

Christian contemplatives sometimes use a very short prayer, such as the Jesus prayer,² as a form of meditation. Depending on how it is used, it is the same as meditating. *Metta* meditation (instruction is easily found on the internet), something like prayer, was devised by Buddha to help us get beyond ourselves. You use it to wish others and yourself well-being and send them thoughts of loving kindness. Although it is not a prayer to God because Buddha did not see God as a helpful idea, the word *may* gives that feeling. For example, “May I be happy. May I be well. May I be safe. May I be peaceful and at ease.” Then you would repeat that for someone you love, for strangers, or for people with whom you have difficulty. We will discuss it again in [Chapter 6](#).

Eyes-Closed, Silent Meditation

The mind is most quiet when meditation is done in silence with eyes closed or in effect closed, by staring at a candle or blank wall. As I have said, the spiritual goal of meditation has always been to attain something like awakening. But there are very differing views on what that really is like and how to get there, so of course there are differences in types of eyes-closed meditation. What follows is a quick introduction to these variations. The next chapter will take you deeper into their roots and the research.

Three Types of Eyes-Closed Meditation

Besides the instruction given for each of these three forms of meditation, we can differentiate them by the types of brain waves

they each produce. For a summary of this research, see Fred Travis and Jonathan Shear, "Focused Attention, Open Monitoring and Automatic Self-Transcending: Categories to Organize Meditations from Vedic, Buddhist and Chinese traditions.⁸" There are some problems with dividing meditation methods so neatly, because it is easy to find exceptions, especially in Buddhism. But it helps to think of the brain as operating in distinctly different ways while meditating, according to the purpose of the meditation, because operating differently is exactly what it does!

Focused Meditation

The first type of eyes-closed meditation that Travis and Shear describe involves focused attention or concentration. For example, as a beginner in Zen Buddhism you might be told to focus on counting ten breaths. When a thought interrupts your counting, you start over at one. (If you try it, you will see it requires considerable focus to get to ten without having any other thoughts.) Or you might be told to concentrate on an idea, probing deeper and deeper into its meaning, as when one meditates on a koan, a Zen question such as "What is the sound of one hand clapping?" Or one might focus deeply on the fact of impermanence or the Four Noble Truths. The general purpose of focused attention, at least in Buddhism, is to bring the mind under your control, so that you can see more easily when it is out of your control and being influenced by the various hindrances such as attachments and aversions (those *kleshas* I described earlier). (If you are serious about Buddhist meditation, a teacher is considered essential for choosing the right subject for concentration. For now, I am just explaining in a general way how it is done.) If your mind wanders, you bring your attention back. The associated brain waves are beta and gamma, typically found during any type of focused attention.

Open-Monitoring Meditation

Open monitoring is most clearly found in what you may have heard of as mindfulness meditation. It involves observing rather than focusing. Most commonly you observe your breath, other body sensations, thoughts, or the content of ongoing experience objectively, all without an emotional reaction, or if you have a reaction, you simply observe that, too, sometimes naming it.

Buddha taught mindfulness meditation as a way to calm the mind and focus it very gently before proceeding to reflecting on various points of knowledge and behavior that together lead to nirvana, but today, mindfulness meditation is often taught by itself. The goal is to become reflectively aware without judgment. The associated brain waves are theta, typically found when monitoring internal processes. This is indicative of a more relaxed brain than during focused attention.

Automatic Self-Transcending Meditation

In this form of meditation, usually you transcend on a sound, sometimes called a mantra. It is a sound in your mind, and you repeat it according to careful instructions, until ultimately the sound becomes fainter, then disappears. When both the mantra and all thoughts are gone, you are left with what is called pure awareness. This is the approach behind Transcendental Meditation (TM), Christian Centering Prayer (CCP, which partly originated with TM), and Christian Meditation (CM, also probably derived from TM). Sometimes Tibetan Buddhists, especially those with advanced practices, may do an *unsupported* meditation in which they simply aim to fall into a place without thoughts, perceptions, or feelings, experiencing the clear, lucid mind free of *kleshas*.

Automatic self-transcending methods involving a word or mantra are sometimes wrongly categorized as focused-attention meditations because descriptions of the methods may sound like you focus on a word or mantra, but the instructions are clear that you are not to stay focused on anything. You are encouraged to go beyond that sound rather than staying with it. There is no need to observe or

name thoughts. When noticing a thought, one goes gently back to the word or mantra and transcends it again. The emphasis is on no effort. I will discuss thoughts and the mantra more in the next chapter. The associated brain waves are alpha 1, typical of an alert, relaxed mind with internalized attention and expectancy.

What About You?

Have you ever tried meditating? Did you stop? If that is the case, reflect on why. Or maybe you meditate now. What have you experienced during it? Has it changed over the years? Meditating or not, have you ever experienced something like a sense of unboundedness or deep silence inside? A sense of deep calm? Perhaps an entire forgetting of your own self? Have you ever felt even for a moment as Buddha did, that you slipped into a bit of nirvana, a freedom from the attachments that lead to suffering? Has this ever persisted through the day or even during the night? Did it seem spiritual? Write about it if you wish—how often you have had it, whether it was a good experience, and its effects.

What About Me?

Before I began TM I had never meditated, and I do not recall any experiences of anything like the goal of meditation. In the last session of the five evenings of TM instruction, everyone is told about seven states of consciousness: waking, dreaming, and sleeping, then the critical fourth, transcendental or pure consciousness, on which three more after that build.

Over the next months I certainly transcended in the sense that my body changed during meditation. Breathing seemed to almost stop. If I tried to get up from meditation without taking the recommended two minutes, the contrast was uncomfortably strong. My heart would pound and I would swiftly feel a headache. After meditating (and taking enough time before getting up) I was feeling

deeply quiet inside, almost witnessing my activity instead of being involved in it, especially during and after a weekend retreat. But I did not think I ever experienced what they had called during instruction "transcendental consciousness." I was disappointed with myself sometimes, but mostly assumed my experience of this crucial state was something yet to come.

Then I saw a video of Maharishi, the founder of TM, answering questions about transcendental or pure consciousness. He said you might only experience it as a moment between thoughts or as a background to thought, a background that begins to predominate. Think of pure awareness or awareness itself as the screen onto which a movie is projected (the old-fashioned way). The movie is all of the rest of life, including your thoughts. But suppose you became more aware of the screen than the movie? That is awareness of consciousness by itself, or pure consciousness.

Seen as the background to all of my experiences, I realized that this was my experience in meditation all along. What a relief this was. I see now that I may always have thoughts most of the time in meditation, because I have a very active mind. That is my nature. But I am always drawn back to the experience I prefer, pure consciousness, or as close as I can get to it—pure consciousness as foreground and thoughts as subtle, usually boring background. In fact, now in meditation my thoughts are mostly so vague and uninteresting that I usually cannot say afterward what they were. But I only have really pure consciousness, no thoughts, no mantra, when I am close to falling asleep. That's simply how I am.

A recent insight about meditation came as a dream that showed me that my thoughts are like ants, energetic little beasts running all over the place, luxuriating metaphorically in the tasty fruit and tall grasses of my brain. When they find something delicious, they certainly can get organized—all marching in the same direction. It really was a good metaphor. I have always found ants fascinating, and I know they are important parts of their environments. My thoughts can be fascinating and useful too. Yes, in meditation they can be total pests, just like ants. Ants are a very successful species found all over the world, again, metaphorically true for my thoughts

outside of meditation. Look at all those books I wrote. I get it. I can be glad that ants will always be with me. I would just like to keep them where they belong.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

Given this review of your experience or lack of experience with meditation, and given the categories of meditation I gave above, what kind do you know best or always thought of as meditation? In the next chapter we will look again at types of meditation but in a different way, so keep in mind your thoughts or experiences.

Applying Western Knowledge About Cleaning Up to Enhance Eastern Methods of Waking Up

In the rest of this chapter, I will look at four subjects from Western psychology that can help with cleaning up, but also with waking up, in that they have a potentially huge effect when they arise in a relationship with a spiritual teacher. You may be thinking I am now way ahead of you. You have no plan to have a spiritual teacher. But if you want to meditate, you will encounter meditation teachers, even if only in a YouTube video or as authors of books. Whatever their qualifications, they have taken on some spiritual authority. That means power. And Western psychology has a great deal to teach about power relationships. Indeed, what follows can do double duty—it applies to relationships with a psychotherapist when using one for cleaning up, as well as with a spiritual teacher when using one for waking up. Indeed, there are many parallels.

Ranking and Linking

Let's start with a common problem: Many people start meditating, then stop. You will hear many reasons why, but often the bottom

line is, *I have too many thoughts*. Or *I'm not the type*. That is, I am flawed. We are now entering ranking territory.

Dan Brown, a Harvard professor specializing in attachment trauma who also taught Tibetan Buddhism to hundreds of students, echoes John Welwood, one of the few psychotherapists to blend their work with waking up, in saying he was shocked to see how many of his Western students suffered from low self-esteem due to their childhoods. They felt they could not meditate and certainly never become awakened.⁹ Their completely unconscious sense of ranking low had them defeated no matter how long they practiced.

Low self-esteem seems to be a problem mainly in the West. When a group of psychologists and meditation teachers were meeting with the Dalai Lama, one asked how she might help her students with their chronic low self-esteem.¹⁰ The Dalai Lama was astonished once he understood the question—the translator had to struggle because there is no word for low self-esteem in Tibetan. It makes sense that when Westerners learn to meditate, many assume they will not be good at it, and certainly never become awakened. Their completely unconscious sense of ranking low can have them defeated no matter how long they practiced.

Of course if low self-confidence can stop a person from meditating, it may also act as the strongest reason to pursue it, all the way to the goal, the seemingly highest rank. Surely to be awakened might seem like the ultimate way to feel permanently self-confident. But that sort of *spiritual bypass*, as Welwood termed it, has its dangers, to oneself and those you try to impress.¹¹

Ranking (being aware of your place in a group's hierarchy) and linking (forming friendships with particular others in a group, regardless of rank) are instinctive behaviors found in all social animals, including humans. I wrote a book about this, *The Undervalued Self*, because I realized that most people in therapy want more linking in their lives. But they cannot help being obsessed about ranking due to their upbringing. They tend to be having thoughts like *no one could ever like me* or *I am just not good enough to be successful in this world*.

To be clear, ranking is normal. If you go to the fence of a horse pasture and offer a carrot, all the horses will come, but one takes your offering and the others must wait. If it isn't perfectly clear, a nip or kick will settle it. Ranking organizes: Everyone knows where each individual is in the hierarchy, eliminating the need to fight it out every time. (Imagine going to work each morning and immediately having to decide who is in charge.) A lower rank does not necessarily lead to low self-esteem and defensiveness. Most people are surprisingly happy once they know their rank in a group. They can link with their friends and perhaps rank higher in some other real or imagined group, maybe on a team or in their knowledge of something.

Ranking high, however, does mean you have power (or influence, another word for it)—from the role you have been assigned (e.g., chairman), or for being respected (e.g., for wisdom, generosity, talent). Power can also come from having more allies, amassing more resources or, too obviously, threatening or resorting to violence. In a spiritual group, rank and power can come from your apparent level of awakening or connection with God, or from how the leader treats you.

Numerous clever experiments have been used to show that when you give someone power—that is, raise their perceived rank, even just by giving them a bigger chair than others in the room—they will begin to take advantage of it, often quite unconsciously, by choosing a bit more often what is best for themselves and thinking a bit less about the needs of others.¹² Applying this to spiritual leaders, they have power over you as soon as you grant them in your mind a high rank. How that power is used depends on a leader's awareness of how much power corrupts. The situation is also complicated by the fact that power also empowers. Seeming to be, or actually being superior, especially awakened, is a tool spiritual teachers can use to keep a student committed and consistent in their practice. Hopefully the teacher intends to use this power only to see that the student also awakens. The point is, you need to be savvy about the reasons

you grant power to any teacher and the ways the teacher uses that power.

HSPs, Ranking, and Linking

I have found through informal surveys that almost everyone enjoys linking more than ranking, but HSPs, with their high levels of empathy, especially do. Sensitive individuals, within whichever species this trait is seen, tend to be less aggressive, less determined to rank high. They find other ways to get what they need.¹³ HSPs do the same, but an HSP's preference to link or stronger feelings of empathy for others¹⁴ can be seen by competitors or bullies—that is, in ranking situations—as a sign of weakness. (Happily, HSPs have good role models, such as Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr., who knew how to stand up to bullies, demonstrating that in the end, linking can be a greater strength than ranking.)

Further, while HSPs may prefer linking, they are often among those most obsessed by ranking because of having low self-esteem due just to being a member of a minority. They may see themselves as lower in rank than they actually are. For example, they may not realize how much they are valued in their workplace. This initial low self-esteem means HSPs must actively work to gain respect, sometimes first just realizing they deserve it and not assuming roles that are beneath them. That especially applies in the context of spiritual leaders. They may be awake, in Wilber's sense, but how developed are they in other areas of life? Perhaps you surpass them there.

Ways Ranking Can Lead to Anxiety and Depression

I wrote a great deal in *The Undervalued Self* about how feeling low in rank can lead not just to anxiety about your rank—who is going to

take it from you—but also, if you fall in rank, to a sense of defeat that can be identical to depression. Western research revealed this first with animals.¹⁵ While fights in a group are usually avoided because everyone's rank is already clear, when one individual wants to move up in rank, a fight with the one having the higher rank does occur. (In humans you might call it jockeying for a better position, playing politics, kissing up to the boss, etc.) During a contest, it eventually becomes clear that one of the two is going to be defeated, and to avoid possibly mortal wounds, the defeated one runs far enough away to give the message that the fight is over. (In humans, this running away takes many forms. For example, you might deny that the higher rank ever mattered to you.)

However, if an animal is kept in the same cage with the victor (actually or metaphorically, as when a person cannot leave a family or workplace), that individual must shut down more completely to signal that he or she is no longer a threat. This shutting down of behavior and physiology is apparently innate and, at its extreme, is exactly like that seen in a depressed person—sharply reduced activity and apparently no pleasure or meaning left in anything. So, if you are feeling depressed and it is not caused by a physical problem such as a virus or low hormone levels, you can often find its source in some real or seeming defeat, recent or in the past, even in childhood.

Applying this to a relationship with a spiritual teacher, you and those around the person have given that person power. It is crucial that you, as the student, can sense that the teacher's power is genuinely held in the service of love, of caring, and of fondness for you and all students. That is, the teacher promotes linking and equality, even if some ranking inevitably does exist. No one around him is allowed to feel defeated (at least not for long) or to have failed to the point that they are depressed and cannot try again.

If you have a history of painful defeats, it may be difficult for a teacher, even a brilliant spiritual one, to judge how feedback will affect you. Some students are tough, but for some a mere glance can be experienced as devastating. Certainly, highly sensitive

students will be more affected by feedback of all kinds. So, if you are susceptible in this way, be especially aware of the potential for a spiritual teacher, maybe any teacher, to leave you depressed by a sense of being defeated, as a nobody in comparison to them. You certainly will need to clean up in this area to be around a teacher who is brash, brusque, or grouchy, for example. Above all, maintain a sense of your own power, including your power to leave the relationship. Total obedience is fine to expect from children or monks sworn (after years of mutual testing) to lifelong devotion, but not from adults living out in the world, with other allegiances. If you feel that you have no power in your relationship with a spiritual teacher, there is a problem, and you may need help to decide the source of that feeling and what to do.

Insecure Attachment in Terms of Ranking and Linking

Attachment models, discussed in the previous chapter, are easily seen in terms of ranking and linking. An infant whose parents are momentarily unresponsive becomes anxious. If this continues, they may cry and even scream. But when that fails, there is nothing left but defeat, a deep sense of helplessness, until the one with all the power, the parent, decides to help. Such a child has a low rank indeed. Fortunately, most parents are intensely linked to their infants, using their power totally in the service of love. First-time parents may even feel that the infant is controlling the family, and they are the ones who are helpless!

However, when infants feel helpless too often, they no longer sense the linking. When parenting is inconsistent, as I said in the previous chapter, children become anxiously insecure, or we can say worried about their rank, and they will try to exert control to, in a sense, rise in their rank or importance to the parents. But if they fail too often, they may fall into depression. As adults, they may be willing to do anything to avoid the defeat of being rejected or left.

As you also learned in the previous chapter, when a child is neglected or abused, they adopt the avoidant attachment model. In a sense they are even lower in rank, but the child defends against this defeated state by acting indifferent to the ranking in the family. (Siblings rank, too, of course.) As adults they may continue to feel or act indifferent to rank, or else strive to be the highest. That means leaving someone first if they sense they are about to be left.

It is easy to see how insecure attachment styles can lead to an obsession with ranking around spiritual teachers. Some students will feel inferior and do anything to please; others will do anything to rise in rank, to be the favorite, the most enlightened. And even if you are normally secure, your attachment issues can be triggered in these situations.

Here is where choice matters most, before you enter into something you cannot handle. We could not choose our caregivers, but later we can choose teachers, mentors, managers, therapists, and, especially, spiritual teachers. Why not choose people who increase your security? Again, you should sense that they like you and expect you to become their equal and will be okay without you when you are ready to move on.

Changing an Adult's Insecure Attachment Model Through Transference

An insecure attachment, because it happens so early in life, is difficult to heal in brief, cognitive behavioral therapy. It requires working, often for years, with what psychotherapists call transference. In the transference, the client assumes (transfers their experience) that they will be treated by their therapist the same way they were treated in childhood by their caregiver. (This happens to some degree in all therapy, but transference is discouraged in brief therapy.) Expecting the usual, the insecure patient leads with his or her well-honed defenses—being very, very good, or being very distant, superficial, or hyperintellectual. But good depth therapists

do something irresistible—they are quietly interested and caring. The patient, who missed this in childhood, instinctively attaches, often desperately. The resulting childlike emotions occurring in an adult professional relationship can lead to a client suffering greatly at times during treatment (feeling shame, intense longing, etc.) as well as the reliving and reworking of many sad, traumatic events. But in this safe and caring relationship, gradually the brain changes in what it expects, enjoys, is attracted to, allows in, and eventually gives in return.

I do not know how often a spiritual teacher heals an insecure attachment, but it would probably occur through an intense transference. I am sure it does happen with enough time with the right teacher. But before you let the genie out of the bottle, so to speak—before you let that inner child fall adoringly to the feet of the loving teacher—you need to be aware of the risks and problems. It is well understood that in psychotherapy an intense transference increases the risk of boundary violations such as sex between patient and therapist, but depth therapists are rigorously trained to avoid these violations, and they also fear serious legal problems if they fail. (Although, even with all these protections, it does occasionally happen.) A spiritual teacher might well take largely unconscious advantage of such adoration to receive, if not physical closeness, then tireless volunteer service, for example, or large financial donations and unquestioning loyalty.

Second, just as the ¹⁶therapists who lack training or the right personality for it may find an intense transference simply too much to tolerate, a spiritual teacher may find the intensity too much and eventually fail the student—stop showing interest, stop offering unlimited contact, or, most likely, find fault in the student for being too needy and dependent, all of which only intensifies an insecure adult attachment style.

How is a transference finally worked through? Often the patient begins to see the therapist as a real person, perhaps feeling some empathy or regret about the burden they have asked the therapist to carry. Or the patient moves from idealizing to beginning to see

flaws, just as young children first idealize their caregivers, then gradually experience their failings. Eventually the patient sees that the therapist, and all people, are not completely perfect or completely flawed. They learn not to *split*, as psychologists say. The same lesson hopefully comes with a spiritual teacher. The challenge is to view everyone, even this new category of the clearly enlightened, as whole—wonderful yet flawed.

However it happens, the intense transference energy inevitably moves on. Where does that energy go? As the *Upanishads* teach, “All love is directed towards the Self.” Not the small self or ego, but the Absolute Self. Cleaning up and waking up can be separated in the sense that they take place in different spaces, but I think the intense human relationships that especially foster cleaning up and waking up are not so different when they are at their best, deep and skillfully navigated.

Regarding HSPs, I have no data on it, but I suspect HSPs have always been more involved in psychotherapy than others. And as I have said, HSPs have that issue of differential susceptibility, meaning they may be more damaged, but also usually gain more from interventions, including psychotherapy. Likewise, I suspect they have sought out Eastern practices and teachers even more than others, as another way to manage strong feelings. So, I want HSPs to be especially careful about what practices and teachers they engage. However, HSPs also have great intuition and can probably sense what is going to be good for them and what is not. And with the right teacher, they will gain even more than others.

I realize this discussion of power, attachment, and transference has taken us a long way from simply learning meditation, but there are so many sad stories about people damaged by spiritual teachers (and by poorly trained therapists, too, of course). Although some, like Andrew Harvey in his *Direct Path*, urge people to avoid the whole “guru system” entirely, I doubt it will go away. Giving a high rank to those who seem superior spiritually seems part of our nature. A good sign of human growth, however, is that the issue of the betrayal of a student’s trust is being widely discussed and written about—for example, in *Meeting the Shadow on the Spiritual Path* by

Connie Zweig. Some spiritual teachers have even created an Association for Spiritual Integrity,¹⁷ with a twenty-four-point code of ethics and support groups for spiritual leaders. Perhaps we do not need to throw out the guru system, but clean it up and grow it up, aiming to make sure that this power is used in the service of love and the hope for a true, permanent alleviation of suffering.

What About You?

If you have done any cleaning up—maybe working on anxiety, depression, or insecurity in your relationships—what has been the role of ranking or power in your cleaning up? If you have or had an insecure attachment model, were you able to address this in psychotherapy? Did your therapy go on much longer than you expected because of a powerful transference? How has any of this affected your path?

If you have been in an ongoing personal relationship with a spiritual teacher, how has that been? How were power issues handled? How did ranking show itself? If you had unexpectedly intense feelings for your teacher, how was that handled? I imagine a wide variety of experiences here, from not much to a lot. Take the time you need to explore this truthfully.

What About Me?

I never felt an intense personal attachment to a spiritual teacher. I was around many people who had such an attachment with Maharishi. But I now feel fortunate that I was never close enough to him to experience kindness from him, which was always the bait that hooked me. But my Jungian analyst was exceptionally kind, and because of that I truly did worship him. Still, for at least the first ten years, every time I went to his office, I was deeply afraid. I think my conscious mind, especially the logical left brain, was threatened by the unconscious. My left brain knew scary thoughts and feelings

were arising and reasoned that they would be unacceptable if I spoke them or if he even guessed them, and then the kindness would end. But being a therapist myself by then, I also understood that every one of these thoughts and feelings had to be brought out eventually for this to work. Plus, I wanted—the child in me desperately wanted—all of this that seemed unacceptable to be accepted. And perhaps the seeker in me wanted to see how much of God was in this man.

Another fear was that I was not important to him, as my child part had feared that her parents were merely being nice but did not really like her—that is the essence of an anxious attachment. I also feared that expecting him to like me any more than as my therapist would be intrusive. I told him once that I wished I could believe he liked me at all, and he said he wished that I could believe that he did. On and on like that. To enhance the security and lessen the time I was in fear between sessions, we decided together that we should meet three times a week, and he also suggested that I could (and I always did for years) call on the weekends, leave him a message, and he would call back and leave me a message in response.

I desperately wanted to know where he lived but also feared knowing. (Some therapists do not want clients to know where they live. I understood that, feeling the same way as a therapist myself.) For me to find out would be as though I had violated some essential boundary that would be the fatal blow to our relationship. When he knew I felt that way—my rule was to talk about everything I feared—he did let me know, playfully. He mentioned the name of the street where he lived one day, then a month or so later he gave me a photo of him standing outside his entryway, the number clearly there on a post, letting me figure out his clue.

The need for these extras gradually waned. But right up to the end we spent many hours talking with the little girl in me. To keep the dialogue focused on her, we used methods from Voice Dialogue.¹⁸ When I was her, I would move from the chair where I usually sat to the couch, to keep us focused on her real presence.

He told me—sincerely, I knew by then—that he especially liked being with her.

I do think we were a good match, both of us being introverted HSPs with spiritual as well as Jungian interests, so that perhaps liking me was not that difficult. But I would never have imagined that during those twenty years.

Most important, my analyst understood that a secure attachment takes years to create, especially when it must replace caregivers who were feared for various reasons. My father's obsession with sex and his poor boundaries were just a part of that. (To be clear, my father never engaged in any overtly physical sexual behavior with me.) One major turning point was when my analyst decided near the end of his practicing to work from home. It hit me that I would be in his house alone with him. While on one level it seemed perfectly fine, and the little girl was thrilled to be going to his home, she had another feeling that surprised us. Perhaps remembering something about her father, she was truly physically terrified of this new plan of being alone in a house with him. My analyst suggested I first drive by a few days before our session, then the day after that maybe walk up to the door, and then we would see how it went on the day when he would answer the doorbell. Of course I was safe, but his complete acceptance of the fear helped dispel it. The little girl in me had found a father she could trust.

He was also a new mother for me, one who never became angry with anything I did. I feared even getting out of my chair and walking around his office, even taking a few steps (not that clients usually do that). Knowing that, he encouraged me to try it, but it took years for me to feel free just moving around.

I was extremely fortunate to find this therapist, and he had the professional credentials to match. For me, he was the protector on my path as I traversed a jungle full of monsters. Together, we faced them bravely and always found a way to tame them enough for them to let us through, although some still followed me at a distance. However it came about, I believe that every change inside of me was from being loved so genuinely and unconditionally by someone I revered, respected, and initially feared as being so far

above me in goodness that there seemed to be no hope of that. My job was to test his caring by talking about every fear and everything that seemed shameful. He took it in, held it, and cherished it just because it was mine.

The day my analyst told me he would retire felt like the worst day of my life. It was Good Friday. He gave me two-and-a-half years' notice, knowing it would take that long for me to be ready, if that would even happen. About a year before the planned ending, I announced I was quitting therapy as of that week, thinking I could not bear any more, but he pointed out I would be missing out on the chance to work this through. Nearing the end, we talked about what we would do on the last day, in detail, so that we both would be less nervous. On that day we actually felt celebratory about what we had accomplished.

After that seemingly miraculous ending, my spiritual progress in the Upper World seemed unstoppable.

Looking Back on What You Reflected Upon

If you have ever experienced an intense transference, you may be having some strong feelings right now, after reflecting again on that period in your life. If it still feels raw, or maybe shameful, this is a good time to continue to integrate it as something that was normal and necessary. If you were not able to work it through with your therapist or teacher, you may want to seek help with that. But seek carefully! If the feeling still feels raw, the one with whom the feelings arose probably did not have the skill to resolve them, and you do not want that pattern to happen again with someone else. Therapists who work well with an intense transference are rare. Spiritual teachers, probably even rarer.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

We started in the Upper World, with Krishna's advice to Arjuna about Being and Buddha's teachings about nirvana, both describing a state free from suffering. Both made meditation central to their solutions. So, next you learned that not all meditation is the same, and then focused on three types, categorized by the brain waves they produce. In the second half of the chapter, we were more in the Lower World, looking at the causes of suffering, the instincts behind ranking, anxiety, depression, and insecure attachment, which seem to especially plague those in the West and therefore require our attention on a spiritual path. We also touched on the healing potential in irrational idealizations or transferences, along with their dangers. We looked at how all this might affect the interactions of students and spiritual teachers, because you may someday be thinking about a relationship with one.

In all this, we have been moving toward waking up while diligently considering issues around cleaning up, using the best of East and West. Remember the snowplow from [Chapter 1](#)? Meditation is the perfect example. As an engine, the desire for nirvana, for waking up, moves us forward, providing increased energy and creativity, but our approach adds a blade on the front that cleans up. It reduces obstacles by considering the sources of anxiety, depression, and irrational attachments that give too much power to others. Still, the snowplow's engine is key. Having so much to offer and so many meditation methods to choose from, the topic of meditation needs another chapter.

CHAPTER 6

FURTHER EXPLORING MEDITATION

This chapter focuses entirely on eyes-closed, silent meditation because it is a very powerful practice if done consistently. And so many people do meditate or are considering it and many others have tried it and quit, thinking they now know enough about it. Yet there are huge differences in methods that most people do not understand. This is because methods are rarely compared in an objective way, as I will try to do here. You cannot expect to hear the whole story from any single teacher of meditation or practitioner. Most of them only know their method, so what they say about other methods is often sadly misinformed. As promised, in this sanctuary you will not be pushed around, corralled into thinking you really ought to meditate or must meditate in a particular way. I will discuss all types of eyes-closed silent meditation as objectively as I can (in spite of what you may have read in italics about my personal choices), so that you can see your options.

We will start with the two meditation methods that have been most popular in the West: TM and mindfulness meditation. But first, we will explore the two traditions behind them, Vedanta and Buddhism. Paradoxically, TM is in a sense the oldest as well as the newest aspect of Vedanta, old in that it is somewhat similar to the earliest teachings about meditation, but was drastically updated in

the last hundred years. And mindfulness meditation is just a small part of Buddhist practices, there from the beginning as a warm-up for more complex practices, but now taught on its own. In a way, both are partially cut off from their roots and grafted on to Western science, where they flourish. But the roots are still there, deep down, and influencing these two kinds of meditation and therefore you.

Next, we will explore the Buddhist meditation systems you are likely to encounter, in their Westernized forms, including Insight or *Vipassana*, Zen, and Tibetan Buddhism. Then we will turn to ways of categorizing methods of meditating, those we may not discuss here. There has been a wide proliferation of meditation methods. Almost every new book teaches a new method. So, you need to know how to sort these out.

You learned in the last chapter about the three types of things you might be asked to do in meditation and the resulting brain activity—gamma brain waves associated with focusing, theta brain waves associated with open-monitoring, and alpha brain waves associated with automatic self-transcending. In this chapter you will learn two other ways of categorizing meditation methods, according to the philosophy behind why you are doing what you are doing, one of two ideas about how to reach enlightenment.

These two categories come from Jonathan Shear,^{[1](#)} who co-authored with Fred Travis the article about the three brain activity categories. What are these two categories? First are the methods intended to help your mind work like that of an enlightened person. For these he used the term Practice Makes Perfect. Shear says that in these meditation methods the goal is to cultivate *dispositions* held to be important for daily life and mental health, and the mental habits or *characteristics* of enlightenment. The logic here is straightforward: practice makes perfect. The mind/brain is trained to become better at doing outside of meditation, 24/7, the kinds of things it learns to do in meditation. As you will see, these methods can include both focusing and open-monitoring brain activity.

Shear called the second category state-enlivening methods. These methods are intended to generate and stabilize pure consciousness as the background to all activity. That background is seen as the essential basis for the spontaneous development of such things as better perception, mind-body coordination, moral maturity, creativity, and self-actualization. You do not practice at any of these, but they develop automatically, as side effects of the ultimate goal, the state of enlightenment. You will see that this goal can be reached using either focusing or automatic self-transcending brain states. I hope you can see that these are quite different philosophies for you to think about.

I realize this sounds a little complicated, but understanding the three categories of brain activity and the two categories of ways to approach enlightenment will allow you to recognize the type of meditation being taught, whatever the tradition it comes from or even if it has been newly invented by someone. As I said, we are dealing with the chaos of a supernova. This subject refuses to stay simple, so I will end with another approach, often ignored, which is meditation from the heart.

Again, all of this is intended to help you understand and choose the meditation practice right for you—if any do seem right. Indeed, if you are going to read through all of this, I will begin with the evidence for the value of meditation in general, with a quick review of the research on meditation. But first, a story.

A Lived Experience

As you know by now, I give my personal experiences mostly in italics so that you can skip them if you wish. But here is one that I think will dramatize why you should meditate consistently enough to have the meditation response built into you.

I was riding a subway in Manhattan when the train suddenly stopped, not at a station but in the dark tunnel between stations. There was no announcement about it, which was peculiar, and as the minutes passed, people began to have their various reactions of

fear, irritation, and blaming. Voices were getting louder, weirder. The car was packed, and I was standing, clinging to a pole. I was not exactly scared, but I guess I was close to it. I was alone, surrounded by strangers. This was the New York subway, not exactly my home territory.

So, I closed my eyes and meditated, in the same way I have done for decades, except I was standing up. I certainly did not expect to have some cosmic experience. I was just calming myself while shutting out the people around me. But soon I noticed they had fallen quiet, seemingly feeling calmer. Definitely much calmer. Then the train moved on to the next station and things were back to normal—at least what's normal for the New York subway.

Any eyes-closed silent meditation is a powerful tool, because if done consistently, it teaches your mind and body to calm down whenever you start the process. This training can come in very handy, as it did that day. For example, I use it when having an MRI (removing me from the noise and my nascent claustrophobia), at the dentist, and when things get rough on a plane (with the weather or the passengers).

Imagine a scale of zero to ten, with ten feeling totally stressed and zero totally calm. It is lovely to meditate where it is quiet and there will be no distractions. At such times, your meditation will probably start at a very calm three and maybe end at zero. You want lots of these experiences, of course. Yet I would argue that a meditation starting at ten and getting you down even to eight is a real victory. Your body will rejoice. If you are around others who are stressed, by reducing your own stress, they will feel it. Affecting others on the subway was not my goal at all, but I might have expected it. Bodily states of emotion are highly contagious,² and brains can synchronize.³

The point is, if you practice meditation long enough, you have developed right inside your own body a sort of medication that you can try applying whenever you think you can use it. It can help with everything from insomnia to trouble making decisions. Anything

stress-related. And there is no worry about strange chemicals with weird side effects. It's all naturally yours.

By the way, you can definitely begin to feel meditation does *not* work if you have too many meditations up around ten on my scale, but if they are that common, and you are meditating correctly, it usually has to do with your own stress level. If this is temporary, just accept it. If you are always stressed, do not expect a daily meditation practice to solve it all. You need to take other action, depending on the sources of that stress. According to how I approach meditation, all meditation sessions are good ones, doing what you need that day, but even a snowplow cannot move an avalanche.

Meditation Research

I understand if you still need to see some research before deciding to practice meditation and do it consistently. The research on meditation is a huge topic, and I am going to divide it into research on the potential effects of any kind of meditation on your daily life—its effects on health, mental health, relationships, and so forth, whatever the method used. That is, the overall benefits. Most of this research has been done looking at mindfulness meditation and TM, with few differences found between them in short-term studies.

The other type of research is on the subtler cumulative effect of different methods—what happens in the brain and body during and after a meditation session or after some weeks, months, or years of meditating, depending on the method. So I will cover that research later, after we have looked more at the types.

As I said, there are huge quantities of research on meditation generally and on the different types, and I have spent many hours reading it. This book is not the place for a thorough review of these thousands of studies, especially as it would already be out of date by the time the book is published, and even a brief summary can get complicated. I also suspect you would not enjoy it. Still, you really need to know some of this.

About the effects of meditation on one's daily life (forgetting for now any long-term goal), the good news is that the short-term benefits are somewhat similar for all types of meditation. Taking "being mindful" as an example, where you might expect a difference, in that mindfulness meditation might increase mindfulness more than TM,⁴ a study comparing those practicing TM and a group of nonmeditating controls found that after three months, the meditating subjects scored higher than the controls on a standard measure of mindfulness—that is, being able to observe and describe what is going on, being aware of what you are doing, not judging your inner experience, and not emotionally overreacting. It appears that whatever type of meditation method is practiced, it calms the mind so that we can be more aware, more mindful in the general sense.

Because methods do not matter much in the research on daily effects, as I go through these, I usually give only one study as an example, not worrying if it was specifically on mindfulness meditation or TM. There are now so many studies, however, that the research often appears as a meta-analysis, which is a statistical summary of a large body of similar studies meeting certain criteria. The goal is to try to sum up the effects of many studies in a single number, what is called the effect size. In all the meta-analyses I report, the effect size was "moderate," which is very good for this type of research.

Simply naming the topics of the studies in one of these meta-analyses,⁵ you gain a good sense of the breadth of the results. A meta-analysis done in 2012 had the advantage for this purpose of comparing mindfulness and TM plus a few other methods so I will discuss this one. There were 163 studies deemed methodologically sound (worthy of inclusion), and these found improvements in interpersonal functioning, mindfulness (as described above), positive emotion, self-realization, perception, attention, cognition, and behavior (coordination, reaction time, etc.). Plus, there were reductions in anxiety as a state (transient anxiety), anxiety as a trait (persistent anxiety), negative emotion, neuroticism, and stress. In

this study, mindfulness meditation and TM seemed to be about the same in their effect—some slightly higher in one area, some a little higher in another (on average, TM was slightly higher).

Regarding mental health alone, a meta-analysis of fifty-two selected studies found broad improvements.⁶ Looking at general health, there are so many meta-analyses that there is a metasynthesis of all the meta-analyses of randomized controlled trials of the effect of meditation on health, all finding a moderate positive effect.⁷

Turning to some specific studies as examples, meditation appears to improve intelligence,⁸ including intelligence in older people.⁹ It helped people with their mental health during COVID-19.¹⁰ A systematic review of ten studies found mindfulness practice improved the emotional intelligence of health care professionals in general.¹¹ Meditation is good for adolescents as well as adults.¹² And meditation is helpful during pregnancy and for postpartum mental health.¹³

Turning to specific aspects of physical health, meditation reduces blood pressure.¹⁴ Indeed there are reviews of all the meta-analyses on that problem alone¹⁵ as well as meta-analyses of how meditation affects other cardiovascular conditions.¹⁶

Other studies found that meditation slows aging¹⁷ and improves immune functioning.¹⁸ Changes in gene expression in long-term meditators¹⁹ provide evidence, according to the authors of the study, for positive change in stress-related molecular mechanisms that could underlie the observed reductions in anxiety, PTSD, cardiovascular disease, and other chronic disorders and diseases. Further, while the human brain begins deteriorating after the first two decades of life, a study of one hundred long-term meditators (age twenty-four to seventy-seven years) using various types of meditation found that, compared to controls, this decline (looking at reductions of gray matter) was much more limited.²⁰

Now perhaps you want to be one of those meditators, or at least keep learning about meditation.

The Two Traditions

As I said earlier, meditation in the sixties was what the Beatles did in India. It happened to be Transcendental Meditation (TM), a practice from the Vedanta tradition. Today, meditation is often equated with mindfulness meditation, what the Buddhists do.

Are TM and mindfulness meditation the same, more or less? Yes, in that both come from traditions in which meditation was practiced with the goal of enlightenment, although that goal is frequently lost sight of in the West. The same is true of yoga. For many students and teachers, these practices have nothing to do with awakening or even with spirituality—one practices for the health benefits, for increasing creativity and productivity, or decreasing stress and anxiety. As we saw, meditation does provide all of this. If that is your reason for meditating, that is absolutely fine with me, and yes, again, these two popular methods are more or less the same for these purposes.

On the other hand, as I said earlier, the two methods are not at all the same in their philosophy about how to reach enlightenment, and to understand how they differ and why, you need to know even more about their roots.

The First Tradition, TM and Vedanta

The *Bhagavad Gita*, with its story of Krishna and Arjuna, that early seed of TM, comes from Vedanta. Vedanta emerged in India around 800 BCE. Buddha was born later, in what is now Nepal, in 624 BCE, so he would have known some form of Vedanta. Again, Vedanta in English means “the end of the Veda,” which refers to it being the last part to be written down and also the culmination of Vedic thought.

Vedanta is said to have emerged from three sources: the *Upanishads*, which I mentioned earlier, having been written down between 800 and 200 BCE; the *Brahma Sutras* (on the subject of attaining knowledge of Brahman), well-known between 600 and 200 BCE but written down maybe 400 to 450 CE; and the *Bhagavad Gita*, written down sometime between 500 BCE and 400 CE. Krishna's teachings in the *Gita* are all based on the *Upanishads*. I emphasize *written down* because all of this would have been part of an earlier purely oral tradition.

The most important figure in modern Vedanta is Adi Shankara, who lived 700 to 750 CE, well after Buddha. Shankara revived and codified Vedanta, making it Advaita Vedanta, some say as a reaction to Buddhism, and some say to make it more like Buddhism! (Advaita means oneness or nontwoness, as opposed to Dvaita, twoness.) Advaita Vedanta has a great deal to say on the subject of Brahman: that it is everything, including yourself, so enlightenment comes when you realize you are Brahman. This realization was observed to lead to a sense of bliss and wholeness. (While Vedanta seems to be teaching a nonduality that would rule out the worship of God or Isvara, Shankara was comfortable with worshipping his version of God, as are many in India. As I said previously, it is common in India to be comfortable with both nonduality and duality being true, or maybe each being true in different states of consciousness.)

The point here is that while TM seems very new, its roots go back to 800 BCE. Shankara created the position of Shankaracharya, a title given to the four teachers heading the monasteries he had set up in the four corners of India. They were given the sacred task of developing and preserving Advaita Vedanta, and their names are known back to 1445. The position in the north was mostly vacant, however, from 1776 until 1941, when Brahmananda Saraswati, Maharishi's teacher, who was affectionately called Guru Dev, was asked to fill the long-empty role. Guru Dev refused several times, being a hermit who had lived his entire life in various caves and huts deep in India's forests. But he was apparently renowned for his enlightenment and was the obvious choice to those involved. He

finally emerged at age seventy and accepted.²¹ TM appeared in this context. So, we are now up to modern times and TM. Let us now turn to Buddhism and bring it up to modern times.

The Second Tradition, Buddhism, Up to Mindfulness Meditation and Modern Buddhism

The relationship of Vedanta to Buddhism is not clear. Vedanta is the soil from which Buddhism sprang. We know Buddha studied with what would have been Vedanta teachers, and he must have heard a wide variety of approaches to awakening. I say heard because in those days, again, teachings were not written down. It was thought that the face-to-face teacher-student relationship was essential to conveying this type of knowledge. After Buddha died, others wrote down what he allegedly taught—an obvious problem for those who want to know exactly what he said versus what others added over time.

We know this much: After years of seeking, Buddha rejected all the intellectual Vedanta ideas he was hearing as not relevant and instead focused on meditation. He said it many times: He was not interested in the nature of the Self or Brahman. He believed you could think what you liked about these metaphysical concepts, but he was teaching how to reach an experience *beyond anything that his mind or any mind had created*. He was only interested in what got you to nirvana, and he said that having enjoyable states or comforting beliefs (how he viewed Vedanta's teachings about being established in some blissful state) were still clinging to something, and clinging to anything means you do not yet have the perfect freedom of nirvana.

You received a taste of Buddhism when I explained the Eight-Fold Path and then, later, the Four Noble Truths and nirvana. If that was complex, I'm afraid it gets more so. Buddhism has spread out over the centuries, sprouting all kinds of new ideas along the way. Given all that, anything I say will be wrong from someone's point of view,

maybe yours. But hopefully you will learn something new here. Just be patient as I take my own stab at it.

First, to be honest, no one knows exactly what Buddha taught. But he was at it for forty-plus years after he became enlightened, so there was quite a bit. The written texts date from well after his death, which leaves ample room for debate about what he really said. Since those early texts, there have been 2500 years' worth of commentaries and disputes, each a cause for division into schools of thought. There is Theravada (38 percent of Buddhists), which aims for individual nirvana; Mahayana (which includes Zen, 56 percent of Buddhists), in which you aim/vow to liberate not just yourself but all beings; and Vajrayana (6 percent), a more esoteric form of Mahayana, sometimes equated with Tibetan Buddhism. There is a further horizontal spread due to various lineages and schools of thought arising in different countries and languages (India, Tibet, China, Japan, Korea, Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, Taiwan, Sri Lanka, etc.). Now in the West, there are adherents of each of these who studied with teachers in one of these places and now provide their own interpretations of what they learned. Mayhem! Or wisdom.

But let's begin by talking about meditation as Buddha taught it (we think). We say meditation, but Buddha's term for it was *bhavana*, meaning cultivation, as when one cultivates a field and gradually improves it, so that the harvest is fully satisfying—an analogy the people around him understood. (Notice the sense of practice makes perfect.) Different kinds of *bhavana*—or as we say, meditation—improve the mind, the body, our compassion, our wisdom, and so on, some directly and some by cleansing the mind of those *kleshas*, and any ill will, laziness, worry, or doubt. Weeding, you might say. It is all about developing every aspect of the Eight-Fold Path to nirvana—right view, resolve, speech, livelihood, etc. But the last three, right effort, right mindfulness, and right *samadhi* are the closest to what we think of as meditation.

To review the last three, right effort is about energetically getting rid of unwholesome and evil thoughts and producing good, wholesome ones. On the Buddhist path you do this all the time, but definitely in meditation. Right mindfulness means being diligently

aware of everything going on, all the time, in the body and in the mind. When right mindfulness is practiced in meditation (as opposed to during daily tasks or walking), this would be open-monitoring meditation (observing your experiences without judgment or reaction) and the source of modern mindfulness meditation. Right *samadhi* means right concentration, which means focused-attention meditation. There are four stages (*jhana* states) in developing right concentration, and in the last there is only pure equanimity or awareness.

Another, simpler way of thinking about Buddhist meditation is in the two forms of *bhavana* or cultivation. The first form is *samatha*, which calms the mind, but also develops concentration and the capacity for what we would call higher or mystical states. Mindfulness meditation on the breath is the classic example and the first one taught. Buddha mastered these *samatha* methods to the point, apparently, of having experienced mystical or higher states, but saw them all as mind-created and not leading directly to nirvana. These are mostly open-monitoring activities.

The second aspect of *bhavana* is *vipassana*, which develops the real insight required for nirvana—that everything is impermanent, including your own life and your own thoughts. You observe that everything comes, stays awhile, and goes. Every thought is dependent on other thoughts. There is no essence. Or you might reflect on the truth of each of the Four Noble Truths. If *vipassana* is practiced faithfully, with a calm and observant mind developed with *samatha*, you eventually realize the truth behind all that you experience, and that realization is the mind in nirvana. It is not that what you experienced before is unreal, but instead of perception being habitual and robotic, you perceive with the “clear light mind,” to use a term from Tibetan Buddhism. In brief, nirvana is the result of working on all Eight Folds simultaneously, but very skilled meditation is central to it.

There are at least forty subjects of *vipassana* meditation or observation, covering all aspects of the path. For example, you might meditate on your mortality, your body after death, compassion for those who are suffering, or joy for other’s success. Especially

important are meditations on unlimited universal love and goodwill to all living beings, or *metta*. Scripts for *metta* can be found all over the internet. How much of these methods were taught directly by Buddha is not known, but we are now up to modern times in Vedanta and Buddhism, so we turn next to the two modern forms of meditation, so popular in the West today, TM and mindfulness meditation.

The Modern Two—TM and Mindfulness Meditation, Plus *Vipassana*

Somewhere in the past, Buddha learned a method of meditation from Vedanta that he used to reach nirvana, so one could say that TM and mindfulness meditation have a common source. But that was in the distant past. Today, we have two very different approaches to meditation. By now we have covered quite a bit about Buddhist meditation, but not much about its modern forms. The same is true for Vedanta. We have discussed Vedanta at length, but not its modern variation as TM. Let's do that now.

TM

According to Maharishi, he learned what he called Transcendental Meditation from Guru Dev, who learned it from his teacher, and so on, back many generations. But we do not know how far back. Dana Sawyer, an author and professor who has spent considerable time in India, learned meditation from a number of swamis in the same tradition of monks, called *dandis*, to which Guru Dev belonged. They are the primary lineage holders of Shankara, making them the only group from which a Shankaracharya can be selected.^{[22](#)} There are about five hundred to one thousand *dandis* in India now, and Sawyer, while researching them, met about half of them. He found that they all taught exactly the same method of meditation as

Maharishi taught TM teachers to use. (Being a TM teacher himself in the past, Sawyer said he could even sing along during the ritual *puja* used when teaching TM, a ceremony honoring the tradition.)

What makes TM so unique that it needed its own automatic self-transcending category in the previous chapter? Its method of meditation and for attaining enlightenment is simply to have the direct experience of pure being or pure consciousness in meditation and alternate that with daily activity. The focus is no longer on developing the steps leading to enlightenment, as in Buddha's Eight-Fold Path or Patanjali's Eight Limbs of yoga. Rather, the goal is to have brief direct experiences of pure consciousness until these gradually expand into daily life, becoming present 24/7.

What you do during the rest of the day is still important. In fact, it is essential to alternate meditation with some daily activity, assuming it is not too stressful. TM teachers use the analogy that to dye a cloth you dip it in the dye (pure consciousness), then let it fade in activity, then dip it again, then let it fade, repeating this until there is no more fading and the cloth is dyed permanently. Some yoga and breathing instruction is available from TM teachers if you ask for it, but there is no discussion of proper behavior. The idea is that the more you infuse pure consciousness into your nervous system, the more that other positive changes will occur automatically or at least happen more easily.

TM does involve a mantra, so that, as I said in the previous chapter, it is often confused with focused attention meditation. But you are told not to concentrate on the mantra, but rather to let it go if the mind wants to fall quiet. When you notice having thoughts, you return to the mantra, then automatically your mind becomes quieter, going deeper again, so there is a cycle. We will discuss the use of the mantra in automatic self-transcending methods more when we explore the TM spinoffs, Christian Centering Prayer and Christian Meditation.

While meditation with a mantra is very common in India today, this automatic self-transcending method of mantra meditation, leading to alpha brain activity, was relatively rare. Key to its spread in the West was the recognition of its value by Maharishi and above

all his description of this new method in terms of modern physics. He was a university student studying physics when he met Guru Dev. He was smitten and became Guru Dev's disciple and eventually his secretary, but Guru Dev encouraged him to first finish his degree.

Maharishi's study of physics provided him with Western terminology to describe this method's uniqueness. He reasoned that if the state of pure consciousness is so desirable, so blissful, so deeply restful, why doesn't the mind just go there, easily? Automatically transcend? Perhaps it does, he reasoned, if we think of it as the nervous system's state of least excitation, following the law of least action in physics. (I think the meaning of these terms is obvious, but you can look them up.) If a meditation method does not require one to focus or to monitor anything, the big discovery here is that the mind really does just drop into quieter and quieter states until it is utterly silent, unbounded. Except that, as every meditator will tell you, thoughts will come and take you out of the deep stillness of meditation. Why is that?

Maharishi argued that thoughts are just part of the process, part of what the mind does to get rid of the stress that is in the way of staying in the experience of pure consciousness. He reasoned that most people, except on retreat, are carrying stress when they sit down to meditate—thoughts and sometimes physical sensations carried over from the day, the week, the year, or a lifetime. The now common use of the word *stress* to describe the effect of accumulated strain in humans comes from physics, where it describes how molecules within a material can put pressure on other molecules—for example, due to being heated—until the resulting change in shape turns into measurable strain or deformation. In human brains, we could say that the more strain or pressure on neurons due to overstimulating experiences, the more unwanted, unnecessary thoughts we have in meditation and out. Remember, this is only a metaphor, but we can think of neurons as being similar to molecules in that they can heat up more with more activity. Then, as we cool down by thinking the mantra, thoughts leave or dissolve just as heat dissipates until, like cooled-down molecules, we reach this sought-after state of least excitation, pure consciousness.

This new way of seeing thoughts, as the natural result of recovering from stress, was revolutionary. True, since TM arrived in the West we commonly hear when learning any kind of meditation that *when you have a thought, effortlessly return ...* to whatever you are supposed to be doing. But in the context of other methods, it is not usually an invitation to return to pure consciousness or to your mantra in order to return to pure consciousness. You are usually effortlessly returning to your breath, to observing your thoughts, to concentrating on an object, or whatever. You are effortlessly returning to focusing or open monitoring. Experiencing pure consciousness by itself is usually seen in other traditions as too difficult to do without considerable practice controlling thoughts. So, it is a real game-changer to say that experiencing pure consciousness does not require learning to concentrate and keep out thoughts but rather requires allowing thoughts to come because they indicate stress going. (When asked about the problem in meditation of the *monkey mind*, Maharishi liked to say that with TM we offer the monkey a banana, the bliss of pure consciousness.)

The idea that the mantra disappears into pure consciousness is how several other Vedanta teachers were describing meditation at the time. In particular, the much-revered Ramana Maharishi (1879–1950) and Sivananda Saraswati (1887–1963, founder of the Divine Life Society in 1936 in India) made a point of distinguishing their forms of meditation from concentration forms. So perhaps the method was in their traditions as well. But it was Maharishi who translated it into the vocabulary of Western science—the principle of least action, the state of least excitation, and the reduction of stress in a physical system.

To be clear, the experience of thoughts dissipating during the deeper periods of meditation is usually followed by more thoughts arising (more stress being removed), so that usually in every meditation the process repeats several times—into that pure silence, then out in thoughts, then back in. During the deep silence, there are few or no thoughts, breathing is very subtle or even suspended, blood pressure drops, and the heartbeat slows.²³ Yet one is fully

awake. Because the process is effortless when done right, the brain waves of someone who has been practicing for two months is similar to those of people doing TM for years.²⁴ There is no learning involved, except initially learning not to try. Again, the key idea is that the mind will gladly settle down to a resting state, or as close as it can get, as often as it can. This is automatic self-transcending.

Mindfulness Meditation and All the Rest of Modern Buddhism

We have now brought Vedanta up to modern times, in the form of TM. So, let's do the same with Buddha's original ideas about meditation—we will bring them forward to better understand the widely popular secular mindfulness meditation and the main schools of modern Buddhism that you are going to find, for example, on the internet.

Thanks to the intensity of our supernova, the Buddhism practiced in the West is quite different from the Buddhism of the past or even in the East now. Western Buddhism is also called modern Buddhism because Buddhism all over the world is being modernized by Western thinking. For example, it de-emphasizes key traditional Buddhist doctrines, such as reincarnation and the goal of avoiding rebirth, because Westerners usually do not believe in these. Buddhist teachers like Thich Nhat Hanh or the Dalai Lama may firmly believe in reincarnation, but they do not insist that their followers agree, and the next generation of Buddhist teachers are even less insistent on reincarnation.

In addition, because many Westerners are atheists or agnostics, they are especially attracted to Buddhism because, at least in their understanding of it, it does not involve the belief in God or even something without qualities, like Brahman. Actually, traditional Buddhism has always included a belief in supernatural beings and the worship of icons, although none of that was ever seen as necessary to achieve nirvana. But all of these beings are also left out

of Western Buddhism, or they are interpreted as Jungian archetypes²⁵ or symbols of natural laws.

Mindfulness Meditation

I said that mindfulness meditation truly arrived in the West with the Vietnamese Zen Buddhist monk Thich Nhat Hanh, but its secular version was very effectively spread by Jon Kabat-Zinn. Kabat-Zinn earned his doctorate in molecular biology in 1971 at MIT, but this was right at the height of the initial supernova, so he was soon reconsidering his life's purpose while acting as a founding member of the Cambridge Zen Center. After studying with Thay, as Thich Nhat Hanh is affectionately called, and other Buddhist teachers, mostly Westerners, Kabat-Zinn took the mindfulness ball and ran with it all the way to what he saw as the real goal: many, many people learning to calm themselves through meditation, which was best done unencumbered by any Eastern or even spiritual flavor, including the unnecessary goal of enlightenment.

In 1974 he created the Stress Reduction Clinic at the University of Massachusetts Medical School, and soon created an eight-week course in Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR), as well as training teachers to teach it in every area of life, not only in connection with health but also business, education, the military, prisons, the inner city, and almost any place you might imagine. Of course he has also published considerable research on the practice.²⁶

MBSR teaches you to observe your breath, experience any sensations or feelings that arrive, and observe thoughts without judgment. Buddha did teach this method, as you saw. He called it *samatha* on the breath or, as I said before, *anapanasati*. In terms of the previous chapter, this is clearly an open monitoring practice, intended to help you to be more aware in a calm way of your body, thoughts, and feelings.

You can easily learn this form of mindfulness meditation online or from many books.²⁷ Or learn from Jon Kabat-Zinn's website, or that of the MBSR organization (or just mindful.org). After three months of practice, you can even take the leadership training course (which the website says has been taken by ninety thousand people) or do a one-day or five-day silent retreat.

If you wonder what you are missing by dropping all Buddhism from your meditation practice, there is a good comparison of MBSR with mindfulness learned in a Buddhist context by Thubten Chodron, a Western Buddhist nun.²⁸ Chodron points out that MBSR does not address ethical conduct as Buddhism always does; it is for feeling calmer and being healthier, not obtaining nirvana or developing wisdom and compassion; and it is only a small aspect of the meaning and practice of mindfulness in Buddhism. So let's look at a different tradition involving mindfulness.

Mindfulness in the Plum Village Tradition

Thich Nhat Hanh, or Thay (simply meaning Master or Teacher), who died in 2022, was a truly charismatic figure with a worldwide following. As a young monk in Vietnam during the war, he was entirely focused on the Buddhist goal of alleviating suffering, and he saw a lot of it. In 1966, after expressing opposition to the war and refusing to take sides, he was exiled. Once in the West, Thay quickly became popular. In 1982, he founded a monastery and meditation center in France, what he called Plum Village, and then other centers, mostly in the United States. There are now numerous practice centers around the world.

With his first book,²⁹ *The Miracle of Mindfulness*, it is clear that Thay saw mindfulness as Buddha did, as an entire way of living to reduce suffering. He emphasized being mindful at all times, being fully present and alive, body and mind united. If one can maintain mindfulness, awareness, in all areas of life, that is in his view the same as enlightenment. Remember, mindfulness is its own item on

Buddha's Eight-Fold Path. Thay encouraged cultivating it in walking meditation as well as when eating, cooking, or doing chores. So, again, in Buddhist meditation you practice mindfulness to be mindful all the time. Practice makes perfect.

You can try meditation in Thay's tradition by finding *how to meditate* on the plumvillage.org website. But it is probably best to learn it through a live online course or in person. If you visit one of the eleven centers, you will find an emphasis on the ethical precepts, building community, and engaged Buddhism. That is, once one is mindfully centered inside and also within a community, one can begin to serve the world. All in all, thanks to Thay's sweet, gentle personality, meditating within the Plum Village tradition is about the heart—feeling good, smiling, embracing life, and being positive.

***Vipassana* Through the Insight Meditation Society and Goenka**

If you want to explore Buddhism further, you obviously need to look into *vipassana*, Buddha's term for the insight aspect of his path. But in modern Buddhism it refers specifically to a type of Theravada revived in Southeast Asia and now a major influence in North America. You can get a feeling for it from books and articles—for example, "What Is³⁰ *Vipassana* Meditation and How Do You Practice It?" by one of the founding teachers, Sayadaw U Pandita. It goes into nice detail, from how to sit to how to end meditation and take it into life, as walking meditation and ultimately as an awareness of the same fleeting nature in everything that had seemed solid or permanent before. But if you seriously want to try *vipassana* meditation, you should learn in person from a teacher.

Most *vipassana* teachers are found in two organizations. One is the Insight Meditation Society, www.dharma.org, founded in Massachusetts in 1975 by Sharon Salzberg, Joseph Goldstein, and Jack Kornfield. Others, such as Tara Brach, have founded their own

insight meditation teaching organizations, but these operate under the Insight Meditation Society umbrella. (See the tab at dharma.org for “Insight Meditation Centers and Communities” under Resources.) You can watch some of their videos online and then perhaps go on one of their retreats. If you prefer reading more first, I recommend Joseph Goldstein’s book^{[31](#)} *Mindfulness: A Practical Guide to Awakening*. Goldstein is not only a founder of the Insight Meditation Society but a very prominent leader in Western Buddhism generally.

Another way to learn *vipassana* would be through the large network of students of S.N. Goenka (1924–2013), an Indian lay teacher born in Burma who made the spread of this method his life’s purpose. While Goenka mostly taught in India, his students teach in about 340 centers in over ninety countries.^{[32](#)} Goenka’s *vipassana* meditation has the same focus on developing the ability to observe everything happening in the mind and body with perfect objectivity. You learn it on a ten-day retreat, with a much more rigorous format than Insight Meditation Society retreats. You arise at five a.m., remain in silence all day, obey your teacher no matter what, and sit in meditation for ten hours (with breaks), no matter how much pain you are in. There has been some scandal about these retreats; a *Financial Times* podcast,^{[33](#)} “Untold: The Retreat,” focused on some mental health crises that have occurred on them. The podcast is a bit sensationalist, done by someone who has never meditated and calls the Goenka’s movement a cult. Still, they did capture the dangers for some people of such a rigorous format.

Goenka *vipassana* teachers can be found through their website www.dhamma.org. Note the similarity of the two website addresses, *dharma* and *dhamma*, so that you do not confuse them. Before going on any retreat, find out what it will involve, including how important it is to sit without back support for hours. I know people who have tried to tough it out without back support on a long *vipassana* retreat to obey instructors or prove to themselves and those around them that they were real meditators and, as a result, developed chronic pain. Remember, in some countries people grow up sitting without back support in school and perhaps all day. Maybe

you did not! Find out if you can meditate sitting in a chair on your retreat if you feel the need.

Zen

Zen Buddhism has also been wildly popular in the West. (But as I said before, Zen Buddhism is not particularly popular in Japan now.) Zen has its own history. It began in China as Chan, when the Mahayana form of Buddhism met Taoism. The hybrid crossed to Japan, as well as Korea and Southeast Asia. In Japan, Zen separated from other forms of Japanese Buddhism in the twelfth century, forming three schools. The two best known in the West are Soto, the larger, and Rinzai (the third school, Obaku, is similar to Rinzai).

Zen Buddhism first came to the United States with Japanese immigrants. It became popular with Westerners through D. T. Suzuki and the Beat Generation. Beat turned to hippie, and in the 1960s, Zen centers with different lineages from within the two larger schools sprang up on the West Coast and spread throughout the country.

Zen Buddhism has always tended to de-emphasize Buddhist *thinking*, there being so much of it by then. The emphasis is much more on direct experience through meditation and gaining nirvana. The term in Zen is *satori*, meaning “full comprehension.” Rinzai emphasizes meditating on the meaning of koans or paradoxical questions or statements given by a teacher to hopefully achieve a sudden flash of enlightenment, *kensho*. The idea is that you focus on the koan for so long that you eventually drop free of all mental effort to understand it, and in that void, see your true nature, the luminous mind, empty of self and of all of the self’s thoughts. The teacher continues to give koans until the breakthroughs, *kenshos*, turn into a constant clear-light mind, *satori*. Obviously, with this tradition you need to be meditating near a Zen teacher so that you can meet periodically to discuss your progress.

The other Zen tradition is Soto (founded in Japan by Dogen, 1200–53). Here you may start with mindful breathing or using

koans, but ultimately you meditate without any object, such as a mantra or the breath. The goal is the same, flashes of *kensho*, seeing, and then permanent *satori*, a pure knowing of one's own nature and all existence. But the method is to simply sit, called *shikantaza*, waiting in silence with an empty mind until the mind's own nature becomes all that there is, although you may also be told to observe your thoughts until this happens. (Think state enlivening.) Western Zen has more variations within these two traditions, so if I have said enough to interest you in Zen, go to a Zen center and ask how they practice meditation. If you are not attracted to that center or teacher, try another.

Tibetan Buddhist Meditation

Tibetan Buddhism added substantially to the supernova when the Dalai Lama was forced into exile in 1959, along with many of Tibet's monks and teachers. How do you do Tibetan meditation? The Dalai Lama, in his book *The Art of Happiness: A Handbook for Living*, recommends starting by observing your natural state of consciousness—that is, observing your thoughts and whatever else your mind is doing. This sounds like *vipassana*, and it is. Tibetan Buddhism has the same division of practice into calming the mind, *samatha*, and gaining focused insight, *vipassana*.

Tibetan Buddhism, however, has four distinct lineages, each with their own slightly different approaches to meditation, so the subject is quite rich and complicated. If you want to learn specifically Tibetan Buddhist meditation, you will need a teacher, and that person will be someone coming from one of these traditions. So you may want to learn more about that particular lineage when you sign up with someone.

You should know some general points about Tibetan Buddhism, however. It incorporates two of the three major Buddhist schools, Mahayana and Vajrayana. Mahayana Buddhism, you might recall, emphasizes the goal of enlightening all beings, not just oneself, by achieving Buddhahood. Buddhahood allows you to return after dying

to help others. This *bodhicitta* or mind of awakening mindset or motivation, emphasizing the development of compassion and the heart, is important to Tibetan meditation. Vajrayana entails more rituals, chants, images, and methods of deity worship, most of which are secret. You have probably seen some Tibetan artwork depicting deities, traditionally looking either pleasant or fierce. These are typical of Vajrayana. Some of these methods are used in the West, being seen as ways to speed up awakening. But you would not be initiated into those until you were deemed ready.

Finally, the teacher or guru, called a lama (or Rinpoche if he or she is especially important), is given greater honor than in the rest of modern Buddhism. If you find a Westerner teaching Tibetan meditation, this will be less the case, but Tibetan teachers themselves (who are still most of the teachers you will meet) are holding by their traditions. Thus respect, loyalty, and even displaying reverence to one's teacher are seen as essential to your progress, raising all those questions about whether the teacher you encounter deserves this. Tibetan Buddhists in the West have had their share of scandals.

Two of the many traditions of Tibetan meditation that you may encounter also bear mentioning, as they transcend the four Tibetan lineage schools and are viewed by some to offer the most advanced meditation methods: Mahamudra (Great Seal or Great Embrace) and Dzogchen (Great Perfection). These traditions focus on direct experience of consciousness itself as the very nature of reality. In that, they fall into the category of state-enlivening. They rely on pointing-out instruction from a master (the teacher tries to use words to bring about the experience of pure consciousness), along with meditation methods suitable to the stage you are at, much of which is focused meditation. Daniel P. Brown's *Pointing Out the Great Way*³⁴ is his attempt to give us the best of all of Mahamudra, including something like the student-teacher relationship he felt was essential. Alas, he died in 2022 of Parkinson's without leaving a clear organization of teachers to carry on his work.

You will learn more about Mahamudra in the next chapter. For a sense of Dzogchen, see *The Awakening Heart: 108 Pith Instructions for Buddhist Practice*³⁵ by Jamyang Tenphel.

Finally, there are a few Westerners who have delved deeply into Tibetan Buddhism. One is Dan Brown, whom I will discuss in [Chapter 7](#). The other is Andrew Holecek, who has written books on both death and dying and lucid dreaming from a Tibetan perspective, although not dogmatically so. For example, his *I'm Mindful, Now What?*, offers a variety of additional ways to meditate, all basically Buddhist. Most interesting might be his *Reverse Meditation*, which I will discuss in the last chapter, where we look at ways that have been suggested to speed up reaching enlightenment.

Final Comments about Western Buddhist Meditation

There are today at least forty practices in the Theravada tradition alone. The other major school of Buddhist thought, Mahayana, has even more forms of meditation, plus other practices. Whatever the tradition, you are going to need a good teacher to take you farther along.

Still, you can gain much from Buddhism indirectly, through reading (perhaps while meditating with some other, less complicated method, such as TM or secular mindfulness). There is a huge amount of Buddhist advice and philosophy on the internet and in books—for example, in the very diverse offerings in the online magazines *Tricycle* and *Lion's Roar*. *Tricycle* will even send you a quote every day to inspire you. Tara Brach, a well-known Insight Meditation teacher, provides very explicit secular guidance for becoming calmer and more objective in daily life, more mindful. Her book *Radical Compassion* emphasizes a meditation (her term for it) that she calls RAIN (Recognize, Attune, Investigate, and Nurture).³⁶

Sometimes modern Buddhism can seem more like cleaning up than waking up, but for those who feel too anxious, distressed, or

just too busy and restless to meditate, methods such as RAIN seem like an excellent practical vehicle for moving forward on the path. It may seem to be a long way, in time and space, from what Buddha taught. But our knowledge of psychology has grown, and perhaps he would be very happy with the changes.

On the other hand, some say Buddhism has changed too much. Evan Thompson is thoroughly familiar with the old and the new Buddhism since childhood, having been raised by parents who had placed themselves practically right inside the supernova, close to several Buddhist teachers. After years of deep involvement in such organizations as the Mind and Life Institute, founded under the auspices of the Dalai Lama, Thompson wrote *Why I Am Not a Buddhist* to protest what he calls Buddhist “exceptionalism.” By that he means the view that Buddhism is better than other religions because of being inherently rational (requiring no belief), or it is said to be not a religion at all but a type of science, therapy, philosophy, or way of life. He points out that just the term Buddhism seems privileged. For example, consider the 2017 *New York Times* bestseller, *Why Buddhism Is True*, by Robert Wright. If you substitute in the name of any other world religion, you cannot imagine the book being a bestseller. For some reason we are less judging of Buddhism.

The subtitle of that book also captures Thompson’s point: *The Science and Philosophy of Meditation and Enlightenment*. Thompson argues that Buddhism does not approach the mind with scientific objectivity as claimed in phrases such as “seeing things as they are,” but, like other religions, holds many beliefs—for example, that there is no self, really, or that nirvana is the best goal in life. And the neuroscience being done is intended to validate those beliefs, which makes it scientific in method but not objective in its goals.

I discuss Thompson because I see him as stepping back and protesting the effects of the supernova, mainly the way that Western science has been applied to Eastern spiritual traditions. I think it is natural that someone has done this. Thompson’s may be a healthy voice for the post-supernova world, in that he recommends what he calls *cosmopolitanism*, or a human community in which different

religions and values are all honored equally. He advocates that we identify less with our own religion or the one we have embraced for some reason (such as it not requiring a belief in God or that the meditation technique works well for us personally). In other words, he would like us not to take our beliefs so personally, going to battle for them as if they are the best. Certainly cosmopolitans do not try to convince others they are wrong about their views. You can sense here Ken Wilber's idea of growing up, and also the intended spirit of this book.

Returning to the Two Categories of Methods: Practice Makes Perfect and State Enlivening

I mentioned at the beginning two categories of, or really philosophies about, how to reach enlightenment: Practice Makes Perfect and State Enlivening (hereafter sometimes PMP and SE). Buddhism clearly favors the PMP approach, although there are exceptions. But mostly you are building skills like learning to calm yourself and to concentrate (the *samatha* aspect), feel compassion (*metta* practice), and recognize and control various mental states (*vipassana*). In Buddhism, these all work to bring you closer to nirvana, perfection.

Vedanta also mostly employs PMP methods. One of many examples is *Kriya* yoga, brought to the West by Paramahansa Yogananda, author of *Autobiography of a Yogi*, whom I mentioned in [Chapter 1](#). His autobiography helped ignite the supernova. It is second in Amazon's all-time sales for a religious leader's biography. (I know you are probably asking, whose biography is number one? A biography of Mr. Rogers.) Steve Jobs discovered the *Autobiography* in his adolescence and reportedly read it every year and had five hundred copies of it given away as a gift at his memorial service.^{[37](#)} Yogananda came to the United States from India in 1920, so he was one of the earliest. He founded the Self-Realization Fellowship to teach *Kriya* yoga, eventually training teachers and creating a

monastic community to further his work. You can learn some of his methods of meditation, all involving concentration, at the Self-Realization Fellowship website.

Another example and important influence on the West has been Integral yoga, an entire philosophy developed by Sri Aurobindo (1872–1950). Aurobindo was educated in the West and was an activist in the struggle for India's independence until he became enlightened and took up a new cause.³⁸ (His Integral yoga is not to be confused with the Integral yoga of Swami Satchidananda Saraswati, the guru at Woodstock who taught mostly physical yoga poses and whose sexual misconduct seems to have been a major problem.) Aurobindo's form of meditation incorporates a series of steps for attaining enlightenment, beginning with methods of training the mind to think clearly and then to concentrate, all with a PMP goal.

State Enlivening (SE) methods are mostly the same as the previous chapter's category of automatic self-transcending, as they include TM, Christian Centering Prayer, and Christian Meditation. But some forms of Zen and Tibetan Buddhism fit as well, which you have already read about in this chapter, in that they aim to enliven a state, albeit with more effort than automatic self-transcending methods. There are other methods found outside of the Zen tradition that have that state-enlivening flavor. Examples are some of the meditation methods taught by Adyashanti, a teacher in the United States who studied with a Zen Buddhist teacher and practiced Zen meditation for fourteen years before his first awakening (there can be more than one in his tradition). At that point he developed a variety of methods on his own, but with your three categories of brain activities and two categories or ways to reach enlightenment, you can always figure out what he or anyone is teaching you.

I should say a bit more about Christian Centering Prayer (CCP) and Christian Meditation (CM). Both are part of the supernova in the sense that they were derived from TM. Christian Meditation began with John Main and Laurence Freeman, two Benedictine monks. John Main learned TM in 1968, before teaching his own version.

Christian Centering Prayer began at Saint Joseph's Abbey, where some of the monks practiced TM for years, although the fact that CCP and CM came out of TM is not always discussed by these teachers. But the instructions are very similar, including how to deal with thoughts and practicing twenty minutes, two times a day.

It is interesting that there is also a long if fragile tradition of something like SE meditation in Christianity, described, for example, by Cynthia Bourgeault, an Episcopalian priest who teaches CCP in her book *The Heart of Centering Prayer*, or by Basil Pennington, the author of a chapter on CCP in Shear's book *The Experience of Meditation: Experts Introduce the Major Traditions*. CCP instructors trace it back to various early mystics such as the author of the anonymously written *The Cloud of Unknowing*,³⁹ which teaches that the ideal prayer is the repetition of a single word or two. But the method of how to handle thoughts, for example, was not as clear. The classic introduction and instruction to CCP is *Open Mind, Open Heart* by Thomas Keating.⁴⁰

To review, all SE methods seek to nudge your mind/brain into the direct experience of what Zen would call *kensho*, seeing the nothingness, emptiness, or no-self behind thought. With TM the desired state is described a little differently, more as pure awareness or pure consciousness. In all cases you are not trying to stay with the method, but to transcend it. Having this global state during meditation is thought to lead to the same good things as Practice Makes Perfect—better concentration, calmness, emotional control, kindness. But State Enlivening methods hold that these are automatic results of spending time in that state.

A Word About Mantras

Mantras can be used both with PMP and SE goals. In the case of TM, the mantra is a Sanskrit sound chosen by the TM teacher using a straightforward method given by Maharishi. If you have a TM mantra, you could probably find out its supposed English meaning,

but knowing that meaning would probably lead to thinking about it, whereas its value is in the sound. That is a potential problem with CCP and CM, in that they allow you to choose a word to use as a mantra that suits you spiritually, but a word in your own language runs the risk of diverting you into associations with its meaning. CM recommends the ancient Christian prayer word *maranatha*, meaning “Come Lord” or “the Lord has come,” which might have fewer immediate associations.

The other issue when choosing your own mantra or word is the pure sound quality of what you will be repeating over and over every day. You want something that gently falls away, like the sound of a bell fading, such as *ma* or *fling*, not something with an abrupt ending, like *heart* or *Christ*. Keep in mind the importance of that purely vibratory quality of a sound when thinking about where you will get your word or mantra. But remember, the key in State Enlivening methods is not the mantra or word—it’s how you use it.

Do not rely on learning any of these methods only by reading a book. TM instruction is quite standardized—you can learn about it and sign up on the internet. For CCP or CM, go to a retreat where it will be taught, or at least watch a video course, hopefully one that gives you access to a teacher if you have questions. But given that you hope to meditate every day for the rest of your life, you might want to learn TM to have the correct mantra and an available teacher, then go to CCP or CM retreats to enjoy the Christian context.

A Taste of the Research on How Meditation Works in Brain and Body

I promised to return to the research on meditation’s effects on the brain after you knew the different types so that we could look at how the types differ in certain fundamental ways. This is going to be very brief, as the topic is simply huge. But to begin, is there anything in common between the effects on the brain of PMP and SE

methods? Some people suggest that there is growing evidence that the global state of pure or nondual consciousness is present in all forms of meditation, given how people describe their deepest experiences. For example, one of the leading mindfulness teachers, Pema Chödrön, said, “In my own training, I’ve been taught to look for the gaps: the gap at the end of each out-breath; the space between thoughts ... These fleeting moments of no-big-deal me, no internal conversations, no frozen opinions, are very simple yet powerful.⁴¹”

Another Buddhist, prominent in Thailand, Upasika Kee, said in her book *Pure and Simple* (quoted in Goldstein’s book—hers is not in English) that focus on awareness of the breath should evolve into awareness of the “knowing mind” itself. Goldstein also quotes Sayadaw U Pandita, the *vipassana* teacher I cited earlier, that when mindfulness has gained momentum, we do not need to do anything anymore. It is called effortless awareness.

When the Dalai Lama teaches meditation, part of his lengthy, basically *vipassana* technique includes watching for pure awareness. According to Tibetan Buddhist teacher Scott Snibbe, the Dalai Lama instructs that we should watch for the consciousness found between thoughts.⁴² In these gaps we discover pure awareness, and we can try to stay there more and more, letting the gaps expand. These instructions sound exactly like an SE method, except the experience of pure awareness is not the only goal, but part of a larger PMP goal of being able to observe the mind.

Given all this, it is understandable that there is a growing consensus among meditation researchers that the nondual experience of pure consciousness, silent consciousness, mental silence, and so forth is the advanced (if not ultimate) goal of all meditation practices.⁴³ A systematic review⁴⁴ of nondual experiences or transcendent states looked at twenty-five different methodologically strong studies of meditators across meditation and contemplative traditions who had been practicing from two to forty years. Each study was looking specifically for times when meditators said they were transcending, whatever method was being used.

Further, these were times of transcending regardless of focused attention or open monitoring activities in the same meditation period.

Transcendent states were most consistently associated with slowed breathing, respiratory suspension, reduced muscle activity, increased alpha brain waves (measured by electroencephalogram or EEG), brain wave coherence (all neurons firing similarly), and brain neurons being more connected as they operated. Besides physiological measures, subjects were asked about their experiences and described a state of relaxed wakefulness that felt like a different space-time than when they were not meditating.

One of these studies stood out for me, and that was by Berman and Stevens.⁴⁵ The authors looked at the EEG activity of persons doing a variety of meditation practices—TM, mindfulness, *vipassana*, and several other methods—but the researchers focused only on moments of experiences of nondual awareness, pure consciousness, or transcendental consciousness. All participants understood what that was, had experienced it, and could signal as soon as they came out of it. They were engaged in different meditation methods, each with their particular EEG characteristics. But there was a very pronounced change in the EEG during the self-reported states compared to the rest of the meditation session, regardless of the particular EEG pattern beforehand. More specifically, the brain waves (measured by EEG) being produced during meditation, aside from the nondual moments, were gamma waves (indicating focused attention) probably because most of the meditators were using concentration methods. But when transcendence itself was reported, gamma waves were replaced by both alpha (usually associated with automatic self-transcendence) and theta (usually associated with open monitoring). Again, it seems that however you divide methods, they are valid paths to the same nondual experience, whether it is viewed as the ultimate goal or only close to it.

Now, having seen this similarity in what the brain does during transcendence, using either SE or PMP methods, what about the differences? The many studies of TM naturally focus on rest, the

measurable effect of moving toward that state of least excitation. The first research on the meditation's general physiological parameters appeared in⁴⁶ *Science* in 1970, finding that during a TM meditation session there were reductions in oxygen consumption and heart rate similar to those found in the deepest phases of sleep, as well as changes in EEG. Since then, numerous studies of TM have appeared regarding physiological changes such as reductions in stress hormones,⁴⁷ all in keeping with SE methods aiming for the deepest state possible rather than developing mental skills in meditation through mental activities.

As for brain studies, as you know, TM studies find a predominance of EEG coherence in alpha waves throughout meditation, suggesting relaxed alertness. Higher coherence is associated with all the parts of the brain being able to work together, something called general connectivity.⁴⁸ This means information moves around better; there is a general brain coordination.⁴⁹ Later studies of EEG coherence during TM found coherence across a broader range of frequencies.⁵⁰ In a review of the literature on EEG coherence, the authors report research that has found lower values of EEG coherence are associated with white matter lesions and decreased cerebral blood flow, schizophrenia, depression, and general aging, while as said above, higher coherence is associated with better information exchange and functional coordination between brain areas.

As for brain activity during PMP methods, mindfulness meditation tends to create more activation on the left side of the brain during meditation, called lateral asymmetry, which is associated with positive emotions such as friendliness, confidence, and happiness. This occurs soon after beginning mindfulness meditation.⁵¹ One would also expect improved cognitive performance, and that does happen. For example, mindfulness meditating leads to better attentional focus.⁵²

There are also morphological studies of changes in brain structure in those practicing mindfulness meditation, and a recent

one found that mindfulness interventions have the ability to affect neural plasticity in areas associated with better pain modulation and increased sustained attention.⁵³ Another study identified how certain brain changes resulting from mindfulness meditation result in reduced depression and anxiety.⁵⁴

Another way in which SE and PMP methods demonstrate the different jobs they do during meditation is in the activity of the default mode network or DMN. The DMN is a set of brain regions, only recently discovered, that are always active in the background, consciously or unconsciously, and actually use 90 percent of the brain's energy. The DMN helps us adapt to changing circumstances by continually exploring our personal and social lives, thinking about others' perspectives, and remembering our own past, allowing us to construct future and replay past scenarios.

While working on any task or observing external stimuli, we do not notice the DMN's activity, but if you are depressed, this is the part of the brain that ruminates about negative scenarios, so it has gotten a bad name. (If you are seriously depressed, the entire brain contributes to the DMN's negative activity.)

As you would expect, because PMP, specifically mindfulness meditation methods, involve doing a task, even a simple one, the DMN is less active.⁵⁵ During SE meditation, which focuses on effortlessness and allowing the mind to wander between dips into the transcendent, the DMN is relatively more active.⁵⁶

Whatever the brain research may say, do not forget to do your own research on your own brain. What works best for you? Actually, some people mix methods, preferring an SE method like TM for meditation itself,⁵⁷ but take up the knowledge and ethical/behavioral teachings in one of the Buddhist traditions. I already said you could learn TM to get the mantra, then if you prefer, meditate in the context of Christianity. Or in a Buddhist context. Why not? It's a supernova! Everything is mixed up already. When the cosmic dust settles, we will see more clearly what works best.

Practical Differences that Might Matter to You

What about the cost? With TM, the fee is standard (you can find the current fee at tm.org/course-fee) and includes meeting with a teacher as often as you want or need, anywhere in the world where there is a TM teacher. Further, satisfaction is guaranteed, meaning they refund your money within sixty days of your completing the full course (initial course, ten-day follow-up session, and at least one personal follow-up, all included in the fee) if you have meditated regularly for thirty days. Fair enough. As of now, the organization has a sliding scale, on the honor system, and you can pay over four months. There are also scholarships.

Costs will vary with PMP methods. Buddhist instruction is traditionally free, although you will be encouraged to donate, or you might be told that you need to learn on a retreat, so your fee is in a sense the cost of the retreat. This may be true for Christian Centering Prayer and Christian Meditation as well.

A word about the organizations themselves. Because PMP organizations and teachers are so varied—as I said, all of Buddhism feels sort of spread out or horizontal—they are difficult to generalize about. In contrast, the TM organization is quite vertical, the product of one person, Maharishi, although he was not a typical guru. He planned for TM to outlast him by training thousands of teachers and establishing TM centers in major cities. CCP and CM are Christian in orientation, but each was also founded by one person.

In spite of Maharishi's plans, while he was alive and even more so since his death in 2008, the organization behind TM has changed. The basic TM instruction so far is almost the same as in the sixties, but there are new teachings offered (advanced techniques, which are usually new mantras, and the TM-Siddhi program, based on an entire chapter of Patanjali's *Yoga Sutras*). There is considerably more optional "Vedic Science"—for example, *Ayur Vedic* medicine and Vedic-style music, architecture, astrology, and so forth.

Meanwhile, the inevitable tension between orthodoxy and change has sprung up. Some TM teachers have formed an independent

International Teachers of Meditation Association (ITMA), using the term Effortless Deep Meditation, and a few teach entirely on their own, calling it Vedic meditation. But if you investigate (and you should), it is all still basically TM. If you cannot find a regular TM teacher from Maharishi's organization nearby, you might look for these teachers. You know it is an SE method when there is no instruction to focus on your breath and you hear *effortless* repeatedly! I would stay with the TM organization's teachers when possible, but do not give up if you cannot find one near you.

If you are interested in knowing more about the TM organization itself, you can read [58](#) *The Transcendental Meditation Movement* by Dana Sawyer and Cynthia Humes, which seems to be fairly objective.

How and when do you practice? All meditation practices need to be performed daily for best results, but with PMP, as I have said, you may also be instructed to be mindful all you can, inside meditation and out. Walking, for example. Or you take your mind to a quiet place with a gatha, a song or verses repeated while in an activity (probably from the Zoroastrian tradition but added to Buddhism). Gathas were reintroduced in recent times by Thich Nhat Hanh. Examples are ones for waking up, turning on the water, opening a window, brushing your teeth, and so forth. These are added to your mindfulness outside of meditation. The hope is that by practicing a quiet style of acting, it will become the permanent style of the mind in any action.

In contrast, SE practices typically are done only twice a day, before meals, for a specific length of time, usually twenty minutes. Then you go about your life without further practicing of anything.

How do you sit? All methods of meditation encourage you to sit upright, back straight. Some, such as Zen, would prefer that you sit with no back support, in full lotus if possible, although you are always free to use a chair as long as you sit up straight. *Vipassana* varies. With TM, CCP, and CM, and in the Plum Village tradition, you sit in whatever way is comfortable.

What about falling asleep? It is strongly discouraged in PMP meditations and Zen. (The traditional Zen way of keeping sleepy meditators awake is with a blow on the shoulders with a *keisaku* or warning stick.) In contrast, with SE meditation, if you get sleepy you lie down and sleep (if you have the time). Usually, the sleep is brief. After sleeping you are encouraged to sit up and meditate a little more.

What else is offered? All methods encourage (as do I) increasing your knowledge around meditation to better understand your experiences. This is very important given that you no doubt live in a culture and subculture that has nothing to say, or mostly negative things to say, about meditation. Without social support, at least someone else close to you who meditates, you will probably stop. If you did once meditate and do not now, consider if lack of social support was a factor.

All methods have group meetings for gaining more knowledge. Buddhist meditation practices emphasize the *sangha*, ongoing meetings of small groups of meditators. (Some say the *sangha* is the oldest continual organized social group.) You may be encouraged to take vows regarding taking refuge in Buddha, the teachings, and the *sangha*, and vow to follow the precepts involving not causing harm, etc. If you are exploring Mahayana Buddhism (including Zen and some Tibetan Buddhism), you might be offered the chance to take the *bodhisattva* vow.

TM offers meetings for meditators, usually with a videotape of Maharishi speaking on some point. Some videos of him can be found online too. But there is less expectation that you will attend anything more than your TM instruction, and no expectation that you will have an ongoing personal relationship with a group or teacher. But just for that reason, regular checking every six months or so with any TM teacher is very, very important. This lack of regular social reinforcement may be one reason some people stop TM, but perhaps this lack of pressure to belong to anything keeps others at it.

Retreats are also offered by most meditation organizations. Some Buddhist organizations may emphasize them as the only way to

progress. I highly recommend them if you can afford them and have the time. They can especially help if you are having doubts about the value of meditation. Your meditations might be quite different during a retreat, giving you a taste of what is possible. TM retreats focus on rest; *vipassana* tend to focus on more intense practice; and the Plum Village tradition tends to emphasize the experience of practice within a community.

The Eastern Orthodox and Sufi Prayers of the Heart, and Jewish *Hitbodedut*

I said there was another meditation method that is difficult to fit into the two categories above, but you should have it as a choice. Are they part of the supernova? If Eastern can include Middle Eastern and Eastern Orthodox Christianity, then yes. Interest in Sufism, Islam's form of mysticism, definitely increased in the sixties with Idries Shah's books and speaking, which took Sufism out of Islam and viewed it as a universal wisdom predating Mohammad. (Shah was born in India from Afghan lineage.) Soon after that, the Sufi poet Rumi's work became extremely popular. As for the Eastern Orthodox Christian prayer of the heart, it was central to the immensely popular *Franny and Zooey* by J. D. Salinger, published in 1961 (twenty-six weeks on the *New York Times* bestseller list). Salinger was a student of all types of Eastern philosophy. Ah, that supernova again.

In a way, PMP and SE methods are defined by what you do about distracting thoughts—focus and control them (PMP) or not worry about them because you will transcend them when you are ready (SE). In the traditions I am about to describe, belief in God is a must even for dealing with thoughts, because the emphasis is on God's grace uniting with your own humble efforts. But there is no doubt at all that the goal is the same as the other Eastern traditions, as illustrated by the words of a Byzantine hymn quoted in Cynthia Bourgeault's *Wisdom Jesus*, which speaks of a serene light that

draws the singer past the snares of the mind, past all symbols and words, into the darkness that “veils the ground of my being.”

Eastern Orthodox Christians practice the Jesus Prayer, “Lord Jesus Christ have mercy on me” (there are longer and shorter versions) as a silent prayer of the heart repeated over and over like a mantra, so it is clearly a form of meditation. The Sufi’s Prayer of the Heart is similar, usually a repetition of the *shahada* (“there is no god but God”). However, you do not achieve your goal, union with Jesus or God or the Beloved (Sufis use this term for God) without surrender to God’s will. You do hear some reference to concentration, especially in the sense of needing to concentrate one’s feeling in the heart rather than in the mind. The idea is that love from the heart overwhelms thoughts from the mind, but it is more than a PMP method.

As for learning this form of meditation, Sufis have many traditional lineages with different methods of instruction and a teacher from one of those lineages is considered essential. But I can give you a sense of it. According to the modern Sufi teacher Llewellyn Vaughan-Lee, the first and perhaps most essential step is to develop an intense desire for the Beloved (God).⁵⁹ In meditation it may come as a spontaneous prayer from the heart, or you can repeat the *dhikr*, the repetition of one of the names of God. Other Sufi teachers would have you begin with repetition in a mechanical way, turning the attention inward and away from the outer world, and sometimes the breath is involved. The idea is that, working together, you and God approach each other, you offering love and effort from the heart and God waiting to offer His grace so that your desire can be achieved.

In the Eastern Orthodox Christian tradition, you are advised⁶⁰ to begin with a mechanical repetition of the Jesus Prayer, day and night, until the prayer (which functions like a mantra) settles into your very being. Next you meditate more as if using a PMP method, thinking about the meaning of every word of the prayer, elaborating on that if your mind wanders. However, by the end of learning this practice, you are using something more like an SE method, simply

repeating the Jesus Prayer until the day when God, by His grace, brings the permanent prayer to flower, without words, without a break, rushing like a brook. While there are elements of both PMP and SE in the Sufi and Eastern Orthodox practices, again, there is an essential third element, God's meeting you at least halfway.

Meditation in the Jewish tradition, *hitbodedut*, has a long history, according to Matan Weil, dating back at least to the Middle Ages or earlier.⁶¹ *Hitbodedut* literally means to be in solitude, but in that solitude you pursue *devekut*, a clinging to God or dedication to God. The methods of meditation were mostly secret until Rabbi Nachman of Breslov (1772–1810), a leading Hassidic teacher.⁶² He taught how to do *hitbodedut* in detail. You begin with a conversation with God, but with time this can be intensified emotionally, which in turn leads to a loss of the sense of self, replaced by a state of feeling at one with God. Because the meditation is so entwined with God, it seems to belong here with the Sufi and Eastern Orthodox methods. However, it has also been caught up in the supernova from the East, in that the present-day form of *hitbodedut*, taught, for example, by the Israeli rabbis Israel Isaac Besancon and Avraham Zvi Kluger, places considerable emphasis on what amounts to mindfulness of the present, self-healing, and self-nullification. Indeed, Kluger describes living one's daily life imbued with God's love in a way that seems very similar to Eastern ideas of enlightenment. For a fine example of a blending of East and West, see Rabbi Yoel Glick's⁶³ *Living the Life of Jewish Meditation*.

Can Meditation Be Harmful?

This is a complicated topic, because researchers must first define harm, and over how long. Meditation teachers expect some negative experiences, such as feeling more anxiety, and are trained in handling them, and then they are over. Still, a survey might find these students did admit to some passing negative experiences.

The risks may go up if you learn on your own or, once you learn, do not seek any further guidance as your experiences change. After all, until very recently, meditation was always taught face-to-face by an experienced teacher who could tailor the practice to the individual and hear immediately how it went, adjusting the method as needed. Obviously, the risk of going without guidance is greater if you are already struggling in your life, especially with repressed material, such as experiences of abuse or other PTSD. Indeed, because people may start to meditate because they are having various problems, we would expect people who meditate to report more problems.

Now that Buddhism is so popular, and at the same time research methods are better, the studies of adverse events focus more on Buddhist meditation, especially during and after long retreats. Although adverse events were not being studied on TM retreats, they apparently did occur in the early days,⁶⁴ as there are now strict retreat guidelines about when and how long to meditate, when to eat, and even when to go for a walk, which is always with a partner. On a TM retreat these days, if meditators experience adverse events such as not sleeping, becoming very emotional, or having physical effects that may need to be addressed, meditation times are shortened. The goal is to keep a balance between meditation and activity so that meditation experiences can be integrated.

Overall, outside of retreats, a systematic review of studies of harmful effects of meditation found that as of 2020 roughly 8.3 percent of meditators reported having had adverse experiences that felt harmful or undesirable and lasted more than a few hours.⁶⁵ These were highly varied, including increased depression, anxiety, a sense of dissociation, trouble focusing, reliving of traumas, and panic. One study found it was closer to 10 percent, although the same study found 88 percent were happy with their meditation practice and this was unrelated to reporting harmful event⁶⁶s. However, researchers are well aware of the problems in this kind of survey research. For example, something that seems adverse one day may seem like the beginning of something good the next. The

incidence of bad effects lasting over a month has been estimated to be around 5 percent, about the same as for any other psychological treatment, although one study found it to be closer to 10 percent. But in that same study, 85 percent were happy with their meditation practice, and that did not differ whether meditators had had adverse effects.

Again, teachers of both PMP and SE methods expect meditators to have some adverse experiences as part of the learning process, but competent teachers can usually help with these. If a person stops meditating without discussing it with a teacher, feeling meditation harmed them, there is no doubt some truth to it. But as a therapist, I can attest that some people come for help right when they are about to fall apart, and then the help is too late or not what they really needed or even blamed as the cause when the real cause was always waiting to erupt. I cannot know in any particular case, but meditation seems very safe or maybe totally safe as long as you turn to a knowledgeable teacher if a problem arises.

I should also mention energy-like somatic experiences (ELSEs).⁶⁷ These occasionally happen to meditators, mainly on long courses or retreats, although they can also happen to people not meditating. These are usually described as subtle energy in various parts of the body, usually rising upwards, or occurring mostly in the spine to the top of the head, or it may be an intense feeling that some energy is blocked. But it can also be felt as heat or vibration, sometimes very strong, and sometimes involuntary movements. All of these are usually called kundalini, a term based on the Sanskrit term for *coiled* because it is seen as an innate energy in everyone that is coiled at the base of the spine.

ELSEs are important in some tantric traditions emphasizing body energies. Tantra in Sanskrit means woven together, or an extension, so tantra practices try to weave together mind and body, among other things, rather than, as they see it, leaving the body behind. Tantra is a topic too complex for me to discuss here. You have probably heard of it as some kind of blend of sexuality and spirituality, but this is the supernova's sexualized version of this very

ancient, highly varied set of beliefs and practices. As with any other practice, learn its origins and range of philosophy and observances before diving in.

Tantra practices have been combined with both Buddhism and Vedanta over many centuries and discouraged by the mainstream of both. Similarly, ELSEs are generally ignored or discouraged in TM and today's Buddhism. The general view is that the more you pay attention to them, the stronger they become, and they are not necessary at all for progress in meditation. If you feel you need to know more, there are quite a few books on the subject.

What About You?

You have already reflected on meditation in the last chapter, but has anything changed for you now that I have oversimplified the vast number of meditation practices into just a few categories? If you already meditate, what kind are you doing? How do you see it now? If you once meditated but do not anymore, do you see better what you were doing or why you stopped? If you are wanting to start to meditate, has this discussion helped you choose what to practice? Or are you leaning toward trying several types?

What About Me?

You know my choice of meditation methods, so no need to belabor it. But let me explain the experience that lit my desire to be so evenhanded about meditation—whether people should do it or not and what kind. It started years ago ...

My beloved mother-in-law was sobbing. She had been acting a little strangely, and it did not take much for her to blurt out to us what was the problem. "I'm afraid you won't love me if I don't meditate!" Art and I were horrified. We had taught her to meditate a few days before, and because she tended to be anxious by nature, we had hoped it would help with that. "I just can't sit still," she

wailed. "I never just sit around. It makes me so, so anxious. I feel like I've got to get up and do something."

I knew that could be fixed by having her meditate for as short a time as she liked and increase it when she liked. But my heart knew the real problem. How had I missed it? We had come back from TM-teacher training wildly enthused about saving the world through meditation and wanting to teach her right away for the sake of her health and "nerves." There was even more pressure because we were about to rush off with her only grandchild to teach at the new university in Iowa based on TM. Mostly it must have been scary to her, how much we had changed. How easy it must have been for TM to seem more important to us than she was.

We hugged her, begging her to stop meditating forever if she wished. We told her over and over how much we loved her, whether she meditated or not.

We have had other friends and family members start TM and most of them have loved it. Some thought it saved their lives. My mother loved it, I think because I had given it to her, but would only do it once a day, not twice. And others began but then stopped, and we had to be careful, as with Art's mother, not to push, even if we thought we knew the problem. There can be deep resistances to meditation of various kinds and I have learned to honor those. Then there are dear friends who have their own meditation paths. Over the years I have learned—vowed—not to let anyone's meditation method or spiritual path or lack of one interfere with my respect for them or our friendship. If a friend asks me what form of meditation I recommend, I will tell them. But cautiously. I am through with proselytizing.

Looking Back on What You Have Reflected Upon

What you reflected on obviously depends on what your experience has been with meditation. I hope that is now more firmly rooted in

fact and you can take the time to decide what you want to do about a meditation practice. Just remember, no judgment. I find that meditation teachers and groups often encourage meditators to discuss how much they are getting from daily meditation, which can often lead to comparing who had the best (most like enlightenment) experience. But that can leave other people feeling they are not getting as much from meditation and must not be as good at it. Who wants to persist in doing what you are inferior at? Ranking again. Resist it. Try to appreciate the goal behind the original teachings of Buddha and Vedanta, which did not emphasize flashy experiences and short-term benefits. They knew that unless you were very unusual, only long-term, consistent practice gets you there.

Especially for HSPs

It is no secret that I have always recommended that HSPs learn to meditate, and I usually recommended TM simply because it involves the very least effort, even allowing (actually encouraging) you to sleep if you need to. TM is true downtime, what HSPs need so much. On the other hand, the depth and breadth of Buddhist teaching may be just right for some HSPs. Either way, beware that with any spiritual practice, HSPs are prone to try too hard. Then you may start to put off meditating because you do not have the energy for it. The last thing you want is for your meditation to be overstimulating, tiring, or just one more chore. Or you might start and then decide you are not good enough at meditating: "I can't concentrate well enough." Again, that is falling into ranking, and HSPs often rank themselves too low. With TM at least, remember the key instruction, that you are not supposed to concentrate or even make an effort to focus. You don't have to try to be good at it.

But again, TM may not be right for you. Use your excellent intuition, guided by actual personal experience, to see if you want to meditate, and if so, what kind. Just beware of trying too hard!

A Final Word About Twos

This chapter talked about two traditions and two very popular forms of meditation coming from them. Then it talked about two general types of meditation, PMP and SE. Two, two, two. The human body is bisymmetrical. Most of our organs exist in pairs—hands, feet, lungs, kidneys. Perhaps that is why we think so much in pairs.

Further, the symmetry always breaks down. One is more dominant. Read these pairs: up down, right left, back front, red green, black white, salt pepper, cat dog, man woman, East West, London Paris. Looking back over each pair, you can see you have a slight favorite. This is how the human mind works, for better and for worse. Polarities can emerge even when unity is supposed to predominate, and then favorites emerge from the pairs. Sometimes the divisions lead to insight and growth and sometimes to prejudice and misinformation. Usually it is some of both, as those associated with the old ways try to stifle division and change, seeing the new as a threat to the truth, and it very well may be. I say all this because sometimes you have to choose. HSPs in particular dislike choosing. So we often try to choose both.

I wrote this book in part because I saw divisions in the world of meditation that are not usually spoken about together and that fact affects people's choices. I simply wanted to present both sides. Especially as I wrote this chapter, I kept finding pairs. These divisions go back to Buddha himself, who wanted a better way to meditate than what he had learned from his Vedanta teachers. What a blessing that he wanted something better! Because of that urge, we have another way to meditate and another view of the goal of meditation that has spread around the world with such beautiful results.

Moving forward in time from Buddha to some unknown Vedanta meditator in the *dandi* tradition of renunciates going back to Shankara, there must have been one who thought meditation should not be so difficult. The result has been TM, another division, another

choice about how to meditate, that has spread around the world with other beautiful results.

I wish we could hold two things equally, but it involves real effort to overcome prejudice about a favorite, especially if your life has become entwined with one of the pair in some way. I say all of this because I am sure many, many people, in trying to decide about meditating and how to meditate, have asked a meditation teacher what is the best way to meditate. How obvious. These people must really know what they are talking about. But they only know one side of it.

If you ask a teacher of Buddhist meditation about TM, you are likely to hear it dismissed as not serious meditation. If you press the point, you may hear it is all about rest, which is good, but resting more will not take you to nirvana. True, you may have deep meditation experiences soon, even in the first session. Even Buddha recognized them as wonderful experiences. But if pressed, a Buddhist teacher may say that Buddha saw these as *jhana* states, only created by the mind. They are one more thing that will come and go, as consciousness itself comes and goes as different, impermanent states. As for the idea of pure being, the Self, or Brahman, these ideas are comforting to the ego, but simply further attachments. Buddha vowed to go beyond all that, and he did.

What do you hear if you ask a TM teacher about Buddhism? Usually they think you are asking about mindfulness meditation and will tell you that while it gives you some rest and reduces stress to some degree, TM provides a much deeper state of rest, which is what the body needs for healing from stress and achieving higher states of consciousness. This is because TM aims to be effortless. It does not involve concentration or even just monitoring your breath, so you can go deeper. And you will look forward to it rather than seeing it as a task to do. As for the experience of pure or transcendental consciousness, it is not a matter of belief in anything. It is simply the state of least excitation of the mind, easily measured by EEG.

A TM teacher reasonably familiar with Buddhism (most are not) might ask what makes the experience of nothingness more real than

the experience in meditation of unboundedness and deep silence? They might add, “Buddha made nirvana rather complicated and difficult to achieve. Buddhists will have you practice numerous mental gymnastics to try to get there, while with enough easy, effortless meditation, the mind will go there naturally.”

The good news about this imaginary debate is that you can see clearly that you really do have choices. But, as you can also see, it very much matters who you ask. Or what book you read.

Where We Are Now, Where We Are Going

We have looked at two ancient Eastern traditions, Buddhism and Vedanta, along with the two most popular forms of meditation now associated with them, mindfulness and TM. We also considered research on the benefits of meditation. Then we added two new ways of sorting out kinds of meditation. In the last chapter you learned about three categories, according to the brain activity they produce. The two in this chapter, Practice Makes Perfect (PMP) and State Enlivening (SE), cut across those categories, focusing on methods of reaching enlightenment. With PMP you develop in meditation the traits or abilities (focusing, observing, feeling compassion, the desire to be ethical, etc.) that are typical of the enlightened and hopefully lead you there too. With SE methods you experience in meditation the pure awareness that is the background to enlightenment, which is thought to lead automatically to those same traits and abilities.

You will find spiritual teachers who give their brand of meditation all sorts of names, but now you should be able to see past the name to the method. For example, if you became interested in Sam Harris’s book *Waking Up*, you would recognize right away that he is advising and teaching straight mindfulness, and perhaps *vipassana* eventually—PMP methods. (If you read further, you will find that in spite of the title, he is not very enthusiastic or detailed about waking up or enlightenment.)

On the other hand, if you come upon references to *objectless meditation* or *natural awareness*, even in a mindfulness or PMP context (especially advanced Tibetan Buddhism such as Mahamudra), you will recognize an SE method in the instructions, intending to help you settle into something effortless.

We have gradually moved from an emphasis on seeing what you might want to clean up to what may be new to you, waking up, and meditation has been the bridge between the two. Two again. But it is true—you can meditate either to improve your daily life and perhaps reduce anxiety or depression, or you can aim for waking up. Or some of both. Now it is my job to introduce you to all that goal stuff—nirvana, enlightenment, awakening, Fundamental Wellbeing, God-Realization, Self-Realization. Remember, you do not have to accept anything I am going to say. This is a sanctuary, away from the hype and pressure. But I hope you are curious enough to take a stroll in this new realm.

CHAPTER 7

ENLIGHTENMENT, AWAKENING, OR WHATEVER

In the first chapter (and several others!) I wrote, “In its simplest terms, this book is about gradually changing your brain until it is able to maintain a background state permanently, 24/7, that makes life much, much easier and more meaningful.” This seems so important, especially for HSPs, both because they need that equanimity given their greater susceptibility to all that is going on in the world, but also because most HSPs seek something far deeper than what has been generally offered to them in the West in terms of spirituality, religion, or even greater brain development and self-actualization.

Yet even though there are many books and websites on the subject now, I am always surprised that most of the people I know, including HSPs, *still* have no clear idea about enlightenment, which is probably the main reason I wrote this book. So, let’s get into it.

First, the words for it matter, yet do not at all. I apologize if enlightenment or awakening seems too esoteric. They are historically correct English words chosen by Eastern teachers, but if you prefer, please think *permanently changed brain state*. I have used these traditional terms because for some they have been the

key to tickling their curiosity, and I need all the keys I can find for opening minds.

Adyashanti, the widely admired spiritual teacher in California whom I mentioned earlier, is a fine example of how these powerful words matter. He found his path when he was twenty¹ as he was browsing through spiritual books in a bookstore and picked up one on Zen. “I came across the word enlightenment ... I had a huge response to it.” He said he just had to know the meaning of that word. It was the moment when he became a spiritual seeker. He found a Zen teacher living and teaching only fifteen minutes from his home and studied with her until he was thirty-three, having had an awakening at twenty-two and another, more profound one in his early thirties. (There are levels of awakening, the subject of the next chapter.) At that point she told him to begin teaching on his own.

Adyashanti was born in 1962, so he is an example of someone having received the fruit of the Eastern teachings that arrived as just seeds when he was a baby. Because of that amazing growth of the supernova, by the time he was twenty he easily found a book on Zen in a local bookstore and a Zen teacher nearby. Now he is over sixty and has awakened many followers.

From Eastern Teachings to Western Science

Even a metaphoric supernova leaves us with a great deal to cover. I will try to define the state of awakening, give you examples, describe data from surveys, and explain some quite advanced brain studies. We will move away from the Eastern traditions, with their conflicting metaphysical views around the nature of the goal—emptiness versus pure bliss. Many think they are not really fundamentally different, but I will not go into that. The focus of this chapter is the current Western descriptions of the experience, from personal interviews, surveys, and brain research.

It seems strange that until about fifty years ago, almost no one in the West talked about permanent higher states of consciousness, even though they were thoroughly known in the East. As I have said

repeatedly, the sixties began the change, with the arrival of Eastern meditation teachers. As time went on, new meditators became experienced ones, and they kept exchanging descriptions of their awakening experiences, and around 2010 what was once only talked about in small circles began to spread. In October 2009, Rick Archer recorded the first interview for what would become *Buddha at the Gas Pump*, the podcast with videos of “Conversations with ‘Ordinary’ Spiritually Awakened People.” At about that same time, Steve Taylor was preparing a dissertation on spiritual awakening in the U.K. and Jeffery Martin, a Silicon-Valley-success turned would-be academic, began to research what he came to call Fundamental Wellbeing. All of them were seeking to address the subject objectively, outside of the Eastern traditions. My point is, a decided shift seemed to occur around 2009–10.

Note that both Archer and Taylor prefer *awakening* or *awakened* because it captures the idea of a noticeable permanent change in how the world is perceived, as when one wakes from sleep, but also allows for a continuing process after we are awake.

To All My Varied Readers

For many of you, as I said in [Chapter 1](#), I suspect that enlightenment seems too out of reach. Maybe you stayed with me to learn more about meditation, but now are about to toss aside this book, muttering, “This is really too much.” Or, “Why learn about how I am an inferior human?” But I repeat, this is a sanctuary, and one of its rules is that you not compare yourself to others. I think the more you learn about this subject, the less threatening it will seem. You will see you are not inferior, whether you ever awaken or not. A journey, a path, a pilgrimage, a trail is not just about the goal. There can be great joy in the journey itself. And as we learn more about awakening, we find it is only a border-crossing into, yes, a new land, but the journey continues as long as we are in a human body.

I repeat: If you never cross the border, that is okay. Trust that you are exactly where you ought to be. If you follow your heart,

your intuition, your inner voice, or whatever you call it toward whatever pulls you, you will have all the experiences you need. I truly believe that.

On the other hand, do not dismiss the idea that you personally can awaken, given the growing numbers saying they have done so. We seem to be at a tipping point in that regard. Are you older? Not many years left to meditate? In some cases being older (and wiser) can help. Do some longer retreats and the boost may do it. Possibly it has even happened to you already, at least the beginning stages. You might not know it, given that the indicators of enlightenment are still not exactly common knowledge. So, let's fix that.

Six Generalizations about Enlightenment, Awakening, or the Nondual Experience

Before I turn to the specific researchers, I will make six generalizations based on my reading, listening to podcasts, watching videos, and just talking with people. But I will start with an antigeneralization. *The more I listen and read, the more I see that every awakening and what follows is unique to each person.* There are categories, like sudden and slow, but the differences go way beyond that. Everyone's nervous system is different, shaped by genetics and conditioned by prior experiences and certainly to some degree by what they might have learned to expect. And the experience changes over time. Still, generalizations do capture some of it. Ah, paradox.

1. It Is Not an Idea

First, this is a *persistent nonsymbolic state*, to use Jeffery Martin's term. It is persistent in that it is a change in your brain and your consciousness that is there 24/7/365. Nonsymbolic means that it is not in itself experienced in words as a thought can be, such as *I trust in God*. Not being a thought, it is not always on your mind. But

it is right there. You do not have to search for the experience and re-create it, just as wearing a warm coat is not always on your mind, yet when you are wearing one it is always there. This state is more like a permanent change in the background on which all experience occurs, or a basic change in all perception—a new lens through which you see your usual world. Your mind can still be full of thoughts and feelings, and while these may be somewhat different or fewer than those you had before, they are not the state itself. You will see that research is clear about the brain being able to create this background mode to its usual activity, affecting or adding to the usual activity, but not replacing it. For HSPs, that probably means as much depth of processing as ever, but something more fluid, too, less getting preoccupied and stuck.

I say the state is not a thought reduced to a set of words. Yet of course people do try to describe it, with terms like *unbounded*, *infinite*, *the emptiness of pure existence without a self*, *nonduality*, *pure being itself*, or *pure awareness*. When asked about its effects, people often say they are calmer, kinder, or more content, but then often add that it is just basically indescribable.

2. It Is Not a Lifestyle You Can Adopt

The state cannot simply be adopted as an attitude or lifestyle, such as becoming a contemplative. A change in lifestyle might help, as when people go on long retreats. And it may require some specific effort to make it happen. It's like swimming. We all know what swimming is, but we cannot do it without learning how, sometimes with great patience and practice. (Yes, infants put into water will hold their breath and move their arms as if swimming, but they cannot swim and they lose those reflexes by six months.) Sometimes the change to this new state comes suddenly. But again, you cannot just decide to make your brain change permanently.

A pertinent example is the difference between a *perceptual experience* of the unity of everything and the very common and commendable *idea* of our fundamental unity—that all of us are part

of the human family, or even better, part of the entire ecosystem, the web of life. If you have had even one moment of *experiencing* that unity (for example, people report that experience with psychedelics), you know the difference between that and the idea. But until it lasts, that experience is not enlightenment.

3. It Is Not Imagined or Learned from Others

A few decades ago, with the supernova all around them, some scholars balked, saying that experiences of pure consciousness and of awakening were socially constructed states, coming from one's cultural or religious tradition or, these days, from the internet. But that thinking has shifted some, partly because of the debates between Robert Forman, a TM teacher with a doctorate in comparative religions, and Steven Katz, holder of a doctorate from Cambridge and the leading proponent of the culturally constructed position. Forman seemed to turn the tide² by using an analogy: Suppose people from different places on earth took off in different rocket ships, each ship designed by that culture, although with necessary similarities. Once in outer space, however the astronauts got there, they all had the same experience—weightlessness.³ You see the analogy. There are too many descriptions of pure consciousness and awakening coming from different times and cultures for this to be the recent product of a single culture in a single location.

4. It Is Not Rare, Not Anymore

Exactly how many people are now enlightened is impossible to say, and it does depend on how traditions define it, but since about the middle of the 1990s, more and more people have awakened, according to the researchers I will discuss below. This increase also has been noted by the thousands of TM teachers on the front lines, who now sometimes see people report awakening even after their

first meditation. I have given some possible reasons for the increase in numbers. As you will see from some *Buddha at the Gas Pump* interviews, many people learned to meditate in the sixties and seventies and after consistent practice are now awakening. Also, the internet has made knowledge and discussion of higher states more accessible. Spiritual teachers by the hundreds offer videos you can watch. Better knowledge makes it clearer what you are aiming for, so more people do just that. Some people see the growing numbers as a sign of an impending major change in human evolution. Maybe you will agree, or maybe raise a skeptical brow.

5. It Can Happen Suddenly and Cause Temporary Turmoil

An observation from both traditional knowledge and recent research is that although I spoke of this state as something that develops gradually with years of meditation practice, some people experience awakening suddenly. Whatever their religious or spiritual beliefs or lack of them, these people may experience awakening either as a complete surprise or after some initial turning toward the idea. Often it follows a trauma or some dramatic change in a person's life that left them feeling out of control,⁴ inviting a total shift in one's self-system or way of viewing oneself. Given this potential for a sudden awakening, even outside of a tradition, a person could have this shift without even knowing what it is. This is another reason to rule out imagination or enculturation.

In fact, because awakening has been so uncommon until recently, some who awakened suddenly have spent years thinking something terrible had happened to them, having lost much of their sense of personal self, leaving only an infinite impersonal awareness.⁵ Indeed without adequate understanding of the experience, the process can potentially be very disturbing. For example, people may lose interest in what previously was important to them, stop believing in what they once believed in, or find it

difficult to converse with friends and family, given their changed sense of themselves. Those around them, not understanding, may worry that this is the beginning of some serious mental illness, not some wonderful spiritual change. Many of the newly awakened, understanding their experience or not, learn the hard way to stay quiet about it in certain company.

6. It Is Often Seen Now as Only the Beginning

Although I have been speaking of awakening as a permanent, very noticeable shift in how the brain operates and in how you experience life, most traditions and certainly Westerners studying it see that as only the beginning of a process. As perception changes, so does our understanding of reality, but this happens more gradually. There are considerable adjustments to be made, such as in personal relationships. If one talks about one's change to close others, they may be unbelieving. If one does not talk about it, but others notice a change, they may or may not like the change or even be alarmed by it.

Further, how much we have to change in order to be considered awakened depends on where we put the finish line. The Buddhists are very vague about the finish line. If you are working all eight folds of Buddha's path at once, when exactly are you done? So much depends on one's behavior, but who can judge that? If one declares oneself as having arrived, doesn't that put one's humility into question? Indeed, as we saw, all traditions admit that the awakened still have personalities, meaning possible flaws. The awakened still have the temperaments they were born with, plus the histories that have shaped their personalities. Many Westerners, such as Mariana Caplan, author of [⁶ *Halfway Up the Mountain: The Error of Premature Claims to Enlightenment*](#), hold that the path is infinite, that there is always room for growth, even after seemingly huge shifts. She thinks that the truly enlightened do not discuss their attainment, but simply take up a life of continuing growth and service to others. After her own awakening, she took up the practice of psychotherapy,

so of course she cautions against thinking waking up ends the need for cleaning up, but she also writes from the experience of interviewing many supposedly enlightened people who privately confessed to enormous personal challenges they were still working on. Where is that finish line? Still, many seem to think they know that they have crossed it.

It Does Not Mean Perfection—The Perfect Person is an Archetype, Not Reality

Before we go further, I wish to address squarely the issue of reality versus perfection. In [Chapter 2](#), I discussed the distressing paradox that supposedly enlightened teachers could mess up ethically by putting that paradox in the context of waking up versus cleaning up. Without cleaning up one's personal issues, these things happen, even among the enlightened. Further, no one is ever completely *cleaned up*, so the awakened are never perfect. Awakening suggests a new day, a new way of seeing things, but not the full light of noon. Even at its fullest, it is not a feeling of constant happiness because it is not a mood or emotion. That is, the awakened can still feel appropriate or even inappropriate temporary anger, fear, or despair. But the emotions and the situations causing these emotions leave an impression more like a line drawn in the air (to use a traditional analogy) rather than one in sand or stone. And as I have said repeatedly, enlightenment always brings an enormously helpful equanimity, even if it can be temporarily disturbed.

Some people discussing the subject prefer the term⁷ *spiritual maturity*—a gradual evolution that includes no longer thinking of enlightenment as perfection, in themselves or others. Buddhists, especially Tibetan Buddhists, judge a person to be enlightened mostly or entirely by their behavior, not their reported inner experiences. And the enlightened among them say that to keep their conduct pure requires their full attention.⁸

I think this idea of perfection comes from our wish that perfection really does exist in *someone*. The perfect person is an archetype, a recurrent symbol or motif in stories and art. An archetype carries cultural information around an instinctual human need, in this case a person in our lives, or out there somewhere, who knows all. The archetype has many names—the Enlightened, the Awakened, the Buddha, the Messiah, the Saint, the Wise One, the Wise Woman, that guy in the cartoons up on the mountain. The archetype gives us hope, gives some of us a very high goal for our lives, and helps us recognize and follow wise leaders. We project the archetype onto those it seems to fit at the moment—maybe the Dalai Lama, certain popes, certain spiritual teachers, even a favorite leader of a country—and then we listen to them carefully.

While there are real differences in saintliness, even the oldest traditions have recognized that the awakened still have their flawed personalities and bodies, faults or eccentricities they still need to work on and others that they cannot eliminate at all. The Sanskrit term for it is *leisha vidya*, or the remains of ignorance after enlightenment—the result of whatever you had done in this life after being born but before waking up. Having achieved enlightenment, you would not be reborn, but you would have to live out these remains until you died. Buddhists saw it the same way. Nirvana while you are alive is nirvana with a remainder, *sopadhishesa-nirvana*. Buddha saw the actions of these remains personally—he witnessed a few serious conflicts arise among his followers, even among those probably in nirvana. Final nirvana or nirvana without remainder, *parinirvana*, only comes after death.

Now we have come to the big question: What exactly is the nature of enlightenment or even of calling it something so flattering if one can still remain so flawed? That is the question Western researchers are trying to answer. And I will warn you that I do not think the question has been answered yet.

Surveys of the Enlightened

A number of researchers have tried to interview or do surveys of enlightened people. There is a good summary of these in Elizabeth Stephens' 2018 article "Complexities and Challenges of Nonduality,"⁹ along with an excellent summation of the issues being discussed among professionals as of 2018. If you want unbiased information, this is a very good article to read. Note that it uses nonduality terminology. I discuss the radical nonduality path to enlightenment in the next chapter. It is a popular, modernized method taken from the Vedanta tradition. Nonduality teachers aim to minimize the importance of the ego or individual small self through experiences in which the ego disappears. The article does not especially advocate the method, but interviewed those who used it because at least when they became enlightened they were unaligned with any traditional spiritual methods. But now I will focus on two larger studies, even more outside of any tradition. First, there is the work of Steve Taylor, summarized in his 2017 book¹⁰ *The Leap: The Psychology of Spiritual Awakening*. Then we will turn to the research by Jeffery Martin, some of it summarized in his book *The Finders*.

Taylor: Measuring the Leap

Steve Taylor is a psychologist at Leeds Beckett University in England, where he oversees a bachelor's and master's degree program in the study of awakened individuals. He has no affiliation with any particular spiritual tradition, but he took up the study of temporary and permanent wakefulness, as he sometimes calls it, because he had these experiences himself. He began his surveys in graduate school, with interviews of those who were suddenly awakened due to personal turmoil, then continued with the study of gradual cases and those who seem to have been born awakened, all of which are described in *The Leap*. His methods are entirely phenomenological—that is, based on interviews of people who identified with having had a "transformational experience of spiritual awakening" and volunteered to be interviewed. Then these interviews were

transcribed and coded to create a summary of his findings. I've outlined his findings below. Please note that these experiences are not necessarily true for every awakened person. Again, there is huge variation.

1. *Your self (small self or ego) feels as if it has dissolved a little bit*—or a lot. This is a sign of that permanent change in the self-system which Taylor feels is the essence of awakening. If you put your experience of yourself up beside an experience of the infinite, the self is bound to seem smaller.
2. *You are calmer*, thinking and feeling less, worrying and planning less. Things often seem to just happen. You are still thinking, and thinking busily when that is required. But when the self is less important, there is less to think about.
3. *You still can sometimes feel fear, anger, and sadness, but not much*. It is as if someone else is feeling them. Hence, you feel deep equanimity. You can still get upset, but less so. It feels as if there's a safety net you just can't fall through into despair, terror, rage—not unless absolutely necessary to respond adequately to circumstances, and not for long.
4. *You do still feel positive emotions, but probably not as intensely*. Instead, along with the equanimity, there is a contentment that can almost be blissful or joyfulness, but not that intense—more like just a flavor, but enough to reduce desires for almost anything else.
5. *Your desires are not as strong*. Your desires are another product of your self-system. If you think less about yourself, including what you think you need or would like, all these feelings are less prominent. You have preferences, but nothing you absolutely must have because that *you* has softened.
6. *You are less worried about your reputation, others' opinions, and even your death*. You may feel the infinite is who you really are, or that your self seems simply unimportant. About death—your self is simply one wave on the ocean. It has risen, then it will fall back, like all waves.

7. *Your attitudes have spontaneously changed.* You have less need to push your views unless it seems urgent for the benefit of others, which is just as well because your views are often nonconforming. Seeing national and world events, for example, within a larger picture can make you seem uncaring. Yet you may feel inside that you actually do care more than others about the world's problems because you see them more clearly. They just affect you differently.
8. *There is a heightened sense of right and wrong,* an innate knowing, or at least an intensification of your previous values. At the center of this is compassion for others. To stand by those feelings, you might even break laws or at least the established norms and engage in considerable self-sacrifice, without feeling it as such. For example, Mildred Norman, also known by the name she gave herself, Peace Pilgrim (and, according to Taylor, given her diaries, was awakened), walked twenty-five thousand miles wearing just a tunic declaring her mission of world peace on front and back, carrying no money, usually sleeping outside, and counting on strangers for food.¹¹ This was no martyrdom for her, but a joy. All in all, given your different way of seeing things, others may find you a bit eccentric.
9. *You are not easily bored.* Most can do nothing and it's okay. Loneliness becomes blessed solitude. You do not identify with the consumer-driven culture—neither the entertainment nor the products it produces. (Although you can still enjoy some of it.)
10. *You identify less with groups,* including specific religions. Again, you may be even more active in the world, doing good and being more responsible than ever, yet the compulsion is gone. You are not moved by social pressure.
11. *Socially, you are seen as kind.* You can meet the needs of others without concern for how you are seen. You are attuned.
12. *You have much deeper appreciation of the world around you,* especially if you awakened suddenly, so that the contrast is greater. Maybe this is because the self's concerns are no longer in the way. At a beautiful spot, you are less likely to be distracted

by thinking, *I must have a photo of that* or *I'd like to move here*. Instead, you can just *be here now*, as Ram Dass would put it, engaging with its details and meaning for you.

13. *There is a sense of being in the present.* The past and the future seem less important. There may be a sense of the presence of an all-pervading spiritual energy, like the Tao in Taoism, or Brahman in the Vedic tradition, or God as described by Christian, Jewish, or Sufi mystics. There is an aliveness and harmony to everything. Again, the small self and its many thoughts have melted away and are no longer interfering with the moment.
14. *Life seems easier.* While your needs are not intense, they do exist, and when you need something, it tends to appear. Weird, maybe, but often reported. When you have a problem, it is easily solved, or else it turns out it was a good thing that you did not get what you wanted. The things and people you like are more available. Things you would like to happen, do.

This is quite a positive list. While there is no explicit mention of either Vedanta's pure bliss consciousness being present as a background, or the freedom and emptiness that is nirvana, you can see how the list might arise from such states. And Taylor emphasizes, like so many others, that the awakened still have their quirks. You can have personality problems, and some of these may get in the way of having some of the characteristics I just described, such as attunement to others. Unless you watch for it, you can still be poisoned by power. You still may have to clean up.

In an appendix, Taylor's book has a twenty-eight-item measure of wakefulness developed by him and Kelly Kilrea, a co-researcher, and others.¹² Like all measures, the items are simply a succinct list of what they see as the essentials of what they are studying.

Another reason not to oversell enlightenment is that, although the end result sounds positive, the process is not always so wonderful. Taylor's sample was heavily weighted on the sudden side (nineteen of twenty-five), and most of these sudden shifts occurred

after some intense stress or turmoil in the person's life. Eight of these nineteen were cases of a negative sense of sudden ego dissolution that made life difficult until the change was integrated. In some cases they or others thought they were insane. They could not concentrate on anything and felt flooded by rapid, subtle, strange sensory impressions. Some were hospitalized. They and their doctors had no idea of what this might be. A psychosis? Except it eventually felt like an undeniably positive transformation. All of them finally found books or teachers who were able to explain what had happened to them. Five cases entailed an explosive release of physical energy such as I described in [Chapter 6](#) as energy-like somatic experiences (ELSEs) that was also at times very difficult to get under control, so that they could not move for brief periods even though fully conscious. In all cases the change from the old ego to the new was so great that, as one individual expressed it, he felt in the end *like a new person*. But again, Taylor's sample was unusual in this way.

Martin: Finding Fundamental Wellbeing

Jeffery Martin is another researcher who has worked independently of any tradition and found similar results. I told his story earlier: He was a highly successful Silicon Valley entrepreneur who felt he had everything but still was not happy. He searched for anyone who was truly happy and discovered that enlightened or awakened people were the only ones experiencing what he wanted, a state he now calls Fundamental Wellbeing. Thus, he enrolled in graduate school and set out to study these individuals (which he did) and then to find an efficient path for becoming one of them himself.

Martin does not have a professional background in science or even academia. His background is in business and marketing, which sometimes shows through in his work. For example, he sells courses that are meant to turn you from a seeker into a finder. But listening to the interview with him on [13 Buddha at the Gas Pump](#), I could feel his enthusiasm about his research on these truly happy people.

Although for the public he calls their state Fundamental Wellbeing, his scientific term, which I have already used in this book and quite like, is a persistent nonsymbolic experience (PNSE). It cannot be described in words, hence nonsymbolic. It is beyond thoughts, perceptions, feelings. It is just pure being or pure emptiness, as you like, and qualifies for that term after it persists for more than a year.

What matters here is that Martin began by interviewing over a thousand people whom others had identified as enlightened, not just those who said it about themselves. These interviews lasted two hours or more. As I said, he then organized courses to try to help seekers become finders of his Fundamental Wellbeing, providing him with even more data, including participants' scores on a large battery of psychological tests.¹⁴ Martin asked questions centered on five topics: thinking, feeling, perception, memory, and sense of self. Most interviewees admitted these were subjects they did not usually think about. That is, his research was not going over the same ground as the spiritual traditions from which most of his original interviewees came. You definitely will hear in Martin's work echoes of Steve Taylor's findings, such as being calmer and more in the present because of thinking less.

Besides his general observations of those with PNSE, he has identified four locations on a continuum of PNSE, which we will discuss in the next chapter. For now, we will stay with his general observations, but keep in mind that these intensified the farther along the continuum.

About changes in thinking, the first of the five topics he asked about, what was most noticeable was simply less and less thinking, a reduction of as much as 90 percent. His interviewees were able to think as much as anyone else when necessary. In fact, they thought their thinking had improved because they were less distracted by needless thoughts. Inside, the mind simply felt much quieter. The largest reduction was in thoughts about oneself.

About feelings, the intensity of feelings was reduced, although this changed dramatically according to one's location on the

continuum. The fewer the thoughts, the fewer the feelings, and vice versa.

About perception, objects and situations seemed brighter, more anchored in the present, and less affected by distracting memories or thoughts about perceptions.

About memory, fewer memories came to mind, both from early in life and more recent ones.

Similar to Taylor's findings, central to all of this was the changed sense of self. It was as though it had expanded, in a sense, but also that it had almost disappeared—although participants certainly still knew who they were. Interviewees thought they had a stronger sense of right and wrong than before and easily made decisions, but that it felt less like they were personally deciding. It just happened. The self seemed to be simply observing rather than being a participant with an agenda. Overall, there was a deep equanimity.

Although all of Martin's interviewees felt enormously changed, those around them saw little that was new in their personalities, unless the change ended a long history of depression or there was a dramatic shift in attitudes or political views. For example, others did notice when Christians lost their former faith in Christian dogma, replaced by something they saw as larger and more inclusive. Talking about their change sometimes irritated or frightened others, who dismissed it or saw it as a disorder. Many of the interviewees had found themselves talking about it less and less. Also, Martin found that a few lost their PNSE during the research period due to stress or overwork.

***Buddha at the Gas Pump* and Other Sources: Letting the Awakened Define It**

Now that we have considered the generalizations derived from research surveys, what about specific cases? To listen to some of them, go to the website/podcast *Buddha at the Gas Pump*, where there are over seven hundred long interviews with people, most of

whom are awakened, are awakening, think they are, or otherwise seem to have something to say about it. Rick Archer created the video podcast, originally a local radio show, to demonstrate that there were quite a few ordinary people in the community who had made the shift to a permanent higher state of consciousness.

Shifts with TM

Buddha at the Gas Pump was not just any local radio show. Archer lives in Fairfield, Iowa, the location of Maharishi International University, formerly Parsons College. The TM organization purchased the failing school in the early 1970s and turned it into an accredited college where everyone meditates. But the town itself changed when, in the eighties, Maharishi asked as many meditators as possible to move there to meditate together as a group. The goal was to *create coherence* throughout North America by doing their TM-Siddhi program, an advanced system of meditation Maharishi introduced in 1975—to further personal growth and increase brain coherence even more than meditation by itself¹⁵ as well as apparently increasing scores on measures of creativity and intelligence.¹⁶ Brain coherence in meditation, as I said in [Chapter 6](#), is associated with transcendent states—slowed breathing or respiratory suspension, reduced muscle activity, and increased alpha brain waves (measured by electroencephalogram or EEG). Brain wave coherence (all neurons firing similarly) and brain neurons being more connected as they operated is associated with many benefits. Moreover, it is suggested that brain coherence creates a field effect, affecting other persons in the same room and also at a distance.¹⁷

About three thousand people moved to Fairfield to help with this project and simultaneously speed up their own progress toward enlightenment. Fast-forward twenty years, and at least some of those who had moved, although happy enough living in a community of mostly meditators, had given up on becoming enlightened. Archer, however, knew from various discussion groups

and close friends that quite a few in the community actually were enlightened, by Maharishi's definition of pure consciousness being present 24/7. It just seemed many did not even realize it, or perhaps did not want to claim it, its onset being so gentle and gradual. So he set out to interview some in the community who did admit they were enlightened. "Buddha at the gas pump" was his way of saying that these awakened people looked just like everybody else in town, running errands, shopping, and stopping for gas.

I am providing a few examples from his first interviews, just brief descriptions of the shift itself, which we do not have from Taylor or Martin. (If you are interested in the full interviews, there are transcripts for most of them.) All of these shifts were permanent—Archer makes it clear as he interviews that he is not asking about great experiences. Most of them go on to describe the changes afterward being much like those described by Taylor and Martin. Because the interviews began with Fairfield residents, they had all been practicing TM for many years. But some had felt the shift came only after contacting or even just reading books by spiritual teachers beyond Maharishi. As one said, "I seemed to need a 'finishing school.'" While the first interviews are of TM meditators, Archer has gradually expanded who he interviews. We will get to those later.

Archer's first interview, on October 7, 2009, was with George and Mary Foster. (Biographical information is available on the website with each listing.) George said, "Meditation puts you in the seat of your own silence over and over again for years." After spending many hours there, he said the shift became not something he visited, but who he was.

Mary Foster's shift came after she had finished meditating one evening, walked out on the porch, and suddenly "Everything disappeared. Everything. Even Mary [herself] disappeared, which was quite interesting, but there was still an experiencer... ." Regular experience was still going on in the background, but there was a vast, infinite emptiness, and this is what she knew she really was.

On December 9, 2009, Archer interviewed Steve and Winifred Boggs. (He did not just interview couples, but they were among his first.) Winifred had been meditating for many years, but something

changed in 1999. She started looking at what she thought enlightenment would be, and eventually realized she was there. She still had emotions and her daily life that went on, but when later that year she had a serious illness, and “nothing changed,” that’s when she knew this was permanent.

Steve Boggs had been meditating for thirty years and had pretty much given up on enlightenment, feeling that being a sincere, spiritual seeker was enough. But then he began conversing with a Waking Down in Mutuality teacher in Colorado. Waking Down in Mutuality, later also called Trillium, was developed by Samuel Bonder in the 1990s. If you are interested, Archer interviewed several Trillium teachers and students, listed in his categorical list under Trillium Awakening.

Back to Steve Boggs. He felt increased panic as the Trillium teacher questioned him about who he really was and where he was really located. One day the panic came to a head. Something “just snapped.” He said everything was just silent and open and spacious. “It’s an ineffable thing to try to put words around.”

On March 5, 2010, Archer interviewed Fax and Sharon Gilbert, again both doing TM. Sharon described the process as happening very gradually, over many years. She said she did not know it was happening until the process completed itself and there was almost a clicking into place. Her husband, after doing TM for many years, met a spiritual teacher who taught him a type of self-inquiry that finished the process for him. “I went home and I sat down to meditate and there was nowhere to go ... and this just deepened over the next six months.”

Other early interviews that are very representative of the shift are that of Sue Berkey and Andy Schulman. Do explore Archer’s website to get more information.

Buddhist Shifts

Buddha at the Gas Pump makes its own shift with its thirty-ninth interview, one with Dana Sawyer. (You met him in the previous

chapter, explaining the origins of TM; he is a professor of religion and philosophy at the Maine College of Art.) Dana Sawyer introduced Archer to Khen Rinpoche Tsetan, who became the first Buddhist Archer interviewed (interview 46). In this interview, we catch a glimpse of why there are not more interviews with Buddhists about their enlightenment. Rinpoche will not talk about his state of enlightenment or anyone else's. To not talk about one's "attainments" to laypersons is one of the vows made by some Buddhist monks and nuns. (This was for various reasons—for example, so that laypeople do not give more alms to those who are perceived as enlightened, and to avoid a "cult of personality" around certain people, rather than laypeople simply trusting the teachings and the integrity of their local group of Buddhists.) In this interview, we learn that at the time Archer knew almost nothing about Buddhism. And in a later interview with one of the leading Buddhist teachers, Joseph Goldstein (mentioned in several chapters here), Goldstein admits to knowing almost nothing about Vedanta or TM. "Never the twain shall meet." Except, it seems, in this book.

The whole discussion of nirvana is more difficult in Buddhism because different traditions have different ideas about when you are finally there, making everyone more reticent to speak up about it. Still, Archer found a few shifts described by Buddhists. Constance Casey, interview 703, wrote¹⁸ *Time for Awakening*, the story of her spiritual journey and then her awakening in Malaysia on a retreat with *vipassana* teacher Sayadaw U Thuzana. Eleven days into the retreat, she was surprised by an enormous, permanent shift. This was validated by her teacher, who declared her a "stream enterer," a Buddhist term you will meet in the next chapter. Later, her teacher in Malaysia invited her to become a meditation teacher, as did Jack Kornfield and Trudy Goodman, her teachers at Spirit Rock, in California.

Zen Buddhist Henry Shukman's first awakening, told in interview 521, occurred on a Zen retreat. On these retreats, he would often stay up all night. One night, he said he was experiencing deeper and deeper states, until suddenly it was "very, very clear that basically

there is no me at all.” He sensed hearing, breathing, and so forth, but where the presumed me would be sitting, it was just a beautiful space.

Stephen Snyder, interview 654, is now a teacher who combines Zen and *vipassana*. He has written a book on the awakening process,^{[19](#)} *Demystifying Awakening: A Buddhist Path of Realization, Embodiment, and Freedom*, so his account feels a bit more intellectual. He had been meditating on his own, without a teacher, for years, and one day came upon a line in a book that read, “produce the thought that is nowhere supported.” He was somehow so impressed by it that he meditated on it for months. The result was an astounding realization that came in waves. After this he felt his sense of self had permanently shifted.

Books Containing Interesting Shifts

Eckhart Tolle was twenty-nine when he awakened, after years of anxiety and bouts of suicidal depression. Again, these sudden cases are often birthed during turmoil. He describes the shift in his first book,^{[20](#)} *The Power of Now*, which has affected many, many lives. During a night of especially deep terror and self-loathing, he began to analyze who it was who had these feelings, fell into a deep vortex, and awoke in the morning a new person. The first sound he heard, a bird chirping, sounded like a “precious diamond.” He walked around the city all day, dazed by the miracle of life, as if he had been reborn. He wrote later that “the most significant thing that can happen to a human being [is] the separation process of thinking and awareness” and that awareness is “the space in which thoughts exist.”^{[21](#)}

Valerie Gangas in her book^{[22](#)} *Enlightenment Is Sexy* describes a similar sudden change. She was suicidally depressed after her mother’s death. Someone suggested TM, and after the first meditation she opened her eyes and found, as she put it, that everything she knew was wrong. When Oprah Winfrey asked to

learn more about TM, the TM organization asked Gangas to give a talk to Oprah and her staff. When Gangas finished, apparently Oprah pointed to her and said, “I want what she has!” Oprah learned TM and paid for all four hundred of her staff to learn, too, and she still praises meditation.

Robert Forman, whom I mentioned earlier as successfully debating the view that enlightenment is purely socially constructed, wrote a real gem of a book with his²³ *Enlightenment Ain’t What It’s Cracked Up to Be*. The title reflects what we know now: that the enlightened are not left in perfect bliss and wisdom forever after (something Maharishi and other Eastern teachers have implied). His awakening was a mix of gradual and sudden: It was 1971, he was twenty-five, and had been meditating for four years, very consciously seeking enlightenment, with gradual results. But the shift came relatively swiftly while he was on a course with Maharishi in Spain, learning to become a TM teacher. The book then takes you through his early days, from his youthful shoplifting and emotional turmoil, to his psychotherapy and earning a doctorate and much more—in all, forty years of life in enlightenment. Echoing Tolle, Forman says that countless texts from every major tradition say that enlightenment is a shift in the relationship between consciousness and its objects. He says enlightenment is the²⁴ *unmingling of a mingled reality*.

Finally, there is the autobiography of Jacques Lusseyran, *And There Was Light: The Extraordinary Memoir of a Blind Hero of the French Resistance in World War II*, which was rated by a panel assembled by HarperCollins as one of the one hundred best spiritual books of the twentieth century²⁵. He describes his awakening (although he did not have a term for it) while near death in Buchenwald, the Nazi prison camp. This is obviously presupernova. His awakening is an example of an extraordinary, persistent state of consciousness that happened without him or those around him having any concept of enlightenment.

Curious about whether Lusseyran’s state persisted, I found one more book by him, six essays under the title²⁶ *Against the Pollution*

of the I. In the title essay, you sense his desire to give others what he has but cannot name. In the next essay he describes Jeremy, a fellow prisoner at Buchenwald, a plainspoken welder, given the name Socrates by the prisoners. Wherever Jeremy went, people wanted to be near him, yet gave him the personal space not given others. As Lusseyran describes him, Jeremy was a source of silent calm and joy where there seemed to be no reason. There is no doubt that Jeremy would qualify as enlightened.

What About HSPs and Enlightenment?

Naturally, I have wondered if HSPs awaken more often than others. There are good reasons why they might. For example, some may have a greater spiritual inclination—feeling beneath the surface of things, thinking about what is behind thought, ego, and all of the stuff of relative existence. This might lead to a more serious practice or study. Maybe they would be more consistent in a practice because of a greater depth of processing, seeing the possible long-term results regardless of short-term ups and downs. I have no way to know for sure, but it remains a question in my mind because of something that happened during a weekend seminar I was teaching for HSPs.

We had spent an afternoon talking about spirituality, and I briefly described enlightenment as pure awareness along with activity, including even sleep. Then I formed three discussion groups: those feeling at a loss on the subject of spirituality, or of their own lives for that matter; those deeply involved in spirituality in some way, perhaps with many questions but overall happy with their path; and a third group I designated for anyone having pure awareness along with activity, at least sometimes. Would even two people go to the place I indicated for people experiencing pure awareness, so I could call it a group? Actually, a third of the participants went to that group. I could not help noticing that they were the quietest members and many of them, I knew, had very successful lives, however you define success.

Are HSPs more likely to awaken or to seek it? That is a research study for the future. What matters is *you*, and I want to encourage you strongly to do what feels right for you. You are getting good at that, I hope. You may sense that those around you, especially many of those without the trait, would find the entire contents of this book preposterous, if they were even interested enough to want to know about it. But you are no doubt processing it more deeply—business as usual for an HSP. Still, follow your own path, not mine or anyone else's.

Where and How Did Enlightenment Arise?

What we now call enlightenment appears to have its roots in prehistoric times and reflects the experiences of shamans as they entered into altered states, which often changed them permanently so that they were seen as different, transformed humans. These states seem to come with amazing abilities, such as flying, knowing the future, and of course healing. How to achieve the basic state as well as the resulting supernatural powers was first written down by Patanjali (who he exactly was is not certain) in the *Yoga Sutras* in India between 100 BCE and 300 CE. If you read Mircea Eliade's^{[27](#)} *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy*, the powers Patanjali describes are the same feats ascribed to shamans since the dawn of human religion.

According to Eliade, flying is probably the oldest and most universal perfection, linking the seeker with the realm of God or the gods. Christian saints such as St. Francis, Theresa of Avila, and St. Joseph of Cupertino all were seen to levitate.^{[28](#)}

Where did the oral teachings begin? Probably in the Himalayas or near the Arctic Circle (where shamans also live). We know that those going forth like Buddha to gain nirvana headed for the foothills of the Himalayas to study with the ascetic teachers there, who were very likely the descendants of shamans. Tibetan Buddhism, further

up in the mountains, is an interesting blend of Buddhism and prior traditions, such as Bon, which probably had shamanic roots.

Of course knowledge of something like enlightenment could have developed out of shamanism independently in other places. There have always been extraordinary spiritual individuals, even in the earliest tribal societies. But we do not have their practices written down.

While Eastern teachers brought methods for reaching enlightenment to the West, there were also teachers and saints in the West trying to lead others to permanent higher states. You might enjoy Peter Kingsley, a sort of Greek scholar/mystic, who has argued that Pythagoras, Empedocles, and Parmenides—all living around 490 BCE and called pre-Socratic philosophers—were heavily influenced by Tibetan-Mongolian shamanic teachers who came to Greece.[29](#)

As for Christianity, knowledge about methods of achieving something like enlightenment definitely entered into the religion through its contact with Greece and Rome, but there has also been the question of whether Jesus himself was teaching about enlightenment. It may be that knowledge was mostly lost because his followers could not make use of it. This is a big subject, but since the discovery of the Nag Hammadi scrolls, and the Gospel of Thomas in particular, some have proposed that Jesus may have been a wisdom teacher. If you are interested in further exploration of the theory, see Cynthia Bourgeault's (I mentioned her earlier as one of the founders of Christian Centering Prayer) *The Wisdom Jesus*.[30](#) She argues that Jesus taught as wisdom teachers traditionally did and still do, with parables similar to Zen koans, meant to completely shake up listeners' perception (think of the Prodigal Son), with the message over and over being that the Kingdom of God is different and within you.

The bottom line is that the phenomenon of permanent higher states of consciousness certainly goes back to the shamans and was probably a goal of humans even before that. It seems that all approaches to reach altered states, whether traditional or invented recently, are branches of a deep human interest in this. But the real

goal was always to find a way to make this remarkable change permanent, and now that it may be, how does one study it to make it more accessible?

Neuroscience and Genetic Research on Enlightenment

While what follows is long and somewhat technical, for me it has been essential for grounding all of these varied experiences in whatever scientific research I could find. You, however, should feel free to skim it or just skip it.

Enlightenment with TM: Transcendental Consciousness 24/7, Alpha and Broad-Band Coherence, and Rapid-Choice Efficiency

Brain studies of enlightened persons have mostly been done using TM meditators. This is partly because enlightenment is so clearly defined in that tradition, as the increasing presence of pure consciousness, 24/7, which can be easily measured using EEG (a means of observing the electrical activity in the brain).

As for comparisons among methods, there is only one that I know of: a review of research on Tibetan Buddhist monks who have been meditating many years and presumably were enlightened, comparing it to the research on long-term TM meditators showing objective signs of enlightenment.^{[31](#)} This comparative survey found a variety of unusual improvements in perception and cognition common to both groups, but there was only one study comparing Tibetan Buddhists and TM meditators on the same measures. The author wrote that he planned to do a second article on enlightenment, but as of this writing it has not appeared.

Again, the only studies using an objective criteria of enlightenment involve long-term TM meditators (about eighteen

years average), using the criteria of reporting transcendental consciousness (TC) as a background to experience 24/7/365 for at least one year. Besides having clear criteria for enlightenment, TM has the additional advantage for research purposes of being a standardized procedure and now, after years of practice, quite a few people are describing this experience of TC with sleep and dreaming as well as during daily activity.

Just to be clear about TC with sleep, it is not as though one is awake but also asleep. In deep sleep there is no experience and nothing to remember except perhaps a sense of pleasant repose that is without informational content. There is merely a sense that *I was there* throughout the night, an inner wakefulness. In the morning, there is the sense that TC is fully present along with the awake state.

In a study comparing those who reported inner wakefulness during sleep (and all the time) compared to those who did not,³² the inner wakefulness group had higher rapid eye movement (REM) density during dreaming, similar levels of delta EEG during stage-3 and -4 sleep (delta indicates deep sleep), but higher levels of alpha 1 activity, again while asleep. Since alpha 1 coherence is typical of transcending, it makes sense that it would appear, coexisting with the brain patterns of deep sleep (delta). Thus, self-reports of TC during sleep were verified with brain data.

It is technically difficult to measure EEG in daily activity. The best that has been done is measuring EEG in those sitting with their eyes open. In those studies, it was found that those reporting more frequent TC, compared with subjects reporting less, had more frontal broadband coherence.³³ In an interview study³⁴, those reporting continual TC, and having more EEG coherence typical of that, also described themselves as more unbounded. That is, when looking at something or even thinking of themselves, there is some element of infinity also present.

What else has been observed about those reporting TC 24/7/365? The most relevant study³⁵ comparing them with those who did not used an experimental task meant to measure one's

efficiency on a particular type of task. Bear with me, as this study is complicated, but I think brilliantly captures what enlightenment means in terms of brain functioning in daily life.

Actually, three groups were compared. Group 1 was composed of those intending to learn TM but had not yet done so. Those in group 2 had been practicing TM for an average of eight years and were having frequent experiences of TC, sometimes while asleep or dreaming, but not always. Group 3 had been meditating an average of almost twenty-five years and was composed of those reporting TC all the time, including throughout sleep. One participant described her daily experience this way: "The flurry of waking activity comes and goes; the inertia of sleep comes and goes. Yet, throughout these changing values of waking and sleeping, there is a silent, unbounded continuum of awareness" (p. 295).

In this study, EEG was recorded along with a measure a bit like reaction time that quantifies the brain's preparation to act. It measures in milliseconds, too fast to involve conscious decision-making, but shows readiness to respond, in this case during a computerized task. In fact, there were two tasks. In the first, participants had to watch for an asterisk on the screen, which was followed by a tone they had to stop with a button press as quickly as possible. In a second condition, subjects saw a number instead of an asterisk and then another number instead of the tone and then had to decide as quickly as possible which number was higher. On the first task—pressing a button to stop a tone only after an asterisk appeared—group 3 (those with TC 24/7, including during this task) showed brains that were most ready to act before seeing the asterisk. The brains of those in group 2 were a little less prepared, and group 1, the not-yet-meditating group, were least prepared.

On the second, more complex task, however, brain preparation arousal was reversed. Group 3 showed the least preparation to act while waiting for the second number, the other two groups more. Remember, in this more complex task there was no way to know how to act until you had both numbers and saw which was higher. Thus, being aroused before that was a waste of energy. The beauty of this study is, again, that things happened too fast for a conscious

decision, but it seemed that the executive functioning of the frontal cortex in group 3 understood that in the complex case they had to see the second number before they could decide how to react. There was no point in preparing before then. I repeat: Everything was happening too fast for conscious decisions—they were being more efficient automatically. Group 2, less so, and group 1, least efficient, as their brains were preparing before there was any point in doing so. All of this means that in daily life, group 3, those indicating enlightenment by the 24/7 definition of it, would probably not be getting stressed or over aroused unnecessarily. Remember “Established in Being perform action”? They are living Krishna’s words.

Meanwhile, during the tasks, the EEGs for group 3 compared to the other two groups showed the highest EEG coherence in the alpha range (6–12 HZ) in the frontal cortex and the highest amplitude of alpha (6–12 Hz) in larger areas of the cortex, plus coherence across a broader range of frequencies (6–45 HZ), which was unexpected. As I explained in the previous chapter, EEG coherence is understood to be a measure of cortical connectivity, which is associated with all sorts of good things.

A Brain Integration Scale Applied to Nonmeditators

As part of the study described above, Travis and his colleagues created a Brain Integration Scale based on the differences of the EEG among these three groups at rest and during the computer task. The scale includes a sum of broadband frontal EEG coherence, indicators of higher frontal and central relative power, and an efficient brain preparatory response to task demands during the simple and choice reaction time tasks. Moral development was also measured and correlated with brain integration. While this was done to create a measure of higher states of consciousness (higher scores meant more evidence of pure consciousness 24/7), they found a

similar pattern on their Brain Integration Scale in nonmeditating highly successful athletes compared to nonmeditating less successful athletes, although not as high as the 24/7 meditator group.³⁶ They also found high scores on their scale in all the skilled musicians they tested³⁷ and in a set of high performing managers compared to those rated lower in their performance.³⁸ Most interesting perhaps, in research involving eleven police officers from various places in Colorado, five of them women, who had been interviewed previously about their spirituality and were relatively high in their ratings on this, their average Brain Integration Scale scores were close to levels of people who had been meditating for over twenty years.⁴⁰

While the athletes, managers, and musicians were not enlightened by Maharishi's criteria, their scores on the Brain Integration Scale were surprisingly close to those who were. The authors concluded that enlightenment, at least by Maharishi's definition, is not so much all or none, but that everyone who has developed their brain to an unusual extent will show these brain changes, as well as changes in moral reasoning, which is especially good news for the world. Travis and one of his collaborators, Harung, have authored a book on this: *Excellence Through Mind-Brain Development: The Secrets of World-Class Performers*.³⁹

Again, none of the people in these last studies of athletes, managers, musicians, or spiritually inclined police officers were meditators. We do not know how they gained the state of consciousness indicated by the Brain Integration Scale, but only that it correlates to some degree with those who have been meditating for years and reporting pure consciousness 24/7. That is, it would seem to validate this Brain Integration Scale as an objective indicator (vs. subjective report) of the brain in or near enlightenment, or at least at relatively high levels of functioning (in cases lacking subjective reports of enlightenment).

Buddhism and Gamma Coherence

In contrast, Buddhist nirvana, with its emphasis on behavior outside of meditation, has not yet been translated very well into the language of brain science. (An exception is one type of Tibetan Buddhism, which I will also discuss momentarily.) Two lifelong Buddhists, David Yago and Jake Davis, both interested in applying neuroscience to the study of mindfulness, discussed the thorny question of using neuroscience to study nirvana in a 2013 article, "Can enlightenment be traced to specific neural correlates, cognition, or behavior? No, and (a qualified) Yes."⁴¹ In 2024 psychologist/philosopher Julien Tempone-Wiltshire wrote an almost identical article, raising the same issue.⁴² The "no" comes from the fact that the Buddhist traditions are so varied in their views of what enlightenment is, what it looks like in an individual, and whether anyone is ever really there. Further, scientific secular materialism simply does not fit with Buddhist metaphysics. The "yes" comes from the fact that some research on enlightenment has already been approximated by looking at long-term meditators in various traditions. As you learned in the previous chapter, mindful breathing is meant to prepare for insight practices, usually focused attention practices, and these are correlated with gamma waves in EEG, as are any tasks requiring focus. Hence, finding that long-term meditators have both more gamma coherence at rest outside of meditation⁴³ and more of it during sleep⁴⁴ implies that this coherence is becoming a 24/7 phenomenon, or a trait as the authors describe it, rather than simply a state that occurs only in meditation. However, again, enlightenment or awakening itself is almost never discussed.

An exception to this lack of discussion of enlightenment among PMP researchers is Dan Brown, a Harvard professor I mentioned earlier who translated some of the main Tibetan texts and taught meditation to many. I heard him say in an interview that he was tired of being asked about meditation, because the only reason for meditation is enlightenment! He stated that he had thirty-one enlightened meditation students, presumably the participants in his last study.⁴⁵ While it was only a study of the brain during meditation,

the students were engaged in the most advanced practices, and again, the most notable finding was gamma-band coherence, the EEG frequency related to focused attention or concentration, which is seen as essential to progress in this practice.

During a *Buddha at the Gas Pump* interview of Dan Brown, Rick Archer brought up that Travis finds alpha coherence as an indicator of enlightenment and Brown is finding gamma coherence. Archer asked if people using different methods of meditating, with their brains functioning differently as a result, could or would end up with the same universal state of enlightenment. Brown's ambiguous but intriguing answer: "Same but different." If you recall in the previous chapter, meditators using quite different methods and with different EEG frequencies during meditation could all recognize moments of nondual awareness, which is the basis of enlightenment. Thus, it makes sense that gamma coherence as an indicator of a meditation technique involving concentration can precede enlightenment and occur in sleep in long-term Buddhist meditators as easily as alpha coherence. Also, Travis found in his long-term meditators broad band coherence (coherence across many bands, including some gamma), not just alpha. The main similarity is, not surprisingly, brain coherence, whatever the EEG band.

Genome-Wide Changes in Meditators with 24/7 Pure Consciousness

Another attempt to identify something physiological resulting from a permanent shift into enlightenment was a study of two very long-term meditators⁴⁶ experiencing something like transcendental consciousness 24/7, although apparently not permanently. The study looked for genome-wide changes in gene expression, which would be a major shift in the physiology.

What does gene expression mean? Although a person has thousands of genes encoded in his or her DNA, only some of these are in use at a particular time. Gene expression is the process by

which the information encoded in a gene, such as hair color, is used to either make RNA molecules that code for proteins or to make noncoding RNA molecules that serve other functions, such as gene regulation and cellular stability. Gene expression acts as an on/off switch to control when and where RNA molecules and proteins are made and as a volume control to determine how much of those products are made. The process of gene expression is carefully regulated, changing substantially under different conditions, such as hormonal changes inside the body or changes in daylight or temperature outside—or possibly years of meditating.

In this study, the researchers looked for changes in gene expression in two meditators who were each using different meditation methods (neither was doing TM) and at times experiencing pure awareness 24/7. (The researchers used only two because the data collection was complex and the study exploratory.) Both had similar EEGs during meditation, mostly alpha 1 (it seems that coherence was not analyzed). The authors saw hundreds of changes in gene expression in these meditators compared to others not experiencing this higher state of consciousness. I mentioned the same study in [Chapter 5](#) as evidence, according to the authors, that the specific changes they saw might underlie reductions in aging—specifically reductions in anxiety, PTSD, cardiovascular disease, and other chronic disorders. But the changes were complicated, and I will not try to interpret them myself.

What About You?

What feelings, thoughts, or memories have come up for you around this subject of enlightenment or awakening? Are you disappointed it does not bring anyone to real perfection? Does it all sound too fantastic and that people must be making it up? Or is it exciting to read about it? Were there intimations of something like this during your childhood? Have you had as an adult an experience like what I have described or know someone who has? Do you feel a desire to

have this experience permanently, as a background to the rest of your life? A little desire, if it were easy? Or none at all?

What About Me?

The day after I ended my twenty-one years of Jungian analysis, Art and I took off for a six-month "pilgrimage to Nowhere," as I called it. We would visit most of the Rocky Mountain states, then the U.K., Sweden, Switzerland, France, and Hawaii, and we would rent a house every month, wherever we were, to do a one-week meditation retreat. (Again, unsupervised retreats are not recommended by TM teachers, but Maharishi had given us permission to do them.) Please do not think the pursuit of enlightenment requires wealth. Time, yes, but how you use time and money depends on your priorities. We do not usually spend much money on ourselves. We have one car and live in a two-bedroom condo. But this was important to me. Being self-employed, we had the freedom to take six months for this. The traveling was secondary. I figured that after forty years of meditating, it was time to nail this enlightenment thing!

*A "pilgrimage to Nowhere" refers to a Taoist story, "Where Is Tao?" told by Chuang Tzu.⁴⁷ (This version was translated by Thomas Merton (1965/2004), *The Way of Chuang Tzu*, Shambala Library.) A man of the world, Tung Kwo, asked Chuang to show him where Tao is found. Chuang replied that there is nowhere it is not found, but the man persisted in wanting some definite place Tao is found. After a long Q and A, Chuang Tzu says Tung Kwo's questions are like those of the inspectors in the market, testing the weight of pigs. He invites Tung Kwo to come with him to the palace of Nowhere, the land of Non-Doing, where he would see that Tao is simplicity, stillness, indifference, purity, harmony, and ease.*

Of course the nowhere referred to is another term for pure being, and that was what I was experiencing in meditation. I was so near that darn palace. I probably had been all along, but now I really focused on it—without straining, I knew better than to do that. But

deeply desiring. I wanted it with me 24/7. I wanted to remove every obstacle. Hence, we set out metaphorically for the palace of Nowhere, meditating during the retreats about five hours a day plus rest and yoga. It is easy for us. We have almost never missed a meditation in our entire lives because we enjoy it. For us, TM has been slow and steady, although speeding up as we came closer to the goal. Now I wanted full speed ahead.

It was near the end of the six months, in Hawaii, around Christmas, that I felt the shift. I know right where I was—walking along a path at our favorite place to stay. Pure consciousness was suddenly there, had probably always been there, but now I could see that it predominated, even though I was not meditating at the moment. It was a definite shift, but nothing flashy. I think that its coming gradually made it less intense. I felt some deep euphoria for a while, but that has worn off some. The equanimity is what is stronger now.

I have just told you something about myself that I hope will not be misunderstood. Traditionally you do not talk about a shift in consciousness like this. Humility is part of it all. However, it was a big help to me to hear about so many others awakening. I think we all need encouragement that it is more common than it seemed while people were not talking about it. Just please, please do not project onto me that I am some kind of saint or special person. I am not even rare anymore. Technically, to project means projecting onto another what is really true of yourself, and if it is that much on your mind it will be true of you soon enough.

I still meditate and still try to spend one week a month on retreat. Before a retreat, while I am working hard, I do sometimes wonder how I can settle down and meditate so much more, but once I begin, it is so sweet that returning to the usual, shorter meditation time seems like trying to fit myself into a laundry basket. Still, it is absolutely necessary to alternate meditation with activity. The two are what carry you forward, not either one alone.

If my shift sounds like the product of enormous effort, something you could never do, remember I started meditation back when, I think, progress for everyone was slower. Mine was also an unusual

path in that I was simultaneously in Jungian analysis for twenty years, most of it three times a week. I am not sure if my need for cleaning up had been an obstacle to waking up. At the time, the two processes seemed very separate. In analysis I rarely mentioned meditating. Meditating was not resolving my intense transference and complexes. Equanimity and well-being are certainly goals for psychotherapy and psychoanalysis as well, but most of the time equanimity seemed far off. Then when the results of each finally integrated, it was profound and miraculous, in particular that my analyst simply became a person I was fond of and grateful to, and one who deserved to have a separate life, free of my projections. The intense transference was gone (and has never returned, projected onto anyone else). Indeed, he recently died, and while I miss him, I am not devastated.

Still, I sometimes wonder if the waking up was delayed by the cleaning up, as if my psyche wanted the two to be finished at the same time. When the cleaning up was largely done, I began to ardently desire awakening. I prayed for it, at the deepest, most silent level of my mind. During my pilgrimage, I also watched for pure consciousness to appear more regularly in daily life behind my regular activities, and it seemed like watching for it helped make it there permanently.

Where We Are Now

I have given you a general picture of enlightenment or awakening, using research and history to provide a sense of its objective reality. I have also tried to be objective about its results, not making it seem like a state of perfection or bliss. For example, I said that the process of entering and adjusting to permanent awakening can be tumultuous and the end result, as Forman says in the title of his book, "not all it's cracked up to be." You are still you, quirks and all. Although, I have not found evidence of anyone who wanted to go back to who they were before!

In the next and final chapter, I will provide more knowledge about the states and stages the brain might go through, maybe making it easier for you to recognize what is happening to you or someone else. Plus, I will try to sort through more of the countless discussions and offerings of ways to awaken more quickly or perfectly. That is, you will see more of the traditional understandings of how enlightenment unfolds, usually gradually and in stages, plus how these traditions are rapidly evolving, out in the marketplace rather than the monastery, with householders like you and me seeking enlightenment. As Westerners, we are willing to experiment and to spend some money, a perfect setup both for progress and mistakes. That is, we are in the thick of an evolutionary process, and I want you to be among those who come out of the process satisfied with how it has affected you personally.

CHAPTER 8

STATES, STAGES, AND BOOSTER ROCKETS—MORE ON AWAKENING OR ENLIGHTENMENT

In the previous chapter I described enlightenment or awakening as if it was one state, even if it varied among individuals and in the ways to attain it. Wasn't that enough, you might ask? Maybe enough, but if you have any desire at all to change your brain and therefore your life in a permanent way, you will want to know more of the details.

First, I will present views on stages of awakening or of increasingly higher states of consciousness. Vedanta teachers tend to see them as progressively more advanced phases of enlightenment, while Buddhism sees them more as steps or stages on the way to the final goal of nirvana. Plus, we will return to Ken Wilber and Jeffery Martin, who have their modern view of stages.

Then we look at new methods for awakening, Western shortcuts, as if to say, *Skip the theory—why not just build a booster rocket with whatever stages you want as long as it gets you to outer space?* And I will finish the chapter and the book with the issue I asked you to keep under wraps until the end: How does all of this impact the huge world problems we have today? Isn't this more burying our

heads in the sand? How is it not pure selfishness to seek to become enlightened in these times? You will decide, after we complete the picture of what is known about higher states.

Vedanta—Four Higher States of Consciousness

I start with Maharishi's description because it is most detailed, and then use this as a template for comparing other views. Maharishi gradually opened up to his students in the West about these additional states as he felt TM meditators were ready for that knowledge, finally putting it all onto a vinyl record in 1967.¹ He liked to talk about seven states, each with its own brain wave pattern and subjective experience. He started with waking, dreaming, and sleeping, since we all experience these states. You know these, so I will skip them, and we can move on to the others.

Transcendental Consciousness

We have already discussed the fourth state, transcendental consciousness (TC), which we discussed at length in earlier chapters because it usually first occurs only in meditation, at least in State Enlivening meditation, where it has been well studied in TM meditators. We saw in [Chapter 6](#) that comparable nondual states—without thoughts, feelings, or perceptions, states of greatly reduced breathing and coherent brain waves—are experienced by advanced meditators doing most methods. The only difference might be the interpretation of what that state (*samadhi*, *jhana*, pure light mind, etc.) means within the broader goal of awakening.

This fourth state can also occur outside of meditation spontaneously, especially in childhood. You might transcend or simply find your mind has dropped into a place relatively free of thoughts, perceptions, and feelings. Hence it is sometimes called pure consciousness. Since you are not thinking during it (or not

thinking very much), it may be that you only notice afterward that you were in a state of alert awareness without content.

In this fourth state there is a sense of deep silence or unboundedness, the sense of only awareness itself. But these are simply metaphors, since that silence can be felt along with noise (e.g., traffic sounds, a clock ticking) and the unboundedness can be there along with some boundaries (such as the sense of your breath). It is more as if pure consciousness is behind everything, like a movie screen on which we see thoughts, perceptions, and feelings. In the fourth state, or because of it, the screen now predominates and the movie is gone or barely noticed.

Cosmic Consciousness

The next state represents that shift into deep inner peace 24/7. Maharishi called it Cosmic Consciousness (when these seem to be specifically his terms, I capitalize them). In the movie screen metaphor, you are aware of the activity on the screen along with the screen itself, in that the brain maintains the screen of brain coherence as a background to all activity, and it is always there as an experience if you turn your attention to it. You have already encountered this in the previous chapter, as TC, along with waking, dreaming, and sleeping, as studied by Fred Travis and his collaborators, and you read descriptions of shifts into this state by those who have experienced it.

Subjectively, the Vedanta tradition would say that the sense of an absolute Self (*atman* in Sanskrit) that was there only in meditation is now fully awake and present, witnessing the functioning of the ego and all that the ego perceives and thinks. In this state, you identify with this witness, not your ego, so it is a huge change in perception or what is called the self-system. There is a sense of separation or *unmingling* of your small self with whatever it sees. You are no longer mixed with or lost in whatever you are experiencing. There is now this big Self, watching self and object. This is a way to understand the term Self-Realization. It is as if one is witnessing life,

with your true identity being the silence of transcendental, pure consciousness, the Self.

Just to be clear, this witnessing does not mean that you are learning to have two experiences at once. As said in the previous chapter, in these higher states, pure consciousness is not *on your mind* and being noticed at every moment. The screen, as described above, is not an idea the mind is having, so you may not notice it when you are focused on work or making plans. A Vedanta teacher might make the analogy of a child playing more freely in the yard, knowing Mother is at home, but never actually thinking about her. Or wearing a warm coat and enjoying it without thinking about it. Neither Mother nor the coat require your thoughts for them to be with you. You no longer have to go within and transcend from waking to transcendental consciousness to experience that state. It is permanently with you.

This type of witnessing is also not the same as dissociating, which can result from psychological trauma. In clinical dissociation you feel odd, almost disembodied or ungrounded, or have entirely forgotten some parts of your past experience because your mind is trying to keep you from remembering something too disturbing to handle. In this fifth state you are fully functioning. Indeed, in the study I described in the previous chapter of rapid-choice tasks, those who reported this state functioned far more efficiently.

God Consciousness or Glorified Cosmic Consciousness

In the next state, according to these teachings, after becoming separate from the outer world, you are drawn back into it because your nervous system has continued to evolve, your perception has refined, and the outer world simply looks very different. Frequently, it is said that it is as if the world is almost painfully beautiful, and you are automatically pulled out of the previous separateness by this beauty, inspiring emotions like love or devotion.

Maharishi originally called this state God Consciousness, but later changed it to Glorified or Refined cosmic consciousness, perhaps for those uneasy with the idea of God. But as David Buckland explains in ² *Our Natural Potential: Beyond Personal Development*, which goes more deeply into Maharishi's descriptions, this is not about belief. It does not matter if you are an atheist. He claims something like God becomes a direct experience—clear, unmistakable. (On the other hand, you will see that some people do seem to skip this state.) If you have been uncomfortable with the sense that enlightenment is not really spiritual, given all the secular thinking about awakening, perhaps this helps.

Unity Consciousness or Brahman Consciousness

Although God Consciousness and this next state, Unity Consciousness, are traditionally described separately, with the one leading to the next, this order does not seem to be fixed. According to Buckland (and Jeffery Martin, whose *locations* we will look at soon), some people jump from Cosmic Consciousness to Unity, skipping God consciousness, perhaps later going back to it. Others, according to Maharishi, who are in God Consciousness, may choose to stay there. (Jeffery Martin found the same.) It's really a matter of the person's personality or tradition.

Normally, or perhaps traditionally, God Consciousness evolves into Unity Consciousness as one sees the commonality of the divine in everything. This sense of unity or oneness with the objects of perception is unlike the mingling in the waking state, in which there is no sense of the Self. Rather, the Self, sensing the aspect of the relative world that is as close as possible to the transcendent, or pure being, is pulled toward this subtle realm until the Self and pure being merge (not that they were ever actually separated), creating Unity Consciousness. Maharishi said this movement from God to Unity Consciousness is an automatic process. Indeed his view is that

once you are experiencing transcendental consciousness, all further states are automatic, although they take time to develop.

Clearly Unity Consciousness is yet another change in the self-system, in which the self has become so expanded that it is almost entirely lost. This may be what Thomas Merton entered on that famous (to Merton devotees) day in Louisville³ when he stepped off the bus at the busy corner of Fourth and Walnut and was suddenly overwhelmed with the realization that he loved all these people, everyone he saw.

Maharishi emphasized that this unity is noticed first in particular situations (how about the center of Louisville!) or with particular objects, but as the process proceeds, one reaches a unity with everything, all the time. This is traditionally called Brahman Consciousness. Yes, now I just added an eighth state, but Maharishi did not usually discuss this one with the public, so I will stop here too. You can read about it in *Conversations with Maharishi*, coauthored by Vernon Katz and Maharishi⁴, or *Realizing Brahman* by William Sand⁵.

In the Vedanta tradition there are *mahavakyas*, phrases that can be said, usually by a teacher who is in that unity state already, that reveal the unity of everything, so that you recognize it for what it is. In a sense, only then do you formally enter into Unity Consciousness. The classic example of a *mahavakya* is "I am That, thou art That, and all of this is That." If that makes no sense to you, you just are not quite ready to hear it. No problem. On the other hand, if you were in Unity Consciousness but did not know it, it would make good sense. *Mahavakyas* are not always so fancy. Anyone knowledgeable could hear you describe your experiences and deliver an informal *mahavakya*: "That sounds like you're in Unity now."

By the 1980s, Maharishi stopped talking much about Cosmic Consciousness and God Consciousness, not because they were not real and being experienced but because more and more people were going directly to Unity Consciousness and its final development, Brahman Consciousness.⁶ Interestingly, if you go there directly,

without the noticeable changes in the earlier states, Unity can almost seem a bit like nothing has happened. Life is much better than before the jump, but there may be only one shift in the self-system, in that the self seems like a small, unimportant part of a totality and not really doing anything. Emotions are much different—still there but less personal. This is a time when knowledge is key for understanding your experience.

Maharishi mentioned this risk of missing Unity early on, in 1964 even.⁷ He said that just as when you become an engineer, it may not feel like anything has happened. You just have a new way of being. You no longer worry, for example, but nothing seems to have happened. “This is that growth of abstract absolute. It has its field in the silence, silent growth.”

Similar States or Stages in Christianity

In [Chapter 7](#) I mentioned the historical basis for something like enlightenment in every religion’s mystics. For example, Meister Eckhart, everyone’s favorite medieval Christian mystic, is often quoted but rarely understood in his entirety simply because no one knew the code. Remember Robert Forman from the previous chapter? He earned a Ph.D. in religion from Columbia University and an honorary doctorate from Lund University. On a hunch about Eckhart, based on his own experiences of higher states, Forman set out to decipher the Meister. Noting the different terms Eckhart used to describe the same things, always keeping Eckhart’s bigger vision in mind, he broke the code, so to speak, and discovered Eckhart was writing about the three higher states of consciousness I have discussed here.⁸ Forman even found a medieval illustration, reproduced in his book, made by Blessed Henry Suso (1295–1366), one of Eckhart’s followers, of how these stages proceed from one to the next.⁹

Saint Theresa of Avila (1515–82) also described stages or states as seven ascending chambers in her¹⁰ *Interior Castle*. They also are

reminiscent of our familiar seven, ending with the seventh as a union with God. Thomas Merton also described all the higher states, if you read carefully the last pages of the second to the last chapter in [11](#) *New Seeds of Contemplation*. This was published two years before his death, as a major revision of an earlier book.

Modern, Secular Descriptions of Higher States

With the supernova, there has been an effort to verify a consistent pattern of higher states, looking through a modern, secular lens. Most of this work has been done by Ken Wilber and Jeffery Martin. Wilber has tried to summarize various traditional views, looking for the commonalities. Martin's list is based on his interviews of those who have awakened, some gradually, usually within a tradition, and some suddenly or through his secular courses.

Ken Wilber's "Supraconscious" States

You met Ken Wilber in [Chapter 1](#) when we were discussing his idea that spirituality is a common human ability that develops more if focused on, and you came to know him more in [Chapter 2](#) with his idea of humans developing from childhood into adulthood and beyond along many lines. Three stand out for this book: growing up, cleaning up, and waking up. Ken Wilber's work on higher states of consciousness [12](#) is really an attempt to fully summarize all the traditional descriptions of waking up, although he was heavily influenced by Sri Aurobindo, an Indian who used new terms but was still thoroughly Vedanta. What is nontraditional is that Wilber's states are a part of his larger Integral Theory, which in turn has its roots in prior philosophers, mainly Jean Gebser, who first used the term *integral* in this way, and Teilhard de Chardin. (I apologize for throwing names at you, but Wilber's name is so often equated with Integral Theory that I simply want to be clear that Wilber did not invent the entire subject by himself.) Wilber and his colleagues have

reviewed all the different traditions and decided there are two states after the basic shift of waking up.

The first of the two states are similar to Maharishi's Cosmic Consciousness—witnessing or experiencing transcendental consciousness 24/7. It is that disentangling of your true identity from the relative world, bringing a sense of calm and freedom. Wilber calls it the "self-witnessing spirit," and in it the separate small self is "buried in splendor."¹³ One experiences the source of the path, the path itself, and its goal, all three at once.

Wilber emphasizes that this witnessing of the world, including the ego, by the Self was sought over thousands of years through experimenting with methods to go beyond thought. The methods were not teaching attitudes, ideas, or even perceptions of anything. Every teacher knew this state is beyond all those mental activities. It is a release from them. It was just difficult to teach a method for reaching it.

The second, still higher state, described in all traditions according to Wilber's research, occurs when the witness is one with everything, as in Maharishi's Unity Consciousness. It is as though the Self has emerged from that deep well from which it had been viewing the world in the prior, witnessing state. Now everything is One. In this state there is no difference between the ego (the *you* with a name, occupation, etc.) and a tree you might look at, or the book or device you are using to read or hear this. Wilber sometimes calls this One Taste, which comes from Tibetan Buddhism (via Wilber's collaborations with Dan Brown) and refers to the way that both the diversity of the relative world and the Oneness of the absolute are *tasted* in this state at the same time. Wilber does not mention a state like Maharishi's God Consciousness, which is not too surprising, given our prior discussion of how it is sometimes skipped over in the development toward Unity.

Martin's Locations within the Persistent Nonsymbolic Experience

You may recall Jeffery Martin from the previous chapter, and his research on persistent nonsymbolic experience or PNSE, what he publicly calls Fundamental Wellbeing. In his book¹⁴ *The Finders*, he describes the enlightened/awakened people he interviewed as fitting into one of nine locations along a continuum, although almost everyone he spoke with could be placed in the first four. I said in the previous chapter that he looked at five psychological aspects: thinking, feeling, perception, memory, and overall sense of self. Let's look at these five as they change along the continuum.

The farther along, the less thinking in general. Some said they thought they now had 95 percent fewer thoughts, especially about themselves, although people still found their thinking clear and useful. This may be the result of the inner quietness, which makes thoughts seem almost nonexistent because they arise from a subtler level than before the transition.

Emotionally, at every location there was always a deep sense of peace and well-being, which is what made the change precious to almost every finder. It was something they would never wish to give up. This feeling of well-being did not have any particular content—this is what makes it nonsymbolic, in that it is beyond any thought or emotion.

Besides this general feeling, or along with it, there were differences in specific emotions at each location. Location three involved more intense feelings of inner peace, plus a mixture of compassion, joy, and love that was not personal but related more to God or the universal. It was part of the present moment, without necessarily being a reaction to anything. In contrast, at location four, ordinary emotions had basically disappeared, replaced by nonduality, or the sense that the personal self is gone or insignificant because it has become one with the Self, the universal. So location three was similar to Maharishi's God Consciousness and location four similar to his Unity Consciousness.

In terms of perception, the farther along the continuum, the more interviewees reported being in the present moment most of the time, with more perceptually vivid experiences that were less

interrupted by thoughts, memories, or plans. At location four, the sense of unity could create the strange perception that, for example, touching another person could be confused with touching one's own body. There was no perception of any sense of self or of making decisions. Life was simply unfolding, and the person at this location was observing.

In terms of memory, the farther along the continuum, the fewer spontaneous memories, including the recent past, although this only had practical effects in location four or while shifting locations.

The sense of self clearly altered the most. Starting with the first location and increasing along the continuum, people identified less and less with their previous identity—name, occupation, family ties—all of what others see as a normal sense of self. This occurred even for those not expecting any loss of self, so that they thought something was wrong with them when it happened. At the second location people reported witnessing a complete separation from self, much like Cosmic Consciousness. And at location four, the report was of being one with everything, with no real individual self at all (although of course there was a functioning identity or ego that knew its name and its history if the person was pressed about it).

Martin found that some of his finders who had experienced more than one location could move among them, even voluntarily, according to situations or preference. In particular, the indifference typical of location four could be set aside in favor of returning to location three, usually because it felt too strange to have no feelings or someone wished to return to the universal peace, joy, and compassion of location three. Indeed, Martin identifies a "Path of Freedom," on which seekers sought to go to even farther locations than the fourth, and a "Path of Humanity," on which seekers chose to serve others rather than pursue still higher states. (However, some felt that the freedom path actually serves humanity more in the long run.)

Overall, the attributes of Martin's locations do not seem very different from Maharishi's list, those of the Christian mystics, or Wilber's.

Stages in Buddhism

In Buddhism there is very little that resembles Maharishi's list of higher states, perhaps because tradition has it that Buddha became enlightened with one long meditation sitting, in which he passed through lower states or stages and discarded each as not what he was really seeking. When he found nirvana, every lower state was simply that, and a possible distraction if one stopped there without moving on to the goal. One might equate nirvana with Brahman Consciousness, as long as one remembers that in Buddhism the ultimate is empty and formless, while Brahman is paradoxically formless yet fullness, full of potential form.

The Original Stages, from Buddha

Still, there are some stages in Buddhism, a list ostensibly from Buddha himself. They may seem strange to Western ears, but after each I provide the way the Elders in the Theravada tradition in Southeast Asia view it.^{[15](#)}

1. **Stream-Entry:** The fetters of doubt, personal identity, and attachment to rituals completely fall away (no more than seven rebirths are required to reach the final goal, number four below). This is the first stage of enlightenment, in that reaching nirvana is now inevitable. (The *fetters of doubt* falling away means you now completely believe in the Buddha's teachings, and the *attachment to rituals* falling away refers to no longer being part of the Vedanta traditions of rituals performed by Brahmins.)

According to the Theravada Elders, stream enterers have fully tasted enlightenment and are forever changed but must purify their character and actions to fully embody this understanding.

2. **Once-Returner:** Sensual desire and aversion are greatly attenuated, but still exist (only one more rebirth required). The

Elders describe once-returners as having discovered and released habits of grasping and aversion that come from a still limited sense of self.

3. **Non-Returner:** Sensual desire and aversion are extinguished. The Elders add that non-returners are now resting in calm and emptiness. Any remaining limiting thoughts or feelings are easily extinguished.
4. **Arahat:** All craving is extinguished (including desire to have material existence). This is what is rightly called nirvana. The Elders say there is no longer any clinging even to feelings of joy or good experiences in meditation. There is no more identification with the self at all.

Although I'm sure some Buddhists would find it a stretch, it is tempting to see the Stream Enterer as similar to Maharishi's Cosmic Consciousness, which he also said was only the beginning—that real enlightenment occurs in Unity or Brahman consciousness. The once-returner and non-returner would be similar to the next two states, in which purification occurs, and *arahat* would only be achieved with the last state, Unity.

Buddha also described seven "factors" within the awakening process:

1. Mindfulness
2. Investigation of the dhammas (by meditating on them)
3. Energy
4. Rapture
5. Calm
6. Concentration or *samadhi*
7. Equanimity.

These have been especially well-described in Western Buddhist language by *vipassana* teacher Joseph Goldstein, mainly in his book, *Mindfulness: A Practical Guide to Awakening*, which I already mentioned. But these are not stages or prior states.

In modern Theravada Buddhism, none of the states Maharishi described would be viewed as nirvana. But as I mentioned in the previous chapter, they would be seen as *jhana* states, or higher states achieved in meditation through concentration. There are four, and they are successively deeper and more blissful, until one transcends that bliss and enters nirvana. *Jhana* states are a bit controversial in modern Buddhism. (Indeed, if you read Wikipedia on the subject of *jhanas*, you may see reference to the “jhana wars.”)

Stages in Zen Buddhism

In the ninth century, Chan master Dongshan Liangjie (founder in China of what became, once it was in Japan, the Soto School of Zen) described the Five Ranks of Awakening.¹⁶ The gradations are based on the doctrine of Two Truths, namely relative and absolute truth. First, the absolute truth is hidden within the relative, before knowledge of the absolute. Second, the relative is hidden within the absolute, as when we meditate. That can lead to the third state, the absolute alone, as in transcendental consciousness. But it can also lead to what Maharishi termed Cosmic Consciousness, when one is so identified with the absolute that one feels like a witness to the relative world. Fourth, the relative is relatively alone, without the absolute, as with the fascination with the beauty of the relative in God Consciousness. The fifth state is the goal, when the absolute and the relative are together, as in Unity.

I think the idea of Two Truths are helpful in daily life—one can feel one is overloaded with the relative, as when one is overstimulated, so one meditates and the absolute returns to prominence, balancing the relative.

Spiritual teacher Adyashanti, coming from a Zen tradition, also suggests stages. In some places he keeps it to two: nonabiding and abiding awakening. Nonabiding, as the term implies, comes and goes for a while. (Adyashanti had two or three awakenings before it became abiding.) However, he also teaches, in his book¹⁷ *The Direct*

Way, that awakening first occurs by seeing that simple awareness (pure awareness) is behind everything, the conscious context of all experience, which leads to awakening from identification with the ego. This would be similar to entering Maharishi's Cosmic Consciousness. Adyashanti has two more stages—awakening the heart, much like Maharishi's God Consciousness, and awakening the ground of being, much like Maharishi's Unity. Again, I draw these parallels between Maharishi's seven states, which is a Vedanta perspective, and stages found in a Buddhist context, only to point out that there is sometimes something in common.

Stages in Tibetan Buddhism

In Daniel P. Brown's *Pointing Out the Great Way: The Stages of Meditation in the Mahamudra Tradition*, which I mentioned earlier, there are also stages. Mahamudra began in India, in perhaps the eighth century, but was quickly taken up in Tibet as well. It was one of those reformations that happen in religions—it arose outside of the mainstream Buddhist monasteries and universities and often attracted commoners. It began with teachers simply pointing out, when students seemed ready, the "true nature of the mind," which is that it is empty yet luminous, the clear-light Buddha mind. (I should remind you again that from the point of view of Buddhist philosophy, being empty yet luminous is not quite the same as Vedanta's view of experiences of pure consciousness. The clear-light mind realizes that everything is caused by everything else, so there is no essence to anything. Behind everything there is nothing.)

In the earliest days, Mahamudra teachers, some of them famous poets, actually sang this insight about the empty yet luminous mind. But as the teaching became richer, the idea was that first the student becomes familiar with the concept of the clear-light mind through verbal teaching, and then experiences it directly through meditation. As one's meditation practice evolves, the student sees that the clear-light mind never goes away, even when one is thinking. Once this is well established, the student is encouraged to

“take it off the cushion” and go outside into nature while maintaining that state, and then engaging in more and more activities. All of this sounds like developing Cosmic Consciousness. Further developments through additional practices lead to the Awakened Mind, similar to Unity Consciousness.

Mahamudra also has a State Enlivening practice for students who are ready to go beyond traditional mindfulness and *vipassana* (which were not part of Mahamudra originally). Being ready means that you are able to stop any falling into coarse or persistent thoughts and practice unsupported meditation. That is, you relax or meditate without effort, in order to be one with the silent, unbounded, empty mind along with the fluctuations that are always occurring in it. In this unsupported meditation there is no mantra, as with some Zen meditation. It is State Enlivening in that one uses only just enough effort to return to the desired state if the mind wanders. One must balance that small effort with relaxing into the emptiness.

I should add that Brown was quite critical of how meditation is taught in the West. In the introduction to *Pointing Out the Great Way*, he blasted the most popular Buddhist teachings as failing to emphasize that the point of meditation is or should be enlightenment, and the popular methods do little to get students there (some do not even bring it up). He said they use the odometer approach, assuming the more hours spent meditating, the deeper the meditation, but most meditators do not reach the goal because errors in meditation arise and remain for years without proper knowledge and guidance. He thought that each student should have a personal teacher, as is traditional in Tibet, helping them advance through various stages until they reach enlightenment—and after that, helping them to stabilize it. That said, he was also quite confident that with the right teacher, the methods in his book could make almost anyone enlightened in six to eight years.

The Stage of Post-Enlightenment

At the end of his book, Brown has a chapter on Path Walking, or the long-standing Tibetan-Buddhist methods of protecting and growing enlightenment after it has occurred. There are only a few other books on post-enlightenment life. There is Adyashanti's *The End of Your World: Uncensored Straight Talk on the Nature of Enlightenment*,^{[18](#)} which I highly recommend if you are at that place of a fresh awakening and wondering how the process further unfolds. In it, Adyashanti also speaks of the mind, the heart, and the gut, as he does in *The Direct Way*, but this time even more as stages of awakening, again echoing Maharishi's higher states above.

Another post-awakening book is *After the Ecstasy, the Laundry* by Jack Kornfield^{[19](#)} (of Insight Meditation Society), in which I found the interpretation of the Burmese Elders' four stages of awakening. Kornfield finds there is so much growth to do after an initial, albeit permanent awakening, perhaps in the sense of cleaning up versus waking up.

Other Ways of Getting There, Maybe Faster?

Now that enlightenment is coming under such scrutiny, and there has been this explosion of those experiencing it and teaching about it, naturally there are suggestions of ways to improve or speed up the process. We will look at two approaches: one said to be based on empirical evidence about individual differences and the other, more controversial, known as radical nonduality. It focuses entirely on the self-system or ego.

But we will transition to these speeded-up approaches with a book based on traditional methods, which are usually slow, that have been boiled down to just one volume: Andrew Holecek's^{[20](#)} *Reverse Meditation: How to Use Your Pain and Most Difficult Emotions as the Doorway to Inner Freedom*. Like Dan Brown, Holecek sees the Mahamudra teachings of Tibet as providing a precise path to enlightenment. But Holecek has shortened this path much more, beginning with PMP methods such as mindful breathing

and ending with State Enlivening meditations, employing pointing out along the way, all of it based on facing pain as the shortcut.

Holechek argues that meditation is sold as a way to feel better, but what happens when we feel bad? If equanimity is the ultimate sign of enlightenment, why not tackle it at the start? From a Tibetan perspective in particular, facing physical and emotional pain—reverse meditation, not first pursuing feeling better—is the fastest way to enlightenment. Holechek certainly fires up the booster rockets. By the end he is teaching how to experience pure consciousness without using a mantra or attention to breathing. In this open place, the “I” who feels the pain, the fundamental constriction we live with, is gone, and so is the specific pain one is feeling, replaced by awareness itself. Again, the self-system is the focus. What else has been done to speed you on your path to awakening?

On Becoming a Finder

Jeffery Martin, after studying over a thousand awakened people from every tradition, reported that no one method consistently worked. It all depended on the person. While sticking to one method was generally good, so was switching until you found what suited you. (Not good was inconsistent practice of whatever you chose to try.) Martin developed a course based on his findings, something that would move people faster from being a seeker to being a finder. One of his strategies has been to give people a chance to try a variety of methods, usually for one week at a time, along with receiving some general positive-psychology instruction. You generally meet in a group, adding social support but also social pressure to describe more progress. He reported that about 65 percent became finders during his courses, a high degree of success.²¹ However, Martin does offer a sort of brush-up course, so I presume that finders sometimes get lost again. By the time you read this, his courses may have changed, as he often updates them. For example, in 2025, on his birthday, June 12, he said he was giving the course

away at no charge.²² So if you want you can look him up to see what he now says about the best way to become a finder.

Self-Inquiry and Radical Nonduality or Neo-Advaita

As you have seen by now, the more you learn what people are experiencing when they say they have awakened, the more you hear about a loss of the sense of the self (or small self) or ego. These descriptions range from simply having many fewer thoughts or taking one's thoughts less seriously to an almost total loss or ego death. Some of the sense of greater well-being is definitely associated with this sense of ego reduction. Think of all the hassles that arise when our ego gets involved—when it feels slighted, gets competitive, worries about being rejected, or is caught up in planning things that might work out better with much less advanced planning. (Remember, Fred Travis found the enlightened were more efficient in forced-choice tasks, staying calm until it was time to act, without any conscious thought or ego involvement.)

Naturally, if you are looking for a way to speed up the enlightenment process, you might focus on lessening or eliminating the ego. This has been the approach of many of those who have become very popular for their awakening teachings based on radical nonduality or neo-Advaita (some people identify with one term more than the other). Their idea (not in itself new, of course) is that everything we see and feel is an illusion, including and especially ourselves. According to them, even the idea of being on a path only reinforces the illusion. They would say you can awaken right now to the fact that all you are, all everything is, is pure consciousness, pure awareness, pure being.

The Background to Neo-Advaita

Put in context, radical nondualism or neo-Advaita comes from Advaita Vedanta. Remember, Vedanta means *end of the Vedas* because it teaches that better than the ritual sacrifices described in the older parts of the Vedas, or even better than study of the Vedas, the best path to enlightenment is to meditate on, to know, to intuit, to realize what is the source of the manifest, relative world, which is, again, pure awareness, pure consciousness, the Self, Brahmin. Advaita Vedanta takes this to its ultimate, saying everything else but Brahman is an illusion.

One of Advaita Vedanta's chief proponents was Shankara, whom you met in [Chapter 6](#). Perhaps some of his fame and success came from his compromises on this main point of everything being an illusion. He said there are three kinds of knowledge—absolute knowledge, as taught by Advaita Vedanta; empirical knowledge (always changing); and imagined knowledge. Advaita Vedanta teaches absolute knowledge to those ready for it. Only a very mature student would receive the final teachings. Enlightenment was expected to be instantaneous after receiving absolute knowledge, but only because the teacher saw the student was ready after years of preparation. Buddhists understood the same, that there is the ordinary truth of physical reality, which we need to operate in the world, and there is greater reality of nothingness in nirvana. We need to live in both.

Modern Advaita Vedanta in India was revived by Ramana Maharishi (1879–1950), a greatly revered saint who was enlightened while in high school. (He said he prepared in his past lives.) It is taught to anyone, using various methods, such as having students read the key *Upanishads* and commentaries, hear an enlightened teacher speak, or meditate on a *mahavakya* (the short sayings I mentioned earlier that are intended to bring you into Unity). The most famous Advaita Vedanta teachers after Ramana Maharishi were Sri Nisargadatta (1897–1981) and H. W. L. Poonja or “Papaji” (1910–97). Their books are easily found. A proponent well-grounded in traditional Advaita Vedanta is Swami Sarvapriyananda, a monk in the Ramakrishna Order and head of the Vedanta Society in New York. He has numerous videos on the internet and has authored several

books, all intended to bring you enlightenment, at least if you happen to be ready.

These Advaita Vedanta teachers do expect the process to take time. They focus on the traditional formula of self-inquiry into what is the essence of who you are. Where do your thoughts come from? Who experiences them? If you are with a teacher, these questions might be posed to you again and again in different ways. Sri Nisargadatta liked to ask, "Who was present before you were born? Who will be present after you die?" The hope is that you will see, not intellectually but as a full realization, that there is only pure consciousness, Brahman, or the impersonal God.

As part of the supernova, Westerners went to India and studied with some of these modern Advaita Vedanta teachers, then came home hoping to speed up awakening using this modern Advaita Vedanta or neo-Advaita. As the teachings moved to the West (the Wild West, where anything goes), the use of basic questions remained, but were gradually stripped of tradition. For example, in India it is understood, as I have said, that one can both adhere to Advaita Vedanta and worship God, meaning you accept both nonduality and duality. Sri Nisargadatta, said, "Wisdom says I am nothing. Love says I am everything. Between the two my life flows."²³ In contrast, in Neo-Advaita-Vedanta, you cannot be a bona fide nondualist and believe in God. No way.

Some standouts in this next Advaita Vedanta generation are Jean Klein, Francis Lucille, Rupert Spira, Michael Singer, Gangaji, Mooji, Fred Davis, and Tony Parsons. Some clearly awakened through Advaita Vedanta. Some did so spontaneously on their own but then came to see their experience through a no-real-self, nonduality lens. Some came to it suddenly but after years of spiritual practice—twenty-five years in the case of Fred Davis. Some had the benefit of being around enlightened teachers, sometimes for years, before their own awakening. But still they have been earnestly, sincerely trying to pass on a streamlined, almost instantaneous path to enlightenment.

For example, Fred Davis has written a book,²⁴ *Awaken Now*, and he insists that by simply reading it, you can awaken. Many videos and online groups run by nonduality teachers promise the same. They use pointers, as is always done in Advaita Vedanta. For example, you might be told to close your eyes and imagine that everything around you is gone, both what you can see and everything you cannot see. Then imagine all your past and future are gone: your name, your relationships, your entire history. But notice you are still here, thinking. Now stop thinking, or imagine how it would feel to stop thinking. But you are still here, as awareness. With no thoughts, sensations, or feelings, you are pure awareness. As you return to the world, you are supposed to keep that pure awareness as a background to everything else.

Once you see that pure consciousness is all there is, Neo-Advaita teaches that you need nothing more. Meditation is no longer considered necessary or correct because it feeds the ego's sense that it exists and does things, including making progress. Neo-Advaita also says you need no further teachings, and ethics, personal problems (e.g., past traumas), and the world's problems are all illusions.

Pros and Cons of Radical Nonduality

Many people feel they have awakened thanks to nonduality teachings. These adherents have created almost spontaneously a nonduality movement, sometimes called the *satsang* movement. In Sanskrit *sat* means truth and *sang* means together, so it is a gathering to seek truth, usually around a charismatic teacher. But some nonduality leaders, not wishing to set themselves above others as spiritual teachers, prefer the idea that friends are just coming together in a *satsang* to hear the truth that they all agree on. Thus, anyone interested in enlightenment can join a *satsang*, even for just an evening, without pressure to give their allegiance to a teacher. There seem to be new teachers with new websites and books about

it every time I look. It truly is the Wild West. New wagon trains pull into town every day.

Pure nondualism gets almost funny. In 2020 they held a Nothing Conference. What else could they call it, given that they view language as dualistic by nature, breaking the wholeness into bits of meaning that all have opposites? To enjoy the convoluted wordings a nonduality stance requires, see the “Glossary of Non-duality” by Brad Stephan on the *Buddha at the Gas Pump* website.^{[25](#)}

Even those who have been teaching a while, using a variety of methods—Adyashanti, Eckhart Tolle, and Deepak Chopra, for example—are also climbing aboard, adding pointers in the style of Neo-Advaita to help speed up those who are seekers but not finding much. Adyashanti seems to have done this especially effectively. After fourteen years of Zen meditation led to his awakening, his Zen teacher told him to teach without worrying about adherence to any one method or school. So he has added pointers to his work, especially in *The Direct Way*. Eckhart Tolle’s work really began as pointers, telling you about how to live in the Now, and Deepak Chopra (who was close to Maharishi for many years) has begun to emphasize this path to enlightenment much more than he had, adding pointers to his book^{[26](#)} *Total Meditation*.

Most of the nonduality movement is much more uncompromising than Adyashanti, Tolle, or Chopra. So, of course, there has been a backlash. While I want to be as objective as I can about different paths, in this case that means letting you know about the criticisms.

One nonduality teacher, Jeff Foster, has entirely recanted. In a widely read article, “Awakening from the Dream of Nonduality,”^{[27](#)} Foster is most distressed by the way that so many nonduality teachers and their students think they are done when they have actually taken only the first step into higher states of consciousness. After each step, according to Foster, the new state has to be integrated, lived in the real world.

Foster admits that it took a long time for him to realize that there was a nondual club, so to speak, with rules about what was nondual, “and even its own police force!” He saw it as having become a new

religion, with a new dogma, which was not reducing suffering, but justifying it and even feeding it. There's no one suffering, according to this doctrine, and nothing one can do about it anyway. Foster calls it "a recipe for devastation, and a deep blindness to truth. And endless conflict."

Jessica Eve, a "spiritual emergence coach," has also spoken up about the harm done by Neo-Advaita. She was in a flat state of no-self for years before realizing it was so bad for her, and for many others, some of whom have become suicidal after finding life no longer had any point, any meaning. Parents left their families after seeing the whole arrangement was an "illusion."

Both Jessica and Jeff have been interviewed on *Buddha at the Gas Pump* (and there are transcripts provided) plus have websites and videos of their own. However, remember all of this is about the most extreme nonduality teachers and teachings.

Final Thoughts on the Ego

This sense that the goal in awakening involves moving beyond the ego is not just in Eastern traditions. All the modern contemplative Christians—Thomas Merton, James Finley, Richard Rohr, and others—talk about the false self, the one that only identifies with thoughts and objects, versus the True Self. In their view the True Self knows God, lives within God, in the Kingdom of God, and spontaneously lives God's will.

I was curious about the²⁸ *Course in Miracles* (lovingly called the ACIM), and found it is also basically about moving beyond the self. The first lesson in the ACIM workbook asks you to practice holding the idea that nothing you see—in the room, from the window, on the street, your body, your hand—means anything. The ultimate goal is to see the wholeness of everything. This all sounds remarkably like a course in Advaita Vedanta.

Turning back to the East, all of the four paths discussed in Vedanta and described in [Chapter 3](#) attempt to interrupt our thinking about ourselves by having us focus on something larger. Most

monasteries or ashrams, whether Hindu, Buddhist, or Christian, have set up orphanages, clinics, or ways of distributing food to the poor. It is not just done to make this a better world but because selfless giving helps us stop thinking about our individual desires, needs, fears, and so forth. Monasteries and ashrams further reduce the ego by asking all members to conform to the rules of the order—to obey all rules, dress the same, follow the same schedule, treat everyone with equal respect, and generally leave personal wishes at the door. (Armies and prisons use some of the same methods for reducing the ego's will.)

Most of us would not choose to live in such a complete state of surrender, and what is not clear is whether a deliberate strategy of reducing the ego is necessary. To me, the big question is whether the ego diminishes on its own as it is drawn into something so vast that it simply becomes irrelevant by comparison. Remember all those in the surveys who reported having fewer thoughts? Some remarked on feeling they had lost their self, but hardly all of them, and none of them completely.

Retreats can be an excellent compromise—not quite a monastic life but a way to take your ego out of its field of (often intense) activity and go deeply into the absolute and whatever knowledge is being offered on the retreat.

I like the way Adyashanti talks about the issues raised by the radical nonduality teachers. (This is not from any single talk but several, so I am not exactly quoting him.) Even if we are enlightened, or think we are, and have a sense of having reached the goal and feeling almost perfect, the paradox is that we are also incomplete and growing toward completion. Remember Adyashanti began in the Zen tradition, and in Buddhism generally, one does not claim enlightenment based on experiences. It all has to do with behavior. Rick Archer, in his interview with Buddhist Stephen Snyder, repeated one of Archer's favorite quotes, "supposedly from Padma Sambhava" (a legendary Tibetan Buddhist teacher). This saint said, "Although my awareness is as vast as the sky, my attention to karma [my action or behavior] is as fine as a grain of barley flour."

Adyashanti did discuss his awakenings—there were several before he had established what is called an abiding awakening. But he is very honest about still having difficulties in certain areas and expects this will happen to anyone who is apparently enlightened. This all fits with the idea we began with in [Chapter 2](#), of waking up and cleaning up. Adyashanti calls it accepting paradox. Yes, the small self is an illusion if we see it as separate from the totality, the absolute. But eventually we see that it really is part of the totality. The fact is, the unique person who has our name is also very real, as part of the totality's constant change, its process. This is the perspective of Unity or Brahman consciousness.

We may fear we will lose our awakening if we allow that separate part of ourselves to express itself too much or to go through processes involved in cleaning up. But your true nature can never go away. Returning to Adyashanti, I like how he points out that your life as a whole is actually better this way, back and forth, than if you had either the pure part or the messy part alone. Every time we face something painful and work through it, and then rediscover that bliss, it becomes more solid. The actual experience in enlightenment is that the small self takes over when you need to focus to complete a task, make a decision, or look at what is painful. But the small self and large Self are not really separate but one indivisible whole.

You could not possibly seek enlightenment without an ego having that desire, and when enlightened you still need it. There must be a knower to know the emptiness, God, Brahman, or whatever you want to call it. Think of your ego as a donkey, if you will, but one you definitely need to do the everyday lifting and to carry you to your goal. The answer, in short, lies in the paradox of self and no-self, self and Self, living together in contradictory harmony.

Before you began to read this book, you may have only known this relative world of what we see, hear, touch, and think about, what you and I deal with every minute, whether furthering a career, raising children, writing a book, or deciding what to have for dinner. The relative is so real that it almost seems that we need no term for it—until you realize that at least some have discovered another side to life, pure being, the absolute, that empty essence functioning

simultaneously with our relative self. Relative and absolute. You can see them as one, nondual, a unity, but it isn't necessary. Sometimes seeing them as two is more helpful. I hope that just learning about these two, relative and absolute, and that you can experience both if you choose to, makes your life richer, more meaningful.

The State of Our Knowledge about Enlightenment/Awakening

It is time to take stock. The supernova has exploded, and the creative, expansive, and analytic aspects of the Western personality have all been brought to bear. As a result of all of our surveys, brain studies, and especially all the connecting on the internet, we have the impression now that enlightenment or awakening can occur in many ways.

- Suddenly following a physical or emotional trauma
- Suddenly in the presence of an enlightened teacher
- Gradually, after years (or sometimes much less) of meditation or spiritual interest
- Not seem to be happening even gradually, but suddenly there is a shift
- Be accompanied by intense physical sensations—kundalini or energy-like somatic experiences (ELSEs)

What We Do Not Know

As can happen with science, the more we know, the more we realize what we do not know. Do all of these shifts end up producing the same state? And what about the end result from practicing any of the variety of methods for awakening or becoming enlightened that have been described:

- *Vipassana*, Zen, Tibetan Buddhism—all one of the many Buddhist paths, most of them PMP or Practice Makes Perfect
- One of many PMP paths from Vedanta, such as *Kriya* yoga
- A State Enlivening method such as TM or certain Zen or Mahamudra practices
- Nonduality teachings alone
- A mixture of methods such as Jeffery Martin's Finders' Courses, in which you choose what seems to work best for you
- Western approaches, usually heart based—Christian, Jewish, Sufi. Or following *A Course in Miracles*

Again, the question is, do all of these result in the same state, identifiable physiologically? We know that people who may be enlightened through TM, pure consciousness 24/7, will show increased coherence among parts of the brain—maybe coherence in the alpha wave length, maybe frontal lobe coherence across many wave lengths, plus much more effective behavior. But why do some of these characteristics also appear in special people, such as top athletes and spiritually inclined police officers, who do not meditate or think of themselves as enlightened?

As for those who became enlightened using focused attention techniques, such as the preparatory work in the Mahamudra tradition, they show a different type of coherence, gamma coherence. But besides the research by Dan Brown, it seems unlikely that we are going to learn much about the neurophysiology of nirvana as described by other branches of Buddhism, given their understandable desire not to have to decide what nirvana really is and who has it.

Still, we could definitely look at the brain activity in those who claim they are enlightened through nonduality realizations. And what about all those Finders from Jeffery Martin's courses? Martin claims to be very interested in research. We saw that his course uses a variety of methods, yet 65 percent seem to have reached the goal. It seems like the ideal situation to compare the different methods that worked. Could it be that they are all equally helpful? So what about comparing Finders to those high on TM's measure of enlightenment?

That should be easily done. Jeffery Martin did go to visit Maharishi International University, where Fred Travis teaches and conducts his research on Transcendental Meditation. They were thinking of collaborating, which seems like it would have been a major breakthrough. But Travis reports (personal communication, June 20, 2025) that Martin wanted to test transcranial magnetic stimulation (something Martin was trying at the time) on meditators at MIU, but Travis declined, “since I did not know how it would affect their brain.” Martin “was not open to using the EEG measures to assess his people.” So they parted as friends but not collaborators.

I am confident that all of the necessary research will happen eventually. I simply want to point out how much we still do not know.

What We Do Know

I apologize for repeating this, but we do know a lot, at least in four areas, and these are points I want you to remember. First, cognitively, enlightenment brings this remarkable change in the self-system, as Taylor emphasized. Fewer thoughts about one’s self. As Martin found, there are progressively fewer thoughts, perhaps 95 percent fewer—the self-system is thinking less. Buddha defined nirvana as the realization that the self has no separate, permanent existence. Talk about a change in the self-system.

Maharishi did not discuss a loss of the self, probably following Shankara’s example of not talking about the self as an illusion to those not prepared for it. Instead, he set up a process that has exactly the effect of Advaita Vedanta: the self is forgotten in Transcendental Consciousness; is only witnessed in Cosmic Consciousness; maybe reemerges to fall in love, so to speak, with creation, in God Consciousness; until the self merges with aspects of creation in Unity Consciousness; and finally completely identifies with Brahman, both relative and absolute. The small self is gone but is hardly missed.

Second, there are changes in emotions. Equanimity is the emotion associated with the enlightenment/awakening in every tradition and in all of the research. Emotions may come up, but they quickly settle down again. (Cleaning up both contributes to and benefits from this equanimity, but if there are still intense complexes left, such as around attachment, loss, or jealousy, strong emotions can still arise.) Feelings of universal love and even a free-floating bliss may occur, but at the end of the day, equanimity is the foundation of all other emotions.

Third, there is a change in perception, this unmingling of the self from the objects of perception mentioned by both Tolle and Forman. The self separates from what is seen, becoming a witness, then later perceives in an entirely different way, merged as the Self with what is seen, creating the unity state.

So, we do know quite a bit.

About Your Choices

The point of this book was to help you make choices. In [Chapter 1](#) I gave you the choice, perhaps new for you, of seeking to gradually permanently change your brain so that it provides this deep equanimity and a more effortless way of functioning. In [Chapter 2](#) the choice was whether to accept Ken Wilber's idea of cleaning up as well as waking up, and whether to pursue one or both of these yourself. In [Chapter 3](#) you had choices regarding paths and practices; in [Chapter 4](#), information about how your childhood might affect these choices; in [Chapters 5](#) and [6](#), information for making choices about meditation; and in [Chapters 7](#) and in this chapter information about enlightenment and the methods you might choose to arrive at that permanent equanimity.

I should also emphasize that if meditation is your main path, you can choose to speed things up greatly by going on retreats. Daily meditation may only be able to keep up with your daily stress but not dig out the deeper stuff or allow the undistracted concentration

some methods require. There are retreats for every method, varying from a weekend to three months or more.

If you choose to go for the goal of enlightenment, remember no method is certain or for everyone, or so Jeffery Martin found. And how long you must meditate before awakening seems to vary widely, but it also depends on your choice of what the finish line looks like. Perhaps nothing is more stringent than Tibetan Buddhist Chogyam Trungpa Rinpoche's view, quoted in *Halfway Up the Mountain*, who knew many great saints but said only three were what he called enlightened beings.

On the other hand, if you choose as your goal the view of enlightenment as pure consciousness 24/7, especially if you have been meditating for a while, maybe you are closer than you think, and you could choose to reassess your progress. I have met people who have been practicing meditation for twenty, thirty, or more years who say they are not enlightened. However, if I know or ask about how their lives are, they are very happy and have very few negative thoughts. They do not have serious worries about anything in their personal lives. If a problem arises, it is easily solved. They do what they want but say their desires and needs are few. They are not complicated thinkers, although they engage in work that requires clarity. They are incredibly kind, compassionate, and good listeners. And humble. If I ask them about how their practice is going, they say they have stopped worrying about ever becoming enlightened. They just want to enjoy their lives.

If they practice TM and I ask them about whether they have transcendental consciousness as a background to their lives all the time, they may not be sure about one aspect, the sense of pure awareness even during sleep. This is a very subtle experience, easily missed. I cannot help but think that some of these meditators are having the experience of higher states without knowing it. Perhaps their shift was very slight. Perhaps they are too humble to think it could be the state they were once seeking, or else they do not care about it if this is all it is. If you are in this group, you may have a choice about how you see enlightenment itself. Suppose you have been wearing a sparkly little necklace for years, a keepsake now,

something you are just fond of. You assume its single gem is only a rhinestone. Then you learn it is actually a diamond. I ask you, do you choose to think less of diamonds or more of your necklace?

Finally, if you feel you are not making the progress you want, consider the effects of the collective culture you live within, and maybe make some choices. In the East, traditionally, if you made awakening or enlightenment your goal, whether you were a monk or a householder, everyone understood what you were seeking. In the West, although Eastern teachers try to provide some similar support, the stressfulness of the modern lifestyle often stands in the way. However, I think this is changing. Indeed, your choices about what you value and what you actually do with your life can influence the culture around you. I have a fantasy that someday a norm will spread of putting the evolution of one's consciousness first, including maintaining an easy schedule and going on frequent retreats (the new vacation). People who adopt that lifestyle—not everyone, of course—will be less focused on achieving great accomplishments or having large incomes. Hence, not needing to be ruthlessly competitive, they will have a reputation for honesty, kindness, creativity, and humility. And my fantasy includes employers loving to have some of these people working for them. There will even be some term for them, and having it applied to oneself will be an honor.

What About You?

Consider how you have been affected by reading these final two chapters on enlightenment and what it means for you going forward. Perhaps it brings to mind a person you know who might be awakened. What are the qualities you notice? Perhaps you are wondering how it would feel to be enlightened (if you are not yet). What state or stage of it would most suit you? How would it be to have equanimity, compassion, and presence almost always available. And let's add humility. Or if you do now think you might already be

awakened to some degree, where are you in your development?
How do you handle stuff when it comes up?

What About Me?

The shift in me, which I talked about in the previous chapter, happened at the very end of 2016, so some years have passed. My friend Robert Forman assured me that things would keep evolving, and they have. I have been a real oozer, as I heard Rick Archer describe himself, or one of Buckland's "Atman types." Nothing sudden or flashy, just pure consciousness there, as foreground or, when I am busy, as a background I can always sense if I seek to.

I think I would like whatever might be going to happen in the evolution of my consciousness to happen even faster. Maybe that is the high sensation seeker in me, or just the seeker. I think my lifelong intense use of my left brain (even as I write this) and my joy in it has affected what I experience. The right hemisphere and heart are probably the source of many of the "flashy" experiences I hear others report, those Buckland calls "sattva types." At the same time, I am convinced that who I am, what I am doing, and what is happening are exactly how it should be for Elaine Aron. Or, in other terms, I think I am doing God's will, as best as it moves through the flawed lens of my individual conditioned mind/brain.

Emotions still arise around complexes that I had hoped were gone, mostly about separations. After being with close friends or family, especially my only son, I truly suffer after they depart for exactly twenty-four hours. Yes, Buddha, I know this is due to attachment. But it is also my heart speaking up, so I cannot complain there. I just observe it and wait it out, humbled. I still have that equanimity and Fundamental Wellbeing. It seems like many fewer problems arise. Inconveniences are solved quickly. What I need often just shows up.

I find my love and appreciation of my husband as the right partner for me has grown enormously. My grouchy periods are brief and due to fatigue. I have always found that the more I love him,

the happier I am, and vice versa, but in the past I often felt deeply irritable, unable to switch to love and happiness. Now I can. But then we are older, too, and have solved our conflicts due to differences long ago. I let him be who he is. Too, we have been meditating since 1971 and right now spend one week every month on retreat. That makes a difference.

Mostly I notice my contentment and lack of worry, even about health issues, compared to other people. I have very few thoughts about myself beyond how best to use my time to serve others. What a contrast after years of depression, low self-esteem, and depth psychoanalysis! If I forget about these changes or think they are insignificant compared to others' experiences of higher states, the partner who has lived with me nearly sixty years, most of them marked by my anguish and self-analysis, will attest to the changes. My longest friends also see these changes in me.

For a while after 2016 I was spending less time in social relationships, as many Finders reported to Jeffery Martin. I experienced chitchat as even more unbearable (all HSPs dislike it, but this was even less tolerance of it than before). That has changed—my heart finally has won me over to the view that just hanging out with family, for example, is no waste of time or boring. I do feel some awkwardness about having so few difficulties when many of my friends are fairly unhappy—we were used to sharing our troubles with one another. But more and more I find they listened to me about things I have been exploring for this book and have grown along with me. Or accept my changes and make good use of me!

Oh yes, aging and death. I just do not pay much attention to it. I know my body is wearing out in its individual ways and has to continue to do so. But I like Maharishi's view of aging: "Ride the tiger." That is, use the passage of time to take you where you want to go. Alas, aging, disability, death, and preparations for those have become the favorite topics of most of my agemates. I notice a wide range of reactions when I do not engage or do so only jokingly. Mostly I guess I am seen as being in an unhealthy state of denial on that subject, but I think it will all be as it should. Maybe I really do live more in the now.

I have to add that as time passes, my relationship with God, or maybe I should say with my Holy Other, becomes closer. I do not need to know exactly what this presence is and do not wish to confuse it with all the other meanings of God. And a unity, a totality that includes me, is also my reality. But then I fall back into a comforting duality regarding God, much as Shankara spoke of. I feel we are working together on this book. I know that could seem delusional, but I am being honest here. My Holy Other is the one who tells me not to be worried at all about my death.

Here is a worry I still have, as I have said: that talking about these changes brings up uncomfortable (or much worse, overly respectful) feelings in others. In my outer life I mostly have not mentioned it up to now, except to my very closest friends. I think I was so low-key that they have forgotten about it. One pleased me by telling me, when I checked in after several years about how my revelation had made him feel, that he wished I would talk about it more! It does get lonely, not having many people with whom to share something so important. With this book, however, I have exposed myself in ways not typical or comfortable for a very private introvert, but I feel I have nothing to lose except that privacy, which serves to protect someone who matters less and less in the big scheme of things.

A Love Letter to HSPs

Now that we are at the end of this book, I can confess how it began. I saw myself feeling increasingly complete regarding research and writing about HSPs. It was around the time of the Pandemic. I was being asked by the media how HSPs are dealing with the lockdown, how should they cope with the anxiety, how, how, how? I wanted to shout, *I don't know! They're all unique!*

As I contemplated my new topic, it seemed as if I had been in a comfortable enclosure that was suddenly a bit small, but it had a gate I had not seen before. Inside the enclosure were my old stomping grounds, where I had been for twenty or thirty years. It is

a lovely place, where we are all just fellow HSPs, and it will always be there. We are still connected. That is why I have written to you throughout this book. But there was that gate I had not seen before, and suddenly I wanted to go through it. I had to.

I did consider how turning my attention to meditation and enlightenment would affect you. You would receive less from me. But there are so many talking about high sensitivity these days, and doing good research on it. You do not need more of that from me. I have worried that you might feel I have gone somewhere that does not suit you or is unrelated to your trait. But I trust you can keep your boundaries and not join me where you feel uncomfortable.

On the other hand, you might find me disappointingly far behind you in matters spiritual. I suspect HSPs have always been among the first out of that gate that I sensed. But I can live with disappointing you in that way. Finally, the effect on HSPs like you of my writing this book might encourage you to join me out here, which would not happen if I had not gone ahead of you out the gate.

Finally, Our Future as a Species and Its Relation to Spirituality or Whatever

We have some unfinished business. At the beginning of this book, I asked you to put on hold your concerns about the state of the world and questions of whether focusing on a spiritual path is hopelessly self-centered or out of touch with the current global reality. Now it is time to look at that issue.

Only Facts and Logic

What do we know for sure about the sources of our species' problems? We are like most other animals—we fight to have the best resources for ourselves and those we want to survive (mostly those with similar DNA, but our generosity can extend to those we see as a part of our group). But in a typically human way, we have taken it

to a whole new level. We instinctively compare ourselves and our group to others, hoping to rank high or highest, to see ourselves as the best, often ignoring the facts. Some humans are so oriented to ranking that they can be categorized as narcissists or sociopaths. Others are called heroes for selflessly defending their group against all others, but this is simply ego in the service of a group, what Wilber describes as not very “grown up” in a social sense. In other words, humans have ego problems, greater than any other species.

In contrast, what we know for sure about awakening is that the self-system is reduced. Because of that, there is a very noticeable decrease in concern about rank, resources, and comparing oneself with others, along with a lessening of the resulting emotions of craving, envy, low self-esteem, worry, anger, and hopelessness plus a decreased identification with groups. It could be that with these decreases in the effects of ego (depending also on how cleaned up and grown-up people are) that we are looking at a new type of human being. And surely enough of this new type and their example to others could lead to a very different world.

No, there are not enough of these awakened people yet, but their numbers are definitely growing. That seems to be an empirical fact. What we do not have yet is enough data on whether the awakened are actually more dedicated and effective than others in doing what is needed to reverse the many crises we face. Travis’s Brain Integration Scale includes moral development, but will higher scores be enough to change behavior? Does it matter how someone reached awakening? Fast or gradual? Are Jeffery Martin’s Finders going to be as full of compassion and concern for the world as those arriving on a traditional path emphasizing ethics and right action?

What Is Happening Already—Sacred Activism

We do already have examples of people who appear to be enlightened stepping up to try to change the world. Adam Bucko, whom you read about in [Chapter 3](#), has made videos and written a beautiful book on this subject,²⁹ *Let Your Heartbreak Be Your Guide*.

And Nipun Mehta of ServiceSpace has a wide reach, all across the world, inspiring people to “be the change they wish to see.” Andrew Harvey, mentioned in previous chapters, called himself “a slave of love in action” in a 2021 interview for the podcast³⁰ *Spirit Matters*. He advocates sacred activism in several books³¹: *Radical Regeneration*, written with Carolyn Baker, and before that³² *The Hope: A Guide to Sacred Activism*. Harvey is firm that climate change, mass extinctions, and all the rest cannot be dismissed as *maya* or illusion. Talking with the Dalai Lama, Harvey asked him if the human race would even survive. The Dalai Lama said, “I do not know and nobody knows. Prepare for the worst but work tirelessly for the best.” That is, engage, from a spiritual place.

There are a number of books you might appreciate that call for sacred activism: *Time to Stand Up: An Engaged Buddhist Manifesto for our Earth* by Thanissara³³; *Towards Sacred Activism*, written for Muslims, by Dawud Walid³⁴; and even a book for HSPs, although not focused on spirituality³⁵: *Social Justice for the Sensitive Soul*, by Dorcas Cheng-Tozun.

What makes sacred activism different, besides being perhaps more efficient, is that facing what must be changed does not lead to lasting sadness and despair, which surely leads to burnout in time. Being Established in Being allows you to experience the facts about the worst and work tirelessly to prevent them, to go to war against them as Arjuna had to do, but remain established in a place beyond despair or hope.

The Example of Victoria Ukachukwu

Here is an example of how enlightenment looks in action. Victoria Ukachukwu, interviewed July 20, 2022, on *Buddha at the Gas Pump*, earned her Ph.D. in organic chemistry and is now dean of Academic Affairs at Union College in New Jersey. After searching first in Catholicism and then science, she went to a couple of retreats by Rupert Spira, one of the nonduality teachers I mentioned earlier. In

2014, she had an awakening that left her confident in saying in her interview, “Consciousness is the eternal truth of Being. In my experience, being aware of Awareness itself is our true nature and our only purpose.³⁶ It is Absolute.”

Victoria may be awakened, but like everyone else, she can have appropriately intense feelings about the tragedies around her, such as the invasion of Ukraine or the murder of George Floyd. (I hope you understand now that the deep equanimity of awakening and appropriately intense emotions can occur together, as if at different levels of the mind.) The famous video of Floyd’s death shook her to the core. But she describes how she takes such things deep within her, to Awareness, Presence, God—she uses all of these terms.

Holding her pain in that Presence, Victoria found that action then happened automatically. A few months after George Floyd’s death she was attending a leadership retreat for her staff, but after a few hours found herself inattentive. When everyone was asked if there was anything more they wanted to address, she found herself asking if they could have a minute of silence for George Floyd. She felt strongly that this was not coming from her personal emotions but from a larger power acting through her. After the silence, a discussion ensued that eventually led to broad policy changes.

She concluded that once you are aligned with that Presence, opportunities unfold to address the real problem using your particular abilities—after the negative emotions have settled in the depths of the absolute. Her point is that we can manage our grief and fear about the world situation and act powerfully when we have access to this place of quiet power. Also note that Victoria’s ego did not make her speak up, nor did it step in to prevent her from it out of fear of how she would be seen. She just spoke.

Voicing My Biases, Finally

Now that we are nearing the end, I need to confess my biases. You have probably already noticed them. But I want to say that I was always aware of them but felt they were unavoidable. I just hope

they have not damaged your trust in this book as a sanctuary from personal bias.

First, you know by now that I am confident that enlightenment or awakening is real and that many or most of you can wake up if you wish to make the effort. Without that bias I would not have written this book. No, we do not know for sure what awakening is, or even if there is more than one kind, depending on the practice used to reach it. No, it is not as wonderful as some might have hoped, although in other ways it may be more than we hoped. But mainly I believe all of us are involved in the experiment that will answer these questions and that we can contribute by carefully observing our own experiences, even if it does not match the average research data. We also need to testify as to how it feels to have tried and not made the shift so far. What seemed to stand in the way. And if we do think we made the shift, how has it been to grow older with that? What does enlightenment look like in a Westerner after twenty, thirty, forty, or fifty years of living it? How does it affect aging, illness, facing death?

You may have noticed another bias. I have mostly left out what comes under the umbrella of the supernatural: synchronicities, near-death experiences, psychic experiences, messages from loved ones from the other side, and all the rest. I apologize for ignoring what is for some of you most central to your spiritual life. I did that, as I think you understood, because I know many people would find discussions of any of that to be a deal breaker, a reason to close the book. As a concession, if you are not totally turned off by these matters, I recommend the very balanced exploration of the subject by Elizabeth Lloyd Mayer,^{[37](#)} *Extraordinary Knowing*. Very skeptical herself, Mayer opens with a factual experience that set her, reluctantly, on a path of thoroughly exploring these matters in a scientific way.

I am biased, however, in favor of at least considering some information on the border of what is accepted by science or known that may soon move into the better known, and some of that might change how you view the crises on the planet. Some excellent

scientists think that the effect of enlightened people and/or of people meditating together in a group is nonlocal, to borrow from physics (feel free to look up the term). This viewpoint regarding the effect of meditators borrows the idea of nonlocality to assert that there is a field of consciousness identical at the most fundamental level of physical reality identified by quantum physics, so that effects of coherent consciousness in groups of people can move through this field in ways not yet well explained. But it is not an unheard of idea at all. David Bohm, a renown quantum physicist, proposed that many theoretical problems in quantum field theory, still not solved, would be settled by understanding there is a nonlocal field of this type underlying reality.

It was Maharishi and the scientists he recruited who have most studied whether events around groups of meditators are changed by their presence, without there being any direct contact. You may recall my explaining that this is why there were so many people living in Fairfield, Iowa—to do the TM-Siddhis program as a group and affect the United States in positive, measurable ways. And there is very strong evidence (and of course persistent skepticism too) that when there are enough of them in Fairfield (or large groups anywhere in the world), they do have that effect.³⁸ But details about the Maharishi Effect, as it is called, strays from the main topic of this book. And I am not going to ask you to rest your hopes on something you may find impossible to believe. If it does not seem totally impossible, explore it—the research is very impressive.

Where We Are Now—Farewell

I suppose this is my final bias: a feeling of fondness for you, my readers, who have stayed with me all the way to here. Indeed, I like to imagine that if you and I had the time to get to know one another, we would probably want to link—to be around each other, to know more about one another, and help one another if we could. But this book, our only link, is coming to an end. You have always been there in my mind and heart, and I will miss writing to you.

I cannot promise you that all will turn out well in the world. But I hope I have instilled in you some of my confidence that this supernova that has mixed East and West, like right and left hemispheres of a global brain, is producing change that has to affect in a positive way the outcome of life on earth, and that because of it, at least some of us can do our part to help, most of the time, more calmly, compassionately, and fearlessly. I hope this book has been a sanctuary for you. But hopefully you now sense the inner sanctuary, where you can remain established 24/7, and where you and I are one. And please feel free to revisit this relative sanctuary when you are in need of it, to remind yourself that we hung out here together for a while in a larger realm and still can.

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I was largely on my own, writing this book. I wrote version after version, trying to get closer to something like truth. Fearing being led astray by the many understandable biases I was finding, I only trusted a few people to read and comment. The most trusted was my husband, Art, beside me at his own desk just six feet away, willing to read draft after draft. Jerry Freeman was also a close companion on this path, reading the entire manuscript at least once. My dear friend and fellow psychologist Camille Wortman also read the whole thing, probably several times. I remember discussing the fine points during a weekend in Glen Ellen, sitting in our cozy cabin overlooking Sonoma Creek. Her not understanding so many things that I had written pushed me to write a much clearer book.

Similarly, I cannot leave out my literature-professor friend Steve Specter, who read an early version and bluntly told me that the beginning had “some problems.” He gave me this suggestion, which he says he gives to all of his students for writing the opening lines of a book or essay: “Imagine your reader is drunk and falling off their bar stool, hearing what your book is about as they fall. Be sure they get it before they hit the floor.” I hope it worked.

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I also must acknowledge Rick Archer, creator of the podcast *Buddha at the Gas Pump*, now with 700+ interviews of awakening people. What a gift to the world! Without even knowing about this book, he gave me so much evidence for the spiritual supernova I was describing.

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